FRAGMENTED CONTROL



– The Salvation of Tempestria Book 4 –

GARY STRINGER

The Salvation of Tempestria

Shifting Stars
Gathering Storm
Shadows Fall
Fragmented Control

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Book 4

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Chapter 1

The Guardians are getting creative. The two I've got locked in my bedroom, that is.

As you know, gentle reader, I've frozen my house in a bubble in Time, but it's challenging even for me to stop two Guardians from gaining a foothold and interfering with what I'm doing. I suppose I should have been suspicious, the way they suddenly went quiet, after working so hard to break through when I first put them in there. I naively thought they'd given up trying to beat me. Not so.

From my first instalment, gentle reader, you may recall that I wedged my bedroom door shut with my mother's old staff and cast an adaptive anti-magic field on my room. Now, you might wonder how I expected that to work, considering I later told you about my mother's discovery that anti-magic fields are useless. Well, the key lies in the word `adaptive`.

Back in the day, my mother's solution, later adopted by Aunt Dreya and eventually by pretty much everyone, was to determine the magical frequency. Then the mage could either adapt their own magic to use the anti-magic field itself and/or absorb its power into themselves. However, techniques evolve with time, and so did anti-magic fields. Now we use adaptive versions that change frequency at regular intervals to prevent tampering. But the two Guardians that I have imprisoned, the modern successors to Catriona and Dreya, were not picked by lottery. So, in the face of my `attack` (which I suppose it is, from their perspective), they got creative.

Their overriding opinion is that we should be out there actively working to stop the void-creature (a.k.a. Daelen StormTiger, my father). Dealing with current events. Aunt Mandalee and I believe that this is futile without help, hence our Illegal Time Intervention. Besides, since I've created my own Timeless zone here, there *are* no current events. That means there's no rush. I thought that would make them content to wait until I let them out, but I underestimated the power of ego.

Every True Guardian who has replaced one of the Original Three has suffered from inevitable comparisons, and, let's face it, my mother and Aunt Dreya were hard acts for anyone to follow.

This means that the two in my bedroom have got something to prove. That's what drove them to try and break through my anti-magic field, running through the frequencies at random and punching through with a portal, of all things.

As Aunt Mandalee told Daelen, we don't use portals anymore – we have better techniques, now – but the brute force approach almost worked. The advantage of portals is that although the co-ordinates need to be precise, the frequency doesn't. The disadvantage is that they damage the fabric of reality, which is why they're banned except in an emergency. (Still, I can hardly blame them for doing something borderline illegal when they're convinced that they're trying to save the world.)

Unfortunately for them, they're forgetting who they're dealing with.

I'm not a Guardian; I'm unique. Although I appear to be a human woman (my Faery spots only emerge in hot sunshine), of about eighteen to twenty years, I'm nothing of the sort. From a Tempestrian point-of-view, my date of birth was almost a thousand years ago, but calculating my actual age is problematic, given Timelessness, Immortality and time spent on other worlds. Suffice to say I have far more life experience than my youthful exterior would suggest, and my true nature extends into places that humans can't perceive. That means I don't need to open the door to reach inside my bedroom. It's similar to what Kullos and Daelen were trying to do in their Final Battle, extending their higher planar nature, their essence, extending their 'light' outside their 'box'. Except I know how to do it gently, with care, control, and precision, so I don't risk tearing reality apart.

Let me put it to you this way, gentle reader: A two-dimensional royal family keep their two-dimensional crown jewels in a two-dimensional vault with a single two-dimensional door and protected by two-dimensional guards. One day, the guards capture a three-dimensional human trying to steal those crown jewels. They lock him up, but he escapes with those crown jewels. He didn't come through the door and he didn't breach the walls, so, question: How did the three-dimensional human escape his two-dimensional prison?

Answer: That three-dimensional human can reach into that two-dimensional vault without damaging anything, steal those

crown jewels from above and escape the same way, because it's wide open in that dimension. It's wide open because those two-dimensional people can't perceive 'above' the way humans can.

Now, if they're *really clever* two-dimensional people, they might be able to intellectually grasp the *concept* of 'above'. They might even have magic or technology that operates in that dimension, but they can't perceive it.

In the same way, back in our plane of the cosmos, the Guardians' portals operate within the parts of reality that humans and other 'mortals' (for lack of a better term) can't perceive. But I can. I can exist there and effectively stand in their way so they can't access their portals. That's how I put a stop to their escape attempt. They'll probably try something else in a while, but for now, they are contained, and I can get back to telling my story.

To begin this instalment, gentle reader, I need to go back to the beginning. Yes, I know I've said that before, but I mean it literally this time. All the way back to the Cataclysm that began the cosmos.

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In the beginning, according to myth, the Creator Entity somehow annexed part of the void and created an ordered cosmos. As a balance to this Act of Creation, the *IT* Entity came into being in the void beyond the boundaries of everything. As the cosmos developed, it separated into the layers of what I continue to call the Great Cosmic Sandwich, and life came into being at all levels. At first, life forms were confined to their own native layers of the sandwich. Indeed, at first, lifeforms were blissfully unaware of the existence of other layers, but over time, sapient creatures evolved, some of which began to speculate that there might be more to Creation outside their experience. Among these, some particularly intelligent individuals started to devise ways to detect the undetectable. Much like my mother, they viewed 'you can't do that' as a challenge to do it anyway.

Eventually, it became possible to contact neighbouring planes. This was not always a good thing. Even with the best of intentions, there were misunderstandings. Those from the higher planes often considered themselves superior to those below, while

the lower planes would often be jealous of the abundant energy resources of the higher levels.

The people of my age (that is, the age in which I live) are very much aware that Tempestria is one world among many in this middle layer of the sandwich. Many of these have joined together in a co-operative way, to form the Commonwealth. Moreover, we know that this plane is one of many more, each of which contains countless worlds, peoples and civilisations.

There is a tendency to view the lower planes as the primary source of trouble. The creatures we call demons continue to invade, as they pull energy from inter-planar forces – magic – and Ascend. Once here, they have an abundance of energy, which they mostly use to wreak havoc, maim, kill and even drag innocent mortals back down to their plane. The deeper their native plane, the more energy they need to come here. That's where summoning magic comes in, using the magic that's available here, wizards pull Greater Demons from the deeper levels of our sandwich. Once they are here, they can be very challenging to control because the energy demons require just to live, is very small compared to what they can now access.

Thankfully, gentle reader, there isn't enough energy in the whole mortal plane to summon the Keeper of the Underworld.

Before the war with the void-creature began, the people of my age generally didn't see the higher planes as a big problem. The Fall of Kullos was a thousand years behind us, and for a thousand years before that, the sum total of higher planar beings in our world mostly amounted to two shadow warriors (one of which was split into two clones), one Ysirian (Pyrah), one leopard god (Shyleen) and one demigod (Ossian Miach Kaidool, a.k.a. Michael). You can count them on the fingers of one hand, depending on how you count the shadow warriors and how many fingers your species has on one hand. Of these, history viewed only Kullos and Aden as a threat, whereas there had been uncountable demon attacks in history and pre-history, and (except perhaps for Tricksters) all have intended harm.

That has helped to create the misconception that, for the most part, the lower planes are `evil` and the higher planes are `good`.

But that wasn't always the case.

If you go back beyond two thousand Tempestrian years, though we know nothing of our world at that time, there is considerable evidence that higher planar beings came and went, freely. They interfered with countless other mortal worlds as they pleased, so it's reasonable to assume that our world was no exception. Often, these beings had the best of intentions, but to quote from the edicts of Balance, '*Power wielded in ignorance is dangerous, regardless of intent.*'

As you know from my previous instalments, gentle reader, a single shadow warrior was more dangerous than an army of demons. People could deal with demons – Aunt Mandalee is one of a long line of demon hunters – but until the time of the Fall of Kullos, no mortal had been able to stop a shadow warrior. The only reason that danger passed, was because Blessed Alycia threw up her barrier that kept higher planar beings from manifesting here. Of course, Shyleen found a loophole, thanks to her unique relationship with Mandalee, who willingly shared her soul. However, as I say, ours was not the only plane to suffer from attacks from higher levels.

According to legend, such trouble began with the Creator contacting the spread of Angels in the plane immediately below. The Creator actively encouraged those Angels, in the spirit of showing off, to explore the whole of Creation, see the beauty that had been Created, and extend the Creator's Blessing to all the peoples of the cosmos.

Angel sightings are abundant in stories throughout the whole of Creation. Every world we've encountered, both in and out of the Commonwealth, has such stories, and interactions with beings from higher planes suggest they may be truly universal. Of all these stories, though, only one is known to be literally true: the story of the Angel who called herself Purity.

Chapter 2

Countless aeons ago, Purity left what she called the Paradise realm, dropped down a single level in the Great Cosmic Sandwich and began to travel from world to world.

This is the plane from which my father hails, gentle reader. In my previous instalments, I referred to this plane as the 'shadow realm', which is an accurate but narrow term. It's like describing our level as the 'Tempestrian realm'. Just as Tempestrians are not alone in this plane, the people of the shadow realm – the Shadowkin – were one civilisation among many in that plane. As they advanced in their technology, they made first contact with some of them. Out of this contact came the stories of Angels, including visits from Purity.

From the moment she arrived, she took a form that resembled the creatures of that world and began preaching the worship of an Almighty god of gods: the Creator. The more she travelled that world, however, the more she was horrified by it. According to the stories, this was Purity's first encounter with evil, and it shocked her to the core.

"Surely," she considered, "the Creator could not intend for their Blessing to be bestowed on such an unworthy place."

Withholding the Creator's Blessing, then, she left that world and its evil behind, traversing that plane in search of others that would be deserving of such a gift. She believed that the first world she had encountered could only be an anomaly in an otherwise perfect cosmos, but the next world she came across was tainted by this same evil force. She moved on to more and more worlds, but try as she might, she could not find anywhere that was truly worthy of the Creator's Blessing. None could compare to her home in the Paradise realm, sometimes called Heaven.

Over time, her attitude changed to one of sympathy for the good creatures of that plane. How terrible it must be for them to be surrounded by evil. To live such painful, miserable lives in the presence of such evil must be unbearable for them. She would spend time in each world, trying to encourage the spark of

goodness, and trying to turn people away from the evil path, but no matter how she tried, evil always remained.

As more time passed, her approach changed yet again, as she began to believe she had misunderstood the Creator's intentions. The Creator had surely seen that things had started to go wrong down here and sent her out to cleanse this poison. That was surely what the Creator meant. She needed to Cleanse these worlds. Only in that way could they receive the Creator's Blessing.

No-one knows the name of the first world, or the first people to receive her Final Judgement. All that is known is that Purity went among them, telling them to devote their lives solely to the worship of the Creator and Cleanse themselves from the corruption of evil. When they failed to pass her unknowable criteria, she bestowed the Blessing of the Creator, Cleansing the world of all intelligent life, thereby eliminating the evil force.

Purity continued her tour of that plane of reality, travelling from world to world, each time delivering her Final Judgement, Cleansing it of all sapient life. It is even said that other Angels learned what she was doing and tried to dissuade her. They told her there was good in the cosmos. Purity could see only evil. The peoples of the worlds that Purity Judged implored her to see the beauty all around. All she saw was corruption.

In each of the worlds she encountered, some flocked to her, sharing her vision, spreading the word and trying to bring good people into the Light of Purity. Other people tried to get her to stop the killing. She insisted she was not killing, she was Cleansing. They begged her to show mercy. She insisted she *was* showing mercy – she was giving life a second chance.

She believed everything in the cosmos should be as it was in the Paradise realm, but everything she saw fell short of that. Hopefully, next time, life would get it right.

World after world fell to her power, but sometimes a few refugees escaped to spread the word, so the Shadowkin began to hear more and more stories of this nature. They lost contact with other worlds they knew, and they got the sense that she was drawing closer.

One day, it finally happened. Their world was bathed in Divine Light, and a voice sang out, "People of the Shadow Realm

rejoice! For I am Purity, and I have come to Cleanse you all. You have suffered for too long, but now that is at an end."

But the Shadowkin had not been idle as the threat grew closer. They had prepared, pouring their resources into high technology. They knew other worlds had tried to use inter-planar forces against her, but she had always managed to cut them off. No matter what they tried, the Angel always seemed to be standing between them and that power, blocking the path. Nothing could stop or even slow her. No barrier could contain her. She always seemed to have a way into every room, no matter how well-sealed they thought it was.

The Shadowkin had studied what they could of this and realised that the Angel existed in dimensions beyond what they could perceive, but some of their finest minds had begun to develop technology that could operate in those same physical spaces. They theorised further that it should be possible to create physical spaces that even an Angel could not perceive. If so, that could give them a tactical advantage. They gave these concealed physical spaces a name: pocket dimensions.

They also developed weapons technology. Weapons that had the means to channel the energy of their own essence from within – the light in a box. In this way, the Angel could not block their powers as she could with any external power source. The force of these weapons would be determined by the power of the individuals who used them, and with the right training, that power might – just might – be enough to stop an Angel in her tracks.

A swarm of Shadowkin flew towards Purity with purpose. She scanned all the dimensions for concealed weapons: they had none that she could detect. Perhaps they were here to welcome her, she thought.

Well, it was certainly a welcoming committee of sorts.

As she watched, cannon-like weapons appeared out of nowhere and shot her with energy beams, causing her searing pain. She'd never experienced pain like that before. It was a kind of power unlike any she had previously encountered and, try as she might, she couldn't block it. She tried to fight back, but other weapons were brought to bear, each imbued with that same strange power. In the end, she was forced to do something she'd never had to do before: retreat.

From that day, these Shadowkin fighters became shadow warriors. The first known beings to stop an Angel. The Campaign of Cleansing moved on to consume other worlds, but the Shadowkin knew it was only a temporary restbite. Purity of Angels would return, and they needed to be ready. To that end, their entire civilisation shifted to a permanent war footing and the ranks of the shadow warriors swelled.

Every time Purity revisited their world, the shadow warriors managed to turn back the attack, but the war was a costly one. Each assault claimed many lives. Boxes were torn open, their light extinguished forever.

One desperate plan by a Shadow Champion named Kullos had gone horribly awry. He had developed what he claimed was the ultimate weapon to force the capitulation of the Angel from Paradise, aptly named Heaven's Surrender.

Purity had been horrified at such a weapon, sensing within it the power of True Destruction. There was only one place such power could come from – outside the Creator's cosmos, in the vast nothingness that was home to the *IT* Entity. That power could unmake everything the Creator had made. There would be no second chances. In fact, there would never have been a first chance, for the cosmos would never have existed.

Many shadow warriors were killed in the battle for control of that weapon, and it took every scrap of power the Angel possessed, but she managed to secure the device and take it away. She had wanted to Cleanse the one who created the technology – she could sense *IT*s presence in him – but the weapon had been her priority. She would return for the maker of this weapon of evil later.

However, by the time she could return, Kullos was gone. He lived, she was sure of it, but she could not understand where he was.

You see, gentle reader, Purity could not perceive any of the planes below the one in which she was fighting the shadow warriors. She had no concept for them. Though that plane was only one level below Heaven, to her, it seemed like Hell.

Things continued in much the same way until, while she was busy Cleansing yet another world that was rife with evil, she sensed *IT* once more. Just briefly. Like catching a scent of something on the breeze. (This was the moment my mother unlocked the

Nameless Book and had to deal with *IT*, imprisoning *IT* in her staff.) That scent was snatched away in an instant, but she had got a direction. A direction that didn't make sense: down. But there was no 'down'. She was already in Hell. There was nothing below that. There couldn't be. Could there?

A moment later, from an Angel's perspective, a blue light shone upward through the planes, displaying symbols on the surface of the membranes that contained them. (This was the formation of the Guardianship. The first time those blue symbols in the sky fully resolved.) That was proof. There really were planes below the ones she knew, and some kind of creature down there had just lit a beacon. It was gone before she could get a fix on any co-ordinates, but she was sure it had come from the same place as the sense of *IT*.

Then, not long after that, as she fought another battle against the shadow warriors, she felt shockwaves emanating through the layers. It felt like Creation magic. (In fact, she was detecting the presence of the original Tempestria through the Cosmic Rift.) But that was forbidden. Only the Creator had that power, and they had used it only once. Using it again could overwrite what the Creator had done. Replace it with a copy, a facsimile world. That was the ultimate blasphemy. These creatures, whatever they were, needed to be stopped. They needed to be Cleansed.

That day, the shadow warrior leaders received a report from the field: Purity had abandoned the battle and Descended to the lower planes. They didn't know how she'd done it, but somehow, she'd found a way through Alycia's Barrier. From the readings on their technology, they were convinced she had bypassed the realm of the Ysirians and several other layers, travelling beyond the Pantheon, where those who styled themselves gods resided. She stopped Descending only when she reached the material plane of the mortals, where she began her search for the facsimile world.

But the material plane of the cosmos was vast, so the shadow warriors believed Tempestria should remain hidden, as long as they kept to themselves, but if those mortals made too much noise, they might just draw her attention.

Once, long ago, the shadow warriors had thought mortals merely products of their dreams. If Purity ever found Tempestria,

then in the future, those mortal creatures would once again exist only in dreams, for they would be Cleansed.

The shadow warriors were still cut off from the mortal plane by Alycia's Barrier, so at first, there didn't seem to be anything they could do. But then came a report that the Renegade, Kullos, had reactivated his control device. That created an opportunity, a link between the planes, but Kullos wasn't who they needed to speak to. They needed the other one – Daelen StormTiger, their legendary Champion. They called in their Chief Technical Advisor, Daelen's mother, Farrella, and consulted her. She told them that although her son had Descended without a control device, if he were to get his hands on Kullos' device, even for a moment, then it would be possible to send a message. It would be mostly subliminal. There was insufficient bandwidth for full telepathy, but the Ysirians had developed a technique they called 'sympathic communication', projecting concept images and ideas. That should get through. Then maybe Daelen could do something to help keep Tempestria hidden. Modern Tempestrians knew the cost of interference from higher planes, and Farrella could only guess at how much damage her people had done to that innocent world as Kullos and Daelen fought. If Tempestria were to be Cleansed, then the Shadowkin would surely be at least partly responsible. She would not allow that to be their legacy. Not if she could do anything about it. She appreciated the irony that she was planning to interfere, to try and make up for past interference, but the only alternative was to sit by and do nothing.

At last, their technology recognised Daelen's touch on Kullos' control device, and a message was sent. In the blink of an eye, they were cut off, and the feedback signal from the control device fragmented and scattered. Further telemetry gave the impression of a massive explosion – a Heaven's Surrender blast – and a renewed sense of *IT* invading that realm. There was nothing more likely to attract Purity, but then something very strange seemed to happen to Time. The Shadowkin technical people could not make sense of the readings, but somehow, the Heaven's Surrender blast and all trace of *IT* were just…gone. It seemed Purity was equally baffled because she still could not locate Tempestria, but she was getting closer. It was only a matter of time.

One of the technicians called out to the Chief, “I’m sorry, but I think…” he trailed off.

“Yes?” Farrella demanded. “What is it?” From the colours of his aura, shining through from within, she could tell that it was nothing good.

“It’s Daelen, Ma’am,” he began, hesitantly, “I think…from the readings…I think he’s dead.”

Farrella hurried over to see the readings for herself. It seemed it was true – his mortal body had sustained irreparable damage, but with a cry of “Wait!” a female technician rushed to her side and took control of the technology herself, fine-tuning the readings in a way Farrella had never seen before. A small light flashed on the display.

“There!” cried the technician, pointing triumphantly. “You see? There’s still hope yet. A chance.”

Farrella wanted to wrap her aura around her, but remained professional, asking her name.

“Alycia, Ma’am,” she replied, her aura blushing slightly.

“You bring honour to the name,” Farrella told her.

“Thank you, Ma’am.”

“But how does this help?” asked the male technician.

Farrella did not immediately respond as more strange Temporal readings displayed themselves, but when they settled down, she could tell her son’s mortal body had been moved and placed within technology that was compatible with theirs. A stasis chamber of some sort.

“Never underestimate mortals,” Farrella murmured to herself, shaking her head in wonder. “She always said that. I’m beginning to see what she meant.” She cleared her aura – she couldn’t afford to get distracted by such thoughts. She had to focus on trying to save her son.

“Maintain a low-level energy field,” she ordered. “Just a trickle. Nothing traceable. That will allow the technology down there to keep Daelen’s mortal body viable.”

“For how long?” the male technician wondered, incredulously.

“For as long as it takes!” Alycia snapped back.

Once again, Farrella approved. What a ridiculous question.

“As long as what takes? It’s not as if the mortals are going to know what to do!” he scoffed.

“Don’t underestimate them!” Farrella admonished him. “I’m certain those mortals had a hand in stopping Kullos, Heaven’s Surrender and even a breach attempt by *IT*. If they know enough to do all that and they know to keep my son’s body in stasis, then they know enough to collect and reassemble the control device fragments together in that same place for safety.”

She couldn’t be sure if her message had got through to Daelen, but as young Alycia said, there was a chance, just a chance, that a world and perhaps a son could yet be saved.

Chapter 3

It was the day after Midsummer's Day. The day after perhaps the most important date in the Faery calendar. A teenage Faery princess named Zarinda was playing alone in the Sylfranian Faery forest community, in the province of Ainderbury, near to the border with the human port town of Gaggleswick. This was as close as she was legally allowed to get to the infamous Black Tower. Closer than her father, Prince Travarin, would be happy with, she knew. He didn't approve of Dreya the Dark and was horrified by his daughter's long-standing fascination with her. The only Sylfranian Faery noble to escape.

She'd heard that their Quarthonian Faery cousins were not so strict about such things, but in Sylfrania, things were still very much ordered along traditional lines. Given that she was, at her last count, something like thirty-sixth in line to the throne, one wouldn't think royal tradition would touch her overmuch. Unfortunately, her father had always had a chip on his shoulder about being the youngest son and ran his minor province as if it were his own private kingdom.

Zarinda wished she had the courage to do what Dreya had done and walk away from it all. The sorceress had got away because, to her noble family, their concern for their daughter was outweighed by the shame of admitting she was seeking magic instruction from humans. Especially in an Order other than the White. On the one hand, Zarinda didn't think that was right, but on the other hand, she wished her parents felt the same so she could escape as Dreya had.

Even if she had such an opportunity, where would she go? What would she do? Compared to Dreya, who had always had a clear plan for her life, Zarinda knew she was drifting. She didn't know what she wanted, beyond a vague wish that one day, her hero would take her away from all this. Rescue her.

Right now, though, she was the one doing the rescuing. A fledgeling sparrow had fallen out of its nest and injured itself on the ground, trying to fly the nest before it was ready. Zarinda felt sure there was a life lesson in there, somewhere.

She could see her own rescue so clearly, when she closed her eyes. Zarinda was always older in her dreams. In her early twenties, she thought. It was Midsummer's Day, and she was getting married to some Faery boy that she barely knew, as traditionally arranged by her father. In principle, she knew she could always say no to such a union, but that would take a lot of effort. Too much. Besides, once again, it wasn't as if she had an alternative plan for her life, so she supposed she might as well stick with tradition.

But in her dreams, just as the marriage was about to be finalised, a black-robed figure thundered into the outdoor wedding chapel on horseback. The hood fell from the mage's head, revealing it was Dreya the Dark, sending out her magic all around. Nothing could stop her or even slow her down. All those around Zarinda had fallen in seconds. She didn't think they were dead, though. Dreya didn't kill indiscriminately. She would use precisely as much power as was necessary to achieve her goal, and it seemed her goal was Zarinda.

"I need you," Dreya told her, and used her magic to levitate Zarinda onto her horse, snatching her from the altar.

Zarinda would have gone with her anyway, but it did save her from the awkwardness of trying to mount a horse in her bridal gown. Her dreams never specified exactly *why* Dreya would want to take her away from all her troubles, saving her from the prison of her arranged marriage. All she ever said were those three words: 'I need you.'

The princess found the thought thoroughly entertaining and wonderfully thrilling. Her heart was beating rapidly, just thinking about it now. She had even composed a song, a ballad, that told the whole story. Her father had caught her singing it once, and he had not been happy. That was a long time ago, now, but she knew he had neither forgotten nor forgiven her. Her father insisted it was nonsense, just a silly daydream, but she knew it was more than that. It was prophecy. It had to be.

Zarinda could scarcely believe her father had done something so foolish as to send clerics to attack Dreya, a few years ago. She was grateful that the sorceress had had the restraint to not kill her father for his actions. She might not see eye-to-eye with him on some things, but she wouldn't want to lose him. He was

still an outspoken critic of Dreya's, but at least he knew better than to do anything about it now.

Her father might not like her ballad, but her injured feathered audience seemed to have a different view. Holding the bird gently in her hands as she softly sang to it, Zarinda could feel its pain and distress fade.

Seeing that, Zarinda switched songs, choosing her favourite lullaby from when she was little: [1]

Angels among us, stars in the night,
Watch o'er your sleep, shining so bright,
Safe in their light, as you close your eyes,
Love will surround you, 'til morning you rise.

Angels among us, shed you no tears,
Bright Angels guard you, quiet your fears,
Nature's embrace, is gentle and strong,
Love will surround you, all your life long.

Her parents had always sung it in the traditional Faery language, but Zarinda had learned it in the human tongue from a book written by none other than Catriona Redfletching. She who was now one of the Three Guardians, alongside Mandalee the White Assassin and, of course, her hero, Dreya the Dark.

Before she'd finished singing the lullaby a second time, the little fledgeling stirred in her hands, fluttered its wings and somehow found the strength to achieve the flight that had eluded it a few moments ago.

"I guess all you needed was a helping hand," Zarinda decided.

She was pretty sure there was a life lesson there, too.

As the fledgeling flew, it chirped at her Faery rescuer. Zarinda had heard that the White Guardian, Mandalee, could speak animal languages. Zarinda didn't have that ability, but she felt she knew a 'thank you' when she heard one.

Good deed for the day done, Zarinda settled back down to watch what was going on in the grounds of the Black Tower. A few

[1] Fits to the tune of Rockabye Baby.

years ago, Zarinda had learned that when she was very quiet and still, if she softly hummed a tune to herself – it didn't seem to matter what the song was – she could project her senses quite a way in the distance. This was her favourite spot from which to do that. From this vantage point, a few days earlier, she had seen some kind of round blue doorway open up in midair, through which Dreya had flown on the back of a gigantic lizard creature. Zarinda had been terrified, but she needn't have worried: Dreya had everything under control, as always.

Zarinda had argued with her father about that. Why was he so against her? She'd learnt about the Black Tower's only previous owner, Ulvarius, in school, so she knew how much worse things could be if a tyrant like him were in residence. But Dreya wasn't like him, not like other Black robe wizards. She didn't lose control like that. Her father was convinced that one day she would. He insisted they were 'storing up trouble' by allowing her to remain living there…or even to remain living.

The princess didn't understand how he could talk like that and yet be willing to meet with someone like Laethyn, Black robe wizard leader and Triumvirate representative, there in Ainderbury where humans were, if not quite banned, then at least strongly discouraged by way of a highly selective visa system. That meeting had taken place just after Dreya had met with Laethyn in her grounds and handed over that flying lizard.

Zarinda didn't trust Laethyn. She didn't like him. She was pretty sure she wasn't supposed to know about his visit – she only knew about it at all thanks to her long-distance seeing – so she'd kept her knowledge secret. Laethyn scared her. She wouldn't be afraid of Dreya if she met her…well, maybe a little…but not like she was scared of Laethyn. She couldn't imagine what business he could possibly have had with her father, or why the wizard had given him that red jewel. That jewel scared her, too. It gave her a funny feeling in her tummy when she looked at it from far away. She didn't want to see it up close.

Shuddering as if with a sudden chill, Zarinda did her best to put such thoughts from her mind, in favour of remembering more pleasant events.

Only yesterday, she had watched something remarkable. Being Midsummer, many betrothals and weddings were happening

throughout Sylfrania, and many royal family members were in attendance at the more 'important' ones, but nobody was interested in having the thirty-sixth in line to the throne getting underfoot, so she'd been left to her own devices. As usual.

She didn't mind. In fact, she was glad of it, because as far as she was concerned, she'd attended the most important betrothal of all: Dreya the Dark had proposed to Catriona Redfletching. They had been living together for a few years, of course, except when Catriona went off on some grand adventure as she was wont to do. Scandalous rumours had been circulating in the Ainderbury court for a while about those two. Most people didn't think it was really true, but Zarinda now knew it was because she'd been there. At least, that's how she saw it.

OK, none of the others had seen her – not Mandalee, not the happy couple, and not those two purple aliens that had appeared a few days ago – and she hadn't actually set foot beyond the boundaries of Sylfrania. Still, Princess Zarinda had watched it all, and as far as she was concerned, that meant she'd been there.

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Current events pulled her out of her memories in favour of the here and now. Something was going on over by the Black Tower, this morning. It was like the grounds were changing, growing wilder. The undead gardeners began to leave their perpetual weeding and exchange their tools for weapons.

The sky overhead grew darker, clouds drew in, and a storm blew up. Storms weren't supposed to suddenly start like that. Zarinda had heard that Catriona had druid magic that could control the weather, but somehow this didn't seem like her handiwork. Something was going very wrong with the Black Tower.

Zarinda heard one of the two aliens scream, "Help!" as both the garden plants and the undead guards started attacking them. She and the other alien pulled out strange weapons that sent out beams of light that seemed intended to be somehow lethal. They weren't much use against the undead, but they were at least burning the attacking plants.

"Cat! Dreya! Come quick!" the other called out. "It's gone all Day of the Triffids meets Dawn of the Dead out here!"

Zarinda had no idea what she meant by that, and neither, apparently, did Catriona, as she stuck her head out of a window.

"Are you doing movie references again?" she asked. What little Zarinda could see of her robes seemed quite dusty, and there was a black smudge on her left cheek. "You know we're not going to get those."

Then the druidess saw what was happening and called Dreya, whose own usually deep black velvet robes had turned decidedly grey. She joined her fiancée at the window and saw the aliens' plight. They had both abandoned their guns in favour of slashing with knives which, despite their small size, were highly effective.

More of the Black Tower's defences were awakening and advancing on their houseguests.

"I don't understand," Dreya frowned in puzzlement. "I haven't used my defences for years!"

Worse, she realised, some of them weren't her defences – they had been put there by Ulvarius.

"How is this possible?" she wondered.

She had destroyed most of those defences herself because, as she'd told Catriona when they'd first met, she wasn't insecure enough to jump at every shadow that passed across her land. But somehow, they were back.

"Concentrate, Dreya!" Cat rebuked her, gently. "Rescue now, reason why later, yes?"

Dreya shook her head as if to clear it of distractions. "Yes, of course. Sorry."

She immediately teleported them both to stand with the aliens and defend them.

Taking in the sight of their friends, one of the aliens asked, "What have you been doing? Fighting a horde of dust monsters?"

Dreya shook her head. "Just clearing out my junk room."

"It's going to be the nursery," Cat explained further.

Zarinda could tell from the aliens' expressions that they, like she, thought that was the cutest thing ever.

Following their betrothal, the two of them had enjoyed their own private celebration in the bedroom. Then, since sleep seemed to elude them both, they had been up half the night working on the nursery project. While Dreya had been sorting, Cat had been

cleaning the walls of years of dust and dirt, including one particularly stubborn scorch mark that was proving tough to remove even with magic. Dreya had no idea how it had come to be there; presumably, a legacy from an Ulvarius temper tantrum, three hundred years ago.

"Like you said, Cat," Dreya put in. "Fight now, chat later, yes?"

Cat conceded that they needed to focus.

"You sort out the plants and calm the weather, and I'll tear down these defences. Again," she added with an annoyed frown.

Her fiancée nodded her agreement.

Then the onlooking Zarinda got the shock of her life as an image of the Dark sorceress loomed over her.

"And you go and find someone else to spy on!" boomed the image. "You're very distracting!"

With a squeal, Zarinda shot up and ran home. OK, so maybe she was a *bit* scared of Dreya, and perhaps the sorceress considered her a pest and a nuisance now. But she was sure that one day, when she was older, Dreya the Dark was going to rescue her and say those three beautiful words:

"I need you."

Chapter 4

Freed from the distraction of that Faery princess, Dreya could focus on getting her grounds' defences back under control. That was the theory. In practise, even now they wouldn't respond, refusing to recognise her authority and stand down.

Moving on to Plan B, it was clear she was going to have to fight them and tear them down for good, this time. She'd beaten the Black Tower's fortifications in five minutes when she'd just finished her apprenticeship. Given the power and expertise she had gained in the intervening years, she didn't expect them to pose much of a challenge to her now. She just needed to concentrate. Unfortunately, she hadn't found that quite so easy, lately.

She tried to call for her elite guards, but there was no response from them, either. It was as if they'd disappeared.

Choosing to go straight to blood magic, she pricked her finger on her dagger, not trusting the flowers in her garden. The pain was minimal, but it did help sharpen her mind. As she did so, some of the plants grew, tendrils snaking out to snare the approaching undead.

"Thanks, Cat," Dreya smiled. It had bought her a little time.

"Hmmm?" Cat wondered, tearing her gaze away from the stormy sky that was refusing to lighten up. Seeing what Dreya was referring to, she did a double take. "Nothing to do with me," she admitted.

"Actually, love, it was me," Jessica spoke up. "Seen you do it enough times, Cat, I thought I'd have a go. Some of our people were supposed to have had nature powers before the dragons took over and the last few days here, I've been practising."

As she spoke, the undead fought free of their restraints and resumed their attack.

"Looks like I need to practice a bit more," she added, regretfully.

Cat tried the same thing herself. The vines held for longer, but ultimately the result was the same.

"It's not you, Jess," she promised, shaking her head. "Something's resisting my magic. I can't get the sky to behave, either."

Giving up, she turned to her fiancée. “Looks like it’s up to you, Dreya.”

The Black robe sorceress drew in her power, channelled it through her blood and unleashed it at the undead, hell hounds and demons that had begun to appear, all the while shielding them all against the wizard magic that assailed them from all sides with increasing power and ferocity. Her shields held, but her offensive spells seemed weakened, somehow. She was keeping the attacks at bay for the moment, but she couldn’t honestly say she was winning. She stepped things up to power words, which helped, but as her magic grew in power, the defences powered up, too.

“I’ve got an idea!” Cat declared, suddenly.

“One of your ridiculous radical ones?” Dreya asked.

The druidess shook her head. “No, it’s a perfectly sensible one.”

“Oh dear, are we that desperate?” the sorceress wondered, worry creeping into her voice.

“I think so, don’t you?”

“Yes,” Dreya sighed, “I suppose we are. Go on, then, what is it?”

“Blanket the place with an anti-magic field. It won’t stop you or me in here, but it might stop that lot out there.”

“Genius as always,” Dreya agreed, and did as her fiancée suggested.

Both were quickly attuned to the magical frequency of the field, so their spellcasting was unaffected, but the attacking magic was unable to penetrate for the moment. Now they needed a way to get on the offensive.

“What about those beam cannon blasts of yours?” Sara spoke up. “Like what Daelen used to use.”

Dreya pulled a face, which Cat silently interpreted as, ‘*I think we want to regain our home, not blow it up.*’

But Sara’s words had had an effect on the sorceress.

“Beam cannon blasts,” she repeated. “Higher planar energy.”

“What?” Cat asked.

“Reach out and sense it,” Dreya coached. “Analyse the power assailing us.”

Cat did as she asked and realised what her fiancée was getting at.

"The defences are partly powered by higher planar energy. But I don't recognise the signature. It's not Daelen's or Kullos' or yours."

As she spoke, she tried to throw up ice walls, using water from the pond, to create choke points, so Sara and Jessica could focus their attacks on the undead and demons with their dragonclaw daggers. Anything to buy time while they figured out what was going on.

"It can't be another shadow warrior," Dreya insisted. "There aren't any."

Cat agreed, "But who else could know anything about combining higher planar energy with magic and use it against you in your own home?"

They had been paying so much attention to the ground that they hadn't noticed the continually darkening sky overhead. Cat had given up on trying to control the weather around them. Helping with the trouble on the ground had seemed the priority, but now it was impossible to ignore the unnatural deep darkness.

Dreya glanced up, a worried look growing on her face.

"But this is how the Black Tower looked years ago before I took it." Something was very wrong here, and Dreya went cold as a theory formed in her mind. "Cat!" she gasped, "I think I know what's happening!"

Before she could explain further, a colossal figure materialised out of the darkness and towered over them. It was wearing tattered Black robes, which parted just enough to see a skeletal body.

"Congratulations, fools!" it hissed. "You have trespassed in Ulvarius' lands. You are the first ever to make it this far, and Ulvarius shall reward you. There shall be no release of death for you. Instead, you will serve Ulvarius, becoming part of the Black Tower's defences. You shall know no rest, nor rescue, for you belong to Ulvarius, now and forever!"

Cat held in her hand a vial of sand, so Nature's Mirror was standing by, ready to reflect whatever might penetrate the anti-magic field.

Dreya wasn't scared of Ulvarius' magic, even with higher planar energy on his side. She had the power to destroy him, but it would require nothing less than what she did when she conquered the Chetsuans' homeworld, Phitonia. The sorceress really didn't want to reduce her home to a crater in the ground. Cat may have rebuilt wizards' towers before, but that was after a careful, controlled reshaping, not total obliteration. Besides, as she'd told her fiancée, she knew what was going on, and this wasn't really where the problem was. Everything that was happening at the Black Tower was a symptom of a much larger issue. That needed the Guardians. All three of them.

Sara and Jessica were valiantly keeping the attacking undead warriors, demons and other hellspawn creatures off their backs, and a combination of Cat's druid magic and Dreya's anti-magic field were blocking the direct magical attacks. That left Dreya herself free to act.

First, she needed to check something, urgently. "Cat, please tell me you've got your notebook on you!"

"In my pocket dimension, same as ever."

"Get it out now. Just in case you can't access your dimensional magic later."

"Why wouldn't I—?" she began, but the sorceress cut her off.

"Trust me."

"Always," the druidess agreed and retrieved the book.

As soon as Dreya saw she had it in her hand, she opened a Prismatic Sphere portal and ushered the Chetsuans through it. Before sending Cat through, she asked, "Can Mandalee make her own portals yet?"

"She's been working on it," Cat replied.

"Good enough," Dreya acknowledged and called for the White Guardian, sympathically.

'*Portal. Catriona's Meadow. Emergency.*'

With one final blast of magic to keep everything back from the portal, Dreya followed Catriona through to the other side.

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The instant Dreya materialised in the lush, green expanse, she closed the portal. A moment later, another portal flared open – just briefly – then it flickered and died.

Dreya glanced at Catriona and rolled her eyes.

"Give her a chance," Cat admonished her fiancée. "It took me a few goes at first, too."

The portal reopened, this time seemingly more stable, and the White Guardian dived out of its mouth, colliding with Dreya and sending them both sprawling to the ground.

"Thanks for breaking my fall," the assassin offered with a scowl, standing and closing her portal.

"Do that again and that won't be the only thing that gets broken," Dreya threatened, also regaining her feet.

"Bring it on, Dreya," Mandalee replied, refusing to be cowed. "Any time. Now, what the hell have you done?"

"What have *I* done?" Dreya protested. "What makes you think I've done anything?"

"Come on, it's obvious something's gone really wrong with Time, so I'm guessing it was either you or Cat and I'd rather blame you!"

"Is this how it's going to be, then?" Dreya asked, indignantly. "Something goes wrong, you automatically think it's my fault?"

Mandalee shrugged. "Might as well assume the obvious until I can rule it out!"

"Charming!" Dreya spat, through tight lips. "Good to know where I stand, I suppose."

"Well, what do you expect, stealing my best friend away from me again!" Mandalee demanded, hands balled into fists by her sides, seemingly a breath away from going for weapons.

As they stood there, glowering at each other, Cat stepped forward to intervene. "Hey, you two! What's this about?"

She couldn't understand where this had come from. They'd been getting along fine. Had whatever had affected the Black Tower done something to them, too?

Then their expressions changed, smiles broke out, and Cat realised she'd been had.

"You're winding me up!" she gasped.

Dreya nodded.

"That was too easy!" Mandalee laughed. "We came up with the idea at your betrothal, yesterday."

"I can see I'm going to have to keep an eye on you two if you're going to be conspiring against me like that."

"You'll learn to love it," Mandalee asserted with a hug. Stepping back, she asked, "Anyway, how's your first day as an engaged couple going?"

"It *was* going fine – we were starting on the nursery."

"Aww, that's great!"

"Then Dreya's grounds decided to attack us."

"Ooh, that's bad!" Mandalee sympathised, then her eyes widened in realisation. "Wait – *that's* why you called me?"

Dreya nodded and explained what had happened, including the return of Ulvarius.

"Dear gods, we can't have him running around again!"

"Of course not," Cat agreed. "That's why we need you."

"Hold on," Dreya put in. "Why did *you* think we called you, Mandalee?"

She was about to answer when she noticed something very wrong with Jessica and Sara. As she looked on, Jessica was suddenly violently sick, while the dark bluish-purple skin of Sara's face turned green. Then she fainted.

*****

The moment the Chetsuans had arrived in Catriona's Meadow, gentle reader, everything had felt wrong. They couldn't see the others properly. It was like they were there and not there at the same time, though that made no sense. They seemed to flicker and blur before their eyes – everything in that place did. They could hear conversations, but they couldn't understand the words. It was as if they were all jumbled up and coming out on top of each other.

They tried to move or speak, but they couldn't.

They saw Mandalee look their way. She had always been looking their way. She had never looked their way. Everything was in contradiction. Their bodies couldn't cope with it and suffered an acute reaction.

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Rushing to their side, Mandalee tried to heal them, but she couldn't. That's when she remembered, "This place is Timeless. Healing magic requires a temporal element! Their body functions need time, too – this place is killing them! Why did you even bring them here?"

"Things were happening so fast out there," Dreya replied, regretfully. "I guess I didn't stop to think." She cursed herself. Why hadn't she thought of this? It wasn't like her to not think things through, no matter how pressing events might be. She really was finding it so much harder to concentrate. '*Control,*' she told herself. '*I will keep control.*'

"Besides," Cat put in, inadvertently coming to Dreya's rescue, "we needed to get here, and I'm not confident enough for us to open two portals close together. I dread to think what might happen if they accidentally touched."

"The question now is where can we safely send them?" Dreya wondered. "Earth?"

"We can't just abandon them on another world!" Mandalee objected.

"How about the Council?" Cat suggested. "Justaria will look after them, I'm sure."

"What!" Mandalee was incredulous. "You mean, you don't know?"

"Know what?" asked Cat.

"That's why I thought you'd called me."

"Time!" Dreya gasped, repeatedly snapping her fingers as she remembered. "You said there was something wrong with Time! Why did you say that?"

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When she received the call, Mandalee was showing Windell some of the sights of Walminster. Shyleen was with them, too, of course. As they walked, Mandalee suddenly felt cold, as if a dark shadow had passed over the city…or perhaps across her soul. In the blink of an eye, the city changed. Some of the changes were subtle, but one thing was obvious: the beautiful Council building that had stood for more than three centuries, now lay in ruins.

She stopped a passing wizard who, bizarrely, was wearing green robes, and asked what had just happened to the Council building.

He looked at her as if she'd just asked, 'Since when was water wet?'

"It's always been like that," came the reply.

"Why did you want to show me this old ruin?" Windell asked with a puzzled frown.

Before her brain had formulated a response, she noticed an information plaque in front of the ruin. It read: *THE COUNCIL OF WIZARDS: THE FAILED EXPERIMENT*.

It went on to explain that the first Council had been formed to try and stand against the brutal tyrant, Ulvarius. They had failed, and the experiment was never repeated.

Mandalee wasn't particularly well versed in wizarding history, but she knew that was very wrong. Still, the truth was undeniable: there was no Council. There never was a Council.

'*Shyleen?*' she asked her leopard friend. '*What's going on?*'

'*I don't know,*' she replied. '*But I think this is probably the kind of thing the Guardians were created to fix.*'

'*You're right, as always,*' Mandlee agreed, stroking her head. She was just about to call Catriona, sympathically, when she got an urgent message from Dreya. She assumed she was calling about the same thing. '*Look after Windell for me, will you?*'

Shyleen promised she would, and so Mandalee opened a Prismatic Sphere portal…or at least, she tried to.

*****

"The rest you know," Mandalee concluded.

"Things are worse than I thought," Dreya worried.

"Never mind that!" Cat admonished her. "We need to take care of our friends first."

"Maybe it'll have to be Earth, after all," Mandalee considered.

"No, wait!" Cat cried. "There's one other person who might just be unaffected by the temporal changes. Mandalee – any idea where we can find Michael?"

"Yes!" she replied emphatically. Thanks to her friendship with Windell, she knew exactly where the demigod was. Concentrating hard, she opened a portal. "Come with me."

Dreya levitated the two Chetsuan girls through the portal, exiting last. On the other side, she found herself standing next to the ruins of the ancient temple that stood on the border between the Corolis Wood and the Rhynas Desert over on the continent of Northern Alloria. This had served as the rendezvous between Daelen StormTiger and Ossian Miach Kaidool – Michael – before the final push to fight Kullos' army a few weeks ago. After laying Daelen to rest, he had been rendered homeless. His old tomb had to remain sealed to protect the fallen shadow warrior, and besides, it had never been a living space. For reasons best known to himself, he had decided to make this old temple his new home.

Seeing the shimmering blue portal open, he came to greet his visitors.

He was immediately concerned about the Chetsuan twins that floated out with the Three Guardians and rushed over to see if he could help.

"What happened?" he asked.

"Timelessness didn't agree with them," Dreya answered as Cat and Mandalee put their healing skills to work. She then briefly outlined the situation.

"But how?" Michael wondered. "What could make Time go so wrong?"

"Yes, I'd like to know that, too," Cat agreed, helping Sara to her feet. She was still a bit disorientated but recovering well. Cat encouraged her to take slow, deep breaths and lean on her.

Jessica had stopped retching and was likewise relying on Mandalee for support. "Blimey, what the hell happened to us?" she asked.

"I'm afraid we've proved that only the Guardians can live within our Timeless zone," Cat explained.

"My mistake," Dreya admitted. "I was so busy trying to take you out of danger that I didn't realise I was taking you somewhere worse." Turning to Mandalee, she asked, "Are they OK?"

"They will be," she nodded.

"Sorry to barge in on you like this, Michael," Cat offered, belatedly.

“Not at all, my dear. You are welcome at any time.”

The druidess looked around at the ruins, except now they didn’t look like ruins so much as a construction site.

“You know I can shape stone with my magic, right?” she reminded him. “I could rebuild this place in no time.”

Michael shook his head.

“Thank you for the offer, but I prefer to do the work myself. I’ve been in this world for centuries, and yet I’ve never had the opportunity to create anything before. It feels good. Besides, it gives me time to think about what I might do with my life, now that I have one.”

“OK,” Cat accepted, “but any time you want a hand, I’m happy to help.”

“Anyway,” Mandalee put in, “sorry to break up the chat, but can we get back to why Time’s so screwed?” She turned to Dreya and counted off her points on her fingers as she added, “Also, while I’m asking questions: How is Ulvarius back? Why did your grounds attack you? And how come the Council that I just joined, now never formed?”

Chapter 5

Before answering, Dreya asked Cat to open her notebook to the page where six sets of portal co-ordinates were written.

As you will recall, gentle reader, during their fight with Kullos, Dreya and Mandalee had combined their efforts to shatter the shadow warrior's dimensional control device into fragments. It had taken virtually every drop of strength and power the two young women possessed – shadow warrior technology did not break easily. Kullos, in an act of petty defiance, had managed to open half a dozen Prismatic Sphere portals simultaneously and send a fragment through each one.

Aunt Dreya had done her best to track the destination of each portal, but there had been so much Temporal magic flying around that, ironically, there hadn't been much time. The notation had been largely instinctive as she scribbled them in Cat's notebook and she wasn't sure how accurate they were, but they represented her best effort and frankly, I defy anyone else to do even half as well. Even in my time.

Since then, the three of them had finished off Kullos, ended the war with his army, used a unique combination of magic and technology to give Aunt Mandalee the female body she'd always dreamed of, endured endless Council meetings, ratified the Guardianship, and Aunt Dreya had proposed to my mother.

In short, gentle reader, they'd been busy, and so they hadn't yet found time to even think about the lost control device fragments. Now, it seemed, Time had caught up with them.

Dreya looked over her notes and pointed out one particular set of co-ordinates. "Work out the date on that one."

Cat analysed the sympathic impression they were giving her and answered, "That would be about three hundred and twelve years ago."

She gasped, her eyes widening as the implications hit her, but Mandalee got in first.

"Right at the heart of Ulvarius' Reign of Terror. Are you saying a fragment of a shadow warrior's dimensional control device flew out of a portal and landed at his feet?"

"I'm afraid so, yes," Dreya confirmed.

“Hang on, slow down,” Sara spoke up. “For the benefit of those of us who aren’t from around here, who’s this Ulvarius bloke and why is it such a problem if he gets one of these fragments?”

Dreya explained that Ulvarius was generally regarded as the most dangerous renegade wizard of all time, a terrible tyrant and the only former owner of what was now Dreya’s home.

Until Aunt Dreya came along, gentle reader, he had been the most powerful wizard in known history, being the first to harness the interplanar forces from above the mortal plane, rather than those below. Those above were more potent, and it had taken an unprecedented co-operative effort to stand against him. Though the wizards of the time didn’t manage to stop him at the famous Battle of Compton, they did force him to retreat. Even that much was viewed as a great victory, and that success was a critical event that led to the formation of the Council of Wizards. It proved the value of order and co-operation in magic.

“A single fragment of a shadow warrior’s dimensional control device would grant access to higher planar energy,” Dreya continued. “If Ulvarius got his hands on it and learned how to use it, his power would grow massively.”

“Correct me if I’m wrong, Dreya, love,” Jessica put in, “but you can use higher planar energy with your magic, can’t you? So why did you have to retreat from your home?”

“Because fighting his power with mine, besides destroying the Black Tower, would devastate half of Gaggleswick and probably take a good chunk out of Sylfrania. When I took the Black robes, I swore to myself I would do things differently. Yes, I want power, but I won’t be a tyrant, I won’t cause mass devastation.”

“Besides,” Mandalee added, “from what I’ve already seen, taking back Dreya’s home in the present would be treating a symptom, not the cause.”

Cat nodded. “There’s a new Timeline in effect, overwriting the one we fought so hard to create to save Tempestria.”

Dreya explained further, “Three hundred and twelve years ago, a portal opened. Ulvarius found what he probably thought was a fragment of a magic sword. That gave him more power, the co-operative effort failed, and so the Council was never formed. Maybe he still killed himself in the end, or maybe not, I’m not sure of the details of the new Timeline. The presence of his lich form

suggests he probably did, but either way, I can be certain of one thing: In this new Timeline, I didn't have the power to take the Black Tower for myself when I'd just finished my apprenticeship. That's why Ulvarius' defences are still intact. I never went there to tear them down. That's also why I don't have my elite undead guards anymore: I never took the Black Tower, so those forces were never sent to attack me, so I never killed them."

"And those are just the changes we know about," Cat pointed out. "There could be a million other consequences."

"Without the aid of the Council, did you still stop Kullos?" Sara wondered.

"Is Daelen still dead?" Jessica added quietly, still feeling his loss.

"We can't be sure," Mandalee admitted.

"This is why the Guardians were created," Cat explained. "It's our job to fix things like this. We're Timeless, so even if our personal Timelines change, we're protected from its effects."

Mandalee took up the thread. "But we won't be Guardians forever, and whenever we decide to hang up our timepieces, there can't be any major contradictions in our own Timelines."

Dreya nodded. "Otherwise, the Guardians might not form at all, and a paradox like that would weaken the fabric of reality, perhaps allowing *IT* a foothold."

"Which could unmake everything," Cat concluded.

Sporting a cheeky grin, Michael pointed out, "These Timeline changes can't affect me. As a demigod, I'm above it all!"

Dreya rolled her eyes. "Well, I wouldn't put it quite like that, but in essence, Michael's right. That's why we brought you here, so you'll be safe."

"Woah there!" Jessica objected, an annoyed look on her face, wagging her finger. "Just you hold your horses, love! What do you mean, 'safe?' When you took the last of Daelen's power, did you absorb some of his personality, too, because you suddenly sound a lot like him!"

Sara backed her sister up, saying, "My sister's right. When we came to live here, we never asked for 'safe'. We weren't safe riding those dragons, blasting Kullos' army with our laser guns and we weren't safe when we were holding Kullos' throne room against all comers, waiting for you to come back."

"No, we weren't," Jessica agreed. "You can't just park us by the side of the road out of the way when things get rough. We can help."

"Admirable sentiments, both of you," Michael approved. "Come to that, I'd quite like to feel useful myself. After over a thousand years fighting by Daelen's side, I'm hardly a stranger to protecting Tempestria. If it's in danger again, you can't expect me to just stay here and build my house, and these two obviously don't need a babysitter. Let us help you."

"We know you can take care of yourselves," Mandalee assured them, "but I'm not sure how you can help in this case. Not if it involves Time Intervention."

"Ah, but what about the other fragments?" Cat wondered. "Do they all need Time magic?"

The sorceress shook her head. "Not all, no. In fact, there is one fragment that our two Chetsuan friends might be ideally suited to retrieve." She pointed one out to Cat, who nodded in appreciation of the idea.

"Now you're talking!" Jessica cried. "Where is it?"

"Lavos," Dreya answered.

"I'm sorry?" Sara asked, convinced she must have heard wrong.

She hadn't.

"Didn't you guys say you'd been there?" Cat checked.

Lavos was one of the worlds Daelen had frequented. One of the Prismatic Spheres in his portal room had led there. It was a world of technology where, conversely to the Chetsuans' homeworld of Phitonia, people hunted dragons.

The girls had indeed visited Lavos on several occasions. They even had a friend there, but they had never felt entirely comfortable there because of the dragons. Intellectually, of course, they understood that the dragons of Lavos were different from the dragons of Phitonia. They looked very different, for a start. They were about half the size and had only four limbs – their wings were extended from their forearms, whereas Phitonian dragons' wings were separate appendages to their four legs and attached to their backs. Lavosian dragons were clearly not the dragons that had tried to exterminate the Chetsuans. Lavosian dragons were in no way responsible for making Jessica and Sara genetic plague carriers –

biological weapons against their own people. Lavosian dragons were innocent victims of oppression and violence.

In that sense, Sara and Jessica had much more in common with them than the people who ruled there – even if they looked similar to Chetsuans. Even then, the situation wasn't that simple. The people of Lavos were diverse in their views on dragons. It was just that, the last time they were there, the anti-dragon political faction was in control. However, they remembered that during the time Cat and Mandalee spent on Earth, Daelen had taken a side-trip to Lavos, according to him, to put a stop to some genocidal plot against the dragons. Something similar to what had been done to Sara and Jessica. They had no way of knowing how that intervention had been received by the general population. They would only find that out when they got there.

"That's a great idea!" Mandalee enthused. "While we go back in Time and prevent the Ulvarius catastrophe, you guys can be off-world. Your knowledge of that world will help you where we wouldn't have a clue." It would also help to shield them from any consequences of Time Intervention on Tempestria.

"Even given the difference in Time flow rate," Cat pointed out, remembering that Time on Tempestria moved at about a quarter speed, relative to the rest of the mortal plane, "the fragment should only have been on that world for a few weeks at most."

"If we can find it, I'll recognise it," Michael asserted. "I know a shadow warrior dimensional control device when I see one, no matter what shape it might take or how many pieces it's in."

"But how are we supposed to find what looks like a fragment of a sword on an entire world?" Jessica wondered. "It's gonna be like…" She broke off to check, "Do you have an expression about needles and haystacks on Tempestria?"

Mandalee smiled. "Yes, we know that one."

"Well, it's gonna be like that."

"A magnet!" Sara piped up. The others looked at her strangely, so she clarified her seemingly random statement, "If you want to find a needle in a haystack, you use a magnet. They have some pretty good tech on Lavos. I could probably rig something up."

"Failing that, just ask around," Cat suggested. "If someone's found it, it's bound to be having an effect."

"What kind of effect?" Jessica asked.

"Not the good kind," Mandalee answered.

Dreya backed her up, saying, "The two of us hit that thing with everything we had, just to get it to break up. Those fragments now contain a mix of different forms of magic as well as higher planar energy."

"A bit like my staff," Cat put in, "except in those fragments, the mix is bound to be highly unstable and the trip through a portal won't have helped matters."

"Plus, even before that, it had just been in the middle of a massive Heaven's Surrender explosion," Michael added. "It's imperative that we collect all the fragments and bring them together in stasis in my old tomb."

Mandalee agreed, "Otherwise, we'll be partly responsible for any harm those fragments might cause."

On a practical note, one last thought occurred to Dreya.

"Michael," she began, "did Daelen ever show you his Prismatic Spheres?"

Jessica snorted with laughter. "I don't think they had that kind of relationship, love. Not that I'm judging."

Cat didn't think Michael was physically capable of blushing, but he seemed to be giving it a good try. Clearing his throat, he replied, "He showed me how to open portals to other worlds, yes."

"Then I'd say we all know our jobs," Catriona concluded, "and I suggest we meet up back here when we're done."

There were no further questions, so each team simply wished the other luck, and opened their respective portals.

*****

After leaving the construction site of Michael's new home, the Guardians stopped off at their Timeless Meadow, once more, to decide on a plan of action. Typically, Mandalee had been keen to get right to the heart of the matter in Walminster, but she was persuaded otherwise.

"For a start," Cat began, "if we open a big blue portal outside the Council building, we're going to attract attention. That's the last thing we want to do."

Dreya agreed, “I’m sure there will be other Time Interventions where we can just dive right in, face down a threat and put a stop to it. This isn’t one of those occasions. If it were as simple as stopping Ulvarius, I could probably do it myself. There were plenty of isolated areas three centuries ago, where he and I could fight it out without collateral damage.”

“With the three of us and our Temporal magic,” Cat added, “we could tie him up in knots, no question, but that won’t fix history.”

“I suppose you’re right,” Mandalee admitted with a sigh of resignation. “This can’t be a victory for the Guardians; it has to be a victory for the people of that time so that they’ll realise co-operation and organisation in magic is a good idea.”

Cat nodded in agreement. “We have to tread lightly. Don’t worry, though, we’ll get to the fighting eventually.”

Before that, though, as usual, Catriona was keen to gather more information.

*****

Three hundred and twelve years back in Time, the Guardians’ Temporal portal opened in the grounds of a large estate in Ainderbury. It was almost the exact spot where, in their time, a young Faery princess liked to sit and watch the Black Tower. If it was a good vantage point for her, it would work equally well for them, too. The estate was empty. The owners had presumably either evacuated or been early victims of Ulvarius.

Dreya left the others almost immediately. The sorceress couldn’t be sure how far Ulvarius’ detection magic might extend, and she didn’t want her power levels to set off any alarm bells by straying too near her future home. Besides, it made sense for her to be the one to check on the progress of the wizards’ co-operative effort. She was used to cutting through politics and getting things done in her own time. No reason why she shouldn’t be able to do that equally well in the past.

Mandalee stayed with Cat. Together, they were going to use their different nature powers to spy on Ulvarius. Hopefully, they would get a sense of the signature of the control device fragment that they needed to confiscate. Their other job was to make sure the

tyrant didn’t get wind of Dreya’s attempt to get Council history back on track.

Chapter 6

Teleportation was a much more discreet way for a wizard to travel than using portals. Even in this age, wizards did it all the time. Certainly, nobody paid Dreya any heed when she appeared outside the Council building, which she took to be a positive sign.

In this period in history, the Council building was brand new, although nobody called it that yet because there was no Council. It was the Wizards' Forum. A place where wizards could gather to exchange views, air grievances, share ideas or just socialise. There was no formal organisation.

Before heading inside, Dreya decided to levitate up high, to try and see beyond the confines of the city. She noticed that the void storms seemed somewhat faded compared to how they looked in her time, but that observation was quickly swept away as she sent out her magical vision to see distant places as if they were right in front of her. What she saw was shocking in the extreme. Villages and towns were burning, having displeased Ulvarius in some unfathomable way, while his undead servants ruled others in his name. They weren't anything like as sophisticated as Dreya's usual elite guards, but they didn't need to be. They might appear to be acting as wardens, but Dreya thought they were more like jailers. Sometimes they brutalised innocent people, seemingly enjoying it, though the sorceress knew there was no way those creatures were capable of enjoying anything. It was just their master occupying them and using them as puppets. No-one was allowed in or out of these towns without Ulvarius' say so, which had disrupted trade, stemming the flow of food and vital supplies, costing more lives. Then there were the countless people who were enslaved and forced to walk perhaps hundreds of miles, under undead escort, to the Black Tower itself. There to be used for all manner of cruel and pointless magical experiments.

"And still people compare me to him!" Dreya grumbled to herself in disgust.

She didn't blame Mandalee for wanting to take matters into her own hands – Dreya was sorely tempted herself – but no, there was too much at stake for that. They had to stick to the plan to preserve the world they knew.

Dreya found it alarming that Ulvarius' influence in Elvaria should be as extensive as it was. According to the history she knew, that was wrong. That told her Ulvarius had found a way to use the unstable power of the control device fragment. He had been an intelligent and capable wizard in his day. That's what made him so dangerous. Dreya knew he wouldn't have hesitated to tap into that power when it presented itself.

*****

Aunt Dreya's assessment, gentle reader, was only partially correct. What she didn't yet realise, was that her Temporal co-ordinates were slightly out. It was understandable: At the Fall of Kullos, in a state of utter exhaustion, she had been forced to try and analyse and record the details of six portals at the same time, while still keeping a close eye on the battle to save Tempestria. Plus, she was new to this Guardian business, and there were many things she didn't yet understand about Temporal magic. Knowledge, skill and technique don't appear overnight. She had done her best to interpret the sympathic sense of the co-ordinates of Kullos' portals and done a far better job than anyone else could have in her age of magic. She didn't yet know that portals caused a kind of Temporal lensing that make past events seem closer than they really are. Learning these things takes time, and this was practically the Guardians' first day on the job. A job that no-one had ever done before. The first Intervention that took place significantly in their past. Frankly, getting as close as she did was nothing short of genius.

When she found out, Aunt Dreya wished she and the others could just go back in time and try again, but she knew from the *Chronicles* that the Guardians' Temporal magic doesn't work like that.

For one thing, by the time she realised, it was too late because she had already interacted with people in that time. Besides, every time the Guardians opened a Temporal portal, there was a risk of being noticed, which could create ripples in history. Doing so more than necessary, created problems that were best avoided.

Even had they interacted with no-one and they could guarantee no-one had noticed their portal, the Guardians had arrived where they were thanks to specific co-ordinates. Those co-ordinates acted like a sympathic lighthouse, shining through Time, guiding them. Just as teleportation requires a clear image of one's destination, choosing to go off the beacon to *assumed* co-ordinates was asking for trouble. They'd done it before, of course, but that was just a matter of a few hours back in Time to a destination they knew would be completely empty. Weighed against the certainty of the end of the world if they didn't, it had been a risk worth taking. But they couldn't risk going back significantly into the past without specific co-ordinates.

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Landing once more, Dreya entered the Forum. Once inside, she took a moment to get a sense of the system they used in this century. Unlike in her time, there were no seats. Mages just stood around, talking among themselves, perhaps or perhaps not listening to the main speaker. That main speaker was identified simply by standing on a box. When that spokesperson was finished, people were free to discuss what had been said – or not – and then the box was passed freely to someone else who might address the previous speaker, or move on to another topic entirely, as they chose.

It was a bit disordered for Dreya's tastes. In her time, the day's agenda was pre-determined, although there was always time allocated for any other business that might arise. Besides, in Dreya's experience, many things were determined outside the main Council chamber, and the formal proceedings were a way to confirm what had already been decided. Some might call this corruption. Dreya called it 'making sure things get done.' The Faery sorceress had learned to wield political power with the same control and precision as her magic. The key difference was that she had no desire to become the 'Greatest Politician Who Ever Lived'. In fact, she could scarcely imagine anything worse. That's why she had rejected the Triumvirate post even though it could be hers at any time. Far better to have the Black robe leader firmly under her control. It was a long leash – most of the time she didn't care what

Laethyn did – but when she needed his support on something, she would grab that leash and pull him close to heel.

Three hundred years in the future, it was a system that worked well. Here and now, Dreya would need to learn to play the game differently. She didn't know anything about the mages here, beyond the obvious that their power could be no match for hers. In a way, she supposed this was how Daelen must have felt when he was surrounded by mortals. Dreya couldn't afford the shadow warrior's attitude, though. The fact was she needed them, and they needed each other. She couldn't let them need her. Not overtly. When the time came to confront Ulvarius, she could help in subtle ways, but she couldn't stand out too much, or she would rob these people of their victory, and through that, their belief in themselves and an ordered system that worked so well for her in the future.

There seemed to be a lull in the parade of speakers. The box currently lay with a group of about thirty wizards and sorceresses in the middle of the high-domed, horseshoe-shaped chamber. At the centre of this group was a large man who appeared to be in his early forties. He was over six feet tall, with a muscular frame that spoke of either a rugged lifestyle or a healthy fitness regime. Breaking with convention, this gregarious individual stood with only one foot on the box, an elbow resting comfortably on his knee as he regaled his audience with a tale of how he had stood up to a group of Ulvarius' undead puppets that had trespassed on his land.

Standing there in a loose-fitting white shirt, black trousers tucked into tall boots, a red cloak fluttering due to magic, as if in his own personal breeze, and a sword hanging from his belt, he fitted the image of a swashbuckling buccaneer more than that of a wizard. Still, Dreya could sense the magic in him, and his power level was not to be underestimated. The tale he was telling of using both steel and sorcery against his enemies was flamboyant, but Dreya didn't doubt that at its core, it was the truth. If he were living in her time, she suspected that his magic would be a match for Laethyn. While that might be a far cry from her own power levels, there was a reason why Laethyn had risen to Black robe leader in a system that involved so much infighting.

The man before her had a look about him that impressed Dreya – and she didn't impress easily. His style wasn't an act, but it was a cover. The look in his eyes reminded her of Mandalee.

They were the eyes of an assassin. As far as Dreya could tell, he had no quarrel with anyone in that room, and yet she suspected that, should it prove necessary to protect his life, he would deal with that threat quickly and efficiently.

This was a man she could do business with, she felt, so she wandered over to join him and his group, hopeful that he might be open to discussing the Ulvarius problem.

She supposed she ought to start by introducing herself. It was no conceit to say that she hadn't needed to do that for a long time – her reputation always preceded her. But that reputation wouldn't exist for another three centuries. On the back of that thought, she decided she'd better avoid creating that reputation too soon, by shrouding her real power levels and using a false name.

"Good day," she began, stepping up to the group before her. "I'm Darla," she lied. "I've just arrived from Sylfrania, and I was hoping to use your speaking box for a moment, to talk about our tyrant problem."

They all ignored her like she was nobody.

'*This century is a bit humbling*,' she thought. Just as she was about to try again, one wizard shook hands with the fellow with the sword and walked away, giving Dreya a shock in the process.

The wizard was wearing brown robes. Dreya knew enough history to realise that the Triumvirate system wasn't in place yet, and allegiances beyond the Three were commonplace, whereas, in her time, non-aligned wizards were rare. Druids were a different story, as they often saw the Council as nothing to do with them – a view that had been reflected and perpetuated by the wizard-centric system that was in place. Dreya hoped that the reforms she had brought about, along with the increasing fame and popularity of Catriona Redfletching, would change that.

Still, what shocked her about this man wasn't his clothes, it was the fact that he walked right through her.

Shock aside, it did explain why everyone had so far ignored her: they couldn't see or hear her. She was like a ghost. How were the Guardians supposed to affect anything in the past, if they couldn't interact with it?

Then she remembered seeing something in the *Chronicles* about this. Interactive versus observational time travel.

"Of course!" she cried aloud – she might as well say it aloud – after all, nobody could hear her. "The Guardians' Timeless state protects them from Timeline changes," she quoted, "and conversely, protects the Timeline from their inadvertent interference."

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In other words, gentle reader, when the Guardians are out of their native time zone, their Timeless state renders them invisible and incorporeal, so they can observe freely and plan their actions with precision. To implement any measures, however, they must close their link to Catriona's Meadow and enter the native Timestream.

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Dreya used her enhanced sympathic link with Catriona to communicate the concept before cutting off her Timeless connection.

The group before her gave a collective start when Dreya materialised in front of them.

"Where in the world did you come from?" asked the man with the sword, stepping back off the box in surprise.

She could see that look in his eyes grow in intensity as his mind tried to think how he might deal with her if she proved to be a threat. She vaguely wondered what he might come up with but put that thought to one side in favour of taking control of the situation in front of her.

"Sorry," Dreya apologised. "Didn't mean to startle you. I just teleported in."

"Didn't look like any teleportation spell I've ever seen," a Black robe sorceress remarked.

Dreya hadn't considered that – she had assumed that dropping her Timeless state would make her materialise in much the same way as teleportation, but she couldn't know for sure, because she'd obviously never seen it for herself.

Trying to cover it, she replied, "Just a bit of a flourish – a personal touch. I'm always telling a…" she hesitated, "…good

friend that she has a flair for the dramatic. I guess it's starting to rub off."

She decided not to say 'girlfriend' or 'fiancée' because she knew attitudes towards same-sex relationships were not what they were in her time. Three centuries of progress meant that almost nobody ever batted an eyelid about it. (As Mandalee could attest – prejudice relating to gender identity, on the other hand – was taking somewhat longer to extinguish than sexuality issues.) However, Dreya was here to stop Ulvarius doing damage to history, not strike a blow for diversity. She had to choose her battles. Hopefully, if they could restore Time to its former course, the rest of history would attend to itself.

"I'm Darla," she offered once more. "Just came over from Sylfrania." She held out a hand to the sword-wielding wizard.

He stepped forward and grasped her hand in both of his, shaking it vigorously. "Dagamir's the name!" he boomed, enthusiastically. "Dagamir the Third."

Dagamir. Dreya had a feeling she had heard that name before, somewhere, but she wasn't sure where or even if he was the same Dagamir that she was thinking of. Being where she was, she could hardly look him up in the history books – they hadn't been written, yet.

"Good to see one of the Faery over here," he rumbled. "Need more of your kind. Always saying so," he stepped back to his casual stance, one leg perched on the box, and called out, "aren't I, my friends?"

His group all eagerly backed up his claim, but Dreya suspected they would probably do that whether his words were true or not. Dreya could see how he used his outgoing personality to gather these mages around him.

Definitely a man she could do business with.

In fact, he made her job easier. To bring these wizards into line against Ulvarius, she needed only to win over this Dagamir. The rest would follow him. She could already tell that threatening him as she did Laethyn was not the way, here. She needed him to like her, not fear her, and the best way to do that was to give him what he desired most: attention. He was a man who craved the spotlight. That suited Dreya just fine. She was content to remain in the shadows next to him.

"Well, Dagamir, sir," Dreya began, "I was hoping to discuss the Ulvarius problem. Two friends and I were just in a fearsome battle with some of his forces."

She knew some of her Black Tower's defences had left a few marks, which would help to sell this. The state of her robes was predominantly the result of redecorating, not battle, but these people didn't need to know that. Let them assume what they would. Lying went against the grain for her, but here and now it made strategic sense. Already, she could see some of the wizards nodding, accepting her story.

"We fought them as long as we could, took out many of them, but then Ulvarius himself showed up, and we had to make our escape, abandoning our home in the process."

That much was true, at least.

"I'm sorry to hear that, Darla," Dagamir sympathised. "Just before you appeared, I was telling my friends about a similar encounter I had defending my home against his minions."

"Were you really?" Dreya remarked, maintaining the illusion that she'd only just arrived.

"Indeed I was, wasn't I, my friends?"

Dagamir's thunderous voice was answered by an even louder cheer. Dreya wondered if he was going to do that all the time.

"Fortunately, my story had a happier ending," he allowed, "because I got my home back. For now."

"I'm glad for you," Dreya told him. "I came here intending to borrow that box under your foot, to try and rally support, but I fear the Speaking Box is not tall enough for a small Faery to be noticed. What I need is someone who knows how things work around here. A familiar voice that people listen to, and above all, someone who knows how to get things done. A natural leader."

"What for?" asked a wizard in White robes.

"To stand against Ulvarius, of course," Dreya replied.

"That's suicide – he's invincible!"

"No-one's invincible. You just have to know how to fight back."

"Nobody has that kind of power," a Black robe wizard insisted, "unless you want to go and ask Daelen StormTiger for help!"

The others laughed at that idea. Dreya noticed Dagamir did not. He was doing what Red robes – or Red capes, in his case – did best: gathering knowledge. He wanted to know what 'Darla' knew about Ulvarius that made her so sure he could be fought, and he was sussing her out at the same time.

As soon as her response entered her mind, Dreya had to hide a smile. She could well imagine Catriona's reaction if she could hear her.

"Power isn't everything."

Chapter 7

Aunt Dreya tried to channel my mother as she spoke those words, gentle reader, and given the way it seemed to grab people's attention, it was clear that she'd succeeded.

"Even Daelen and his kind aren't invincible," she continued. "They'll get theirs eventually, I'm sure of it. But right now, they are neither the problem nor the solution. Ulvarius is the problem."

"And are you the solution?" Dagamir asked.

"No," Dreya insisted. "I think you are. All of you. All of *us.* Together, I think we are the solution."

Giving her a shrewd look, however, Dagamir surmised, "But you have something, don't you? That's why you came here. You have something, or…" he paused, considering, eyes narrowing, "…or you *know* something. That's it, isn't it?"

Dreya hadn't expected her audience to pick up on that so quickly. She hadn't been trying to hide it, of course, but neither had she left it in plain sight. That might be suspicious. She was definitely going to have to keep an eye on Dagamir.

"You're right," she confirmed, allowing her real surprise to creep into her voice. "I do know something, but the knowledge is no use to anyone without support from as many wizards as possible."

Dagamir stood down from the box, yet somehow managed to appear taller in the process.

"At last!" he cried, his voice rising to reverberate around the hall. "Someone who wants to do more here than just tell stories!" The other wizards ceased their own conversations and turned towards Dagamir. The fact that he wasn't using the Speaking Box didn't matter. All eyes were on him. "Listen to me, you lot!" he announced, unnecessarily. "This young Faery just lost her home to Ulvarius, after a pitched battle against the undead army and even Ulvarius himself!"

The assembled mages gasped on cue.

"I, too, had to repel invaders this morning – that's the third time this week! How long before I lose my home? How long before we all lose our homes? We need to fight back – I've said that many times, haven't I, my friends!"

The cheer was louder, this time.

"Now, I confess that even I could not see how to do that," he continued, "but Darla here," as if on some unspoken signal, his circle of friends parted to give everyone a clear view of the Faery woman in their midst, "has come to us with vital information.

"Darla?" he prompted in invitation.

She climbed onto the Speaking Box. She knew some people could be persuaded by the simple observance of such customs. She thought before she spoke, determined to stick as close to the truth as possible. Not just for her usual reasons, but also because she wasn't familiar with this time, so it would be all too easy to get caught in a contradiction if she lied.

"As you can see," she began, "I'm Faery. Specifically, Sylfranian Faery. My home is about as close to the Black Tower as you can get. From there, I can send out my magical senses and spy on Ulvarius. You can imagine the owner of the Black Tower does not appreciate that!"

Some of the other mages chuckled at that.

"From my observations, as my friend Dagamir says, I've learned something vital." Her claim of friendship would help to win more people over. "Tell me, did anybody notice Ulvarius' sudden upturn in power, recently?" She kept the time frame deliberately vague.

Several people murmured that they had indeed noticed.

"I remember it well," Dagamir agreed. "Happened, what, a couple of weeks ago, I'd say, yes?"

Again, the crowd agreed.

"I thought it was damned peculiar at the time. I mean, Ulvarius was a threat before that, but then, overnight, his power shot off the charts. Are you saying you know how that happened?"

She nodded thoughtfully. This was where she needed to be careful. "He has some kind of magical totem that he carries with him at all times."

"What does this totem look like?" Dagamir asked.

"Well," Dreya considered. She knew Kullos' complete control device was in the guise of a sword, but she had no way of knowing whether this fragment was from the blade or the hilt. "It's a metal shard," she replied, finally. That description would fit either way. "As if it's broken off from something and somehow

been imbued with strange power." She hoped that was specific enough to sound like she knew what she was talking about, but vague enough to fit whichever fragment this one was.

"You're right, I've seen it!" declared a woman in the audience, standing out in robes of hot pink. "Just as you describe."

Dreya had hoped others might have seen it. Having locals back up her story would definitely help her cause. "When was this?" she asked.

"If your timeframe is right, it couldn't have been more than a couple of days after he got it. I remember his powers faltered for a moment and he got annoyed with this shard as if it was somehow its fault."

That made sense, Dreya thought. Early days. He must still have been experimenting with how to use higher planar energy in conjunction with his wizard magic. Even for her, it had taken time and practice.

"Yes, I've seen it, too," confirmed a wizard in White robes – one of Dagamir's inner circle of friends. This was precisely what Dreya had hoped for. "I think it might even be a fragment of a bladed weapon. A dagger or even a sword like yours, Dagamir. Again, his power seemed to falter, as if he couldn't keep it under control."

"If this shard is truly so important, why haven't more of us seen it?" a sceptic demanded.

Dagamir spoke up in defence, "Let's face it: most who get in his path don't live long enough to tell tales about it."

Others murmured their agreement.

"Besides," Dreya put in, "I suspect he mostly keeps it hidden, now. Probably worried about too many wizards noticing and doing exactly what we're doing, now."

"Darla's right, Dagamir," the Black robe sorceress by Dagamir's side said softly.

"What makes you think so, Sephora?" Dagamir wondered.

Dreya noted the exchange with interest. The way they used each other's name and shared a certain look – a look she had seen on Catriona's face when she said 'Dreya' in her own special way. She thought the name Sephora was familiar, too, vaguely. Dreya wondered if perhaps they were a famous magical couple from this time. Although why she would have paid any attention to that over

the years, she couldn't imagine. Love wasn't something she'd ever really thought about until she met Catriona.

"Only yesterday," Sephora was saying, "I ran into Ulvarius. Or rather he ran into me."

Dagamir's reaction of shock and concern confirmed Dreya's theory about them.

"Why didn't you tell me?" he demanded. "Are you alright?"

Sephora nodded and reached out her hand to caress his arm. "I'm fine. I didn't want to worry you."

"If you don't mind, Sephora, could you tell us what happened?" Dreya asked gently.

The sorceress swallowed nervously, but agreed, "Of course," she replied. "First, I should explain that I specialise in using magic to manipulate metal objects."

"Interesting," Dreya remarked. She couldn't imagine anyone in her time specialising in such a narrow field, but this was still very much a time of experimentation and discovery for wizard magic. Plus, wizards of the pre-Council era guarded magical knowledge jealously, which hampered progress. Nevertheless, Dreya was not going to underestimate Sephora or her abilities.

"When I used it on Ulvarius, this metal shard that we've spoken about seemed to cut its way out of a pouch on his belt, in response. It flew away from him, but he was pretty quick to run after it and grab it, I can tell you."

"Which suggests it's important to him," Dagamir mused.

Sephora confirmed it. "Lucky for me, retrieving that shard was more important to him than killing me. If I'd realised its value, I could have made it fly to me instead. As it was, I simply got away while he was distracted."

This was better than Dreya could have wished for. In Dagamir and Sephora, she had one wizard who was a natural, charismatic leader and one sorceress who had already relieved Ulvarius of his control device fragment once and could easily do so again.

"Would you be willing to have another go?" Dreya asked Sephora. "If we could take it from him, then his magic would be back to where it was before. Powerful, but ultimately beatable if you can work together."

The sorceress gave her a determined smile. “Get me in range with some decent shields, and I’ll do it, no problem. Like Dagamir says,” she added, taking his hand in hers, “it’s time we did more here than stand around and talk. We need to do something about Ulvarius and thanks to you, Darla, we have a way to hurt him.”

“Maybe we could use his own shard against him?” Dagamir’s white-robed friend suggested.

Dreya shook her head, emphatically. She had anticipated such an idea, and she needed to crush it quickly.

“From my studies, it seems unstable,” she asserted. “That’s why it’s so powerful but uncontrollable. It also means it’s liable to blow up in our faces if we try to use it. ‘*Power wielded in ignorance is dangerous, regardless of intent*’,” she quoted. She may be devoted to Dark magic now, but she had trained with Master Xarnas as a Red robe and understood the value of his Balanced teachings.

Dagamir looked impressed. “I like that!” he boomed. “That would make an excellent motto for the wizard group I’m trying to create.”

Dreya hoped there wouldn’t be some dire consequences of him gaining that from the future. She figured it would probably be OK, as long as Dagamir took full credit, and he seemed the type that would.

“If it’s going to blow up anyway, why not let it blow up and destroy Ulvarius and the Black Tower along with it?” asked the sorceress in pink.

Dreya was understandably not a fan of that idea, for several reasons – not all of them self-serving.

Thankfully, Dagamir’s white-robed wizard friend came to her rescue. “How long do we wait? And how much of Elvaria will be left when it happens?”

Dreya grabbed that seed of thought and nurtured it.

“It might explode tomorrow, or next year, there’s no way to know. When it does, I can’t even guess at how much damage it will do. That’s why I came to you today. Remember, I’ve been spying on him for some time, so I’ve had a better chance to study him and this shard than any of you. I know I can dispose of that shard safely, but I need your help to take it from him in the first place. Even after his shard is gone, Ulvarius will still be a threat, but if we can at

least make him run back to his Black Tower and lick his wounds for a while, other wizards will see that he's vulnerable and they will come here."

"Then this place could start to mean something, Dagamir!" Sephora gasped, with infectious enthusiasm. "Just like you've said. Just like we've dreamed! This could be the start of a properly organised system of magic. If we get this right, we can lay the foundations of the future. Our names will live in history!"

"I think you're right," Dreya agreed. Maybe that was where she'd heard the names: two of the Founders of the Council. She'd never really paid attention to things like that. She was interested in the history of magic as a whole, not individual mages.

Dagamir swept Sephora up in an enormous embrace. "Always the visionary!" he exclaimed. Breaking the hug, he subjected Dreya to a handshake so vigorous, she thought he was going to pull her arm off.

"Thank you, Darla. I can't begin to estimate the value of the information you've given us, but to make it truly worth anything, we need to act on it."

His attitude was compelling as he once again addressed the company of assembled wizards.

"Friends!" he bellowed, "I've always said we need to talk less and act more. Haven't I always said that?"

The crowd cheered.

"Well, finally, we have a clear idea of *how* to act. We can stop Ulvarius, rob him of this unstable power of his and set a course for the future of magic!"

The cheer was louder this time.

"These are troubled times, my friends, but our troubles will soon be behind us if we can just work together to forge the future! I've wanted to see co-operation in magic grow for a long time. Haven't I always said that?"

The noise level was enough to raise the roof, Dreya thought. It would never be tolerated in her time, but here and now, it was a marvellous thing to behold.

"You all share that view – that's why you helped me create this Forum. Now it's time to take things a stage further. Now it's time to show the world just what magic can do if only we band together, each with our diverse, individual talents, working as one.

Together, we can end Ulvarius' reign of terror and light a beacon that will blaze a trail into the future and last forever!"

The crowd was so loud, now, that Dreya had to discreetly cast a spell to muffle the sound and protect her sensitive Faery ears. While she was at it, she shielded the entire building with sound-dampening magic. There was no telling what powers of detection Ulvarius might have, and she didn't want him descending on them here and now.

"Friends! Are you with me?"

The crowd was in such a frenzy, now, that Dreya thought they'd probably agree to do just about anything Dagamir asked. She stepped down from the box and almost unconsciously, Dagamir instantly took her place, still holding Sephora's hand while holding his sword aloft with the other.

"I said: Are you with me!"

Somehow, the crowd managed to grow even louder.

Dagamir stepped back down from the box, and the assembled mages took that as a cue to be quiet and listen carefully as he dropped his voice. He certainly knew how to work a crowd.

"Then let us make plans," he urged them, "starting with where to confront him."

"I vote not the Black Tower," Sephora asserted. "No point giving him home advantage."

Dreya quickly agreed, again for many reasons.

"Do you have any suggestions, Darla?" Sephora wondered.

Dreya found herself briefly distracted by activity in her head, so it took her a moment to recognise her assumed name, but she covered it by appearing to consider the question.

"Well, I'd say not here, either," she offered. "We want this building to be a beacon for the future, not a pile of rubble that gets caught in the middle of this battle."

"I definitely second that motion," Dagamir concurred, "but perhaps close by, so that this can serve as an assembly point *prior* to the battle?"

"Or a refuge for those who need protection," his white-robed friend suggested."

Things were beginning to shape up nicely in line with the history Dreya knew. She knew exactly where this battle was fought – everyone would remember for the next three hundred years and,

she was willing to bet, a thousand years beyond that. But she had to remain in character, and she didn't think a Sylfranian Faery from this age would have detailed knowledge of every human village in this part of Elvaria.

Therefore, she asked, "Does anyone have a map of the local area?"

Dagamir's white-robed wizard friend volunteered to fetch one from an adjoining study room.

"Thanks, Hodge," Dagamir acknowledged.

Now, that name Dreya was certain she'd heard before.

Hodge of the Light, Sephora of the Dark and despite his attire, Dagamir was definitely aligned with the Balance. The first Triumvirate, perhaps?

She made a mental note to do more research in future, before travelling to the past. She was sure Cat would come up with a way to make essential records Timeless. Still, for now, Dreya would simply have to work with what she had, keep the broad brushstrokes of history as they should be, and hope history could take care of the fine details by itself.

Hodge unfurled the map of the Walminster district, and Dreya made a show of studying it, letting her finger hover over a few places before settling on what she knew was the correct answer according to the history books.

"How about here?" she asked, pointing to a nearby village.

"Not bad," Hodge mused. "That could work nicely."

Dreya carefully explained her choice.

"I thought it looked like a small rural settlement, close by, not too many people I would guess?"

"Excellent reasoning," Hodge approved. "They're quite pro-magic there, as well. They'll probably be pretty easy to evacuate."

Sephora summarised their choice. "They can evacuate for us, or they can wait until Ulvarius enslaves and slaughters them."

Dreya found herself warming to her. Frankly, she felt she could do with more mages like Sephora on the Council in her time.

Making a show of scanning the map, she read, "Compton village."

In truth, in that age, it was little more than a hamlet, with only a few families living there. It would grow substantially over the next century, but for now, even the offending '*FaerWay*

Tavern' didn't yet exist. It was tempting for Dreya to stick around in the past long enough to see to it that the name changed, but she supposed that would be an irresponsible use of time travel. Besides, it wouldn't do any good to change the name. What needed to change was people's attitudes so that names like that would be a thing of the past. That would take more than Time magic.

"The Battle of Compton," she mused. "Has a good ring to it, don't you think?"

Dagamir grinned and agreed it did.

Dreya felt another piece of history slot back into place. She was getting the hang of this Time Intervention business. Still, Hodge wondered how they would get Ulvarius there when they wanted him.

"Is there some way we could 'leak' our plan to Ulvarius?" Sephora suggested.

"Well, we can't just roll up and tell him," Dagamir mused. "He'd get suspicious."

"Leave that to me," Dreya offered. "I'm not working alone. If you lot can assemble in Compton and evacuate the place quickly, my friends will be only too pleased to send him your way."

Chapter 8

Meanwhile, gentle reader, from their concealed vantage point overlooking the Black Tower, my mother and Aunt Mandalee watched as yet another group of slaves were escorted to receive Ulvarius' tender care. Aunt Mandalee had been growing increasingly restless with every batch, and now she'd had enough.

Pulling a pair of swords from the scabbards on her back, she stood and declared, "No more."

"Mandalee, get down!" Cat hissed in warning.

In theory, while they were still in their Timeless state, they were undetectable. But given Ulvarius' own power plus what he had gained from an unstable fragment of a dimensional control device, she didn't want to chance it.

"Come on, Cat!" Mandalee shot back, refusing to do as she was asked. "You can't really be OK with this. Those are innocent people being taken to him in his Tower."

"You think I don't know that? Of course I'm not OK with it, but this is history. This happened. We can't go changing history because we don't like it."

"Why not?" Mandalee demanded. "This isn't some grey area where we can't be sure who's in the right. This is clear cut: Ulvarius is evil and those people, whoever they are, don't deserve what he has in store for them. I accept that we can't go in there and kill the bastard ourselves for the sake of history, but that doesn't mean we can't rob him of some of his victims."

Cat was torn. She could see her friend's point, but she was still worried about impacting history more than they had to.

"We can't predict the outcome of our actions here."

"Sounds just like every other day of our lives to me," Mandalee countered. "I know we can't save everyone, but surely every person we rescue is a victory."

"Is it, though? What if, because he doesn't get person A, he kills person B instead? Isn't that on us?"

Mandalee was adamant in her response, "No, it's on him."

"But what if somebody dies who's supposed to live, or somebody lives who's supposed to die?"

"You didn't worry about that when you created a whole new world to try and save it," Mandalee pointed out.

"That wasn't me, that was the other me. The one from the original Tempestria."

"Like you would have done anything different in her place!" Mandalee scoffed.

Cat flushed. Her friend was right, and she knew it. She would have done the same thing, but surely that was different, wasn't it?

"She – I – only did that because it was the end of the world, otherwise."

"Cat, every person out there who is going to die today – for them, this is the end of the world."

Cat laughed, incredulously, "So you're going to fight death now, are you?"

Mandalee wasn't laughing. "Isn't that what living is? Isn't that why we saved the world from Kullos? Don't you think that's why I fight at all? Of course I'm fighting death, and of course I'm going to lose in the end, but that doesn't mean I'm going to stop fighting. Every day I live is a victory against death. Every time I save a life, that's a victory, too."

"What about when you kill?" Cat blurted out before she could stop herself.

She didn't even know why she'd asked – she knew better than that. She cringed away from the look of shock and fury in her friend's eyes, bracing herself from the onslaught that was coming.

"I take life in defence of life, Cat," Mandalee seethed. "I thought you understood that! I kill those who seek to take the lives of innocent people. By killing those people, I am saving lives. I act in the name of their victims, past and future. You know that!

"You've killed, too. Those clerics that used their entire congregation, including children, to attack you. You ended their lives because not doing so would have been to allow them to abuse more innocent people. Then there's that prisoner you tortured – you still haven't explained that, by the way – so don't you dare start questioning my morality!"

"I'm not!" Cat protested.

"No?"

She hung her head. “I didn’t mean to,” she promised softly. “I’m sorry. Of course, I know why you kill, and you’re right – about that and about the morality of this situation. We should help, obviously we should. It’s just…I never thought it would be like this, our first job as Guardians. I thought we’d have had long discussions with the Council, laid down the rules. I don’t like going into a situation, not knowing the rules.”

“Rubbish!” her friend scoffed, not buying it. Cat looked up at her, doing her best to meet her friend’s gaze. “How many times did you make up your own rules when we were up against Kullos?”

“That’s different,” Cat refuted. “I didn’t have time to sit and wait like this. Time to fret. Time to worry.”

Mandalee narrowed her eyes as she studied Catriona’s face. A face she knew better than her own – literally, given the way it recently changed along with her body. Sheathing her swords, she crouched down opposite her.

“Nope,” she shook her head. “Still not buying it. It’s closer to the mark, but it’s still not right.” She reached out to her friend. There was something wrong, and Mandalee was determined that it was her job to find out what it was. “Third and final chance, Cat,” she insisted. “What’s really going on?”

Trembling, Cat let out a deep sigh. “He wanted to kill my baby,” she whispered.

“What?” Mandalee gasped, unable to process what she’d just heard. “Who did?”

“That man I tortured. At first, I thought he was being controlled. There was definitely another presence inside him, but it wasn’t controlling him. It was more like a passenger, encouraging him to do it, but not forcing. He wanted to do it. Can you believe that?”

She burst into tears at the horror of the memory.

Mandalee held her friend, her own tears flowing in wordless shock and sympathy.

“You want to talk about killing to protect the innocent? Well, that’s why I did it. He actually wanted to slaughter my unborn baby.”

“But you didn’t even know you were pregnant then,” Mandalee protested, unable to grasp the concept.

"He was from the future," Cat explained. "I don't know how, but he was. He knew. As for me, I didn't know whether he was right about my being pregnant or delusional. It didn't matter. His intent was the same either way and cutting my belly open with those claw weapons would have made the question academic."

Mandalee continued to hold her friend close and rock her gently. "But he didn't succeed. You stopped him, and he won't get the chance to hurt anyone ever again."

Cat pulled away. "But that's just it – I didn't stop him!" she insisted. "That other being did. The figure with the white aura."

Mandalee didn't see the difference. "He was stopped either way. Surely that's what counts."

Cat smiled, ruefully and shook her head, telling Mandalee there was something she wasn't seeing.

"Have you looked in a mirror since I changed your body?"

Trying to lighten the mood, Mandalee quipped, "Are you kidding? I have to look every day to make sure it was real, and I didn't dream it all. Besides, how do you think I did my make-up this morning? It doesn't apply itself by magic, you know." She paused and considered that. "Actually, do you think it could – you know – with the right magic? Because that would be awesome."

Ignoring Mandalee's question, Cat qualified her own. "Have you checked your reflection as the White Guardian, while Timeless?"

Mandalee scratched her head, considering that. "No," she admitted. "I don't think I have."

Cat stood up and motioned for her friend to do the same. Then, the druidess put her hand in her pouch of sand, sprinkled some in the air and worked her magic to conjure a full-length mirror. She gestured for Mandalee to look.

The White Guardian had no idea what her friend was driving at, or what any of this had to do with her reluctance to save people in this time. As a healer, though, she knew that often a patient would guide their own treatment. Before she could help anyone else in this time, Mandalee first needed to help her friend, so if looking into a mirror would somehow help Cat, then that's what she would do. When she finally did, she instantly turned away. She couldn't believe what it was showing her, but when she looked again, it was the same vision. Somehow, her image was that of a

figure floating in the air, glowing with a white aura. Not quite the same as what she had seen by Catriona's side that day, just before the final push to fight Kullos' army, but close enough to remove all doubt.

"How long have you known?" Mandalee asked.

Cat stepped around to stand in front of the mirror herself, and Mandalee could see her reflection was similar, only with an aura of red.

"Known? Since I saw your reflection in the river in my Meadow," Cat replied. "Suspected? Since the moment it happened. I mean, come on – a figure in white materialises out of nowhere to stand by my side and protect me when I need help more than ever? Who else would it be? It had to be you. It's always been you. Even though that one time I wasn't there for you and Shyleen, you've never once failed to be there for me. Why would the future be any different?"

"So, let me get this straight," Mandalee breathed, trying to wrap her head around it. "One day, when I get a lot more powers than anything I have now, I'm going to travel back in time to that moment and save you?"

"Not just to save me," Cat told her. "To save your niece."

"Niece?"

"Or nephew," she added as an afterthought. "Either way, you'll be an aunt."

"Technically, I'd have to be your sister for that," Mandalee pointed out.

Cat looked genuinely puzzled at that, as the mirror returned to the sand that created it. "You *are* my sister," she insisted. "How are you not my sister?"

"Biologically?" the White Guardian smiled, mischievously.

Cat snorted, derisively. "Like you weren't biologically female? Screw biology. You're a woman, you're my best friend, and you're my sister, and yes, one day, you will travel back to protect us. But not if you get yourself killed here, trying to protect people who are already dead, according to history."

Mandalee wasn't unsympathetic, but she couldn't let Catriona's fears stop her. "Cat—"

"—Yes, I know it's selfish," she interrupted. "But there it is. I'm scared, Mandalee."

Finally, the White Guardian felt like they were getting to the heart of why her friend seemed so paralysed and unwilling to act.

"When I rushed recklessly into danger before, I was only risking myself," Cat continued. "If I do that now, it's not just my life on the line; it's the life of your future niece or nephew, 'Aunt Mandalee'."

Mandalee took a deep breath and let it out slowly. She got it. How could she not? Cat wasn't afraid for herself, but for her child. How could she criticise? Her friend was right – *of course* she would travel back in Time to protect them both. As for what Catriona did to that man – he was threatening, even delighting in the idea of murdering a pregnant woman to slaughter her unborn child. How could any response be considered extreme or unjustified against that? But despite her future self's efforts, that incident had left a scar. Not a physical one – the would-be foetus murderer hadn't laid a finger on her – but a psychological one.

Mandalee supposed things had been too full-on immediately after that incident for Cat to dwell on it. Then after revealing her pregnancy and the downtime between the fall of Kullos and this morning, relatively speaking, she had obviously been thinking about it.

But this wasn't Catriona. Not really. This wasn't the person she had befriended years ago, stuck naked in one of her demon traps. The person who'd spent two days running around as a Trickster just to get her hands on a book with a tarnished reputation. The Catriona she knew and loved – her best friend, her sister – she was full of ridiculous radical ideas. That was who she was, and after helping Mandalee find her true self, she wasn't going to let Catriona shy away from being the bright, vibrant young woman that was *her* true self.

After a moment, the assassin felt she had her argument straight in her head, and began, "Forget that this is the past, for the moment, and forget about time travel. Can you do that?"

Cat nodded.

"Now, imagine the future. Your personal future. A future in which you've long since given birth and your child isn't a child anymore. They're all grown up."

"They do that so fast, these days," she sighed, wistfully.

Mandalee had to hide a smile to prevent things from getting off track. “Just imagine your future child is about our age.”

Again, Cat nodded and closed her eyes, trying to focus. She sucked at visualisation – seeing pictures in her head. She wondered if it was related to the fact that she didn’t recall dreams or even remember having dreamt at all. But she did her best to pretend to herself that she could see the future that Mandalee was describing.

“In front of his – or her – eyes, he – or she—”

“Let’s go with ‘she’,” Cat suggested. “Easier on the pronouns.”

“Alright,” Mandalee agreed. “*She* sees a group of innocent people being taken away to be tortured and killed by a terrible tyrant. Let’s say an evil shadow warrior.”

“Impossible,” Cat objected, her eyes snapping open. “There aren’t any more shadow warriors.”

“Just go with it, OK?” Mandalee implored her.

Cat held her hands up in surrender. “OK, OK. Sorry. Evil shadow warrior tyrant. I’m imagining, I’m imagining!” She closed her eyes again. “Go on.”

“Right, well, she can’t get at the tyrant because he’s too well protected, so what *does* she do?” Mandalee asked.

“She does what she can,” Cat answered. “She saves as many lives as possible while she gains the knowledge and power to stop him permanently.”

“What if that’s somehow against the rules? What if there’s some messed-up law that means she can’t interfere?”

“Then she’s like, ‘Screw the rules. Screw the law. Doing the right thing is more important to me’.”

“What if there are unforeseen consequences?”

“Then she’ll face them. But right now, at this moment, she’s going to help those people.”

“Really?” Mandalee shot back, acting scandalised. “Where do you suppose she picked up that kind of reckless attitude?”

Cat smiled and opened her eyes. She could see what her friend was doing. “From me, I hope.”

“And how are you going to teach her that? By sitting here and refusing to help because you’re worried about whether it breaks some rules, or it’s against some messed up law of Time, or you’re scared of possible future consequences?”

Cat shook her head. “No,” she insisted. “I’m going to show her by doing what she would do in my place – I’m going to help.”

“But we might change the future!” Mandalee protested. “People might die who lived before.”

“And I’m sorry for that, but I’m not a god or an Angel. I’m just a simple half-Faery druid girl who’s going to do her best to deal with what’s in front of her.”

“People might live who were supposed to die,” Mandalee objected.

“And what’s wrong with that? They’ll be alive. Isn’t that good?”

“What about future consequences?”

Cat grinned. “Screw them! I’ll deal with them later. For now, I’m doing the right thing.”

Mandalee shook her head. “No, Cat. *We* will deal with the consequences – just as we’re going to deal with what’s in front of us – together.”

She held out a hand to her friend, but Cat was having none of it.

“As you once told Dreya, ‘Screw the handshake.’” She hugged her friend tight. “Thanks, Mandalee. You’re the best.”

“Hey, don’t squeeze too tight,” the assassin warned her. “You’re carrying my future niece in there!”

“It’s OK, she’s tough,” Cat assured her, breaking the embrace. “Don’t you know? She just saved a whole bunch of people from an evil shadow warrior in the future!”

“Did she really?”

Cat nodded. “I saw it all so clearly. She was awesome.”

“Of course she was,” Mandalee stated as though it were obvious. “She’s your daughter.”

“And your niece!” Cat reminded her. “She reckons she’s got the best aunt ever, you know?”

“Really? In that case, I think it’s about time we did something to earn our future reputations, don’t you?”

“Definitely,” Cat agreed.

As one, then, they dropped their connection to Catriona’s Meadow, let go of their Timeless state and entered the local Timestream.

Ulvarius' undead army was escorting another batch of victims to the Black Tower, but Ulvarius was about to be disappointed. His endless supply of living test specimens was hereby cut off.

First, though, there was one more thing Mandalee had to do. She deftly lifted a bottle of beer out of a pocket and downed it in one.

"I always drink when I'm on duty, remember?" she said, answering Cat's unspoken question. "Besides, I'm about to interfere in the past for the first time. There's no way I'm doing that sober."

Chapter 9

Before the two friends got stuck in, Cat pointed out a problem.

"I know we basically just said, 'screw the rules', but I think I'm going to have to veto your outfit."

Mandalee was wearing one of the combat suits that Daelen had given her while on Earth. It was lightweight, durable and magic-resistant. It was also three centuries ahead of its time, which made it too great a risk to the Timeline. Catriona's red robes were no problem, of course, but she was keeping her staff firmly tucked away in her pocket dimension. From her research on *Shifting Stars* and associated texts, she knew her Angel was due to appear any day now and use the staff to do whatever it was they were trying to achieve. Cat couldn't risk doing anything to potentially disrupt that. Neither did she want Ulvarius to set eyes on it. The same thing applied to Mandalee's combat suit.

"Don't worry," Cat assured her friend. "I have one of your old leather outfits in my pocket dimension. You can do a swap."

She thought she might need to do a bit of shapeshifting magic on it, to account for Mandalee's new body shape, but that was simple enough. The druidess opened her pocket dimension and, true to her word, pulled out the familiar white leather.

Reluctantly, Mandalee agreed to change.

As she removed her combat suit, she asked, "By the way, I've often wondered, how do you keep track of what's in your pocket dimension?"

Cat laughed. "I don't!" she admitted. "I keep thinking one of these days I should pop in and have a good spring clean."

"Is that safe?" Mandalee wondered, frowning.

Cat shrugged. "I didn't suffer any ill-effects from being inside the one in Calin's Tower," she reminded her. "Like I said, it just looked like a perfectly ordinary night sky inside. I'd just need to be tethered to someone I trust," she looked pointedly at her best friend. "I mean, I wouldn't want to get trapped inside one when it closed up. I'm rather afraid anyone in that situation would be lost forever."

She shuddered at the horrifying thought, but dismissed the feeling, preferring to focus on the tangible threat in the here and now.

As Mandalee finished putting on her leather, Cat put the combat suit into her pocket dimension and closed it.

"Ready?" she checked.

Mandalee grinned, "Let's go and kick some undead arse!"

*****

The White Assassin burst out of hiding, her swords slicing into the undead guards that were escorting a group of slaves to the Black Tower. Cat supported her with bow and arrows. It had been a long time since she'd fought like this, but it was the most sensible approach. Mandalee wasn't using her super-speed or any of her clerical powers for the same reason: they didn't want to play their hand too soon.

Neither woman was worried about a handful of simple undead minions – they'd both faced down much tougher opposition. They weren't True Undead – Ulvarius hadn't mastered that magic yet – but he was bound to be linked to them, to some extent. They just couldn't be sure how deep that connection went. A melee fighter and an archer wouldn't stand out too much. After all, according to what Cat remembered from history lessons at magic college, people in this age didn't just stand by and let this happen. There was resistance, albeit limited. This was just another skirmish. The more mundane and ordinary their actions were perceived, the less likely they were to attract the attention of Ulvarius...or history.

On the other hand, if they were to encounter Ulvarius, the less he knew about what they could really do, the higher their chances of escaping unscathed.

Once the undead guards were dead – well, *deader* – the two friends didn't wait around for thanks. They just moved on and found another group. Between them, they had agreed on a compromise. They didn't actively help the prisoners, but merely killed their captors. What happened after that was not their concern. Nor did they plan to rescue anyone already in the Tower. It might be splitting hairs, but Cat thought that strategy would help their

actions be swallowed by history. She didn't know if there was any real basis for that belief, but she clung to it, regardless.

Job done, they needed to find the next closest group of would-be slaves. Not long ago, Cat would have shapeshifted to falcon form for some aerial reconnaissance, but now that was out of the question. Shapeshifting with a baby developing inside her had to be a bad idea. Still, there was a perfectly simple alternative solution: Mandalee was a Cleric of Nature. She could talk to the animals, enlisting them as her network of spies. Through them, she was receiving constant updates, so she could plan their next move. For so much of their quest to stop Kullos, Catriona had taken the lead, and Mandalee simply followed her. Now it was Catriona's turn to follow where Mandalee led.

They were fighting their fourth group of undead when they got a sympathic call from Dreya. She wanted to meet up at their original rendezvous to discuss her plan.

*****

"You want us to what!" Mandalee demanded, incredulously, when Dreya explained what she needed.

"It's the only way I can see of getting our hands on the control device fragment and putting history back on track," Dreya insisted.

"But Dreya," Catriona objected, "we've been trying to keep a low profile. Now you want us to attract attention from the boss himself?"

"Look," Dreya sighed, patiently, "I've got my side of things sorted out. An army of wizards ready to go – again – and I need you to play your part. You've said it yourself, Cat: Control the information, and you control the situation. We need Ulvarius to get this information, and we need him to believe it."

"We can't just knock on the door to the Black Tower and tell him," Mandalee put in. "He'd get suspicious."

Cat shook her head. "Doesn't apply – we'd never get through his grounds alive, anyway. No, much as I hate it, I think Dreya's right. It's the only way."

*****

The ‘only way’ in this case, gentle reader, was for Cat and Mandalee to get captured. The only people who could gain access to the Black Tower and Ulvarius were his undead guards and his prisoners. Since they had no wish to become the former, they were going to have to be the latter. Only then would they be in a position to sow the seeds of Ulvarius’ downfall.

*****

“What about a Mirror Image?” Mandalee suggested. Surely sending in magical copies would be safer, she thought, but Dreya immediately vetoed the idea.

“There’s too great a risk that the Black Tower’s defences would detect an anomalous magical signature.”

“Besides,” Cat added, “if Ulvarius were to suspect any subterfuge on our part…”

“…he would naturally distrust the information, which would defeat the object of this ridiculous radical plan,” Mandalee finished, clearly not happy about this idea.

“Hey!” Cat objected. “I thought you *liked* ridiculous radical plans.”

“I like *your* ridiculous radical plans, Cat,” she replied. “They have a strong pedigree. I’m just not sure about hers.” She cut off any reply, saying, “But I don’t have any better ideas, so I’ll do it.”

“Excellent, thank you,” Dreya approved. “Just be careful and look after Cat, OK?”

Mandalee smiled. “Of course. That’s what I’m here for.”

Dreya acknowledged that with a nod and teleported back to Walminster.

“OK, then,” Cat remarked, breezily, when she’d gone. “It’s time to stop playing nice. No more subtlety. We need to attract attention.”

“Yay!” Mandalee cried with mock enthusiasm. “Let’s get ourselves captured, enslaved and quite possibly tortured by the most dangerous tyrant in history, who’s even more dangerous than he should be. Sounds like a party to me. Dear gods, I need a drink.”

*****

Throughout the next few battles, they used plenty of unnecessary magical force.

Mandalee sheathed one of her swords, in favour of a conjured flame hammer. Her remaining blade she enchanted with her clerical powers as best she could, or rather she enchanted the socket gems that were embedded into the hilt. Everyone knew enchanting steel was impossible.

She missed her Pureblade so much. It had been the finest weapon she'd ever wielded. Sadly, it had shattered along with Kullos' control device and then, presumably, got sucked through the Cosmic Rift to be unmade along with the original Tempestria.

As they advanced on the undead that were escorting the latest batch of prisoners – Faery prisoners – on the edge of Sylfrania, Cat caused the foliage to grab and restrain their captors.

Mandalee had been practising her clerical magic, and that practice paid off now as she cast spells to ignite the air, send out jets of fire from her fingers and shroud them in fog, while giving herself and her friend catlike night sight. She paralysed the undead and disrupted the magic that animated them with Holy Water, which her friend replicated before there was any danger of running out. Holy Water wasn't really necessary because they weren't True Undead, just animated corpses, but it would cause them pain, which she hoped Ulvarius might just feel, too.

Cat ran on her Windy Steps and Rainbow Roads, smashing the skeletal warriors with super-dense air. Ice walls blocked them, ice shards severed their limbs at the joints, and the trees and plants not only restrained them but also pulled them apart.

Despite their new approach to their battles, they still maintained their policy of ignoring the pleas of those they rescued for further help in getting away from the area. There was always a chance they could be recaptured or even killed on their respective journeys, but the two friends were resolute in their belief that they needed to leave that to history.

Resolute, that is, until the children.

They numbered a dozen: human, Faery and one of mixed heritage. Cat had not expected that. Human-Faery couples were still rare even in her time, though there was a gradual, noticeable increase in that number. In this time, Cat believed they could tour

Elvaria for a year, travelling from place to place and still not find another half-Faery.

All the children were crying and shivering with both cold and fear. They were tired and dirty, their clothes ragged, their shoes worn out. They had obviously been forced to travel a long way.

Their undead guards were no more challenging to defeat, but when the moment came to leave, Cat just couldn't do it.

"We can't abandon kids," she insisted. "Adults, fine, they're old enough to take care of themselves, but here I draw the line."

"Why does he even want kids?" Mandalee whispered. "What does he plan on doing with them? Actually," she reconsidered, "I'm not sure I want to know."

Cat thought she knew the answer. She and Dreya had read Ulvarius' diaries, and this stuck in her mind for obvious reasons.

"If I'm right about who these kids are, then he wants them for their magic." Young mages were bristling with untapped magical energy that they hadn't yet learned to control, which was why Ulvarius favoured young victims. Cat estimated that this group were all between the ages of about ten and fourteen. Perfect specimens, ripe for the harvest.

To check her hypothesis, Cat knelt, so she was at eye level with the half-Faery girl and introduced herself.

"Hi, I'm Rose and this is my friend, Melanda," she lied, using the names from the books she had seen in Daelen's library. Books that were written by a kind of alternative future version of herself, far in the past.

"Call me Mel," Mandalee put in, kneeling beside Catriona.

Cat turned to her with a puzzled look. '*Mel*'? she mouthed, silently.

Mandalee shrugged. She wasn't keen on the name 'Melanda', and she was also concerned that, being so close to her real name, she might accidentally trip over her tongue and say the wrong one. 'Mel' removed that danger and although she'd just come up with it, she found she quite liked it.

Turning back to the half-Faery girl, Cat tried to reassure her, "Don't worry, we're here to help. Can you tell us your name?"

"Vashti," she answered quietly.

"Where are you from, Vashti?"

"Tedstone," she replied.

Mandalee recognised the name. In her time, it was known as Tedstone Warf, a cosmopolitan port town in South West Elvaria.

She had spent some time in that region, not long ago from her perspective. It was not far from Tedstone that she'd taken the contract to stop Daelen StormTiger destroying the world. The contract that brought her to the home of Justaria, where she ran into her old friend, Catriona. On horseback, Mandalee had travelled three hundred miles in two weeks. She suspected these kids had been forced to make a similar journey on foot.

More than ever, Cat was convinced that her friend was right. They couldn't stand by and let them complete their journey to the slaughterhouse of the Black Tower. History be damned.

Timidly reaching out a hand to trace the faint Faery spots on Catriona's neck, Vashti marvelled, "You're like me, aren't you?"

Cat smiled. "In more ways than one, I think. We're both half-Faery, and you have magic like me, too, don't you?"

Vashti nodded. "We're all at magic school together."

"Magic school?" Mandalee wondered. She'd had no idea there was such a thing in this time.

Again, Vashti nodded. "A few mages in the town got together and started it up. They thought we'd learn better if we could learn together. It's fun!" She broke off, and tears welled up in her eyes. "Until the monsters came and killed our teachers."

Cat reached out and hugged her close. "I'm so sorry this happened to you."

Vashti's story confirmed Cat's suspicions. Not wanting to scare the kids any more than they already were, she answered her friend's question sympathically.

'*Draining magic,*' and '*Draining blood.*'

Ulvarius intended to bleed them dry, both metaphorically and literally, robbing them of their magic and their lives. It was linked to his experimentation with blood magic and was partly why both White and Red mages in the early Council put a complete ban on any form of the practice. Ulvarius would bind his victims' wrists, suspend them, and then slice open a vein to let them bleed out, all the time channelling their magic though the spilt blood, enhancing it. The renegade wizard tried various methods to gain power from this, ranging from changing the polarity of his own magic to attract and absorb the magic from the blood, to bathing in

the blood to absorb it through the skin, and even drinking the magic-rich blood. The latter began the process that would see him ultimately turn into a lich, in which form he would 'kill' himself, and remain dormant in his grounds for the next three hundred years. Until a young Faery sorceress named Dreya came along and finished him off for good.

At least, she would if they could get the Timeline back on track.

Dreya herself used a form of blood magic, of course, but the only blood she had ever spilt for that purpose was her own. And then only one drop at a time. She also possessed a talent for draining magic and, more recently, higher planar energy. But she only took it from others in battle, or otherwise in defence of herself and those she cared about. Plus, she had developed Ulvarius' concept of power words – compressed magic that could be activated by a single word, with the intricate writing in the language of magic prepared mentally, in advance. Once again, she had achieved this through hard work, dedication and study, not by torturing others.

Unfortunately, Cat knew there were still those who saw only the similarities in the magic of Dreya and Ulvarius and not the crucial differences. Differences that were all the more apparent in this age: Dreya was trying to build a co-operative future for magic, through the fledgeling Council. If left unchecked, Ulvarius would destroy that future. Ulvarius wanted to grow his power by taking it from innocent people, and to destroy any potential challenge for the title of the Greatest Mage Who Ever Lived. Dreya wanted to nurture and develop magic in others. She would take from those who attacked her, yes, but she *wanted* to be challenged so that she could be the best of the best. Dreya's initial interest in Cat had been sparked because the druidess had offered the sorceress that kind of challenge. Their sort of magical attraction had led not to death, but to a whole new life. A relationship that Dreya had vowed meant even more to her than her magic.

And yet still people compared her fiancée to the worst tyrant who ever lived just because they happened to use some of the same tools. It was like comparing a chef to a serial murderer because they both used knives.

Well, this tyrant was not getting anywhere near these kids. Cat was adamant about that. She knew for a fact Dreya would agree and if history had a problem with that, then so be it. Mandalee was right. They had to do the right thing while they were here. They could deal with any future consequences later.

To further engender the trust of the young Vashti, Cat asked, "For me, it was my dad who was Faery. My mum was human. Was it that way for you?"

Vashti shook her head. "Don't have a dad. One of my mums is Faery."

"Vashti!" the boy next to her gasped. "You know you're not supposed to tell that to people outside Tedstone!"

Cat knew that in her time, Tedstone Wharf had a history of progressive social attitudes, but she hadn't realised that history stretched back quite this far. She was impressed.

"Mel and Rose saved our lives, Fumika!" Vashti shot back. "I trust them." Turning to Cat and Mandalee, she introduced him. "This is my cousin, Fumika. He worries too much."

"Well, your cousin might have a point," Mandalee cautioned. "Some people might have a problem with you having two Mums." She knew from personal experience how some people reacted towards those they saw as different. "But you can trust us."

Cat held up her left hand to show the ring that adorned the fourth finger. "Actually, see this? This is called an engagement ring," she explained. "It's a custom of a…faraway land I once visited, like a betrothal. It means I'm going to marry the person who gave it to me: my girlfriend."

"You and Mel?" Fumika asked.

The two friends laughed, "No," Mandalee shook her head, "I'm their best friend. I helped them get engaged, and soon I'm going to be an aunt because my friend Rose is pregnant."

The kids gasped at that. "Really?" Vashti wondered.

Cat nodded. "Really. So you see, Vashti, I think it's great that you have two Mums. My child will, too."

Through this common ground, Cat knew she knew they'd managed to get the children to forget their fears and trust them. But she still had the problem of what to do with a dozen kids three hundred miles from home. She and Mandalee couldn't keep them while they were hunting Ulvarius' minions, especially now they'd

abandoned their low profile. Robbing him of these kids would get his attention like nothing else, and he'd know about it soon if he didn't already. Time was short.

Mandalee could read her best friend well enough by now to know what she was thinking.

"Speaking of your fiancée, Rose," she put in, "do you think she could help? I'm sure her new friends could find a safe place for them."

Cat nodded. It made sense and truth be told, she was curious to see what Dreya the Dark would be like with children.

Chapter 10

Loath as Cat was to ask the exhausted children to walk any more, there wasn't any choice. Thankfully, their Sylfranian rendezvous wasn't too far and for the kids, relief at being rescued and curiosity at meeting the lady who was going to marry 'Rose' overrode their weariness for the time being.

Upon reaching the rendezvous, Dreya materialised out of the shadows, making the kids recoil in fear.

"Don't worry, it's fine," Cat reassured them. "It's just my fiancée, Darla. She won't hurt you. Sometimes she just likes to make an entrance."

"Yeah, I thought she was scary, too, at first," Mandalee confided, "but then I got to know her and she's actually really nice."

"Now, why don't you all stay with Mel," Cat suggested, "while I go and explain to my fiancée that leaping out at people and shouting 'Boo!' is not the best way to introduce herself."

The kids laughed at that.

"I did not shout 'Boo!'," Dreya protested as Cat took her to one side.

"Never mind, you've got plenty of time to work on being around children, and here's the perfect opportunity for you to get some practice."

"Cat, we're supposed to be stopping Ulvarius and getting history back on track. We don't have time for child minding."

"Dreya," Cat returned, "we're Guardians of Time. How can we not have time?"

Dreya rolled her eyes. "You know it doesn't work like that. This is a critical moment for magic and for our world. We're busy."

"And in a few months," Cat countered, placing Dreya's hand on her belly, "or however long it might be for my unique pregnancy, there will be another critical moment for magic and for our world. Even after that moment has come and gone, we'll still be busy people – probably saving the world from something – but we'll still have to make time for our child."

"That's different," Dreya insisted. "It will be our child. These kids are not our responsibility."

Cat let out an exasperated sigh and shook her head. “I’m not asking you to adopt them, silly. Just get them somewhere safe until they can go back home.”

“Why can’t I just portal them back to Tedstone?”

“Because we don’t know the situation there,” Cat answered. “Ulvarius kidnapped them once, what’s to stop him doing it again? I can’t bear the thought of them going through this ordeal a second time. Is their town even still intact? Are their homes still standing? Are—” she took Dreya’s arm and discreetly moved them a bit further out of earshot of the children. Dropping her voice to a whisper, she finished, “Are their parents still alive?”

Dreya’s eyes widened at that. Her own relationship with her parents may have been less than ideal, but she knew her fiancée had fond memories of hers before that Monster killed them. It was not surprising, then, that her thoughts would immediately turn to that scenario when she met these children. It didn’t come naturally to Dreya, but she knew she needed to learn to think a little more about these things if she wanted to keep her relationship with Catriona.

“You’re right,” Dreya accepted. “We don’t know, and we don’t have time to find out right now.”

“Exactly, because we’re busy. So, for the time being, just get them somewhere safe while we do what we came here to do.” Taking Dreya’s hands in hers, she looked her straight in the eye and asked, “Will you do this for me?”

Dreya smiled. She’d said it again: those six words. Six words that could only ever have one answer.

“Yes,” she replied, “of course I will, Cat.” Then, after a moment’s consideration, she continued, “In fact, I think we can use this to our advantage.”

Cat, recognising the subtle change in Dreya’s expression, declared, “Scheming face!”

The sorceress frowned in annoyance. “Am I that obvious?”

“Only to me,” Cat assured her.

“Well, you’re right, I do have a ridiculous radical idea of how to bait Ulvarius and protect both history and the kids at the same time.”

*****

“Finally finished snogging?” Mandalee called out when they returned. Turning to the kids, she encouraged them to join in the teasing. “That’s what we reckon you were doing, isn’t it, guys?”

“Yeah!” they all chorused.

“We were not snogging,” Dreya protested, “we were planning.”

“Oh yeah?” Vashti challenged, hands on hips “then how come you’ve got Rose’s lipstick on your face?”

“What? Where?” Dreya replied, bringing a hand to her face to search for it.

“Well, if you weren’t snogging, why are you trying to find it and wipe it off?” Fumika asked, pointedly.

Mandalee laughed and applauded. “Oh, I am loving this! The great ‘Darla the Dark’ tricked by a pair of fourteen-year-olds!”

“I’m fifteen!” Vashti corrected her.

Mandalee hid a smile. “Oh, well, that makes all the difference.”

“OK, there may have been one little kiss,” Dreya admitted. “Like this.”

She pulled Catriona close and, to her astonishment, kissed her full on the lips. Cat hadn’t expected such a public show of affection.

The children’s reactions were a mix of cheers, applause, giggles and “Aww!”

“OK, break it up, you two,” Mandalee grumbled, good-naturedly. “We’ve all got better things to do than watch you trying to eat each other’s face off, right guys?”

“Right!” they all agreed.

Dreya broke the kiss and Cat quickly composed herself. “Alright then, listen everyone,” she announced, “Darla’s going to open a portal. It’s like a big blue door that can take you somewhere safe, OK?”

They all nodded.

“It might look a bit scary, but it’s perfectly safe,” Dreya assured them. “It’s just a special kind of teleporting, really,” she explained. The advantage being that she could transport multiple people simultaneously.

Mandalee moved over to the sorceress and looked her up and down. “Actually, Darla, I have to say you’re looking a little tired to me. Maybe all these young magic students could help you?”

“Yeah, can we?” Fumika called out.

“What can we do?” Vashti wondered.

“Well,” Mandalee replied, as if considering. She beckoned Vashti over. “If you take Darla’s hand,” the girl did as she asked, “and then…Fumika are you the next oldest?” He nodded. “OK, you can hold Vashti’s hand,” he did so, “and then everyone else can hold hands in a line, from the oldest to the youngest.”

“Can you do that?” Cat asked the remaining ten. “It’s really important that you’re in the right order or the magic might not work.”

“Why, what are we going to do?” Vashti asked.

“You’re each going to give the person in front of you a little bit of your magic,” Mandalee explained, “and then all of those little bits are going to add up to a nice big magic top-up for Darla so she can open up a portal that’s big enough for all of you.”

As the kids busied themselves getting into the right order, Mandalee answered the puzzled look on Dreya’s face, whispering, “Relax, I’m not suggesting you *actually* take magic from them. Just pretend. Help them feel like they can do something to help themselves. It’s a lesson in self-empowerment and sharing at the same time.”

Cat joined them and asked her friend, “When did you get to be so good with kids?”

“I’ve always got along really well with kids.”

“I thought that was cats?”

Mandalee shrugged. “It’s both. You should see me play with kittens.”

The children were all in a line now, so Cat told them, “Well done, guys. Now, imagine the magic inside you is like…” she floundered for a moment, searching for an analogy. She smiled when she found it. “…like light in a box.” That was how Daelen had described his Shadowkin people. “You need to send out a little bit of that light to the person in front, and pass on the light you get from your friend behind you. Ready?”

The kids nodded; serious looks on all their faces.

"OK then, take a deep breath, picture the light in your mind and pass it on."

The dozen magic students had completely forgotten about their situation and the danger, now. They were just focussed on their 'lesson'. Each imagined they were giving a little of their magic to their friend, who was in turn passing it on up the chain to 'Darla' who, to her credit, made a show of 'feeling' that power.

It may not be real in the physical sense, but Dreya found it to be an intriguing idea. After all, she had learned to drain power from others. She had only done it in defence or, in Daelen's case, taken all he had left with his consent, but even then, it was her taking it. Might it then be possible to actively give it, instead?

Shelving that thought for now, she focussed on opening a portal.

"Well done, guys, you did it!" Dreya congratulated the kids. "I could feel your magic flowing into me. I can tell you're going to be really strong when you grow up if you keep practising your magic."

Dreya could see the idea take root in their impressionable young minds: Sharing their individual powers, co-operating together, they could grow strong and achieve goals. It was the Council of Mages in miniature. The very thing she had come back in time to save.

"See, Darla?" Mandalee prompted. "You're fine with kids. You just need a little practice."

Dreya gave her a smile of thanks, amazed that her friend had found a way to help a dozen lost and frightened children plus her relationship with Catriona, and add a new facet to her plans, all with the same idea.

"It's like we were saying about making time for the kids," Cat put in. "I know you're busy with preparations at your end, but in between times, do yourself a favour and play with them."

"I will," she promised, trying hard not to look terrified.

She was Dreya the Dark: she had taken the Black Tower in five minutes, conquered a world of dragons in a spare afternoon and helped defeat Kullos. Compared to that, how much trouble could a dozen kids be?

Checking they all still firmly held hands, she led them through the portal and closed it behind them.

*****

The portal had barely closed when a corpse stepped out of the Sylfranian shadows in Ainderbury. Like Dreya, it did not shout 'Boo!' but it still made the two Guardians jump.

"What a touching display," it sneered in a voice not its own.

Mandalee swore, drawing a sword and chopping it into pieces before Cat had time to blink.

A second corpse appeared and continued, "You two have been making quite the nuisance of yourselves out here, trying to stop the advancement of Ulvarius' plans. As if you could!"

Its lips – or the rotted remains of them – did not sync with the words, but simply parted to allow the sentence to come out in full.

With a glance, Catriona caused the plants to pull the body apart.

Ten more corpses stepped out in front of them, one of which spoke up, "If it makes you feel better, by all means chop these into pieces as well, but it's completely pointless. It's not like Ulvarius is actually inside any of these bodies. They're just meat puppets. There are plenty more corpses lying around and if they did somehow run out, well, Ulvarius can soon make more. All Ulvarius has to do is extinguish a few pointless lives."

"Their lives aren't pointless!" Catriona argued, while Mandalee decided actions spoke louder than words and shattered every last one of them in a heartbeat.

"You're right," came Ulvarius' voice again, this time from a single corpse behind them. The remains of a young boy. "Not all of them, anyway. Not completely. Some of them could be of use to Ulvarius like this one was when I drained the magic right out of him."

Mandalee's assassin's instinct was at war with her love of children. She wanted to smash this defiled body like the others, but she couldn't bring herself to do it.

"Just like I'll do to all those you 'rescued'. As if Ulvarius won't just pick them up again later." The corpse shrugged. "Like I say: pointless, but this one's still useful," the voice taunted. "Ulvarius thought the body of a child might just make you pause for a moment to listen. In many ways, I'm doing you a favour."

"Really? How's that?" Cat demanded, acidly.

"I'm helping you to conserve your energy, instead of wasting it smashing empty bodies. You're going to need all your energy for running in a minute."

"You're deluded if you think we'd ever run away from you," Cat scoffed.

"Oh, no, of course not," the voice replied. "You won't be running *away* from Ulvarius. You'll be running *towards* me. Desperate to be with Ulvarius, you'll be."

"Like my friend says, you're deluded," Mandalee insisted.

The corpse shook his head. "No, I don't think so. You see, Ulvarius controls so much land hereabouts, so many towns and villages, filled with, for the most part, pointless people filling their pointless lives by doing pointless things…pointlessly. But as we've established, not all of them are pointless. Some of them are quite useful as my meat puppets. Now, they might not be up to much intellectually – as if they ever were – but they can follow simple instructions. For example, if I make contact with my puppets in one village at random…" the child corpse made a show of considering, "…say one over that way, for example," he pointed to the North East, "I can tell them to do this." In the middle distance, they saw a huge fireball flare up into the sky as a village exploded.

"No!" the Guardians cried out together. The sound of the destruction carried on the wind, the ground shook and smoke began to drift towards them.

"You care so much about children? How many do you suppose were in that village?" the boy corpse wondered. "More than the dozen you just 'rescued', I'll bet. If you hadn't taken those from me, the ones in that village would still be alive. For a while longer, at least. This is why you're going to run to Ulvarius as fast as you can, because every five minutes you keep Ulvarius waiting, another town or village will end the same way. Like this!" He pointed behind the Guardians, who spun around just in time to witness another explosion.

"Stop! Please!" Cat begged.

"No more, Ulvarius!" Mandalee growled. "You've got us."

Once again, the boy corpse shook his head. "Not yet I haven't, and the destruction doesn't stop until I do. Run to Ulvarius, run to the Black Tower. Then it stops. And don't even

think of using any magic to teleport or speed you up or any other magic for that matter. If you do, Ulvarius will simply guess how many five-minute intervals it would have taken you, add an extra five per spell, and then double it. Ulvarius wants you to understand the cost of your interference. Every random village that explodes, every child that dies while you desperately try to reach the door of my Tower is a result of your actions."

"Alright, Ulvarius, you've made your point!" Mandalee snapped.

"Wait!" Cat demanded. "The *door* of your Tower? What about your grounds' defences? Are they going to let us through?"

"Either way, you're running to your deaths," the boy corpse shrugged. "Precisely *how* you die doesn't really matter, does it? So why spoil the surprise? Now, Ulvarius would suggest you get moving. Run like people's lives depend on it. Because they do."

With that, the boy corpse collapsed to the ground as the puppet's strings were cut, and without a word passing between them, the two Guardians set off running as fast as they could without magic.

*****

As it turned out, the Black Tower's defences did let them through. It had taken them twenty-five minutes to run all the way from Ainderbury. Cat was sure she'd shaved five minutes off her personal best running speed, but that didn't help the handful of villages she had seen explode along the way. She was sure Mandalee could have done better on her own, but she knew Ulvarius wouldn't stop until he had both of them and her best friend would have refused to leave her on her own no matter what.

The black robed figure who greeted them at the door was far from the one Catriona was used to. Of course, this place wouldn't be Dreya's for another three hundred years, and even then, only if they could somehow get history mostly back on track. It could never be precisely the same – that ship had sailed. The best they could do now was to take care of the broad brushstrokes of history and try not to look too closely at the fine bristle-work.

Thinking of artwork, Cat compared the tyrant that stood before her to the portraits of Ulvarius she had seen in her time.

Either the artists had been ‘encouraged’ to use their imaginations, or else his foul magic had led to some serious degradation. She had been attacked by the lich form of Ulvarius when the Timeline changes caused his resurrection. Quite frankly, apart from size, seeing the living tyrant now, he looked little different in the flesh, figuratively speaking, because literally speaking, there was barely any flesh to be seen. He was about five feet tall, with a melon-shaped skull to which half a dozen wispy hairs still clung tenaciously. His body was emaciated with skeletal, talon-like hands and sharp fingernails that looked like they hadn’t been cut for years.

The Champion of the Gods, Ossian Miach Kaidool may have been all skin and bone, but he had a large, imposing frame, a powerful, confident stride and a noble bearing about him that could not have been further from the form of Ulvarius.

To all appearances, there was nothing to fear from this individual who looked like he might blow away in the next gust of wind – if only – but appearances could be deceptive, and they certainly were in this case. For the magic of Ulvarius was unmatched, unrivalled by any of the mortals of this time. With the unstable higher planar energy from the control device fragment he had found, his power was likely a match even for Michael.

Fortunately, as Catriona was fond of saying, power wasn’t everything. There were people in this world who were ready to stand up to this tyrant and, with a little help from the future, they were going to put a stop to this threat and build a legacy that would last for centuries to come.

Chapter 11

"Wow!" Mandalee declared as she stepped inside. "I've always wanted to see inside the Black Tower, haven't you, Rose?"

"Hmmm?" Cat wondered. A look of puzzlement flashed across her face before she realised what her friend was doing. Catriona hadn't been paying any attention to their surroundings because they were so familiar – this was her home. But they couldn't let Ulvarius know that. They had to stay in character, and the Mel and Rose of this time would be awed at being inside the infamous Black Tower.

"Oh, yes, it's amazing," she agreed, but then she decided there was no reason she couldn't put a little of herself into her character. Wiping a finger along the porch door, she pulled off a layer of dust. "Mind you," she added, pulling a face, "I thought it would be cleaner." Wagging her dusty finger at Ulvarius, she warned him, "You'd better wash the cups before we start!"

"The cups?" Ulvarius wondered.

"The teacups," Cat clarified. "The way you invited us over, I assume this is the part where you offer us a nice cup of tea and a chat."

"No, this is the part where I torture you, bleed you dry and take your magic for myself."

"To be fair, Rose," Mandalee put in, "that is more what I was expecting."

"What!" gasped Catriona, as if scandalised. "No tea?"

Mandalee shook her head.

"Well, Ulvarius *could* offer you tea," Ulvarius allowed. "But then another village would burn every five minutes."

"The deal was you'd stop when we reached the door!" Mandalee protested.

"I didn't say the *front* door. I meant the door to my torture chamber."

"Torture chamber?" Cat scoffed. "Bit on the nose, isn't it? Not 'Interrogation Room' or maybe…" she thought for a moment "…the CHamber for Information and Magic Extraction?"

"CHIME," Mandalee said, realising the acronym. "I like it. Did you come up with that on the spot?"

Cat nodded.

"Go ahead, make jokes," their captor cut in. "Ulvarius will just keep burning villages."

"Not for another three minutes by my count," Cat retorted. "Still, I suppose we should probably be going."

"Torture chamber it is, then," the White Assassin sighed.

Turning to Ulvarius, "Well?" Cat prompted him, indignantly. "If you're not going to make tea, you can at least show us to our room."

The Black robe wizard gestured up the steps. "Top of the stairs and turn right."

Cat pulled a face. "Stairs? I was hoping for teleportation," she grumbled as she started to climb.

"I know," Mandalee agreed, taking her arm as if going for a stroll. "First he makes us run here and now he expects us to climb up all these steps!"

"The hospitality here is appalling."

"To be fair, we were promised torture, and these steps definitely qualify."

"Could you stop being fair to our torturer, please?"

"Sorry."

*****

The 'torture chamber' was a room with which Catriona was intimately familiar. Dreya had never found a use for it in the years she'd owned the Black Tower, other than as a place to store junk that she didn't really need. Only yesterday – three hundred and twelve years in the future – she and Dreya had started clearing it out. They were planning to redecorate and turn it into a nursery for the new arrival. It was tempting to let the idea that it had once been a torture chamber put her off such plans, but the druidess dismissed the notion. In the time of Ulvarius, every room in the Tower had probably been used for all kinds of evil purposes, but it wasn't the Tower's fault. It wasn't cursed or damned or haunted. It was just a building. In fact, if this Tower had previously been used to bring death, surely that was all the more reason to turn it into a place to nurture new life.

Right now, though, the walls of the room were lined with people of all ages, chained up, in varying degrees of pain and torment. Two dozen in all. Some were in shock, others were crying, and at least one woman had clearly given up. Ulvarius had set up automated, self-sustaining magic to systematically drain their blood and store it all in bottles that levitated themselves into a glass-fronted cabinet in one corner near the door. It was like a twisted version of the medical technology on StormClaw that Daelen had used after they had saved his life following the accident with Pyrah.

Cat hadn't seen the Ysirian snake since the Battle of Rhynas Desert, but there was nothing unusual in that. She'd turn up sooner or later.

Mandalee and Cat shared a glance. Without a word or even a sympathic message, they agreed that their rule about not helping people who were already captured had just been rescinded. It didn't matter about the Timeline; they couldn't just save themselves and leave all these people if there was any way to help them.

The suddenness of the way Ulvarius casually killed two of his prisoners to make room for the new captives gave the Guardians no time to react. They both closed their eyes against the horror of it, but they knew that they couldn't let it stop them from doing what they came here to do. Those two had been on the verge of death, anyway, having been drained of so much blood. At least now their suffering was over.

They co-operated when he commanded them to strip down to their underwear, and allowed themselves to be chained up. Any resistance at this stage and Ulvarius might simply decide to dispose of them. Catriona had read some of Ulvarius' journals, so she had a good idea of how his mind worked. Mandalee understood that and was content to follow her best friend's lead. Once they were safely locked up, then they could start to cause trouble, because if he couldn't control his captives, he would view that as a personal failure. Killing prisoners before he was done with them would be proof of that failure, so he would do so only as a last resort.

Cat had been stripped of her spell components but, not understanding their significance, Ulvarius had left them in the room, dumping them in the corner. As for Mandalee's weapons, he was at least smart enough to take them all into another room…all

except the two small dragonclaw knives she kept strapped to her wrists. Evidently, Ulvarius couldn't see through a perception filter. Chained up as she was, they weren't going to be much use to her, but she still had her cleric magic. He couldn't take that away from her – a fact she was about to demonstrate.

Ulvarius wasted no time in using his magic to make a surgical slice across a vein in her arm. He was careful not to catch an artery – that would make her bleed out too fast for him to extract her magic. Mandalee didn't even flinch. Instead, she just let out a bored sigh and healed herself right up. Ulvarius inflicted more cuts. Same result. Such low-level healing wasn't even a challenge. She could keep this up for a week without feeling drained.

"You know how we were talking earlier about pointless people doing pointless things?" she smirked. "Well, I guess this makes you one of those. Trying to torture a cleric healer with paper cuts is an exercise in futility."

Ulvarius continued to cut her arms, regardless. Each cut only bled a little before it healed, but each time Ulvarius collected the blood in a small glass, perhaps half the size of a champagne flute. When the glass was about half full, Ulvarius stopped cutting, swirled the blood around the glass and drank it in one go.

"A *really disgusting* exercise in futility," the assassin amended.

Ulvarius scoffed. "You think Ulvarius hasn't captured clerics before? The flavour of your magic is a little different, though, I admit. I just wondered if there might be an element of wizard magic in there, too."

"You could have just asked," Mandalee grumbled, "and if you're going to try and drain my magic next, I really wouldn't bother. Trust me, you'll only embarrass yourself."

Ulvarius was scathing. "You clerics think you're so special! You all think your power comes from the gods, and that makes your magic untouchable. Cut the spiritual crap, and it's just energy from inter-planar forces, the same as wizards use. It's just been filtered a bit. But no, Ulvarius is not going to drain you just yet. I'm more interested in your friend."

"It's nice to feel wanted," Cat remarked.

He stepped over to the druidess and tried to slice her open in the same way, with much the same result. Like Mandalee, she could heal such small cuts with barely a thought.

"Druid magic," Ulvarius noted, after drinking her blood. He sounded intrigued. "A dash of wizard in there, too. Hardly enough to be worth taking, but waste not, want not. Ulvarius may not be able to bleed you – at least not without doing so much damage as to defeat the object – but I have other ways of draining magic. Never saw the point of druids before, but the magic you were doing, while you were out playing the hero, was something new. Ulvarius is going to enjoy taking that power. But which of you first?" he pondered. Then he made up his mind. "Save the special treat for last. Always the best way." Moving back to Mandalee, he placed his hands on her bare arms and closed his eyes, preparing to drain her magic directly.

The journals Catriona had read hadn't explicitly mentioned how he did this, but clearly, it required direct skin contact. Just another way in which his abilities were inferior to those her fiancée had perfected. Dreya needed nothing more than line of sight. The sorceress could feel the way magic flowed; sometimes, she almost thought she could see it.

Although Dreya was wholly committed to the order of Dark magic and the quest for power, she had never lost touch with her Red robe training. She was meticulous in her preparations before attempting any new magic. She kept unnecessary risks to a minimum as she tried to peel back the layers of magic and find out how it worked so that she could truly master it. Ulvarius simply got an idea in his head and used it to gain power. He was obviously powerful and gifted, but he didn't really know what he was doing. A fact the two Guardians were happy to demonstrate.

The look of concentration on what little remained of Ulvarius' face grew in intensity. He began to grunt with the effort, a grunt that grew into a scream, as if he were trying to lift something far too heavy, or stretch every tendon and ligament trying to grasp something that was always going to be out of reach. At last, he was forced to give up, panting with the effort.

"Told you so!" Mandalee taunted.

She wasn't like other clerics. Her magic came from Shyleen, the leopard god who left her plane of existence and came to live on

Tempestria. Mandalee freely shared her soul in exchange for access to clerical magic and complete understanding of wild things. She was a Cleric of Nature. Moreover, at the moment, the source of her magic was three hundred years in the future. That didn't matter to Mandalee – her bond with Shyleen transcended Time, thanks to the Guardianship – but Ulvarius didn't know the first thing about Temporal magic, so he had no way of reaching Shyleen's power.

Ulvarius was livid. "How are you blocking Ulvarius?"

"I'm not, exactly," she replied. "My magic's just…inaccessible to anyone but me."

"How?"

"That would be telling," she told him with a smirk.

"Alright, if you want to play games, you can watch while Ulvarius drains your friend!"

"You really don't want to do that," Cat warned him.

Ignoring her, he placed his hands on her bare arms and tried to focus. He made the connection with her magic and pulled, the same as he always did, but instead of a steady stream that he could control, he got a tidal wave of power. The power surge travelled up his arms and hit him square in the chest, sending him flying backwards. The instant he was in midair, Cat used the magic he had released to generate a gust of wind that blew Ulvarius exactly where she wanted him – crashing right into his blood-filled cabinet. The glass front broke on impact, the cupboard collapsed, and the bottles all shattered, spilling their vile contents.

"Tried to warn you!" Cat teased in a sing-song voice.

Druid magic came from a different source to that of clerics or wizards. They believed it came from Blessed Alycia, Mother of Nature. Ulvarius had tried to drain Catriona's power, but the power was never really hers. In effect, he was trying to drain Nature herself, and not being one to withhold her power, she let him have it, and he got the force of Nature full in the chest.

If Ulvarius was angry before, now he was in a full-blown rage. Considering he drank blood, Ulvarius's skeletal body didn't seem to have much in its veins. Mandalee didn't think he had enough left to make his face turn red, but he seemed to be giving it a good try.

"You said yourself my magic's like nothing you've seen before," Cat pointed out. "My friend's is pretty unique too. Did you not think to wonder if it might react differently?"

"Ah, but *are* they unique, Rose?" Mandalee put in. "Maybe Ulvarius simply doesn't know as much about magic as he thinks."

"That's a good point, Mel," Cat agreed. "Maybe there are loads of us with magic he can't drain; power he can't master."

"Maybe Ulvarius isn't as powerful as he thinks he is," Mandalee suggested. "Not without a certain magical talisman."

Ulvarius rushed over to them and demanded, "What do you know about that?"

"Oh, we know all kinds of things, don't we, Mel?" Cat remarked, needling him further.

"Yep," she agreed. "You see, Ulvarius, this was your mistake: you captured us and went straight to torture and magic draining."

Cat nodded. "You forgot all about interrogation because you're arrogant enough to think you know it all already. But you didn't know about us, did you?"

"So, what else don't you know about?" Mandalee wondered.

One could be forgiven for thinking they'd rehearsed this routine, but the truth was they knew each other so well that they didn't need to.

"Tell Ulvarius what you know!" he demanded.

Cat shook her head. "Nope, it's not going to be that easy. You really don't do interrogation very well, do you?"

"How can Ulvarius be sure you even know anything?" he growled, menacingly, leaning close to Mandalee.

Breathing in at the wrong time led to a coughing fit. "Dear gods, you stink!" the White Guardian complained when she could speak again. "Tell you what, we'll give you a sample on one condition: you go and clean yourself up. We're not talking to you while you're covered in blood, it's disgusting."

"And to sweeten the deal," Cat put in, "we'll even clean the floor for you. It's not good to have all that blood lying around."

"You think Ulvarius is fool enough to let you out of your chains?"

"No need," Cat assured him. "Just bring a couple of mops and buckets of water into the room, and I can do it perfectly well from here."

Keeping a lid on his rage, Ulvarius considered that for a moment and then acquiesced.

"Very well, Ulvarius is intrigued. Deal accepted," he agreed, adding the caveat, "*if* I believe your information is of value."

"OK, here's your sample," Mandalee offered. "That magic totem or talisman, or whatever you call it, it's not unique. It's a fragment, nothing more."

"Ulvarius suspected as much. It appears to have broken off something. What is it? Do you know?"

Mandalee sidestepped the question. "What it's from isn't the point. The point is who it belongs to: Kullos."

Ulvarius reflexively stepped back on hearing that name. "Higher planar energy! That's what this strange power is!"

Cat shrugged. "Sorry, we assumed you knew that bit. Whatever strange device it once was, it was destroyed a th— a long time ago."

She mentally cursed herself for the slipup. It was about a thousand years ago relative to her time, but they were three hundred years in the past. That meant the original shattering of Kullos' dimensional control device took place more like seven hundred years ago. That was not a mistake anyone from this time would make. Fortunately, he didn't seem to notice. He could see power in what they were telling him, and he was so focused on that, it blinded him to all else. Now they had his attention, it was time to bait him properly.

"Kullos has been collecting the pieces, and he has most of them," Mandalee told him.

"Almost all of them, we think," Cat agreed. "All except the one you've got…and one other."

In truth, Catriona had no idea how long Kullos had spent collecting the fragments before the events that ultimately led to his downfall. Still, she thought it unlikely that even Ulvarius was arrogant enough to go and ask the shadow warrior to verify this information. Ulvarius may have been the worst tyrant who ever lived, but next to Kullos, he was just a bully in a school playground.

“You know where there’s another fragment?” Ulvarius breathed in wonder.

This was a good sign, Cat thought. Assuming Ulvarius wasn’t fool enough to imagine he could take on Kullos, the promise of another fragment should be irresistible. Even if he suspected something, he would still have to check it out for himself. If there was another fragment, he wouldn’t risk anyone else getting their hands on it. If they were lying and there wasn’t, well, they were captives under his control. He could just kill them later.

“If you want to know more, you’ll have to do what we agreed and then come back here to discuss terms,” Mandalee insisted.

“Very well,” Ulvarius agreed. He inscribed the language of magic in the air, and a pair of wooden mops and buckets appeared.

“Get cleaning. I’ll be back shortly to continue this.”

With that, he left the room.

Chapter 12

With a bit of concentration, Catriona soon had one of the mops walking around, cleaning the floor by itself. Whenever the water got too bloody, the mop marched down the steps, emptied its bucket and rinsed itself in the pond outside, before marching back upstairs with fresh water.

"Hey, it's like that movie Jessica and Sara showed us," Mandalee remarked.

Cat grinned. "I spent the rest of the day trying to figure out how to make that magic work."

Mandalee shook her head in wonder. "That is so you. That is textbook you."

At that moment, they realised all the other prisoners were staring at them. The man who was chained up next to Cat asked, "Who are you people? The way you're acting, it's like you think you're on holiday or something!"

"And you are…?" Cat prompted.

"Peryx," he answered.

"Well, Peryx, I'm Rose, this is my friend, Mel, and we *are* a long way from home."

"Sort of," Mandalee allowed.

"But it's more of a job than a holiday."

"I would have said 'calling'," Mandalee put in.

Cat gave a facial shrug. "That works, too. Either way, I think it's time we did something about it, don't you?"

Mandalee used her cleric magic to levitate a few shards of glass, which she used to sever the tubes that were still draining the prisoners' blood. The collection bottles smashed themselves in the far corner, where the mop, undaunted, cleaned up the additional mess. Cat mentally called to the second mop, causing it to hop into the other bucket, which had so far sat idle. After soaking itself for a moment, it flicked clean water all over the prisoners. Then the Red Guardian used nature's healing power of water to close all wounds, before sending her magical senses into each of their bodies and asking nature to replicate enough blood to replenish what they had lost. She then encouraged the water on their bodies to evaporate and their clothes to dry. Job done, the mop wiped the

floor and joined its fellow on its trip up and down the steps of the Tower.

Mandalee gave each prisoner a thorough going-over with her clerical magic and decided that given time, they should all recover, at least physically. Sadly, not even Temporal magic could speed up the healing of mental scars. They might well last a lifetime.

The prisoners were mostly grateful, but the two friends could see suspicion in the eyes of some, who couldn't believe someone would help them without it being some kind of trick. That was particularly evident in one woman, who, from the looks of her, had been there a long time. In fact, given her weak condition, Mandalee was sure she would have been beyond help within a day. Where before she had seemed resigned to her fate, she now appeared terrified, as if the lifeline of hope these two strangers had offered was more than she could bear.

"Why are you doing this?"

"Because we can and because it'll annoy Ulvarius," Catriona replied.

The woman was less than convinced. "That's it? Just that?"

The two friends glanced at each other, as if deciding how much to share.

"We have to tell them," Mandalee urged her, quietly.

"Really? I'm not sure we should."

"It's only right," she insisted.

"I know, but we have to be careful."

"If you don't tell them, I will."

Cat let out a long, slow breath. "Oh, alright," she accepted, grudgingly. "I suppose."

"I knew it! Tell us what's going on!" the woman demanded.

"Alright!" Cat hissed. "But keep your voice down. Ulvarius can't know any of this."

The woman still looked belligerent, but nodded her agreement, nonetheless. She didn't want Ulvarius back any more than anyone else did.

"What's your name?" Cat asked.

"Petra," she replied.

"OK, Petra, we're part of a mission, a quest to stop Ulvarius. We were captured because we wanted to be. Thanks to our unique magics, we kind of drew the short straw and got this job."

"Calling," Mandalee corrected.

"Whatever. The point is, we've convinced Ulvarius we've got important information about this other powerful fragment. We're going to try to trade the information."

"Information we want him to have," Mandalee clarified.

"Yes, but we're going to lie about part of it," Cat told them. "We're going to convince him the fragment is somewhere in Walminster. It's not. In fact, it's in a small village just outside the city. It's called Compton, you've probably never heard of it."

"Why lie about that?" asked Peryx. "Why tell him anything at all?"

"Because Walminster is a trap," Mandalee explained. "It won't kill him, no trap's that powerful, but it will keep him busy for a while."

Cat took up the story. "You see, as you've guessed, we're not from around here. Our home is…well, let's just say it takes a long time to get there."

Mandalee hid a smile at that. A long time, indeed: over three hundred years.

"Where we're from," she explained, "there's a powerful sorceress called Darla. She's already had her hands on Kullos' device and has been absorbing its power. Now she's ready to take on Ulvarius."

"*Nearly* ready," Cat corrected. "She needs a little more time, and she's worried that Ulvarius might get wind of her activities and attack her before her preparations are complete."

"That's why you're here," Peryx deduced. "To run smokescreen. Keep him occupied and lure him into this trap."

"Exactly," Mandalee agreed. "Thanks to our unique magic, we can escape any time we want." To demonstrate, she momentarily took herself out of Time, making herself invisible and incorporeal long enough to slip out of her bonds. She returned to the local Timestream in the middle of the room and took a bow.

Cat gave her a withering look. "I'd applaud, but my hands are tied. Stop showing off and get back in your chains before he comes back."

Before complying, Mandalee grabbed a small vial out of one of Cat's spell pouches. Walking back to where her chains awaited, she slipped it unseen into Catriona's hand and used one of her

daggers to slice cleanly through the steel shackles around that wrist. The dragon claws could cut through iron as easily as paper.

Cat was sure to keep both the damage and the vial hidden.

That done, the White Assassin shackled herself back up again.

"When you escape, you'll take us with you, right?" Peryx asked.

"Well, we should be able to take you," Cat fudged.

"But maybe not all of you, right Rose?"

"Mel!" Cat hissed, as if trying to shut her up.

"What's she talking about?" Petra demanded.

Cat glared at Mandalee, but she ignored her.

"What my friend doesn't want to tell you is that some of you are going to be too weak to be transported our way, so some of you will have to stay here."

"Some of us like me, you mean?" Petra realised.

"I'm sorry," Cat replied, regretfully, "but we have to prioritise."

"It makes sense," Peryx offered.

Petra scoffed. "Easy for you to say, you're getting out."

"Don't worry, Darla will stop him," Cat assured her.

"Before he kills everyone in this Tower?" Petra shot back. Cat turned away, not wanting to answer. "Even supposing this Darla does kill Ulvarius, then what?"

"Well, she's got her eye on this place, for a start," Mandalee replied. "This will be her home, her base of power. She's got all kinds of plans for magic on Elvaria."

"So, she'll be just like Ulvarius, only more powerful?" Petra concluded.

"No, not at all!" Cat protested. "Honestly! I mean, yes, she can be pretty scary at times…"

"*Very* scary," Mandalee put in.

Cat frowned at her friend. "Not helping, Mel."

"Sorry, Rose. I was just saying—"

"Well don't!" The druidess cut her off. Turning back to Petra, she tried to reassure her. "Just don't cross her, and she'll be fine with you. Leave her alone, and she'll leave you alone. Probably."

"Look," Mandalee said, "it's either Darla or Ulvarius, and you know what kind of devil he is."

"Trust me, you'll be way better off with Darla in charge," Cat promised.

"In charge?" Petra demanded, clearly not liking the sound of this.

At that moment, they heard footsteps approaching. Ulvarius was returning. They were out of time.

"Not a word," Cat whispered.

She looked over at her best friend, who smiled, grimly. This was it. History hinged on what happened in these next few minutes.

*****

Ulvarius wandered back into the room, all cleaned up and wearing fresh Black robes over his emaciated frame. He took in the activity of the mops with a glance and Mandalee imagined he would have raised an eyebrow, if he still had them, as he remarked, "Intriguing magic."

Cat shrugged. "Bit plagiarised, if I'm honest, but it works."

The tyrant's expression darkened when he noticed that his captives were now healed and no longer spilling their blood and magic.

"This is the deal, Ulvarius," Mandalee offered. "The other fragment is in a major city."

"If you want more than that, you'll have to let us go. All of us," Cat told him.

"That's one option, yes," Ulvarius mused. "Alternatively, Ulvarius could just destroy another village every five minutes until I'm convinced you've told me everything!"

"I don't think you're really going to do that," Mandalee refuted.

"You doubt Ulvarius' commitment?" he growled, menacingly. "Just for that, I'll destroy Gaggleswick. You might not be able to see it, but you'll hear the explosion right enough. If you listen carefully, you'll hear the screams. Hear them, and remember you're the ones doing this. By not telling Ulvarius everything, you kill all those people. Listen to that and know it's your fault! Listen! Listen…" he trailed off.

All was silence.

"I'm listening, but I don't hear anything," Mandalee remarked, facetiously.

"Yeah, what my friend meant to say was, you won't really be *able* to do that."

Ulvarius was livid when he realised he was cut off from all communication with his undead minions.

"Alright, Ulvarius will just go out there and do it himself!" he roared.

He headed for the door, but it slammed shut before he could reach it. Once in place, it warped and expanded at Catriona's request, and nothing Ulvarius could do would budge it.

Boiling with anger, he blasted the door with a beam of higher planar energy. Cat was expecting him to do something like that. Like a certain late shadow warrior of her acquaintance, he would always naturally lash out with power, without thinking. It rebounded off the door without leaving a scratch and began to ricochet dangerously around the room. Thanks to Mandalee, she had her vial of sand ready to fuse into Nature's Mirror, should it be necessary. Fortunately, the only person the energy beam hit was Ulvarius himself, throwing him headfirst into the door.

The two Guardians hooted with laughter as a dazed Ulvarius turned around sporting a bloody nose.

"How have you done this?" Ulvarius demanded. "No-one has this kind of power!"

The Red Guardian shrugged as best she could in her chains. "Power isn't everything."

*****

As you know, gentle reader, the Black Tower was Catriona's home. She was intimately familiar with both its future owner and the building itself. When Dreya first took the Tower, she changed or dismantled most of its defences, but she had kept the shield intact. It had been subjected to all kinds of magical assaults for over three centuries, never once wavering, so why would she change such a winning formula?

Those defences had once had the unfortunate side effect of blocking Mandalee's desperate sympathic cries for help on the day

she and Shyleen were almost killed. It was the biggest mistake of Catriona's life and she would be forever grateful for the way they had both come to forgive her and become the best friends she could ever wish for.

She was also thankful for Dreya who, on that very same terrible day first opened up to her and took the first steps towards a relationship. By that time, the sorceress had already adjusted the shield to allow Mandalee's magic to pass through without interference. It took a while longer for Dreya to trust Cat enough to show her how it worked, but eventually, she did. Catriona had been the one to change the shield to allow the two Chetsuans, Sara and Jessica, to come and go at will. Three hundred years in the past, she could apply that same principle.

In effect, while Ulvarius had been out of the room, she had quietly changed the locks, and now she held the only key. He would find a way to break through eventually, but for now, he was trapped.

*****

"Now you can't threaten innocents to get what you want," Mandalee told him. "And if you harm one of us, the other will have no reason to tell you anything. Now agree to release us – all of us – and we'll tell you everything."

A rictus grin grew across the tyrant's face, which burst into a terrible manic laugh.

"You think you're so smart, don't you? But you've made a mistake, just like everyone does when they try to challenge Ulvarius! You say I can't harm innocents? I count twenty-two of them in this room alone!"

"What? No! You can't!" Cat implored him.

"And these aren't my only prisoners! There are many more in this Tower of mine, once Ulvarius blasts out of this room – and I will. Shall we go with our usual terms? One dies every five minutes until you tell Ulvarius everything. Starting with…" his moving finger stopped at Petra. "This one right now!"

He slowly began to build up higher planar energy, ready to fire at her, incinerate her.

The two Guardians looked panicked, and Mandalee blurted out, “Walminster!”

“Mel!” Cat warned her.

“I had to. I’m sorry.”

Ulvarius began to power down. “Elaborate,” he ordered.

“It’s being hidden by some mages in the Forum building.”

Ulvarius nodded. “Ulvarius has heard something about a group of troublesome mages there,” he mused. “I thought they were all talk, but if they have one of these fragments, I’ll have to pay them a visit. It makes sense…too much sense.” He resumed powering up his energy beam, saying, “Now, you have five seconds to convince Ulvarius that’s the truth, or this one dies!”

He began counting down, and the two Guardians insisted it was true, but when he reached ‘One’, Petra blurted out, “They’re lying!” Ulvarius powered down instantly.

“Petra, no!” Cat cried.

“They told us the whole thing! Please don’t kill me!” she begged, sobbing. “I’ll tell you everything they said, I just don’t want to die! Release me, please!”

Ulvarius shattered her chains with his magic.

“Speak true, and Ulvarius will grant you release. With all I’ve drained from you, you’re no more use anyway.”

“Petra, please, you can’t!” Cat begged her. “You’ll ruin everything!”

“Why should I care?” she shot back. “You were going to leave me to die! As for this Darla, like you say, Ulvarius is the devil we know, and you know what they say about that.”

“Darla?” Ulvarius demanded.

Petra nodded. “Some sorceress who wants to take your place.”

As she relayed the whole story, the Guardians looked defeated.

“So, Walminster is a trap!” Ulvarius raged, incensed at the idea. “Someone dares to try and trap Ulvarius? Someone dares to challenge Ulvarius’ supremacy? Ulvarius is the Greatest Mage Who Ever Lived! Whoever this Darla is, hiding away in Compton village, Ulvarius is coming!”

This was the moment the Guardians had been waiting for. Cat dropped the shields around the Tower and sent a sympathic message to Dreya. '*Incoming.*'

Rant apparently over, Ulvarius turned back to the trembling Petra, "Thank you for that information. As promised, Ulvarius shall reward you with your release…the release of death."

He powered up his energy beam and fired it straight at her, but Catriona was ready. Sand flew out from the vial in her hand, and thanks to the Temporal aspect of her druid magic, it fused into a mirror right in the path of the energy beam, deflecting it. Part of it flew back at Ulvarius, knocking him flying across the room. The rest hit the East wall, leaving behind a big black scorch mark.

Even as Cat and Mandalee pulled themselves out of the Timestream to escape their bonds, Cat's mind was racing at the implications of that mark. She had seen it before…three hundred years from now in the room that was to be her child's nursery. What did that mean? Were they changing history or just fulfilling it? She would have to puzzle over that one later. Right now, she was busy.

Using her super-speed, Mandalee raced out of the door that opened easily for her. She quickly found where Ulvarius had taken her things and was back before Ulvarius had even begun to stand up. She snatched Catriona's robe and spell components, and rushed back over to her friend.

Cat opened her pocket dimension so that Mandalee could throw everything inside. They could sort it out later.

While the White Assassin hurriedly sliced open all the chains that bound the prisoners, Cat asked one of the buckets of water to spill its contents over the floor. The water grew into a thick wall of ice, separating them from the tyrant.

Ulvarius was beginning to stir now, so the two friends used their Guardian powers to buy time by slowing it down. They couldn't stop it – they needed Dreya for that – but slowing it was enough.

"Do you want to open the portal or shall I?" Cat asked.

"Let me do it," Mandalee replied. "I need the practice."

A shimmering blue Prismatic Sphere opened before them into which they practically threw the prisoners one by one. They regretted being so rough with them, but they had no choice. They knew there were more prisoners in the Tower, too, but they

couldn't save them. Even with Time slowed down, they didn't have time. They knew Ulvarius had been holding back. He didn't want to use his full power for the same reason Dreya didn't when her grounds' defences turned on her: he didn't want to destroy his own home in the process. But after the way they'd just humiliated him, they knew he would be beyond such restraint now, and they needed to be gone.

When the last of the prisoners were safe, Catriona jumped through, just as her ice wall shattered. Mandalee dived through the portal last…

…and landed right on top of the Black robed form of Dreya the Dark, knocking her to the ground.

"Oops," Mandalee remarked as the portal closed. "Sorry."

Chapter 13

"You need to work on your aim with your portals," the Black Guardian grumbled as Mandalee helped the sorceress to her feet.

"I'll make it a top priority," her White counterpart promised. "Right behind stopping Ulvarius, getting the fragment, putting history back on track and saving all these people."

In the interests of the last part – once they had reclaimed their clothes and other belongings from Cat's pocket dimension, and got dressed – the Red and White Guardians set about healing the captives they had brought with them.

"You saved us!" Petra gasped incredulously.

"Of course we did," Mandalee replied, matter-of-factly.

"Even me. Even after I betrayed you."

"You were supposed to betray us," Cat assured her. "Anyone would in your place. After being tortured for weeks, we dangled a lifeline of hope in front of your face and then snatched it away, threatening to abandon you and let your torturer finish the job. No-one could blame you for what you did, and you should feel no guilt."

"You betrayed us; we used you," Mandalee put in. "I'm willing to call that quits if you are."

*****

Apart from the moral perspective, there had been a strategic element to their rescue. They knew Dreya's plan: she wanted Ulvarius to come out of his Tower and attack. For the moment, she had a small army of wizards lying in wait in Compton, but the longer they waited, the higher the chance that some might think better of it and leave the group. Therefore, the sooner Ulvarius attacked, the better. The trap was set. Cat and Mandalee's job had been to push him into it.

The Guardians had known that Ulvarius would automatically distrust anything they told him, so they took the decision to use the captives he already had. The ones he had broken. Petra was the obvious candidate, so they played their parts well, sharing a version of their plan. The version they wanted

Ulvarius to believe. Through Petra's act of betrayal in the name of self-preservation, they had baited Ulvarius to attack Compton quickly, 'before they were ready' when the truth was, they were ready now.

Moreover, while the Forum building in Walminster was being used as a refuge, Ulvarius believed it was a trap, so he would stay away from it. That made it the safest place in Elvaria right now.

The Guardians moved aside and allowed other healers to take over. There would be no clerics involved with the Council for another three centuries, of course, but there was the occasional druid who offered their services in exchange for protection.

Finding a secluded corner, Mandalee quickly warned her friend, "He's definitely learned how to tap into the power of that fragment, Dreya. He used a beam cannon type blast."

Cat nodded. "I managed to deflect it, but I don't see how that army of yours is going to survive powers like that. I know I say power isn't everything, but in this case…" she trailed off.

"Don't worry, Cat," her fiancée reassured her. "Mandalee has a ridiculous radical plan to deal with that."

"I do?" Mandalee frowned.

"Better to show you than tell you," Dreya replied.

"You're being enigmatic again," Cat pointed out.

Dreya nodded. "I know, but trust me, if I just told you, you'd never believe it."

"Well, as Jessica would say, you can colour me intrigued," Cat remarked. "Shall we go?"

"Yeah," Mandalee agreed. "We don't want the fight to start without us."

"Alright," Dreya agreed, "I'll make the portal – make sure we get to the right place and don't hit anything. But you two have to promise me something you're not going to like: stay out of the fighting."

"Jessica's right," Cat remarked. "You are starting to sound like Daelen."

"Normally, I'd never hold you back," Dreya promised, "but you studied the Battle of Compton at magic school, didn't you?"

Cat nodded.

"Well, did you hear about the red-robed mage with her amazing druid powers? Or the cleric-assassin dressed all in white?"

Cat had to admit she hadn't. Therefore, if they were to preserve history in any way, those elements couldn't be a part of the story this time, either.

Even Mandalee could only agree, much as she hated it.

"Look, I'm planning to keep a low profile in the battle myself," Dreya told them. "I have someone else who's only too happy to take both the lead and the credit. If you can help from the sidelines, discreetly, that's fine, and healing will be welcome, but unless things go horribly wrong, on the sidelines you must stay. For history's sake."

Having said that, however, she did have a particular job for Mandalee. "Where's your combat suit?" she asked.

"Still in her pocket dimension," Mandalee answered. "She told me it was anachronistic."

"It is, but the wounded aren't going to care what you're wearing, and as long as you're too fast to see properly, it won't matter to anyone else. But when Ulvarius throws everything he's got at you, it's going to matter to you."

Cat opened her pocket dimension, and Mandalee quickly changed as Dreya outlined her plan.

*****

There was nothing in the Compton of this era that Catriona recognised. It was farmland, home to only a few families who had agreed to evacuate in exchange for compensation by the Wizards' Forum and preferential terms in the future. Perhaps this was the origin of the close ties between Compton and Walminster in her time, Cat considered.

The Three Guardians had discreetly portalled in on the outskirts. Too many people had seen their preferred method of travel already. They didn't want to compound that any further. Besides, startling allies on the battlefield was never a good idea.

Dreya led her companions to where Dagamir and the others were waiting. Close to a hundred mages in total. Before she had a chance to make any introductions, however, the ground began to melt to liquid mud in places, and skeletons began to pull

themselves out of the ground in those muddy pools: Ulvarius was creating minions out of the remains of people who had died here in centuries past. As more pools began to form, Dreya glanced at her fiancée, but she was way ahead of her. Ulvarius' foot soldiers obviously needed soft ground to pull themselves up from beneath. Druid magic could deny him that resource, keeping the land in that whole area hard and dry. More skeletons managed to escape before her magic prevented them, but not many. A few pulled themselves up only to leave their legs behind. Here and there, there was just an arm sticking out, flailing wildly, but otherwise, they were trapped below ground where they could do no harm.

Wizards smashed the skeletons with air moving spells, except Dagamir who preferred to conserve his magic and skilfully hack them apart with his sword. Mandalee did likewise with a pair that got too close, and that was the last of them.

The initial skirmish over, Cat and Mandalee retreated behind the treeline. From there, they would observe at a distance and mostly stay out of it, as agreed. For her part, Dreya had taken no action against the skeletons, instead standing her ground in the middle of the wizard army, silent and still, eyes closed as if concentrating on something. After a moment, she moved over to another Black robe sorceress, Sephora, taking her arm and leading her away.

What Catriona saw made her gasp in astonishment.

"She's right," she marvelled, mostly to herself. "If I hadn't seen it, I never would have believed it."

"Why? What's she done?" Mandalee wondered.

But Catriona's answer would have to wait.

Dagamir stood tall and proud in the centre of a ring of bones and called out in a booming voice that Cat was sure could be heard plainly halfway across the continent, "Enough of these games, Ulvarius! Stop hiding behind your minions and face us yourself!"

The bony form, enshrouded in his Black robes materialised in their midst.

"What's this, Dagamir?" he sneered. "You and your fan club having an outing?"

*****

“Dagamir?” Cat whispered so only Mandalee could hear.

“Is he some historical figure?” her friend wondered. As a cleric and demon hunter turned assassin, wizards from the past had never been high on her list of interests.

Cat turned to her friend and smiled, sadly, a tear in her eye. “The man who brought the wizards together for the first time. The man who laid the foundations for the Council we know.”

Mandalee was puzzled by Cat’s expression. “That’s a good thing, isn’t it? Why don’t you look happy about it?”

“Because he never got to see the legacy he created.”

Mandalee’s eyes grew wide in understanding. “Because he dies today?”

Cat nodded. “In the final moments of the battle,” she quoted from her memory of her history textbook, “even as Ulvarius fled the scene, he unleashed one, final, devastating onslaught at the most powerful of his enemies: Dagamir the Third.” She nodded towards the proud figure before them. “Him.”

“History in action,” Mandalee remarked. “Dear gods, I need a drink.”

*****

“More of a team-building exercise, actually, Ulvarius,” Dagamir returned. “Not something you’d understand of course.”

“You’re right, I have no interest in your little team,” the tyrant agreed. “Fortunately for you. Just hand over the one called Darla, and you get to live your pointless lives for a while longer. There’s a game I’ve grown quite fond of, lately,” he told them. “The rules are simple: Ulvarius’ minions destroy a village or town every five minutes until Ulvarius gets what he wants.”

So saying, he sent out his power, but there was no explosion, no indication of damage, nothing.

“While you’ve been playing that old game, Ulvarius, my friends and I have been learning some new tricks,” Dagamir taunted him.

This ‘new trick’ was a boundary spell that surrounded the village in a dome shield. As long as it held, no magic could penetrate, not even mental commands from Ulvarius to his

minions. None of the mages there could have accomplished such a feat alone, but between them, it was quickly done.

"Is Ulvarius supposed to be impressed by that?" the bony wizard scoffed. "It takes a hundred of you to conjure one little boundary spell? Your powers are truly pathetic. Now, bring Darla to me. She has something I want. From what I've heard, the power Ulvarius drains from her will be such a feast, I won't have room for dessert afterwards, so your merry little band will be safe. For now. But if you keep Ulvarius waiting, I may have to snack on a few appetisers."

So saying, he performed a short-range teleport to stand behind a wizard in brown robes. Placing a hand on his neck, Ulvarius began to drain his magic.

Leaping into action, Dagamir charged Ulvarius and plunged his sword through his body, but the tyrant became like smoke on the wind, and the blade swished harmlessly through it. The smoke coalesced back into his physical skeletal form."

"You dare strike Ulvarius?" he demanded, incensed.

"Why do you think we're all here? We have something you want, and you have something we want. I'm happy to make the trade if you are, as long as you go first."

"And what exactly does your squalid little band want from Ulvarius?"

"Your head!" Dagamir cried and channelled a lightning bolt through his sword.

The battlefield erupted, then, as spells of fire and ice, wind and lightning flew at the tyrant. He shielded against everything as they knew he would. They couldn't win this way. Not while he possessed the control device fragment. Dreya mixed her magic with the other mages, being careful to continually shroud her real power. It was so tempting to use her power words or fire a beam cannon blast, but she knew she mustn't. It was at times like this that the power of the Dark end of the magical spectrum seemed to goad a mage into unleashing a full onslaught of magic until the magic consumed the mage.

Dreya was different. She had her power under tight control.

Of course, Dreya could drain magic. It would be so easy for her to pull that power from this army and throw it all at Ulvarius. Or drain Ulvarius and throw it at the army. The power didn't care.

But Dreya did. In fact, she had already done something she would never have imagined attempting, against her very nature, because tactically it was the right decision. Such was her control. So, no power words, or overt use of higher planar energy; conventional spells only. Although she had used her dagger to surreptitiously break the skin of one finger. Just enough to bleed a little. Nothing noticeable – she'd had worse paper cuts – but enough to facilitate blood magic. Even that, though, she used strictly for shields and other defences. Not for attack. She knew Ulvarius never mastered stable blood magic – as with many aspects of magic, Dreya was the first. She didn't want to risk him learning it from her now.

Ulvarius was not so restrained as he counter-attacked, lacing each of his offensive spells with what he now knew to be higher planar energy. It would empower each strike five, six, even tenfold. They should cut through ordinary wizards' shields as easily as paper, but to Ulvarius' astonishment, impossibly, their shields were holding up against him.

The battle raged for an hour or more without any real progress on either side. There were a few allied casualties, but Mandalee quickly retrieved them from the battlefield using her super-speed. She left most of the healing to Catriona so that she could conserve her energy for these quick rescue raids and for what was to come. Druid magic was enough to get the wizards back on their feet and into battle once more, in just a few heartbeats.

But Ulvarius didn't get to be the tyrant he was without being adaptable. Instead of trying to fight the whole army at once, he instead focussed his will on one sorceress in robes of purple. His gaze fixed on her to the exclusion of all else, relying on his shields to protect him as he reached out, mentally, and crushed her heart. The sorceress collapsed to the ground, unmoving. Mandalee didn't bother trying to collect her: she and Cat both knew there was nothing they could do.

Three more collapsed in the next five minutes, only one of whom could be revived.

Casualties were inevitable in a battle, however, and this was the moment Dreya had been waiting for. As Ulvarius fixed his exclusive focus on another victim, Dreya turned to Sephora beside her and gave a sharp nod.

"Now."

The sorceress concentrated her magic to generate a powerful magnetic field, even as Ulvarius focussed on drowning a White robed wizard in his own blood. The wizard died with blood seeping out from every pore and orifice, but before Ulvarius could select another victim at random, he looked down in astonishment at the pouch he kept attached to his belt. The pouch that contained the source of his extra power: the fragment.

"No!" he cried in horror. He couldn't let them take it from him. It had come to him. It was meant for him. It was his to command.

But the sharp metal had other ideas as it cut through the pouch's resilient leather wall and flew out towards Sephora's outstretched hand. Seeing this, Ulvarius turned his furious gaze on her, for he didn't need to be touching the fragment to make it work for him. Proximity was enough, and it was still sufficiently close. He felt the power and pulled it to him. It was stubborn, flying out not in a steady stream but in bursts, as if trying to resist Ulvarius' will, but he had mastery enough for this.

Forgoing traditional magic, he lashed out with a straightforward energy beam, intending to incinerate Sephora on the spot. There didn't seem to be an annoying druid girl around this time to reflect it back, so he believed it was a guaranteed kill, but another Black robe sorceress had already stepped between them as if anticipating the strike. The beam shot out and took a sizeable chunk out of the ground, but when the dust settled, both mages were unharmed.

Somehow, this other sorceress had shielded them. He realised this must be Darla. Neither sorceress held the fragment, though. It had been thrown clear by the blast. He desperately scanned the battlefield for it. Already he could feel his power waning. The wizard army had stepped up their attack, sensing his relative weakness, and some of their strikes were beginning to penetrate his shields. He needed his fragment.

He spotted it, gleaming in the middle distance and teleported to it, but someone else had got there first. A figure in white – his escaped cleric captive.

Mandalee had been watching for this moment and tracked the fragment as it flew. Using her super-speed, she ran to grab it. Her anticipation and speed were enough to beat Ulvarius'

teleportation – just. She held the fragment in her hand and began to streak away, but as Dreya had predicted, an enraged Ulvarius threw wave after wave of spells at her back. She was thankful she'd heeded her friend's advice about wearing her magically resistant combat suit. She could never have survived in her leather. As it was, she wasn't sure how much of a pounding the fabric could take and used her Guardian magic to squeeze out an extra bit of speed. Ulvarius seemed to realise his direct magic wasn't working, so switched to indirect magic, throwing rocks, debris and even trees at the White Assassin. Even that failed, however, as suddenly a blast of wind threw everything back at him, instead, forcing an emergency teleport.

Dreya glanced over at the treeline and caught the eyes of Catriona, who sent a sympathic message telling her fiancée that she couldn't expect her to stand by and do nothing when her friend was under attack. Dreya conceded the point with a smile and a nod.

When he materialised, Ulvarius had totally lost his bearings, and the thief was nowhere to be seen.

Chapter 14

"Where is it?" Ulvarius demanded.

Dreya could feel him attempting a mental assault, so she drew energy from her physical defence shields to counter it, still not wanting to let him know her true power.

"No idea," she replied. "I specifically asked her not to tell me."

She tried to act nonchalant, but internally there was a battle going on, for Ulvarius wasn't the only one attacking her mind. There was someone else. Something else. Something more powerful and dangerous than any tyrannical wizard.

'*I do not need the distraction right now,*' she thought.

She had to stifle this quickly. Fighting a mental war on two fronts now, she was forced to access more of her power. She hoped her shroud was still intact but sparing any effort to check would only make it more likely to crack.

Fortunately, Ulvarius had a distraction of his own, as Dagamir pressed forward with a group of mages to attack Ulvarius up close. Dagamir himself even brought his sword into play. It was a curious weapon. It crackled and sparked, glowing red as he channelled his magic through it, yet it didn't seem to have any gems embedded into the hilt. It was as if the steel blade itself was enchanted. But that was impossible. Dreya dismissed the puzzle with a shake of the head. She couldn't afford to distract herself any further. Not now.

Hodge attacked Ulvarius from a different angle, while Sephora had banded together the remainder to attack head-on. The tyrant quickly found himself under attack from all sides.

Catriona found it interesting to note that most of those with Hodge were wearing something predominantly white, while Sephora's group tended to be wearing black. About half of Dagamir's section were favouring red, and the other half comprised most of the other colours there present, including the sorceress in hot pink. It was almost as if the Triumvirate system were forming before her eyes.

Ulvarius was forced to give up his mental attack in favour of physical magic. More wizards died from his magical assault, but

since Ulvarius was now robbed of his advantage, the remaining eighty-odd wizards of this proto-Council were feeling emboldened, using energy reserves they never knew they had.

Even in her distracted state, Dreya saw this and began to worry that her plan may have gone a little too well. Ulvarius did not fall at the Battle of Compton, but the way things were, it looked as if that might change this time around. Whether the resulting future would be better or worse was not for her to say. As a Guardian, she knew she couldn't permit such a radical alteration to the Timeline. Sure, she had helped to make a bigger one at the Fall of Kullos, but on that occasion, the alternative was the destruction of Tempestria, perhaps the whole of Creation. Changing *that* Timeline had to be justified. This was different. So, putting a tight lid on her internal troubles, she returned her focus to the battle and reversed something she had done earlier.

*****

"Ah, now *that* is the Dreya I know and love," Cat remarked to herself as she watched from her hidden vantage point.

"Why? What's she done this time?" Mandalee asked, having sped back from wherever she'd hidden the fragment. Cat refused to let her see that she'd made her jump. "You never explained before."

"It was your ridiculous radical plan," Cat pointed out.

"Oh, I'm happy to take credit. I'd just like to know what I'm taking credit for."

Cat reminded her friend of their encounter with Vashti and the other children from Tedstone. Mandalee had helped Dreya forge a bond with them by getting her to pretend they were giving her some of their magic. It may have been a game to the White Guardian, but clearly, her Black counterpart had taken the lesson to heart and applied it to this battle. If Ulvarius had accessed the fragment enough to fire beam cannon blasts of higher planar energy, then the allied army was going to need shields of that same energy. By that same token, since Ulvarius would have such shields himself, their magical attacks would also have to be laced with that power, or they would never penetrate.

However, the only other source of higher planar energy – short of an anachronistic meeting with Daelen StormTiger, or asking his dark clone or Kullos very nicely – was Dreya herself.

"Wait!" Mandalee gasped in a loud whisper as she began to see where her friend was going with this. "Are you saying that Dreya the Dark, the power-hungry sorceress feared by many and loved by about four, actually *gave away* some of her power to others?"

"Well," Cat replied, "by the looks of things, it was more of a loan than a gift – she just took it all back again because otherwise they're going to change history and kill Ulvarius right here. But the point still stands." She shook her head in wonder. "For one shining moment, Dreya the Dark gave away power."

"Cat, I know I've said this before, but now I really do need a drink. Are you sure you don't have any in that pocket dimension of yours?"

Cat shook her head. "As soon as we get home, I swear I'm making it a priority."

*****

The attacking wizards ignored what they assumed was growing fatigue and pressed home their advantage. Ulvarius continued to lash out, and more wizards fell. Despite Cat and Mandalee's best efforts, two never got up again. At last, however, the tyrant knew he was beaten. His fragment was lost. Maybe he could find it again, maybe not, but either way, he was still the Greatest Mage Who Ever Lived. This was just a minor setback. He would retreat to his Tower and resume his work. He still controlled most of Elvaria and would soon expand his reach to conquer the rest. Just a bit more work and he would perfect the process of turning people into the most powerful undead the world had ever seen. True Undead with enough intelligence to work independently and adapt to changing circumstances, yet slaves that he could control directly when necessary. Undead that could endure for centuries. Infinitely more useful and productive than all those pointless people living their pointless lives. Soon, Elvaria would be a continent of True Undead, and then he would stretch out his

influence overseas to engulf Alloria and who even knew what lay beyond that?

"Enough of this nonsense!" he declared.

It was time to get back to conquering the world, but just before he left, he was determined to deliver one, final message. Extract the price of their defiance.

He gathered most of his remaining power and unleashed a crackling barrage of dark lightning at the one who was clearly the most powerful wizard there…

*****

Dreya the Dark was still in the process of restoring the balance of her power and dealing with the tormenting presence in her mind. All of this provided sufficient distraction that she failed to notice the warning of her magical defences until it was almost too late. Her shields powered up quickly, but not before some of the dark lightning painfully singed her skin and threw her to the ground. It was a minor wound; one she knew either of her companions could treat in a moment. Indeed, they were both at her side in seconds, fixing up the physical damage. It was nothing.

Far more important was that the capricious entity that was in her mind had taken full advantage. She'd tried to slam the door shut and most of it was contained, partitioned once more, but something had escaped her control. Just a tiny sliver, a small fragment, just for a moment. Now it had slipped away, hiding somewhere in her mind and try as she might, she couldn't find it. She briefly worried about what that might mean for her future, but she stifled such thoughts immediately. No, she was Dreya the Dark, and she would have control, now and always. There was nothing that sliver could do as long as she was vigilant. The instant it tried anything she would be aware of it. Then she would catch that pesky thing and put it back in its box with the rest of it. As long as no more escaped – which it wouldn't – it was no threat to her.

Meanwhile, Ulvarius was incensed that he hadn't killed her.

"Dammit!" he cried. A shout that morphed into a scream of pain as Dagamir's magical sword sliced away what little flesh still

clung to his left arm. “I should have gone for you instead, Dagamir!” he spat.

“Try and correct your mistake if you dare!” he retorted. “You’re finished, Ulvarius! Your reign of terror ends today!”

But Ulvarius still had just enough magic left to crack open the boundary spell and teleport away as the power of Dagamir’s sword, an instant too late, buried itself harmlessly in a tree.

*****

Catriona helped her fiancée to her feet and dusted down her black velvet robes.

“Are you OK?” she asked.

Dreya insisted she was unharmed.

The wizards of the army mostly slumped to the ground where they were as the adrenaline rush that had sustained them finally receded, leaving them exhausted.

Dagamir, however, sheathed his sword and strode over to the Guardians. He was soon shaking Dreya’s hand so hard, Cat briefly thought it was an attack. Mandalee even scanned for damage.

“Darla!” he bellowed in his usual gregarious fashion. “We all owe you a debt of thanks. You and your healer friends.” He shook their hands with equal ferocity. “A druid and a cleric,” he observed. “Interesting company you keep.”

Stepping back, he took in the sight of the fallen wizards.

“It was a victory, but a costly one,” he announced, solemnly. “Still, I’ve always said we can achieve great things if we just work together.” To the assembled wizards, he shouted, “My friends! Haven’t I always said that?”

The wearied response he got was not enough for his liking, so he tried again.

“Friends! Haven’t I always said we can achieve great things together?”

With a supreme effort, they managed to muster up a slightly louder cheer.

‘*Does he always do that?*’ Mandalee asked Dreya, sympathically.

The sorceress gave a small smile and a nod.

“But you, Darla,” Dagamir continued. “You were the one who sparked off this whole endeavour and I cannot thank you enough.”

“Don’t mention it,” Dreya replied. Dagamir grinned, clearly believing she was being modest. “No, seriously,” she stated, firmly, “don’t mention it. To anyone. Ever.”

“Yep,” Mandalee agreed. “Just forget about us.”

“It’s like we were never here,” Cat concurred, her face white as a sheet. She felt like she was talking to a living ghost, and she was keen to stop.

Dagamir noticed her pallor and asked if she was feeling alright.

Offering a weak smile, she just dismissed it as fatigue from all her healing. “But we really should be going, now, Darla,” she prompted.

Mandalee caught on to why her friend was acting so strange and sought to help her cover it.

“Yes, Darla,” she agreed, “I need to show you where I hid the fragment so you can dispose of it safely.”

Dreya didn’t understand why her two companions were in such a rush but didn’t want to argue in front of Dagamir and the others, so she bade a quick farewell and began to walk away.

“But Darla!” Sephora called out. “You haven’t even heard about our plans!”

“Yes!” Hodge agreed. “After other wizards hear about today, they’re going to flock to the Forum, and that will be the start of—”

“—The start of a new co-operative Council for wizards across Elvaria,” Dagamir interrupted, calling after the three who continued to walk away, regardless.

“Yeah, you should get on that!” Mandalee shouted back, her pace unwavering.

“Sounds good!” Dreya agreed.

“But Darla, I thought you’d want to be part of it!”

“Not possible,” Cat insisted. “We were never here!”

As the assembled wizards looked on in astonishment, the three figures softly shimmered out of reality.

“Extraordinary!” Hodge remarked.

"That's how Darla appeared in the Forum," Dagamir remembered. "She said it was a dressed-up teleportation spell."

"Didn't look like any teleportation spell I've ever seen," Sephora insisted once more.

Dagamir shrugged. "Oh well, I guess they were never here."

*****

Having retrieved the fragment from where Mandalee had left it – she had asked a friendly woodpigeon if he'd mind keeping it in her nest for a short time – Catriona wrapped it in a Timeless field so they could transport it through a portal safely, without the power destabilising further.

She resolved not to mention the fact that Dagamir should have died in the battle. A quick glance and a slight shake of the head was all Mandalee needed to understand her best friend's choice.

The truth was, it was a mistake they should have foreseen. Ulvarius had struck out at the most powerful mage in the army. He was consistent about that. Unfortunately, this time that mage was obviously Dreya, despite how she'd tried to shroud her power. While she could defend against the attack, Dagamir would never have stood a chance, so Dreya had unwittingly saved his life. Still, there was nothing they could do about it now. They just needed to make sure Ulvarius' ultimate demise remained on schedule.

According to the history they knew, those seeds would be sown in a few weeks in a village near what would become Lake Quernhow or the Lake of Tears, formed when Ulvarius was in a particularly vindictive mood. There, he was scheduled to meet someone who would prophesy that there would one day be a wizard more powerful than he. A prophecy that would feed his paranoia, eat away at him until he flung himself from the roof of his Tower and cursed his grounds for the next three hundred years until that more powerful wizard, Dreya, could come to claim his home for herself.

That part of history needed to remain intact, for it could affect their own personal Timelines. Compared to that, Catriona believed that any effects from Dagamir's survival should be minimal. Dreya calculated the necessary Temporal co-ordinates,

but Catriona was the one to open the portal, lest she fall out of practice and become too reliant on her fiancée's power. Pulling themselves out of sync with the flow of Time, they entered the portal.

Upon stepping out again, they found that everywhere was dark. Not dark as in night, but dark as in everything's been blotted out. They could still hear events unfolding around them, but dimly, distantly. Too indistinct to make out.

At first, the Guardians were worried they had managed to screw up the world rather than save it, but then Catriona remembered something she'd read in the *Chronicles* about Temporal Black Spots. Wards placed there by the Guardians at the behest of the Council, and given the nature of Time manipulation, present Guardians could experience such Black Spots placed there by future ones.

The three companions took this as a positive sign. It implied that there was once again a Council of Mages to order such wards and future Guardians to carry out the job, which further indicated a fruitful legacy of their own work.

Slowly, gradually, the world faded back into view and the Guardians found themselves standing on the bank of the newly formed Lake Quernhow. The only water remaining in the middle of a dry, desolate expanse. The lake they knew hid an ancient repository of knowledge that, in about three hundred years, Cat would destroy. She wished she could use her Guardian powers to change that, but it was impossible. She couldn't change her own past, and even if she could, there would still be the matter of Ulvarius' undead army to deal with. No, much as she still hated what happened that day, there was nothing to be done about it.

Ulvarius had been and gone by now, having completed his handiwork. The whole area for several square miles was devoid of all life. In time, nature and eventually people would reclaim this place, but for now, there wasn't a single living thing…with one exception.

Standing on the far side of the lake was a single solitary figure glowing with a bright radiance that made it difficult to look at them directly, even from a distance. Neither Dreya nor Mandalee had seen anything like it before, and the figure defied analysis by either magic or nature.

Catriona, however, remembered her one previous encounter with this entity very well. They had come to her on the worst day of her life. The best day of her life. The day the world of her childhood was ripped asunder. The day her new adult life began. It was the day that had made her who she was: a druid and a Guardian. This was the entity Catriona referred to as her Angel.

"Stop probing, you two, it's not polite," she admonished her companions. "Besides, it's futile. Nothing we can possibly do will penetrate their shroud unless they wish it."

The Angel held in their hand a wooden staff with a blue crystal on top, which they casually popped into a pocket dimension, before disappearing.

Catriona was surprised when Mandalee pointed out that she was crying. She hadn't even noticed, but when she brought her hand to her face, her fingers came back wet, and she knew it was true. Her fiancée and her best friend placed an arm around her from either side, offering comfort and support.

"Are you alright, Cat?" Dreya asked, concerned.

Cat assured her that she was.

"You're sure?" Mandalee checked.

Cat nodded, sniffled slightly and wiped away the moisture. "Yes, honestly. Just seeing my Angel again brought it all back. Everything about that day. It's OK," she insisted. "It was a long time ago, now." She frowned for a moment, then added, "Or about three hundred years in the future, depending on how you look at it."

"Time travel's weird," Dreya decided.

"I need a drink," Mandalee put in.

"I think we all do," Cat concurred. "Well, I think we're done here, yes?"

The others agreed.

"In that case, Dreya, I'll let you take us back home."

Dreya opened a portal to Catriona's Meadow. From there, she opened another to the ancient temple that Michael was rebuilding on the edge of the Rhynas Desert on Alloria.

As they stepped through, however, the Guardians felt the fragment's power stir for a moment, and the co-ordinates shifted, as if the fragment were being pulled by something in that region of space and time.

*****

Sara was sitting on a bench at the picnic table outside Michael's home, fiddling with her latest technological attempt. The palm-sized device still refused to work, and she couldn't understand why. It was incredibly frustrating.

"Why won't you work, you stupid thing?" she muttered. "I know it's a different world, and there's magic here, but the same laws of physics apply…more or less." She held up her work in her hands, drawing it close to her face, staring at it, intently. "Why won't you work!" she enunciated once more, as though it might tell her, if only she asked it enough times.

A few feet away, her sister, Jessica, focussed on a group of daffodils growing around Michael's pond, in which the Champion of the Gods, just behind her, was standing knee deep, trying to clear the algae.

"Now listen, Alycia, dearie," Jessica said to thin air, an annoyed frown on her face. "I know I'm not from around here and not really a part of the nature of this world, but would it be so terrible to help me grow these flowers a bit?" She focussed her senses, trying to touch nature's power. Catriona had always made it look so easy.

"I do admire the way you two refuse to give up," Michael approved, "but you could help me and go back to it later, you know."

"In a minute!" the sisters chorused.

"You've been saying that for an hour," he grumbled.

Sara's device sparked into life, suddenly, as a round, blue shimmering doorway opened in midair next to the pond, out of which three familiar young women jumped clear.

Startled, Sara dropped her device, which smashed on the table. Jessica, in turn, lost her focus and glanced her sister's way, accidentally causing two of the legs of Sara's seat to grow fifty feet. It toppled over, sending her flying through the air, straight into her sister. Jessica then collided with Michael, who fell over in the pond with a splash, ending up with a face full of algae and half a lungful of water, which he began to cough up.

Sara was the first to her feet, cautiously walking over to her three Tempestrian friends, her tail swishing with apprehension.

Tentatively, she reached out to touch Catriona and seemed astonished to find her solid and real.

"See?" Jessica challenged her sister, picking herself up. "I told you they weren't dead!"

"Dead?" Mandalee wondered, confused. "Why would we be dead?"

"And what are you lot doing here, anyway?" Dreya wondered. "Shouldn't you be on Lavos finding that lost fragment?"

"We already did that," Jessica told them. Sara still seemed to be having trouble coming to terms with their friends' existence, prodding each of them in turn. "Sara just dropped it over there." She nodded towards the table with the now rather useless seat.

"You found it already? That was quick!" Cat remarked.

"Not really," Sara disputed.

"Girls," Michael called out, climbing onto the bank, "I don't think they know."

"Know?" Cat wondered. "Know what?"

"That day when you came to me needing help," Michael began, "when Dreya's grounds attacked you, and you sent us to Lavos…" he paused and shared a look with the two Chetsuans before finishing, "That was over two years ago!"

Chapter 15

The three companions, Sara, Jessica and Michael, had arrived on what remained of Daelen's Lavosian base, situated in a town in the country of Weslend. It was the principal seat of power and governance for the Northern continent – the Vranian Alliance.

The base was in quite a sorry state. During Daelen's final battle with Kullos, he had pulled power from all of his bases except Earth, causing systems to overload. His Lavosian home was devastated but it was still shielded from the rest of the world.

Just clearing up the mess took up the best part of a week. During that time, Sara and Michael set about repairing the power generation systems to at least get the lights on, and the heating, too, as it was winter in Weslend and the snow had arrived.

Not having her sister's tech skills, Jessica ventured outside with the aid of a perception filter. The filter didn't have to work too hard on this world, because the Lavosian people had evolved along similar lines to the Chetsuans of Phitonia, only their skin tones tended to be golden rather than deep purple. Daelen always had a good stash of local currency in each world he frequented, and so Jessica took what she needed to buy food.

Before heading to the shops, she decided to call on a friend. His name was Laoghaire, Lao for short. The only person in the world who knew Jessica and her sister were aliens.

*****

Lao owned and ran a small technology store all by himself, building personal computers and doing repairs. It was a little place that served the local community, always struggling to survive in the face of competition from larger chains.

He had known them on and off for a few months, back in the day, since Lavos was the world they had visited the most when not on Earth. At first, they had just been new customers – Sara had been on the hunt for parts for whatever gadget she'd been tinkering with at the time. Jessica couldn't remember what it was, if she ever knew in the first place. All she knew was that her sister was curious about the possibilities of combining the technology of Lavos with

that of Earth and even the shadow warrior technology that Daelen had rigged up in each of his bases, although Jessica was convinced he hadn't done it himself. Daelen had about as much technical know-how as she did: enough to use it without any clear understanding of how it worked. Not like Sara did. Over time, they became regular visitors to Lao's shop and, eventually, his friends.

One day, when Sara took her latest project to Laoghaire, Jessica had quickly grown bored, and Lao suggested she might prefer to go for a walk in the local park. Jessica agreed that sounded much more like her cup of tea, although she then had to explain what tea was since they didn't have it on this world.

About an hour later, she was starting to feel quite hungry, so she returned to the shop intending to go out for a meal with Sara, enjoy some local cuisine. Seeing that Sara and Laoghaire were still at it, technological parts and components strewn everywhere, Jessica gave them a long-suffering look. When they got like this, the pair of them could forget all about mundane things like food and rest.

"Come on, Sara, you must be at least a bit peckish by now!" she whined as she closed the short distance from the shop doorway.

Laoghaire looked up and gasped, "Don't step on that!"

Jessica looked down, saw how her foot was coming down onto something that looked fragile, tried to shift her weight to avoid it, tripped and had to grab the worktop to stop herself falling. As she did so, her hand came down close to what they were working on, and despite her best efforts, her fingers touched the delicate components. There was a spark of static electricity, painful enough to cause her to bring her hand to mouth and suck the tip of her finger for a moment. A finger that she suddenly realised was her natural Chetsuan purple colour instead of Lavosian gold. Somehow, that electrical spark had shorted out her perception filter. Sarah deactivated hers, too, knowing that she and her sister suddenly had a lot of explaining to do.

Once he got over the initial shock, Lao took it rather well. Aliens were a known fact to the people of Lavos. Recent technological advances had led them to be able to detect life energy signatures from distant star systems. He'd even rigged up an amateur version himself, and there were many projects underway to try and find a way to make first contact.

“Like a proper ‘E.T. phone home’ deal,” Jessica remarked. “Only, you’re phoning E.T.”

“You’re always saying things like that,” Lao remarked. “Like you have a whole different set of pop culture references.”

“It’s a movie reference from Earth,” Sara explained. “Kind of like the vidcasts you have here.”

“Earth? Your homeworld?” Laoghaire wondered. He blinked and added, “I can’t believe I actually just used the word ‘homeworld’ for real!”

“Adopted homeworld,” Sara corrected, “but Jessica’s gone native.”

“What about your actual native world?” Seeing the look that passed between the two sisters, he realised he’d inadvertently wandered onto a sensitive subject and apologised. “Sorry, you don’t have to tell me, obviously.”

“No, love, you don’t need to apologise,” Jessica insisted, “and we don’t mind sharing, do we, sis?”

Sara shook her head. “No, though you might wish we hadn’t.”

“Tell you what, why don’t we go out and eat together?” Leo suggested. “There’s a place just down the road that have tables in private alcoves. They use sound-filtering technology to help make conversations inaudible to anyone else,” he explained. “It’s an interesting system, actually—”

Lao caught himself as Jessica yawned, pointedly.

“—Yes, well, you don’t want to know how it works, naturally. The point is, we can relax, talk about anything you want and not have to worry about anyone overhearing.”

“Sounds great, dearie, but I don’t think your fancy tech will help much if we can’t fix my perception filter.”

Sara nodded. “Given your world’s media, I don’t think our evening out will involve much privacy if we’re at the centre of a first contact situation.”

In the end, they did manage to fix the device and enjoy their meal without causing a media sensation. Since then, they’d only been back a couple of times before events on Tempestria came to a head.

*****

Reaching *Lao's Techspot*, on the corner of a pair of busy streets, Jessica pushed open the door and stepped inside. Lao was dealing with a customer, so the Chetsuan pretended to browse what he had on display, keeping her back to the counter. When the other customer had left, Lao called out, "Can I help you find something, Miss?"

"That's what I'm hoping," she replied, still not turning around, "but I don't reckon you'll have it here."

"Well, if not, I can always order something in for you," he offered.

"Ah, if only it were that simple," she sighed, "but you see, E.T. needs your help."

Lao shot up out of his seat. "Jessica?"

Turning around at last with a grin, she sang, "Heya, love! Miss me?"

He ran over, swept her up in an embrace and changed the sign on the door to read 'CLOSED', all in one fluid movement.

"I haven't seen you for ages. Let me look at you!" He stepped back to see her properly, and Jessica switched off her perception filter. "There you are!" he beamed. "Now, what have you been up to since I last saw you?"

"Oh, that is a long story," she laughed. "So much has changed, and I'd be happy to tell you all about it, but I meant what I said before: I really do need your help. If you don't have any plans…?" Lao shook his head. "In that case, once I've picked up a few groceries, I'd like to take you home for dinner."

"Home?" he wondered,

Jessica nodded. "We have a place. Sort of. You'll see."

"We? Sara's around, too, then?"

"Actually, love, it's Sara, me and a friend."

"Who's that?" he wondered.

"He's part of my long story, but I need to warn you – you think me and Sara are E.T., but this guy really is from out of this world…or any other."

"Well, you can paint me interested," Lao replied.

"It's 'colour me intrigued', dear," she corrected.

He shook his head. "Not on this world, it isn't."

"Well, however you want to say it, will you come?"

"Sure," he agreed, grabbing a warm coat and opening the door as Jessica reactivated her perception filter. "Just lead the way."

*****

Upon seeing their approach, Sara manipulated the barrier to allow Lao access. Before his battle with Kullos, Daelen had strengthened the barrier to function as a containment field. On Phitonia, Dreya had managed to bypass the technology with her magic, but otherwise, the barrier would not allow even a single atom to enter, apart from filtered air to breathe. There was no longer any need for such defences, so Sara powered down the barriers in all connected worlds to their former state. After that, the Lavosian base would once again accept invited guests just as the Earth barriers had accepted Catriona and Mandalee. The uninvited would naturally avoid the area without realising it. No-one on Lavos even noticed there was a gap in their maps and satellite imagery. The perception filter permeated everything to prevent detection.

Bringing people back to Daelen's base – on any world – had been absolutely out of the question before. Sara had initially been against it even now, but Jessica convinced her that it was the most expedient way to do what they had to do.

Once inside, a slightly grimy Sara greeted him with a hug.

"Thanks for coming, Lao," she offered. "Sorry about the mess."

Lao really didn't mind. To find himself in Daelen StormTiger's secret base was a thrill no matter what condition it might be in.

The next thing to do was to introduce him to Ossian Miach Kaidool. The sisters were nervous about this. Sure, Lao had accepted them readily enough, but other than their colouration, they looked almost Lavosian. Michael, however, standing at seven feet, with dried, translucent skin stretched like parchment over a horned skull, looked somewhat alarming by anybody's standards. The Chetsuans' first sight of him had been at the Battle of the Rhynas Desert. They'd heard of him from conversations with Daelen, but there was little that could have prepared them. A photo

would have helped, Sara supposed, but the only times he and Daelen were together was when they were saving Tempestria from either Kullos or Daelen's dark clone. If it was the former, he was Fated to die in every Final Battle. In the latter case, the clone generally killed him anyway, out of spite, to aid his escape. In either situation, stopping to take a selfie had not been uppermost in their minds. But if Lao was going to work with them, he was going to have to meet Michael. Adapting a perception filter to make the demigod look Lavosian wouldn't alter the fact that he was too large to fit through the average doorway.

Michael was in the kitchen cooking dinner, when his friends brought in Lao, who immediately screamed and ran out of the room until Jessica stopped him.

"It's no good," she growled, trying to look menacing. "You're trapped! You see, when I said I wanted to bring you home for dinner, I meant you were on the menu, and we're all going to gobble you up!"

It took Lao a moment to realise she was joking, but once he did, he burst out laughing, which helped his fear to evaporate. Even so, his heart was still pounding in his ears, as he re-entered the kitchen and tentatively accepted Michael's offer of a handshake.

"Sorry about before, er, Michael," he offered, nervously. "It's…well, you're a lot to take in."

"Not to worry, son," Michael assured him. "I've had much worse reactions in my time. Now, why don't you sit down," he suggested, pulling out a chair, "before you faint?"

Lao gave him a weak smile and accepted the seat.

"See, Jess?" Sara remarked with a twinkle in her eye. "I told you he'd be able to handle it."

"Excuse me, sis!" Jessica laughed from where she was standing over to one side waiting for the kettle to boil, "but I think you'll find it was my suggestion!"

"Don't remember that," Sara disputed, although her smirk suggested otherwise.

"Well, while my sister gets her memory back," Jessica told Lao bringing over a tray with four steaming mugs. "Let me introduce you to something from our new home that's a bit easier to swallow – a cup of tea."

The sisters briefly explained their change of circumstances. The tea they were drinking was a blend of leaves they had picked up from Gaggleswick. Dreya's stocks had quickly run out, now that the number of people living in her Tower had just doubled from two to four, so they'd volunteered to pick some up. It had seemed like the perfect opportunity to begin to orientate themselves with the Elvarian town and get a feel for what daily life would be like for them in their new home, their new world.

When they got back to the Black Tower, though, the grounds had attacked them and the next thing they knew, they were off on a mission on Lavos, so they'd brought the tea with them.

"Somewhere on your world, Lao," Michael explained, "there's terrible danger. A few weeks ago, your time, Daelen StormTiger's great enemy, Kullos, sent a fragment of a shadow warrior device through a portal to Lavos. It must be fairly crackling with an unstable blend of magic and higher planar energy that, with all due respect to your people, you're just not equipped to handle. We need to retrieve it and return it safely to Tempestria where it can be safely locked away."

"This is why we need your help," Sara told him. "Between you, me and Michael, I believe we've got enough technical ability to construct some kind of detector or tracking device."

"Also," Jessica added, "we need some ideas of where to start looking so we need your local knowledge. In general, what's the state of play here since…" she paused, considering how to narrow down a time frame. After a moment's thought, she got it. "Say, since Daelen last came here," she finished.

"Good thinking, Jess," Sara approved. "We know he came here to sort out some kind of plot against the dragons." She remembered the note he had left for Catriona and Mandalee. "He never told us any details, but knowing him, well—"

"—Well, 'subtle' wasn't really in his vocabulary, was it, loves?"

Michael chuckled. "No, my dear, it wasn't."

Lao certainly knew the incident in question – the whole world did.

"So, since then, have there been any major developments on your world?" Michael wondered.

“I’ll say there has!” Lao agreed. “Everyone’s talking about it: they’re calling it the Grand Relocation Plan.”

Chapter 16

Rather than tell them himself, Lao took out his portacom; a portable computing/communications device that looked like nothing more than a folded plastic sheet. He unfolded it to form a ten-inch screen, activated it and propped it up on his mug on the table.

He spoke to it. "News. Grand Location Plan. Play random."

After a moment, the screen played clips from various news broadcasts about the issue he had requested. There were many versions of the story, told from different perspectives, but out of that jumble, the essentials became clear. A 'rogue government faction' had masterminded the development of a biogenic weapon that would be capable of wiping out the 'scourge of the dragons' from the skies of Lavos. According to the reports, research had been at a 'very early stage' when the 'mysterious extra-planar being' Daelen StormTiger had burst into their world and 'exposed the plot'. Actions that led to 'unfortunate but unavoidable casualties.' Government leaders had assured him that they had been 'unaware of the extent of the crime.' However, they had every confidence that their own intelligence agencies would have 'uncovered the plot' before there was 'any real danger' of such a bioweapon being completed.

There had been several high-profile arrests made after the event. The public was assured that those who had been pulling strings from afar would be prosecuted. The authorities were apparently 'sure beyond all reasonable doubt' that, thanks to skilled interrogation, they had identified all those responsible.

The pro-dragon opposition was quick to condemn the plot and called for an independent investigation into government involvement. They demanded the President's resignation and an election in the face of this 'government-sanctioned genocide attempt.'

The government had rejected this 'unreasonable overreaction' and accused the opposition of 'political opportunism,' trying to take political advantage from this 'terrible crime.' They issued a statement, reassuring the public that while they continued to take the 'threat of the dragons' very seriously,

they would never condone such an ‘extremist policy.’ They reiterated their commitment to reducing ‘unwarranted violence’ against dragons and were ‘actively seeking a peaceful solution.’

Now, according to a recent announcement, such a solution had been found. There was a large southern island continent, Wirathia, whose people were known to be very pro-dragon. Wirathian towns and cities were mostly limited to the outer fringes. The interior of the continent consisted of mostly unspoiled forests, deserts and mountainous regions that were unsuitable for modern Lavosian civilisation, but ideal for dragons. Indeed, according to studies, the continent already had by far the highest concentration of dragons anywhere in the world.

A few days ago, the Weslend government announced to the media that, following a successful summit with the other member states of the Vranian Alliance and the government of Wirathia, that the southern island continent was to become the new dragon homeland. Dragons were to be ‘encouraged in the strongest possible terms’ to accept their new home as the ‘best solution for everybody’ so that everyone would feel safe.

A new technological solution had been developed to create a kind of forcefield around Vranian territory that would keep dragons safely within. By international agreement, that territory would extend significantly further into what were currently international waters. This additional territory for Wirathia was the international community’s way of thanking them for agreeing to this proposal. The dragons would be free to do as they wished within this vast expanse, safe from hunters and ‘other hardline elements.’

Responding to accusations from the pro-dragon opposition in Weslend that this was tantamount to a penal colony for innocent dragons, they dismissed such ‘emotive language.’ The area they were talking about was further than many free Lavosians travelled in a lifetime. Besides, if the dragons were only patient, a kind of dragon passport system was being developed. This would grant individual dragons licence to travel beyond the barrier, providing it could be demonstrated that they had committed no crime or offence against Lavosians. It was also their hope, they said, that such a demonstration of peaceful co-existence would offer reassurance and inspire a ‘softening of policy’ against dragonkind.

They strongly encouraged dragons to take up this offer quickly, because, they were sorry to say, the intelligence community were on 'high alert.' They had detected increased chatter in terrorist circles about plans for a major attack against the dragons sometime in the next few weeks. Obviously, they explained, they couldn't go into details for reasons of security. Still, they once again urged dragons across the world to take refuge in the generous sanctuary provided by Wirathia, at least until the 'imminent crisis' was over. Once complete, the forcefield around Wirathia could be erected at a moment's notice and would be 'absolutely impregnable' by any outside force, they promised.

It seemed as if dragons were seizing this lifeline as there had been a mass southern migration and dragon sightings in the northern hemisphere were becoming increasingly rare. Even so, northern governments everywhere were imploring dragons to step up their migration because the terrorist threat was 'absolutely real.' The forcefield was due to be erected in just four weeks, which, according to intelligence reports, would give the terrorists insufficient time to organise. If dragons were to miss that deadline, it would be more difficult to process their entry, and any such delays could leave them vulnerable to the 'growing threat.'

*****

"Sounds like a good idea," Sara offered when Lao shut down his device.

"You can't be serious!" Jessica objected.

"Why not? The dragons get a home, safe from attack. What's wrong with that?"

"You don't really believe this 'terror attack' rubbish that conveniently shows up at the same time as this plan, do you? Sounds too much like some of the excuses they made on Earth for some of their 'security measures'."

"I see what you're saying, Jess, and I guess the timing is a bit suspicious, but it's carrot and stick, isn't it? The pull of a promised land and the threat of this terror attack, real or imagined, to push them into accepting it."

"But if this promised land is all it's cracked up to be," Michael offered, "why would they need to be pushed into it?"

"Look, all I know is if somebody on Phitonia had come up with an idea like this before the dragons turned on our people, maybe we'd still have a civilisation. A home."

Finally, Jessica understood where her sister was coming from. Despite the stories they told Lao and even their Tempestrian friends, no-one really knew what they and their people had been through. The only other person that might have an inkling was Dreya. She'd gone there and conquered their world, using extreme force and the threat of more to make the dragons cower before her. Still, she'd only seen a snapshot of their world. She hadn't grown up there, lived there, so even she couldn't really know what Sara and Jessica had suffered as a people and as individuals.

Despite being twins, Sara had somehow always been the 'older sister' doing her best to look after her 'younger sister', trying to protect and shield her. Even when that wasn't possible, she was always the one to put aside her own pain and terror to try and help Jessica deal with hers.

No, nobody else would ever truly understand like they did, but Lavos was not Phitonia, and Jessica felt that the lens through which her sister was seeing these events didn't work here. She was fighting the last war when she needed to see the new battles for what they were. Still, she didn't want to argue with her sister over events that frankly didn't concern them one way or the other. Leaning close, she nuzzled her sister's neck and wrapped her tail around her waist.

Sara smiled; she didn't want to argue, either. She hated being at odds with her sister. In whatever place they might find themselves, Jessica was her world. The last and only piece of Phitonia, the only other Chetsuan, the only family she would ever know. She would fight any battle anywhere *with* her. But fighting *against* her was such a waste of time. They might see things differently, sometimes, but arguing over the politics of another world was just stupid.

Happy to let the subject drop, Sara nuzzled her sister in return and linked her tail with Jessica's as they both sat back.

"Anyway, thanks for the update, Lao, but I don't think this has anything to do with why we're here."

Jessica nodded in agreement, but Michael leaned forward, frowning and disputed, "I'm afraid I'm not so sure."

"What makes you say that, Michael?" Lao wondered.

"This forcefield around Wirathia. New technology, they said – just recently developed."

"What of it?" Lao wondered.

"Well, I can't help thinking it sounds awfully like the containment field Daelen threw around this place before his Final Battle with Kullos."

"So?"

"So, that was shadow warrior technology, powered by higher planar energy. Now, I'm not saying the same thing couldn't be achieved by other means but, given that we know the fragment we're looking for came through a matter of weeks ago, the timing is suspicious. Somehow, I need to get there and take a look."

Sara was sceptical. "It's a long way to go if you're wrong."

She thought their time would be better spent building their detector. They were also going to need a containment box to transport it safely back through a portal to Tempestria, not having the Guardians' ability to wrap it in a Timeless field.

"Why can't we do both?" Jessica asked. "I mean, I'm sure you and Lao can build your gadgets without needing Michael's help."

"Well yes, of course we can," Sara agreed.

"And let's face it," Jessica added with a twinkle in her eye, "Michael's big and scary enough—"

"Hey!" Michael mock objected.

"—to look after himself, without a pair of Chetsuan bodyguards."

"I suppose," Sara reluctantly agreed. "We'd need to stay in contact somehow, though."

"So, lend him your phone," her sister suggested. "Or I'll lend him mine. Either way, I'm sure a smart girl like you can adapt them to operate with Lavosian networks."

Sara smiled. "Flatter me into submission, why don't you!"

"Only saying it, 'cause it's true."

"There's still the problem of how I get there," Michael pointed out.

"I can help with that," Lao offered. All eyes were on him. "Hey, I'm not just Gadget Man, you know!"

"Gadget Man?" Jessica wondered with a puzzled look.

"You have your pop culture references, I have mine," he shrugged. "But seriously, I can help."

"How?" Sara asked.

"Your lives have changed since we last met; why do you assume mine's still the same?"

*****

Daelen StormTiger's actions a few weeks ago had been a watershed moment for many people. Until then, he had been a legend, a story, nothing more. Then, suddenly there he was, tearing down a plot to exterminate the dragons. That shifted public opinion against the current Weslend administration and its allies. People might be fearful of dragons, but that didn't mean they would condone genocide.

The subsequent PR campaign did much to quell the public's outrage, but things hadn't entirely shifted back to the way they were. Some people continued to question things, and the new Relocation Plan, while generally popular, made some people even more suspicious. Laoghaire was one of them. From his small downtown office, while business was slow, he began to explore the GlobeNet a bit deeper, finding his way into places he shouldn't have been. It was scary, knowing he could be charged with treason and espionage if he were caught, but Lao didn't let that deter him, because the more he looked, the more he began to worry about what he was finding…or rather *not* finding.

"And what did you find?" Michael wondered. "Or," he amended, "what *didn't* you find?"

"The dragon passport system."

"Not with you, love," Jessica confessed with a shake of the head.

"Well, I agree with those who claim that the dragons' new home is meant to be a penal colony. A prison."

He tried to research the company that was supposedly developing the technology under government contract. However, it seemed that this company was just an organising hub, with the actual work being subcontracted out to third parties. Nothing unusual about that. However, when he began to research those third parties, the contract just branched out further, and even those

branches had branches. Money was being split and funnelled through each of these fractal-like branches, but no matter how hard he tried, he couldn't find any of them doing any real work. By now, with the search growing exponentially, the research was too much for one person to make any progress.

"So, I took a risk. I knew what I'd done was illegal, but I couldn't let my findings go unexplored. People needed to know. Because, if I'm right, and there *isn't* a passport system, then it begs one obvious question."

Sara took up the thread. "Where's all that money going? What are they actually doing with it?"

"Whatever it is, it can't be anything good if they're going to such lengths to hide it," Michael rumbled.

It seemed to him that if he was searching for something to do with his new life, now that he was free of his endless battles alongside Daelen StormTiger, then this was an excellent place to start. The shadow warrior had started something here, preventing a genocidal plot against the dragons. Unfortunately, events on Tempestria had been rapidly coming to a head, and that pulled him away perhaps earlier than would have been ideal.

Plus, the demigod couldn't ignore the feeling in his bones that this was somehow personal. Kullos had known he was defeated and threw those fragments of his dimensional control device through his portals. What if those portals weren't random? If he knew about the world of Lavos, then perhaps he knew what Daelen had done here. In that case, what better act of spite, than to set events in motion that could undo his heroic actions?

Sara was right that they needed to build their tracker and find evidence, but regardless, Michael was more convinced than ever that something terrible was happening here. Since Daelen StormTiger wasn't around anymore to swoop in and save the day, Ossian Miach Kaidool would just have to step into his shoes as best he could.

"So, what did you do, Lao?" Jessica asked.

"I turned myself in to the PDI," he replied.

"PDI?"

By way of answer, he reached into his jacket pocket and pulled out a holocard – a small foldable screen about three inches

by two. Upon sensing his fingerprints, it lit up with a holographic logo that read:

PDI: Pro-Dragon Intelligence

"Trainee Analyst?" Jessica read underneath. "Not exactly James Bond, is it, love?"

"Who?"

"Earth reference again," Sara explained, dismissing it with a wave. "Just ignore her."

Lao had told the PDI what he'd done, freely handing over his portacom, security codes, everything they needed. He told them he was prepared to face whatever consequences they had in mind for him, as long as they actually used what he'd given them.

"Well, as you can see, the consequences were that they hired me, and despite what I said, I really wasn't prepared for that."

It turned out they had a team working much the same angle, but they hadn't uncovered half of what Lao had. His work had accelerated theirs, and they were keen for him to help them further in exchange for immunity from all charges. As a cover, he would maintain his business, albeit in a cut down fashion.

"Although, to be honest, the big businesses had pretty much halved my client base already, so there wasn't much cutting down to do. Anyway, Michael," he continued, "I may not be James Bond, whoever that is, but I do have PDI contacts that could help smuggle you into Wirathia. If you can confirm that it really is something to do with this higher planar technology, they could help you deal with it."

Michael turned to Sara and confirmed the plan. "Well then, I suggest we pursue our dual approach as your sister suggested, agreed?"

Sara nodded. "Always been the heart of the family, our Jess," she praised, gently tapping her sister's nose with her tail. "Of course you'd recognise the right thing when you saw it," she told her. "I've got to stop seeing the dragons of this world like they're the ones on Phitonia. If there's some kind of new threat to them, then we have to help stop it, because that's what Daelen would do."

“Forget Daelen, sis, it’s what Dreya *did* do! Daelen may have rescued us, but it was Dreya who made sure our people don’t need to fear the dragons anymore.”

Sara smiled, although inwardly she was worried. Her sister had always had a deep abiding faith in Daelen, even when Sara didn’t believe he was real. Now she seemed to have transferred her faith to Dreya the Dark. Sara liked Dreya for the most part, but she was still wary of her. The Chetsuan had heard people talk about her in Gaggleswick. The ‘Faery who Fell’, some people called her. From what she had learned about the Faery people in general, she could understand the allusion. Perhaps Catriona kept her tethered to the better parts of her nature, but if ever she were to lose that tether, Sara was fearful of what might be unleashed. After all, ignorant, racist, human depictions aside, Faery did not have wings. So, if her sister had placed Dreya on a pedestal, then might the Faery who Fell fall once more?

Chapter 17

Michael caused quite a stir when he revealed himself to Lao's PDI handler at what, from the outside, appeared to be nothing more than a storage facility full of parts for *Lao's Techspot*. Daelen StormTiger was seen as something of a superhero to these people, however, and that connection served to engender trust. Had Jessica been there, the Champion of the Gods was sure she would have teased him about being Daelen's sidekick. Still, from what he knew about such Earth entertainment, such sidekicks sometimes ended up with their own spinoff story. He supposed this was his.

The PDI arranged discreet transportation in the form of a flying cargo transporter, a passenger transport being too small. They had initially been resistant to Lao accompanying him – he was an analyst, not a field agent, but Michael insisted.

"I need someone familiar with this world and its technology, and there may be times when I have to turn off my perception filter. How many people do you want to know I'm an alien?"

The PDI conceded the point and authorised it.

Wherever he went in Wirathia, their PDI contacts had arranged for 'quarters' which was a polite term for 'warehouse'. That was OK. He'd spent most of his life in a high-tech coffin in a tomb. Compared to that, anything else was luxury.

To his credit, Laoghaire didn't complain, either.

"I've always wanted to travel around Wirathia," he told Michael, excitedly, "but I could never afford it. Thanks to you, I'm getting paid to do it. It seems a bit ungrateful to complain about the accommodations."

While it was winter in Weslend and across Vrania in the Northern hemisphere, it was of course summer down in Wirathia. Precisely what that meant depended on whereabouts they were on the island continent. As they were taken from city to city, conditions ranged from warm and dry, through hot and humid, to a more temperate climate. Everywhere he went, dragons filled the sky to the point where he imagined, if Mandalee had been there, as a Cleric of Nature, she'd probably hear the native birds complaining about immigration and overcrowding. What he really needed to see, however, was the barrier. Unfortunately, there was

no way to do that until it was put into operation. In the meantime, he would just have to continue to play the part of a VIP tourist.

*****

A news vidcast began circulating on the GlobeNet that included 'released footage' of some anti-dragon terror group ranting about 'wiping out the threat for good.' In response, the allied governments, led by Weslend, had called for dragons everywhere to head for Wirathia as quickly as possible, because this group was 'deadly serious' and 'well capable of carrying out their threat' against any dragons who remained outside Wirathian protection. Intelligence services were 'working around the chronometer' to try and counter this terror plot, but there was 'regrettably, every chance' that the terrorists might at least partially succeed. To try and avert that as much as possible, they said the decision had been made, with the full co-operation of the Wirathian government, to bring forward the shield activation, to rob the terrorists of more time. The plan was now for the shield to be activated in just seven days.

They estimated that more than ninety-two percent of the world's dragon population had already taken refuge there. The Weslend authorities now 'implored' the rest of the dragon community to accept the protection and warm hospitality of Wirathia for the sake of their safety and survival. They said that 'additional resources' had been allocated to Wirathia from the Northern continents' emergency fund to help speed up the process. It was their 'dearest hope,' they said, that they could get the final figure up as close to one hundred percent as possible. Then, as soon as the current threat was passed and the 'hardline elements' dealt with, the system of dragon passport allocation could start to be introduced.

"What dragon passport system?" Lao yelled at the screen as if it were an interactive vidcast. "There isn't one, and you know it! So, what are you really doing with the money, hmm?"

The PDI still hadn't found the answer to that yet, but they had made a breakthrough of sorts: there were fewer branches than yesterday.

For the first time since Lao had begun his illegal investigation, following the money trail as it continually split, a few had merged. Whoever was behind this was still trying to hide it by using different trading names for the same company, but it hadn't worked for long. If these strands were beginning to converge, then they had indeed turned a corner. It was a race against time. Trouble was, they now had a week less than they thought they had.

Because of his PDI work, Lao hadn't had time to help Sara with her side of things. Still, she was clever, so it hadn't hampered her efforts. He had granted her full, free access to the resources of his *Techspot* and had managed to help her get a few hard-to-find components for her device. As for Jessica, she might not have an aptitude for technology, being more at home tending the garden with strange powers Lao didn't know she possessed, but she was always ready to offer a helping hand or encouraging word when her sister needed one.

She hadn't just been tending the garden for the sake of aesthetics, either. She'd been trying to practice her fledgeling druid magic. It was a bit hit and miss as to whether it would work at all, let alone work as she intended, but she was improving, slowly, as she began to tune her senses into the nature of this world. From this exercise, she was sure she was starting to feel something out of place. Nothing she could put her finger on and certainly nothing she could prove, but she believed it more and more. It surely had to be in Weslend somewhere. She didn't think even Catriona's highly attuned druid senses could stretch much further.

At last, Sara called her sister over and told her the device was ready. She would be able to test it using a ring that Michael had left her, which was imbued with a small amount of higher planar energy. It was barely enough to power an Earth watch, but if her device could detect that, it should have no trouble picking up a trace of the kind of power the fragment must contain. It wouldn't do much good if it were halfway around the world where Michael was, but it should be good for a hundred miles, at least. If her sister was right about the proximity of the fragment, and if her device worked properly, they should at last be able to begin their search.

Frankly, Sara had more confidence in the former than the latter. If she told her sister her tech device could do something, Jessica would never question it, and if it didn't work, she would

just shrug and say, “You’ll fix it.” So, if Jessica claimed her new magic could detect something out of place in Weslend, how could she not have that same faith in her?

“OK, Jess. Here goes. Make a wish!”

They both closed their eyes as Sara activated her device…

…which promptly burnt out and shut down.

“Never mind, sis,” Jessica chirped, breezily, giving her a reassuring hug. “You’ll fix it.”

Sara smiled. No matter what world they were on, she was still the same Jess, and with that on her side, how could she fail?

*****

After a while, Sara called her sister back, excitedly.

“Jess, I’ve figured out why it went wrong!”

“Go on,” Jessica encouraged her, prepared for a technical explanation she probably wouldn’t understand, but she’d nod and smile while her sister told her how clever she was.

“It didn’t!” Sara exclaimed.

“Huh? Did you bump your head or did I?”

“No, listen. It’s supposed to detect higher planar energy, right?”

Jessica nodded. She was clear on what it was meant to do, and while she wasn’t certain precisely how, she was pretty sure it wasn’t by burning out.

“It burnt out because it was too sensitive. The input was more than it could handle.”

Jessica screwed up her face in puzzlement. “What? From that little ring?”

“No!” Sara grinned. “That’s what I couldn’t work out at first, then I realised it wasn’t detecting Michael’s ring – or if it was, it was like a drop in the ocean.” Jessica still wasn’t getting it, so Sara spelt it out, “Jess, you were right! There *is* something out of place in Weslend. Something either very powerful or relatively close…I think it’s both. Whatever Michael’s doing down in Wirathia doesn’t have anything to do with the control device fragment. It can’t do, because it’s here in Weslend! And now that I’ve turned the sensitivity in this device right down…” she activated it again,

and this time it lit up and began bleeping. She turned around on the spot until the bleeping accelerated. "…I can tell it's that way!"

"That's brilliant, Sara!" Jessica cried, hugging her tight at the same time as their tails did a high five. "I knew you'd do it!" She broke the hug. "So, any idea how far it is?"

Sara shook her head. "Haven't had a chance to calibrate distance, yet. I can do that as we travel."

"Then let's go," Jessica declared, grabbing their warm coats.

Sara picked up their perception filters, handing one to her sister. "Should we tell Michael?"

"Why?" Jessica asked as they both prepared to leave Daelen's base, activating the devices. "No point dragging him back here. Whatever's going on, we can handle it ourselves, right?"

Sara gave an emphatic nod. "Right. Michael can save the dragons, and we'll save the world."

"Then we'll be heroes."

Sara nodded, "And we can find you a nice Lavosian to snog, so you'll stop going on about me and my elf boy."

"Hey!" Jessica objected. "I haven't teased you about that for days!"

Sara smiled as her sister linked arms with her. "I know. I've kind of missed it."

Jessica laughed and activated the control that would allow them to pass into the world outside. "Well maybe, when we're heroes, we can find *you* someone new to snog, and I can tease you about that instead!"

As they stepped out into the snow, Sara remarked, "If only we had a nice yellow brick road to follow."

Jessica shook her head. "Don't need one. Your gadget will take us all the way to Oz."

"It'd still be easier to keep our footing, though," Sara pointed out as she slipped slightly.

Jessica gave her a quizzical look. "Why do you think I linked arms? We can just support each other, as always."

"As always," Sara agreed with a smile.

She'd been wondering what their lives might be like, now that they were no longer Daelen's domestic help. Well, life surely didn't get any better than this: here with her amazing sister by her side, off on an adventure to save the world.

So, together, they followed the pull of the bleeps wherever they might lead.

*****

Somewhere in the dark, a countdown had started, Jessica was sure of it. That's how it always worked in the movies she'd watched on Earth. An unnecessarily large clock counting down the seconds to catastrophe. She didn't know where it was, but she was convinced if its existence, nonetheless. Just a few days, now, until the barrier went up around Wirathia and she didn't share her sister's belief that it was unrelated to what they were doing. Again, that was how it worked in the movies. Two seemingly unconnected story strands coming together at the last minute as that clock counted down.

They had been walking on and off, for several hours before they realised they were wasting their time. Now that Sara had calibrated her tracking device, they could see that if they were ever going to make it to Oz in time, they would have to make use of something Dorothy never had on her journey: public transport. A combination of the approximate distance reading and a few logical assumptions led them to decide on Kaelia Capitolina as their destination. As the name suggested, it was the capital city of Weslend, and as such, transport there was abundant, if crowded.

Once there, they had checked into a small hotel for a few days while Sara repaired her device. It had burnt out again a few miles outside K.C., as people called it here, and Sara had to search local electronics outlets for parts. Lao had helped with that when Jessica called him. Being in the trade, he could recommend places to go, as well as warn them about the more disreputable ones best avoided.

The power readings here were so high, it had not been easy to recalibrate her device to cope with the input and give them a sensible reading. She'd also replaced the bleeping with a tiny flashing light that was less likely to attract attention in these crowded city streets. Finally, though, after staying up until midnight, at Jessica's insistence, the device was functioning correctly.

It was Barrier Activation Day and early that morning, after a few hours' sleep – not as many as Sara would have liked – the tracker led them into the warehouse district and finally to one particular building that couldn't be more nondescript if it tried.

Jessica remembered Mandalee telling her about Catriona's plan to cross the ocean while avoiding Kullos' prying eyes. To that end, they had hired an unremarkable vessel called the *Dolphin*. When the attack finally came, Daelen's pride and joy, the *StormChaser* had been targeted, while their real transport had gone unnoticed. The Chetsuan had a hunch that this building had been chosen for a similar purpose and they couldn't afford to make the same mistake Kullos had.

The people milling around it appeared to be a mix of general maintenance workers who looked so completely unlike security guards, that Sara was convinced that was exactly what they were. Moreover, she thought the way the 'gardener' was walking around 'noting' the presence of weeds without doing anything about them was highly suspicious.

Jessica noted the weeds, too. They could prove useful.

After walking around for half an hour or so, she grumbled, "It's no use us wandering around here all day, sis. We need to get in there. Soon. Something here is very wrong – more than your gadget is telling us. I'm sure of it."

The way Jessica's ears were pricked up and her tail bushed out, her body language on full alert, Sara didn't doubt her at all. Her own heart was pounding in her chest as she picked up on her twin's feelings, but she forced herself to concentrate. Concentration that was broken when Jessica's phone rang.

It was Michael. He'd been consulting with Laoghaire, who told him they'd traced at least a portion of the money and it definitely had something to do with the barrier around Wirathia. Except that didn't make sense, because the funds for that had already been allocated through official, traceable accounts. That suggested there was something about the barrier that they didn't want people, even the Wirathian government, to know about.

The PDI had also traced a reference to something else that didn't make sense: some kind of holding in the middle of the Central Wirathian Desert. A holding that needed electrical power. But there weren't supposed to be any such permanent buildings in

the desert. They had searched through old records to try and find anything that would explain this. Eventually, they found something on an old computer printout from just about the dawn of the first digital age. According to that, there had once been an experimental power plant built there, a hundred miles from anywhere, just in case something went wrong. It was decommissioned and abandoned after about a decade when advances in solar energy technology made the whole experiment redundant.

Jessica, already quite chilly in the Wirathian winter, felt her blood run cold. “Whatever they’re doing, it’s something to do with that power plant.”

Michael agreed. “That’s why I’m going there. The PDI are arranging transport. I should be there in about two hours.”

“But what does that have to do with this place?” Sara wondered, her brow furrowing as she tried and failed to figure it out. “The fragment is definitely here, not over there.”

“I don’t know,” Jessica admitted, “but it’s connected. I know it.”

“Oh well, even when Michael gets to this power plant, there will still be a good three-and-a-half hours before anything happens,” Sara pointed out.

“True,” Jessica agreed, relaxing a little.

There being nothing more to discuss, for the time being, the Chetsuans exchanged goodbyes with their friend and hung up.

“Now then, dearie, how the hell do we get inside that building?” Jessica wondered.

“Well, as Cat would say, I have a ridiculous radical plan.”

Jessica grinned. “I love it already.”

“I just need a few components and a bit of time and space to work.”

“And then?” Jessica prompted.

“Then I make us disappear.”

“Huh? I thought I was the one dabbling in magic.”

What Sara had planned wasn’t magic, but technology. They were both wearing perception filters, devices that changed how people saw them by filtering the light around them. With a bit of tweaking, then, she thought, she could probably make the light filter them out completely, rendering them practically invisible to anyone who wasn’t specifically looking for them. It would put a

strain on the technology as it would have to continually shift the image it presented, and it would undoubtedly drain their power supply, limiting the time they could remain invisible. Hopefully, it would be time enough.

As Sara outlined her plan, however, Jessica's phone bleeped as it notified its owner of a news vidcast that it had just picked up. It was a spokesperson from the Weslend central government. She explained to the citizens of the Vranian Alliance that the President had just finished consulting with his 'esteemed Wirathian counterpart' sharing the 'dread intelligence' that the terror attack they had been monitoring for the past few weeks was now an 'imminent threat'. As such, Weslend had 'offered all possible assistance' to ensure the barrier could be ready as quickly as possible. After consultation with Wirathian technical people, it had been agreed that they would bring its activation forward by three hours.

Somewhere, in the dark, a countdown had just skipped down to a little over two hours and thirty minutes.

Chapter 18

Finding the components and making the necessary modifications to their perception filters took just under two hours. A quick test had confirmed that Sara and Jessica seemed to be invisible to anyone but each other, but time and energy constraints had prevented any more extensive trials. By the time they returned to the nondescript warehouse, the Wirathian ornithopter carrying Michael and Lao was just about coming into land. That gave them only thirty minutes until whatever-it-was happened, but at least they should be able to co-ordinate their efforts.

While the Chetsuans were going to have to rely on their pseudo invisibility, Michael and Lao were armed with faked credentials to gain admittance.

For a supposedly decommissioned power plant, it was very much a hive of activity. The cavernous underground space was humming with power. Banks of lights flashed, screens displayed the current status of operations and apparently everything was condition green.

Security led Michael and Lao to a guide who introduced himself as Darragh, Operations Chief for the site and immediately dismissed the security guard.

"You're early," he accused them in a low voice, as soon as they were alone.

Michael and Lao had to school their expressions to avoid revealing their surprise. They hadn't expected to be expected.

Lao dismissed the issue with a casual shrug. "Better early than late, am I right?" he remarked with a grin.

Darragh laughed. "Yes, that's certainly true and it's reassuring to have the evac vehicle waiting outside for when it all kicks off."

That confirmed Michael's fears. He could feel the presence of higher planar energy here, but not enough to indicate the proximity of the fragment they were looking for. Which begged two key questions: where was the power coming from, and what were they planning on doing with it that would require evacuation?

"Our friends in the North just wanted us to do a final check on everything before, as you say, it all kicks off down here," Lao

was saying. “You can understand that, can’t you, given how important this is?”

Darragh frowned. “I suspected it was something like that, but I assure you everything’s in order.”

“I’m sure it is,” Lao smoothed. “Look, the truth is, I really just wanted to see it for myself before…you know.”

The Chief smiled broadly. “Of course, of course,” he agreed, beaming with pride at whatever he believed he’d accomplished here. “Can’t say I blame you.”

“Well then,” Michael breezed, “since we are early, why don’t you show it to us? A quick tour of the highlights.”

Darragh readily agreed and led them out into the factory. Fortunately for Michael, the doors in the facility had been built tall and wide enough to accommodate the easy movement of equipment, so his stature wouldn’t be a problem as long as they stayed out of the smaller office spaces. Given that there were now less than twenty-five minutes until the shield activated, they were hardly likely to stop for a chat over a coffee.

Leading them around the factory floor, Darragh showed his visitors the electrical generation system. It had been well modified from the original design, to accommodate higher planar energy that would simply melt regular electrical cables like fuses.

He showed them circuit diagrams, explaining how his efficient leadership had overseen the connection of the plant to the entire Wirathian electrical grid ahead of schedule.

“That’s why they were able to bring the activation forward,” he announced, proudly.

That was further confirmation that it was something to do with the new barrier system. Besides the usual components of a power station – boilers, turbines and generators, spinning an enormous coil of wires within a circular arrangement of powerful magnets – there was another large device neither visitor could identify. It was a horizontally mounted metal cylinder, about fifty yards in length. Somehow, it seemed to be receiving higher planar energy that was being transmitted from somewhere else. Michael could feel it. But from where and for what purpose? The device looked familiar, somehow, but he couldn’t quite place it.

“It’s been a labour of love, this place,” Darragh admitted. “I’ve worked long hours, lost sleep over this. Lost weight, too.

Although that's probably no bad thing," he quipped, patting his stomach.

Michael and Lao laughed, as their parts required, but nearly choked when Darragh sighed, "Almost a shame to blow it all up, really."

That's what that cylindrical device was, Michael realised with horror: it was like a shadow warrior's beam cannon weapon, only a primitive version. That's why it was so big. Primitive or not, the damage it could do, if powered by the unstable higher planar energy stored within a fragment of Kullos' dimensional control device, would be devastating. What he couldn't work out was what the weapon was supposed to fire at.

"Well, Michael," Lao spoke up, "I think we've seen enough here to know everything's on schedule, so maybe we should tell our friends, so they don't worry," he suggested.

"Good idea," Michael agreed, fishing Jessica's mobile phone out of his pocket."

"Is that a portacom?" Darragh wondered, incredulously.

Lao, covering for Michael who was unfamiliar with the term, just laughed it off. "Retro design. My friend's into old-fashioned tech like that."

Unsurprisingly, Sara's was the last number called, so he just pressed redial and seconds later it was ringing.

*****

Taking a deep breath, Sara and Jessica broke cover and hurried over to the warehouse. They quickly found a window large enough for them to squeeze through. Naturally, being the middle of winter, it was closed, but Jessica's dragonclaw dagger soon sorted that out, finding its way into the tiniest crack and slicing through the reinforced steel bolts as if they were made of tissue paper.

They slipped in quietly and Sara pulled out her tracker, checking the sound was muted before activating it. They were invisible, not inaudible.

The warehouse appeared to be deserted. There were no lights on, but Chetsuans had excellent night vision, so it wasn't too much of a hindrance. Rather more irritating was the lack of heating,

which somehow managed to make it feel colder than outside. With a shiver, the sisters crept along the corridor in which they found themselves. A little further on, they found a door and opened it carefully. On the other side lay the main storage area and some metal steps leading up onto a gantry.

Automated systems were working on something that caused a faint, sinister hum, a somehow threatening vibration. It was coming from some kind of metal apparatus about the size of a major competition swimming pool, taking up half the floor space of this warehouse, but it was too difficult to tell what it might be from this angle.

Despite how pressed they were for time, Jessica dismissed her sister's suggestion that they split up. She'd seen too many movies to think that was a good idea. They would stay together until they had a pressing reason to do otherwise.

Together, they decided on an aerial view. Now that their eyes had grown sufficiently accustomed to the darkness, they could, at last, make out the apparatus in detail. It was principally a vast horizontal cylinder, mounted on a platform about twenty feet high. Sara's detector was telling her it was sending out a continuous, invisible beam of higher planar energy that simply disappeared less than twenty yards from one end of the device. Except that was impossible. Energy couldn't just vanish like that.

"There's something weird going on here, sis," Jessica remarked.

Sara rolled her eyes. "What gave it away? The big metal thingy?"

She didn't know what the device was called, but she couldn't shake the feeling that it was some kind of enormous gun, or maybe 'cannon' would be a better word.

Jessica gave her sister a withering look. "I don't mean the tech! I mean I sense…" she trailed off, waving a hand, vaguely.

"…A disturbance in the Force?" Sara suggested. She expected her sister to laugh at the reference, but she didn't.

"Actually, all facetiousness aside, that's not a bad description. It's like there's a gap in the fabric of reality just in front of that big cannon. That's where the energy's going." She caught a flicker of something in the area where the energy was disappearing. "There!" she declared, pointing. "Look closely."

Sara stared for a long moment, and nothing happened, but then she saw it: the flicker of a tiny blue light in midair.

"Wait," she gasped, "that looks like—"

"—A Prismatic Sphere portal," Jessica finished. It was so small, it could surely transport nothing bigger than a mouse. But she knew from the one Catriona had maintained while on Earth, a micro-portal was quite sufficient to simply transmit energy. That's what this device was doing: it was sending energy elsewhere. From the consistent feel of nature through that portal, Jessica was willing to bet it was confined to Lavos.

"But where on this world could they be using this energy?" Sara knew the answer almost as soon as the question left her lips.

Both sisters answered together, "Wirathia!"

It seemed as if higher planar energy was being transmitted to the other side of the world.

Further along the gantry, the sisters found a display screen. A small light indicated that it was switched on but on standby. A simple tap on the screen would activate it. It would also light up like a beacon that would alert any security that might be monitoring, but they didn't have any choice. They needed information fast and looking around quickly, they could see nothing else that was going to help them, so after an encouraging nod from Jessica, Sara touched the screen and quickly took in the information it displayed. On the screen, there was a diagrammatic representation of the system. It showed the huge cannon being fed power through cables from a box that contained something small. There was only one thing that small component could be: the fragment. Judging by the schematic, it was on a similar platform on the opposite side of the room.

Sara quickly flicked through the options on-screen to learn more. The first thing she found brought a momentary smile to her face, despite the situation: it was a simple clock, counting down the minutes and seconds.

"You were right, Jess," she remarked, but rather than smile back, her sister frowned.

"Check your phone," she insisted. "Don't ask, just do it. Quick," she insisted, cutting off any questions.

Sara handed Jessica her tracker, then with her now free hand, she opened the app that displayed the official countdown to the

barrier activation. She held it up next to the monitor screen to show her sister: they didn't match. The one on the warehouse screen was behind by three minutes and seven seconds.

"I knew it!" Jessica declared.

"Well, it's odd," Sara remarked, "but at least we've got a bit longer. That's good news."

Jessica shook her head, emphatically. "There's been no delay, the barrier definitely goes up in twenty minutes. I don't know what happens here three minutes after that, but I don't believe it's anything good. We should just grab the fragment and go."

"Maybe," her sister allowed, "but I'd rather know what we're dealing with, if possible. Just give me one more minute. She continued flicking through various options on screen and froze as what she saw shocked her. "It's a trap!" she gasped.

"What is?" Jessica asked, looking around, frantically.

Seeing her misunderstanding, her twin clarified, "Not here. Wirathia. They're going to blow it up!"

"The power plant?"

Sara shook her head. "The continent."

"What?" Jessica demanded horrified. "They can't!"

"They can," Sara insisted. "It's all right here."

The plan, she explained, was to get as many dragons as possible within Wirathian borders, which they had. According to the latest figures, there were more dragons than people, around thirty million. Given their already low numbers, that left fewer than a thousand individual dragons that hadn't taken the bait. The energy being transmitted was building at the other end, ready to power a sustained barrier around Wirathia, as per the official countdown. The world would be watching on vidscreens everywhere, and it would appear to be a complete success…for about three minutes and seven seconds.

At that time, the system in Weslend would kick into high gear, shooting a massive surge of higher planar energy through the micro-portal to the other side. That surge would be transmitted throughout the entire Wirthian electrical grid. The whole continent would be ablaze with deadly beam cannon blasts shooting out from every city, every town, every single building with an electrical supply, ricocheting off the barrier. There would be fires,

explosions, quakes, mass devastation, and that was only the beginning.

Ultimately, the power plant at the other end would be unable to cope with all that higher planar energy. So, in one final devastating blast, it would explode with enough force to wipe out virtually all life in Wirathia. In a little over twenty minutes, twenty-five million people and thirty million dragons would be wiped from the face of Lavos.

"The barrier isn't there to protect the dragons," Sara concluded. "It's a trap to make sure they all die. Genocide."

"They're doing it again!" Jessica cried. "Daelen stopped them before, but thanks to the fragment coming here from Tempestria, they've found another way."

With a determined look, Sara declared, "We've got to stop it."

As they turned to walk away, however, lights suddenly flared on, and there came the sound of heavy footsteps pounding on the metal gantry. As Sara had feared, security had noticed the anomaly of a monitor turning itself on. Now they were running up the steps to investigate, guns at the ready. Before they could reach the top of the gantry, the two Chetsuans moved away as quietly as possible, praying their perception filters were working.

Indeed, the guards seemed unable to find them...until Sara's phone rang. Jessica shut it off quickly, but it was too late. Guards immediately came running, and the sisters instinctively dived for cover.

"Hang on," Jessica whispered. "Why are we hiding? We're invisible."

Sara shook her head. "We're unnoticeable, not invisible, and only if we don't attract attention."

"Which we just did," Jessica groaned. She made a snap decision. "Get the fragment," she whispered. "I'll distract that lot."

Sara tried to protest, but Jessica just restored her perception filter to its previous settings, making her look Lavosian. Since that was what the guards would expect to see, they should have no reason to penetrate the disguise.

Taking a deep breath, she called out, "Alright, loves, I'm coming out." Holding her hands up, she stepped from cover. "I'm unarmed," she lied, once again relying on her sister's technology

to hide the dragonclaw daggers attached to her wrists. “Please don’t shoot me!”

Half a dozen guards had her surrounded in a heartbeat. One of them checked for weapons and confirmed that she had none, though they were suspicious about the tracker in her hand.

“Drop the device!” a guard ordered, and she complied a little more thoroughly than he intended, throwing it away from the gantry and letting it fall twenty feet to the ground where it smashed. If they knew she was tracking the fragment, things could go badly. Now she hoped they would just assume it was a portacom. That way she could act like this was a simple break-in, at least for the next twenty minutes.

Sara didn’t like this one bit, but nevertheless, she crept away from the scene, trusting in her sister’s ability to take care of herself. As soon as she was far enough away, she returned Michael’s call.

*****

Halfway around the world, just as Michael was about to try again, the phone rang.

“You’d better have a bloody good reason for ringing,” came Sara’s voice. She was whispering, but the anger behind her words was clear without her needing to shout. “Jessica’s been caught thanks to you.”

As Sara was speaking, Michael grew increasingly uneasy about the approaching security, escorting two individuals to Darragh.

Watching them move to one side to confer, Michael murmured, “Sorry, my dear, but if it’s any consolation, it looks like we’re about to be in the same boat here, so we’d best talk quickly.” He shared what he’d learned, but of course, that only confirmed what Sara already knew.

“Get to the fragment,” he advised, “and work out how to extract it, but don’t do anything else until we speak again. We need to be very careful about how we do this, or a lot of people are going to die – including us.”

“Alright,” Sara agreed, “but we’ve only got about seventeen minutes left. If I don’t hear from you in twelve, I’ll have to do what I think is best, so I have time to grab Jess and run. You got that?

She's my priority. If it comes down to it, I don't care if this world blows itself up as long as I have my sister."

"I know," Michael assured her, kindly, "but it won't come to that. Listen, I have to go," he told her, as Darragh and his guards moved menacingly towards him and Lao, weapons primed and ready.

Through the phone, Sara heard someone shout, "Put the com down and your hands in the air!"

"Good luck," she offered.

Sara wasn't sure if Michael had heard her before he hung up, but she couldn't worry about that. She just had to get to the fragment, rescue Jessica and despite her words to Michael, she did want to save the world and all those dragons in the process. She didn't have time to worry about anything else. She just had to trust Michael and Lao to take care of their side on their own.

Chapter 19

Michael ended the call and prepared to surrender, but Lao had other ideas.

"Make a wish!" he cried and threw something at Darragh's feet.

It didn't explode exactly, but it did flash brightly. Michael hastily closed his eyes, though not quite quickly enough to completely avoid being dazzled. He felt Lao's hand on his arm, pulling him away from the scene and with slightly bleary eyes, he followed, dodging and weaving between plant and equipment as the guards fired their lasers blindly.

Lao pulled them both down behind some barrels, took out a gun of his own and began firing.

"Are your eyes OK?" he asked. "I was hoping you might have the custom of closing your eyes to make a wish on Tempestria."

"We do," Michael confirmed, blinking as his sight recovered. "I just didn't cotton on quite quickly enough." He glanced at the countdown on Jessica's phone. As it gradually came into focus, he saw there were less than fourteen minutes until the barrier went up and they weren't going to be able to do much about it stuck behind some barrels.

After a whole minute of firing, a laser bolt hit a control panel behind them. It was instantly destroyed and the lights flickered for a moment.

Michael glowered at his companion. "Do you really think firing energy weapons in this place is a good idea? We want to stop them blowing it up, not help them."

"We have to defend ourselves!" Lao objected.

"Of course we do, and given that this lot are intent on wiping out all life on this continent, I have no compunction about killing every last one of them in defence of all those lives, but we're not going to achieve anything like this."

"What's the alternative?"

"Lao," Michael answered, patiently, "I think you're forgetting who you're talking to, and I think it's time to show them, too."

Deactivating his perception filter, he spun a shield of magic around himself and stepped out into the line of fire, in his full bony glory. Standing at seven feet, with dried translucent skin stretched like parchment over his massive frame, and a red, pointed wizard's hat pushed onto a horned skull, he cut quite the imposing figure. Even terrifying to those who didn't know him. Lao had managed to put that from his mind during their 'holiday' together, but seeing Michael's true self once more was a stark reminder of the company he was keeping.

Michael summoned a swarm of deadly insects that buzzed all around him and ravens from the gates of hell (or at least native to one of the demonic realms, about two planes down). Then, for extra effect, he caused his red cloak to billow out around him as if in his own personal breeze. The young druidess, Catriona, always had a flair for the dramatic and he'd seen what an ally that had been for her in battle. Sometimes it even removed the need to fight altogether as her enemies recoiled from a simple trick of splitting light as if it were the deadliest thing in the world. Then again, he recalled, she had even wielded rainbows as a weapon, so who could blame them?

The guards froze at the sight, and Darragh himself looked as though he might faint.

"What— What the hell are you?" he stammered.

Putting on his deepest, most terrifying voice, he boomed, "I am the Angel of Vengeance and Death, and these," he indicated the flies and the birds, "are my servants, set to drag you down to hell where I shall devour your souls for what you do here. There is a special place in the hells for those who commit genocide, where you shall be tortured for eternity!"

With that, he roared loud enough to wake the dead.

Darragh and his guards fled the scene in terror, chased all the way by Michael's summonings.

Peering down, the demigod saw a wide-eyed Laoghaire still crouched down behind cover, his gun forgotten in his hand as he stared back, mouth gaping open.

"Too much?" Michael asked with a smirk.

Lao just shook his head and stood, trying to compose himself. "Well, it should free us up to act," he conceded. "How long?" he asked, indicating the countdown.

Michael showed him. In twelve minutes, the barrier went up. In fifteen, it would be the beginning of the end for Wirathia.

Together they followed the signs to the main control room. The doorway was too small for Michael, so he simply burst through. His actions put a gaping hole in the ceiling and weakened it enough to cause a desk, papers and computer terminals to come crashing down, one of which narrowly missed the fire extinguisher on the wall. Of the three technicians in the room, one was buried, unmoving underneath. The second tried to run, but Michael struck him with his great warhammer, imprisoning the Lavosian in unbreakable petrified wood. The third froze in terror.

Ignoring all else, Lao unrolled his portacom and began trying to connect it to the power station's computer system.

"I can hack in," he told Michael, "but it'd save time if I had the access codes."

Michael was about to threaten the third technician when there came the sound of a large ornithopter taking off.

"Well, it seems I don't even need this," he decided, putting his hammer away. "Sounds like you've been abandoned, so you can either help us or die. Unless you think you can travel about a hundred miles in twelve minutes on foot, in which case, by all means, start running."

The technician nodded, not taking his eyes off Michael.

"Hey, focus!" Lao warned him, snapping his fingers in his face. "Don't worry about my friend. Worry about kaboom."

"I—I want to help!" he cried desperately.

"You mean you don't want to die," Lao translated. "How noble. Still, you can be as self-serving as you like as long as the rest of Wirathia gets to live, too. Access codes. Now."

The technician told him, and Lao got to work, pausing only a moment to ask Michael to send the same codes to Sara. The two sites appeared to share a connected system over the GlobeNet, so with any luck, the same access codes would apply.

While Michael did that, Lao sent out a call to PDI and briefed them.

"Do you need us to send an extraction team?" his handler asked.

Lao glanced at the official countdown. "With ten minutes 'til the barrier goes up?" he snorted. "Forget us, but you could send a

team to our friends in Weslend. I'm sure they can take care of themselves, but they're not nearly as scary as my friend here.

"No offence," he added as an aside to Michael.

"None taken," he replied.

"Understood," came his handler's voice. "Will do. Good luck."

With that, the line went dead.

Turning to the technician, Lao commanded, "Come here and help. You know these systems better than I do. Let's see how good you are at your job…and saving your own skin."

The technician ran to the control console and began frantically pressing buttons. Michael was used to technology so sophisticated it made this look like a toy, but still, this toy was what he had to work with if he was going to save Wirathia. As they worked, the minutes ticked by…nine minutes…eight…

"I'm telling you it's too late to stop it!" the technician wailed.

"It can't be!" Lao shot back.

…seven…

"Dammit!" Lao swore. "Alright, Plan B: we sever all the connections beyond this facility, confine the explosion here."

"But how will that help us?" the technician whined.

Lao chose not to waste his breath dignifying that with a response.

…six…

"Won't help anyone much," Michael warned him. "The connections aren't even needed, really, except to disguise the source of the initial blast. Your people are underestimating the power of higher planar energy, especially the unstable kind in that fragment."

"Well, it's the best I can do, so I'm doing it!" Lao snapped back, inputting override codes and bypassing security that kept telling him he lacked the clearance to cut people off from vital energy.

"Of course, my boy. Quite right," Michael agreed, placing an encouraging hand on his shoulder.

Remembering his last conversation with Sara, he realised he was in danger of missing her deadline. In less than one minute, if nothing had prevented her, she was going to extract the fragment.

Would that be such a bad thing, he wondered?

As he pulled out Jessica's phone, however, he glanced out of the observation window and saw the blue flicker of the Prismatic Sphere. Turning back, he noticed a diagram of energy flow flash across the screen before him, along with numbers, measuring higher planar energy. The screen moved on, but he yelled at Lao to bring it back.

He fumbled with the controls, wasting crucial seconds.

"By the Angels!" Michael gasped when the screen finally flipped back. Finding Sara's number, he frantically hit the call button.

…Four minutes and fifty-eight seconds. He prayed she wasn't prompt, for if she was…

"She's going to kill us all!"

*****

Sara made her way, quickly and silently across to the other side of the room where she found what looked like part of the hilt of a sword wired into the weapon system's controls. The Chetsuan breathed a sigh of relief that the schematic was correct. With her tracker in bits, she would have had no way of finding the fragment if it hadn't been there. She didn't have time to search the place. Still, no point dwelling on what might have been. The fragment was here, that was all that mattered, and she had thirteen minutes to figure out how to extract it. She needed to focus on that.

Her dragonclaw daggers could cut through the casing in no time, but there was no point doing that until she knew what to do next. Beside the fragment housing was a control console with a monitor display, although just like the last one, it was on sleep mode having not been touched for a while. Now that the lights were on, however, she wasn't going to attract attention by waking it.

She felt she was getting a handle on Lavosian technology by now, so she confidently navigated her way through the system, trying hard not to worry about her sister as the official countdown ticked down to twelve minutes.

*****

The security guards led Jessica to a small meeting room in one corner of the building. All the while, Jessica kept half an eye on her timepiece, trying to keep track of the countdown. She would co-operate for the moment, let her guards grow complacent, but she had already decided that in exactly seven minutes, she was going to escape. There were two guards on this side of the door and two more on the outside. They may have guns, she thought, as she sat in the chair that was offered, but she could have a dragonclaw dagger in each hand in a second and at close quarters, knives beat guns. Besides, she'd had time to strengthen her connection to nature in this world by now, and given this room, with tall standing plants in pots by the door and a jug of water on the table, she felt confident that she had enough resources for her fledgeling druid magic to work with.

A Lavosian woman entered the room, flanked by another pair of guards, sat down opposite Jessica, portacom propped up before her, and started recording.

"Now then," she began, "I thought we could have a nice, civilised chat before I hand you over to the authorities."

Jessica knew that was a lie. There was no way they would want Weslend law enforcement coming here and discovering that they were planning to commit genocide in just over ten minutes, but she played along.

"Aww, come on, love!" she protested. "There's no need for the cops. I was just poking around. I didn't mean any harm."

"So, what exactly are you doing here?" the woman asked, then she seemed to think better of the question. "In fact, putting that to one side for the moment, why don't you tell us your name?"

Whatever the Chetsuan told the Lavosian woman, she had no doubt she would look her up on the GlobeNet, so Jessica figured she might as well tell the truth, tie her up trying to find something that wasn't there.

"Unusual name," the woman remarked.

Jessica gave her a puzzled look. "Never understood complimenting someone's name," she remarked. "After all, I didn't choose it, my parents did, so you're really complimenting them, not me."

"Well, I wasn't really complimenting you at all," the woman pointed out. "Just commenting."

"Fair point," Jessica allowed. "Just a bugbear of mine, you know? Anyway, what's yours?"

"Breah," she replied. "Now, back to what you're doing here?"

"Like I said, I was just poking around."

"You expect me to believe that out of all the warehouses in this district, you picked this one at random?"

Jessica shrugged. "Today, yeah."

"Today?" Breah wondered.

"Look, it's what I do, OK? I get bored and sneak into a warehouse. Poke around. I've done half of them in this area already. Today was just your turn. Call it a hobby."

"If this is a hobby, how come your name isn't on the Criminal Database?"

"Nobody ever caught me before," she smirked. "Didn't have your security. Speaking of which, why do *you* have so much?"

Judging by the clock on the wall, there were only nine minutes to go. The Chetsuan just needed to keep them talking for another four, and she was out of there.

"This is a restricted building," Breah told her.

"Didn't see any signs," Jessica challenged, belligerently.

"That's because it's Top Secret and I think you know that from your 'snooping' in our computer system."

Jessica nodded, thoughtfully. "Yeah, you've got a Top Secret warehouse that you can't tell anyone is Top Secret because it's Top Secret. I see your dilemma."

"Now I have to decide what to do with you," Breah considered.

"Because I've 'seen too much'?" Jessica suggested. It was such a generic movie reference, she was willing to bet they used it on their vidcasts here, too. Judging by the flicker of a smile on Breah's lips, she was right.

"Without being needlessly dramatic, yes," she agreed.

"Well, you don't need to worry, dearie. After all, what could I do in…" she glanced that the clock, "Just over seven minutes?"

"It's what you do after those seven minutes that worries me, not what you might do to try and stop us before then. Nothing could do that now."

Jessica burst out laughing. It helped waste a bit more time.

"I'm sorry," she apologised, trying to catch her breath. "Did you really just say, 'Nothing can stop us now'? Talk about cliché!"

"In this case, it's true. We've accounted for every eventuality."

"If you say so," Jessica allowed, making a show of trying to calm down.

She wasted a bit more time pouring out a glass of water and putting the jug back down closer to her side of the table. They had no idea she was actually arming herself.

"Look, cards on the table." She didn't know if that was an expression here, but it didn't matter. "I know what you're trying to do – kill the dragons – and the truth is I've got no love for them myself. Because of dragons, I lost my home, my friends, my people. Almost everyone and everything I ever cared about."

She saw Breah visibly relax at that. Good. They were down to less than six minutes. In thirty seconds, she'd make her move. She breathed deeply and closed her eyes for a moment, letting them believe she was thinking about what she'd lost. She wasn't. She was thinking about what she still had: her sister. Time to rejoin her.

"So, you understand what we're doing here, then?"

"Oh yeah, I understand perfectly, love." Jessica opened her eyes and looked her interrogator straight in hers. "Just one question: When you say you've prepared for every eventuality, does that include aliens?"

Breah blinked. "I'm sorry?"

Jessica deactivated her perception filter, sitting there in all her purple glory.

"Heya, love!" she sang. "E.T.'s here!"

Five minutes to the barrier. Eight minutes to genocide.

With a glance behind her, the potted plants reached out to strangle the guards on the door. In the same, fluid movement Jessica sprang back from the table and smashed her glass of water. As the guards beside Breah levelled their guns, she asked nature very nicely to make the spilt water grow into an ice wall. Nature complied. The ice was a little thinner than she'd like, but it wasn't bad for a first attempt. The guards' lasers rebounded off the ice and ricocheted around their half of the room, shattering the window and causing the three Lavosians to dive for cover. Jessica recalled there were more guards outside the building, but she also remembered

the weeds. Reaching out, then, she made them grow tall and thick around the perimeter. That should delay anyone trying to get in. Of course, it would also delay she and her sister getting out, but they'd cross that bridge when they came to it.

Hearing the commotion, the two guards in the corridor flung the door open and came rushing in, but before their guns could be of any use, they saw her conjure a pair of daggers out of thin air. They were the last things they ever saw, as they severed the arteries in their necks.

"What are you?" Breah demanded, "Some kind of witch?"

"That is a highly offensive term where I come from," Jessica objected, snatching the jug of water from the table. "I'm a druid." Seeing hairline cracks appear in her ice wall, she pulled a face. "Trainee," she conceded.

"You said you understood!" Breah shot back, accusingly.

"Understood, yes," the Chetsuan replied. "Agreed with, never. Not for a second."

With that, she darted out of the door, slamming it behind her and, jug still in hand, poured some more water on the floor, growing another small ice wall to block them in.

An alarm sounded, echoing around the cavernous warehouse. Wasting not a moment more, she pictured the way back to her sister in her mind and sprinted that way, dagger in one hand, water in the other. Ready for anything.

Chapter 20

Sara spent a frustrating couple of minutes getting nowhere with the system. She understood about hacking – she'd even dabbled a bit on Earth. She'd never done anything dangerous or malicious. It was enough for her to simply have a poke around.

It had stood her in good stead, the time Daelen had been off on some other world and a massive lightning storm had led to a malfunction, causing the heating to become stuck on full blast. Not only was it going to cook them in the middle of the hottest heatwave on record, but it was also working beyond its safe limit and could very well explode. In that event, assuming they weren't killed, not only would she and Jessica lose their home – again – but it would also expose Daelen's base and his network of portals to the people of Earth. The consequences could have been catastrophic. It should have been a simple matter to turn it off, but the fully automated system seemed to have a mind of its own and refused to co-operate.

Jessica, of course, refused to leave her side.

"But if a voice says, 'I'm sorry, Sara, but I can't do that', I'm getting us both out of here!"

That had proved unnecessary, however, as Sara discovered a back door in the system and found a way to get it back under control. When Daelen returned, she gave him a piece of her mind about rescuing them only to leave them in a death trap. From that point on, he granted her full access to everything.

Compared to that, this system was child's play, but she defied anyone to get much done in two minutes.

At eight minutes to barrier up, her mobile bleeped, telling her she had a message. She looked at it with a puzzled frown, but it turned into a grin when she entered the string of numbers, letters and symbols it presented. Somehow, Michael and Lao had got hold of the security codes. That made operating the system much more straightforward. Putting her mobile down on top of the console, she got to work.

Six minutes to barrier up, she was already deep in the system when her phone rang again. She'd put it on vibrate only, but sitting

on top of so much metal, it seemed to make the entire factory ring in response. Without even checking the number, she answered it.

"This had better be important!" she growled, assuming it was Michael, but the voice that responded was female.

"PDI here. We're sending people your way, but I'm afraid we might be too late. We just got word the government are sending their own operative."

"What, just the one?" Sara scoffed, dismissively.

"Yes, but he's the best in the business. Don't underestimate him, Sara."

Then without so much as a 'Bye', she hung up, which was just as well because that's when the alarm sounded. Sara smiled. That was her sister, she was sure of it. Jessica was on her way, and when they were together, they were unstoppable.

Her smile quickly vanished, however, as in the monitor screen, she caught the reflection of a male Lavosian in a sharp suit levelling a gun. She didn't know how he could see her, but apparently, he could. She dived to the ground as a laser beam slammed into the console. This section of the high gantry was on a corner around a large pipe about three feet in diameter. Leaving her phone on the floor, then, she rolled to put that pipe between them, denying him line of sight. There, she used her left-hand dagger to quickly but carefully slice through the leather thong that kept her right one attached to her wrist.

Breaking cover for a second, she threw her free dagger at her attacker. He dodged to one side, allowing it to clatter harmlessly on the gantry behind him, but that gave Sara the opening she needed to sprint towards him, constantly weaving at random to prevent him tracking her movements and getting a clear shot. She pounced on him, slicing at his right wrist with her remaining dagger. His reflexes were too quick for her to open an artery, but she at least forced him to drop his gun, which she kicked off the gantry to the ground twenty feet below him. As she did so, he flicked open a knife in his left hand, and went for her neck, forcing her to jump back up.

As soon as her weight lifted, he kicked her so hard, he almost sent her over the edge. Sara winced as she slammed into a gated section of the guard rail that was built into this section. Obviously, it was there to allow materials and equipment to be lifted up from

below. She was grateful that the health and safety regime in this place was good enough to ensure that it was securely locked because it was the only thing that had saved her life.

Her enemy rushed at her, and she tried to throw him over the side, but he was wise to the move, stopped himself and jumped back away from danger. In the same movement, he tried to plunge his knife into her, but she blocked his strike with her own dagger. She was surprised that his blade could withstand the blow – her dragonclaw daggers should be able to slice through anything. Unless, of course, his knife was also made from the claws of dragons. Lavosian dragons.

As their fight continued, Sara was keenly aware that she was running out of time. She was sure the countdown must be down to three minutes by now. For a moment, it looked like that might be academic to her, as her enemy slammed her left hand so hard onto the safety rail that she lost her grip on her remaining dagger. He must have managed to sever the leather thong during their struggle, because it tumbled over the side. Now she was weaponless and he had her in a vice-like grip. She struggled to keep his knife away, but he was too strong, and it was getting inexorably closer.

*****

Along the way, Jessica had to deal with more guards as they came at her. If they were at range, she dodged and weaved at random, until she was close enough to cut them down. If they didn't see her coming, then they died without ever knowing why. She was swift, silent and deadly. She stopped for a second, to undo the leather thong from one of her daggers so she could throw it. Setting off again, quickly, this proved to be a wise decision as a guard levelled a gun at her from down the corridor. The dagger struck him between the eyes before he could fire a shot. She retrieved her weapon on her way past without missing a step.

Sara and Jessica had learned to fight at a young age. On Phitonia, fighting meant survival. Just because, on a larger scale, dragons were the enemy, on a smaller scale, that didn't make all Chetsuans their friends. In the face of limited resources, there was inevitably competition for food. Most Chetsuans tried to hold on to some scraps of civilisation and the concept of helping one another.

Others, however, fell back on barbarism and brutality, taking the lion's share for themselves and to hell with anyone else. That wasn't just limited to food, either. Some of the stronger males viewed females as property to fight over and to the victor went the spoils. Then there were those with a taste for younger, fresher meat. Rather than try and shield them from this truth, Jessica and Sara's parents taught them to recognise evil when they saw it and know how to fight it. When someone came at you, intending harm, you ended that threat and made sure they never got a second chance.

Their time on Earth had perhaps dulled their edge a little, not that there weren't threats there, but sparring with Mandalee had sharpened them up again. Mandalee was an assassin, devoting herself to ending threats to innocents. Her style of combat was really an extension of what their parents had taught them, and she knew they would have liked her enormously.

*****

At one point, faced with two guards at once, Jessica splashed a bit of water from her jug into the air to form a pair of ice shards which, with a bit of encouragement, flew on the wind to slay them even as they pulled the trigger. Their shots went wide. She wanted to keep as much water as possible, though, to protect Sara when she reached her, and she needed to reach her quickly because they had a new enemy to fight. With all the weeds she had grown around the outside, Jessica hadn't believed anyone could possibly get in. Unfortunately, she'd overlooked the roof. Using the noise of the alarm as a cover, a male Lavosian in a sharp suit blew a hole in the ceiling and abseiled down onto the gantry where her sister was.

Jessica ran up the nearest set of steps, throwing a security guard all the way down them when she reached the top. Carrying the jug of water was awkward but necessary. Catriona had told her how she'd learned to keep nature with her for her magic at all times, and while this might be a rather awkward way of doing it, for now it was her only option.

As she rounded the last corner, she saw the furious fight going on just ahead. Her sister was in trouble, but she'd seen her approach, and without a word, she had managed to communicate her plan. With their bodies positioned as they were, Jessica

couldn't go for the kill. If he moved at the last second, she might kill her sister instead. But Sara was using all her strength to keep the progress of his knife hand to a slow crawl. An easy target.

Jessica threw her dagger straight and true, and the Lavosian screamed as a dragonclaw dagger stuck itself in his hand, causing him to drop his weapon.

While he reflexively clutched his injury, Sara was able to break free and retrieve his weapon, but she realised he was trying to disguise the fact that he was pulling Jessica's dagger out of his bloody hand and claiming it for himself. Sara was willing to bet he was equally adept with his left hand as his right, and backed away, searching for an opening to attack.

Further along the gantry, Jessica saw Sara's knife lying next to another gated section. That gave her an idea. Finally putting the jug down, she called out to her sister, "Sara! To me!" and threw Sara's dagger at their enemy. He whirled around and managed to deflect it so that it embedded itself in the pipe in the corner, but Sara took that opportunity to duck under his arm and dash to Jessica's side.

At that moment, over by the console, Sara's phone rang. She realised that it must be Michael, which meant there could be no more than two minutes until the barrier went up. Standing in their way was this government intelligence agent.

"So, who's the guy in the suit?" Jessica asked.

"According to PDI, James Bond."

"Cool."

As their enemy charged along the gantry at the two Chetsuans, Jessica kicked over the jug. Water spilt out, which she instantly froze to form a sheet of slippery ice. He tried to stop himself, but it was impossible. Jessica used her remaining dagger to cut through the safety mechanism on the gate and Sara kicked him over the edge. He tumbled to the ground with a scream, which ended abruptly as his head collided with a large metal bolt. Then he lay still.

Jessica harmlessly evaporated the ice, and the sisters did a high five with their tails. He might have been the best individual operative Weslend had to offer, but when the two sisters from Phitonia were together, they were unstoppable.

Sara's phone was still ringing, insistently. There couldn't be much more than a minute to go.

"Jess," Sara said, "I'll answer that and work the controls. You cut the fragment free of its housing, OK?"

"Got it."

Dashing over to their respective positions, Jessica sliced the glass front out of the fragment casing, being careful not to cut herself, and Sara picked her phone up off the floor. She saw she was right: sixty-four seconds.

She accepted the call and spoke without checking the display. "Sorry, Mickey. Had a bit of a holdup here, but we're ready—"

"—Don't touch the fragment or we're dead!" came Michael's voice, cutting across her, his words coming out in a rush.

"Jess, stop!" she screamed, and only just in time as her sister's dagger was a hairsbreadth from the fragment.

"Portals are bi-directional," Michael reminded Sara and she immediately understood. If she suddenly stopped the flow of energy from the weapon to the power station, the energy would surge back through the portal and blow up the weapon, the warehouse and most of Weslend.

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While the demigod was frantically calling Sara, and Lao was distracted with his portacom, the technician had seized the opportunity to grab the fire extinguisher, lift it high above his head and slam it down hard on the console with a cry of, "Death to the dragons!"

The controls were crushed, sparks flew, and flames began to grow.

With the phone in one hand, an enraged Michael formed a fist with the other and plunged it straight through the technician's chest, ripping out his heart. Before the body had even hit the floor, Lao was using the fire extinguisher to put out the fire before it could take hold, but the damage was done. With less than ninety seconds to barrier activation, the console was useless. Lao still had access via his portacom, but he could only do so much without the proper controls.

At last, Sara answered the phone, and Michael convinced her to leave the fragment alone.

"Let the barrier go up as planned," he advised, putting the phone on speaker. "It's the only way, now."

Turning to his Lavosian companion, he asked, "Lao, can you get access to the barrier's field focusing system?"

Lao nodded as his fingers flew over the touch screen.

"Sara, you know what to do at your end?"

"Full reverse," she replied, emphatically.

"Well done," he commended her. He knew she wouldn't need him to explain.

"Got it!" Lao called out.

He, too, realised what Michael was getting at. He could pull the focus in, to form the barrier around the power plant only, containing the blast there. Just two problems: that was where they were standing, and the portal would carry the explosion back to Weslend, killing everyone there.

To solve both problems, Michael grabbed Lao and teleported them down to the main chamber of the power plant, as close as he dared to the portal. He widened it in anticipation of using it to escape to the warehouse in Weslend, but attempting to travel while there was still energy pouring through it would be suicide. Fortunately, there was a small window of opportunity. The surge was due three minutes and seven seconds after the barrier went up. Those seven seconds was the time it would take for the system to realign the necessary components to allow the surge program to kick in. Those seven seconds were their only chance to escape death.

At the other end, Sara counted down the seconds to barrier activation.

"Five…four…three…two…one…now!"

All around the world, millions of people were watching the vidcast, in anticipation of seeing the historic moment when the Wirathian barrier switched on. Dozens of officials were left with red faces as it failed to appear. But it hadn't failed. It just wasn't where they were looking for it. Lao confirmed that it was up around the power plant.

Waiting a couple of extra seconds to make sure the stream of energy had ceased for the moment, Michael and Lao dived

through the portal. Jessica saw them come through and told her sister, whose hands danced over the controls like a concert pianist. The power surge would happen as planned, but instead of pulling more power from the control device fragment, she reversed the flow to pour it all back in again.

Even with the flow of energy stopped, the Wirathian power plant had already absorbed a lot of unstable higher planar energy. Now it had nowhere to go. It would just go around and around in a system that was never designed for such power. In minutes, it would be too much for it to handle and explode, so Michael closed the portal, isolating it. Now, thanks to the barrier, it could harm no-one.

The PDI forces had arrived in Weslend by this time, and having hacked their way through the greenery, were storming into the facility, taking care of the last of the security. Before anyone could relax, though, Michael heard Sara swear, loudly.

Beating him to it, Lao called up, "What is it?"

"I can't stop it!" she cried.

When the enemy agent first attacked her, his laser beam had hit the console. It was mostly still functioning – she could change settings, reverse the power flow – but it wouldn't shut down. Jessica hit the big red Emergency Stop button. Nothing. The fragment was already beginning to throb, ominously. It wasn't designed to work like this, and the fragment was in danger of exploding into yet more fragments, releasing its energy as it did so. Sara had her containment box ready, which would make it safe for transport back to Tempestria, but if they didn't act fast, there wouldn't be anything to transport.

Chapter 21

Without a second's hesitation, Laoghaire told Michael, "Get us together."

Not questioning, the demigod teleported them both onto the gantry with their friends. Almost before they materialised, Lao was on his portacom, "Code Red Evac!" he yelled.

"Confirmed," acknowledged the voice on the other end.

"We need to extract the fragment!" Jessica cried.

"Not yet!" Michael warned her. "You'll create a power vacuum!"

"Huh?"

"It'll blow up," Sara translated.

It wouldn't be anywhere near as bad once the fragment was removed, but it would still take out much of the surrounding city, with them in the middle.

"Hence the evac," Lao said, pointedly.

Sara took out the containment box, Michael stood ready to weave a dampening spell around it as an extra precaution, and Jessica's dagger hovered as close to the fragment housing as she dared, waiting for her sister's say-so.

An almighty crash from above made them all look to the roof, as through it came a wing of a dozen dragons. PDI agents all abandoned what they were doing and climbed aboard. A magnificent golden dragon hovered next to the gantry where the four companions were standing.

"Wasn't expecting this," Jessica admitted, eyeing the dragon, warily.

Lao gave her a quizzical look. "You weren't expecting Pro Dragon Intelligence to employ actual dragons?"

"Fair point, love," she conceded. "You've got me there." Turning to the dragon, she asked, "What's your name, dearie?"

"Meghir," he rumbled in reply.

"Nice to meet you, Meghir," she beamed. "I'm—"

"Jess," Sara interrupted her, "maybe we should save the pleasantries until *after* we don't blow up?"

She nodded. "Just say the word, sis."

"Now!" she cried.

Quick as a flash, her sister cut the fragment free, dumping it unceremoniously into the waiting box. Sara slammed the lid shut and Michael worked his magic. The fragment was now safe, but they were not. There came an otherworldly screech as power surged through the system.

"Let's go!" roared the dragon and they all clambered aboard. He rose into the air, pulling them aloft with powerful strokes of his wings. Below them, the system was coming apart at the seams, fires broke out, and they could hear the pressure building inside the weapon as it strained to contain the chaotic, unstable power.

"Lay close to my back," the dragon told them. "I wouldn't want you to get hit by any debris. Don't worry about holding on, I won't let you fall off!"

Despite their initial fears, both Chetsuans found they trusted this dragon and their faith proved to be well-founded as he punched back outside through the roof without them getting a scratch.

No sooner had they cleared the building, than an almighty explosion ripped through it, destroying the horrific weapon inside. Hot flaming chunks were launched into the cold winter sky, setting more structures ablaze where they landed. All over the city, people were running and screaming, fleeing in panic into the winter streets, choosing freezing over burning. Power lines were damaged, cutting off electricity supplies and shutting off the lighting until everything was dark except for the reddish glow of the fires. Smoke filled the air, but out of that hellish scene came salvation. Dragons, those who had refused the Wirathian honey trap, swooped down and carried Lavosians to safety.

It wasn't always possible to land in the narrow, crowded streets so they simply picked people up in their claws, as gently as they could. At first, the people of Weslend, people who had been taught to hate and fear dragons, misunderstood their intentions and resisted, fearing they were being kidnapped and perhaps taken away to be eaten. Gradually though, most began to understand and see the rescue for what it was.

"You're heroes," Jessica told the dragon. "All of you. These people tried to exterminate your kind, and here you are saving them!"

"Their *government* tried to exterminate us," Meghir corrected her, "and I would gladly let the lot of them burn for what

they tried to do. But not at the cost of all those innocent people below us. Anyway, strange that you should call us heroes when you were the ones who saved my people from being roasted behind that terrible barrier."

"I supported that terrible barrier," Sara admitted with shame on her face and tears in her eyes. "At first, before I knew the truth of it, I thought it was a good idea to lock you all up, even though you'd done nothing to deserve it."

Jessica squeezed her sister's hand and leapt to her defence.

"You have to understand, Meghir, love, on our world the dragons tried to wipe out our people, and we can never see our home again thanks to what they did."

"That doesn't excuse it," Sara refuted. "Jess, you lived through that the same as I, but you saw this was wrong right from the beginning." She spoke to the dragon, once more, her golden flush growing, deepening. "Your kind aren't the dragons from our world, Meghir, and I shouldn't have treated you as if you were. Can you forgive me?"

"It seems to me that you had more cause for your fear of dragons than any of the people down there," Meghir considered. "The difference is you didn't rely on what you were being told about us. You found out for yourself, and when you discovered the truth, you changed your views and acted accordingly. I can see no fault in anyone who does that, so there is nothing to forgive."

With that, Sara lay comfortably on his back and hugged him tight.

"You're hugging a dragon," her sister observed, drily.

"I know."

"Sara, you're actually hugging a dragon!"

"I know!" she repeated with a grin.

"You'll be snogging him next!"

Sara just laughed.

*****

The anti-dragon government in Weslend tried but failed to squirm out of the consequences. They were expelled from office, charges were brought, and a new pro-dragon provisional

government was formed in its place until free elections could be held. There were similar scenes all over the continent.

The revelation of the genocidal plot and the heroic actions of the dragons in Weslend combined to sway public opinion, and the new provisional government chose to ride the tidal wave of goodwill to reveal exactly who it was that had saved the world.

The event was held in a large public park in the heart of Kaelia Capitolina, where a capacity crowd stood watching with dragons flying overhead and Lavosian vidcast technology streaming the whole thing across the GlobeNet.

"Amid the terrible events of the last few days," a spokeswoman began, "something incredible happened. As you all know, for years we have been sending out messages to the stars, dreaming of the day we might make first contact with people from another world. It somehow never occurred to us that people from another world might save us the trouble and pay us a visit instead. Yet that is precisely what happened.

"Why did they come? To invade and conquer us like in our vidcasts?" She laughed. "No, of course not. They came to help. You see, just as our world has come through a crisis, theirs has, too. Daelen StormTiger fought a terrible nemesis alongside the bravest of souls from this other world called Tempestria. Daelen himself was slain in that battle…"

The crowd gasped.

"Still, the battle was won, and their world was saved, but not before their enemy threw a fragment of his terrible power far away from Tempestria to Lavos.

"Some people found that fragment, but rather than seek to contain it and keep it safe, they decided to use it to construct a horrific weapon right here in this city!"

The crowd booed.

"Now, what did our neighbours from Tempestria do?" the spokeswoman asked, rhetorically. "Did they decide it was nothing to do with them? No. No sooner had they helped to save their own world, then they came to save ours, too!"

As the crowd cheered, Jessica, watching from behind the stage curtain, remarked, "Laying it on a bit thick, isn't she, dears?"

"Gotta love public relations," Sara sighed.

"Be grateful she's getting them to like us," Michael pointed out.

"I suppose," Jessica allowed. "Still, it doesn't seem right that Laoghaire's missing out on this hero's parade."

"It was his choice," Sara reminded her.

He had decided that his involvement should be kept secret so as not to jeopardise his future work with PDI.

"I know," Jessica sighed. "Still don't like it, though."

"Now, citizens of Lavos," the spokeswoman continued, when the crowd had quietened down, "from what I have learned, Tempestria is very different to Lavos. As you might expect, their people don't look like us, but if recent experiences with the dragons have taught us anything, it should be that we need not fear those who are different. Rather, we should judge them by their actions, and the actions of these people have set an example for us all. Now it's up to us to be worthy of that by welcoming them to our world!"

The crowd cheered louder than ever, and the dragons overhead roared their appreciation. Without waiting for them to quieten down, the spokeswoman continued, "Are you ready to do that?"

The cheers grew louder.

"Are you ready to meet these visitors to our world and welcome them in the name of Lavosians everywhere?"

The noise was deafening.

"Then I ask them, please come and join me on this stage: Sara, Jessica and Michael!"

"Not telling them your real name, then?" Sara asked the demigod.

"Oh, I gave up on anybody pronouncing that right centuries ago. Michael will do fine."

*****

This was a major turning point in Lavosian history, gentle reader. At the next elections, pro-dragon governments were sworn in all across the Vranian Alliance, and a mandate was quickly drawn up by many Lavosian governments to seek formal relations with Tempestria. The companions couldn't see how that would be

possible anytime soon but promised to pass on the message, regardless. Eventually, formal relations would indeed be established, leading to the formation of the Commonwealth that exists in my time.

Formal apologies were sent to the Wirathian people and the dragons. The Grand Relocation Plan was abandoned, and dragons once again spread throughout the world. Nevertheless, a large proportion of dragons chose to make Wirathia their home anyway, the inner desert being an ideal habitat for them.

The companions stayed long enough to see the changes unfold, taking advantage of the time difference with Tempestria, where only a couple of weeks would have passed. At last, though, they bade farewell to Laoghaire, and Michael opened a portal home, materialising outside the ruins of the ancient temple on the edge of the Rhynas Desert in Northern Alloria. From there, they made their way to Elvaria, to check on the situation there.

*****

The Council building in Walminster stood tall and proud. Wizards came and went in robes of Red, Black and White. There were druids, too, and even a few clerics. The companions met with the Triumvirate leaders, Laethyn, Maia and Justaria, and all seemed to be as it was before the Timeline shifted. Indeed, the Council were unaware that any such event had occurred.

Michael explained that the Guardians had gone back in Time to correct the problem and were surprised to find they weren't around.

"Has anybody tried the Black Tower?" Sara wondered.

Nobody had, so they asked Michael to portal them to Gaggleswick. Walking to the edge of the town, where the Tower stood, it seemed as warm and inviting as they remembered, suggesting Dreya was once more in control, the Time aberration of Ulvarius gone for good.

Still, Jessica advised Michael to wait outside the gate. "No offence, love, but I'm not sure you're on Dreya's guest list, and we don't want any trouble."

When they reached the door to the Tower itself, her elite guards were waiting inside. A quartet of death knights and a trio of

ghouls. The sisters held hands to help quell their fears at being this close to such deadly creatures without Dreya's direct control.

Swallowing nervously, Sara asked if they had seen their Mistress lately.

"Not for many days," the chief knight answered.

"You've no idea where she is, I suppose?" asked Jessica.

"We have tried, but we cannot sense her," one of the ghouls replied.

"But she…" Sara hesitated. "She's definitely still alive somewhere?"

"Or somewhen?" Jessica suggested.

"Most certainly," the knight insisted. "We are sworn to serve her until she dies."

"If she were dead, we would be released," whispered the ghoul.

There seemed to be nothing more they could accomplish there, and they wouldn't be comfortable staying in Dreya's Tower by themselves, surrounded by the undead. So, instead, they volunteered to help Michael build his home, in exchange for moving in with him when it was completed. He assured them he would be glad of the company.

*****

Weeks ticked by, turning into months. After a year, the Council of Mages declared the Guardian Project officially dead and although they tactfully categorised the Guardians themselves as 'missing', it was clear what they meant.

The two Chetsuans argued long and hard over that, but in the end, Justaria cut through it all, saying, "I understand your feelings in this. Really, I do. I was fond of Catriona myself—" Then before the sisters could object again, she held up a hand. "My apologies. I mean to say, I *am* fond of her and miss her greatly. The absence of Dreya in these lofty halls is keenly felt, and as for Mandalee, we have barely begun to know her. Nevertheless, the fact remains that they are not here."

The girls couldn't argue with her on that.

"In their absence, the world moves on, and I am intrigued by the notion of contact with another world. To that end, I have

already authorised projects to conduct research into that possibility. At the same time, these fragments you speak of are still out there doing perhaps untold damage. Although Time magic is lost to us for now, surely any fragments that were thrown into Tempestria's past must exist in the present. Since you have already proved your effectiveness at finding one such fragment, perhaps you can help us recover the rest."

The twin sisters looked at each other, communicating without words. Catriona had always spoken highly of this Justaria, and they could see why. While they might disagree over the status of their friends, they couldn't fault the practicalities of what she was saying, and there was a certain thrill at being charged with such a responsibility. So, they agreed they would do as Justaria asked to the best of their abilities.

*****

To that end, they had returned briefly to Lavos and paid Laoghaire a visit, asking him for the components to build another tracker. Sara constructed it in Daelen's base and tested it on the only safe source of higher planar energy available: Michael's ring. It worked perfectly, so they travelled back to Tempestria, keen to begin their search.

Their enthusiasm faded, however, as everything started to go wrong. Sara's device refused to function, leading to frustration and disappointment that grew into a despondent sense of embarrassment and failure. Jessica tried to keep her spirits up, but over the weeks and months, even her declarations of unwavering belief began to sound hollow. Plus, she had problems of her own, as her magic, so reliable on Lavos, began to fail her until she couldn't do the simplest things. Plants would wilt when she wanted them to grow, and weeds would grow when she wanted them to wilt. Spilt water refused to become ice and evaporated at the same rate whether she used her magic or not.

As the second year passed, gentle reader, all three felt they could no longer claim to be working for the Council when they'd achieved nothing, and while they didn't give up, exactly, they did find themselves stuck in something of a rut.

At the same time as restoring the ancient temple to its former glory, they busied themselves by helping the alien community, a stone's throw away to the North. After the Fall of Kullos, they had been granted amnesty. Kullos had used them, bringing them here to fight, through a combination of lies and force. Now they were stranded on Tempestria, almost certainly never to see their homes and loved ones again. Wasn't that punishment enough?

Sara and Jessica could relate to their situation, and Michael, also something of an outsider, was keen to help, too.

Kullos' former fortress and the surrounding area was already a self-sustaining city, so it made sense for the aliens to stay and build their new lives there. As for the name of this new community, Michael knew that there was once another city close to that site, called Qiapolis. It was lost during a terrible catastrophe in Alloria known as the Demon Apocalypse. However, with the fifty-year commemorations so fresh in people's minds, resurrecting the name was deemed insensitive and vetoed. Still, it was suggested that a subtle echo of the name might be acceptable. So, since the city was in the Rhynas Desert, the alien city became known as Rhynapolis.

In the beginning, there had been plenty to do, which helped to distract the three of them from dwelling on their missing friends. More than two years on, Rhynapolis was a thriving community. That meant they were no longer needed and so that distraction had faded considerably. By now, Sara had lost all hope that the three friends they had come to this world to be with, could possibly still be alive. Michael mostly kept his own counsel on the matter, but he, too, was convinced they must be dead. Jessica refused to accept it, at least on the surface, but in the darkness of the small hours of the morning when sleep eluded her, she knew that was more of a coping mechanism than a real belief.

But then, one ordinary day, a blue portal shimmered into existence in Michael's garden and their friends stepped out like nothing had happened.

Sara's device smashed, Jessica's magic flared, Sara flew, Jessica fell over, Michael went for a swim, and the Guardians seemed to think they'd only left yesterday.

"That day when you came to me needing help," Michael began, "when Dreya's grounds attacked you, and you sent us to

Lavos…" he paused and shared a look with the two Chetsuans before finishing, "That was over two years ago!"

Somehow, the Guardians had got lost in Time and missed two years, four months and sixteen days.

Chapter 22

"Two years?" Dreya echoed. "How is that possible?"

"You obviously got your Temporal co-ordinates wrong," Mandalee jibed. "And you say I can't steer my portals straight!"

"I didn't use any Temporal co-ordinates," the sorceress insisted, shaking her head, trying to make sense of it. "We went via Catriona's Meadow. We were Timeless. We should have defaulted to our natural Time, so I just used spatial co-ordinates."

"Personally, I think I would have used them anyway, but you're right, it shouldn't have been necessary," Cat hedged, diplomatically.

Taking in the scene before her, with Sara's broken technology, Jessica's out of control druid magic, and trying not to laugh at Michael's predicament, soaked to the skin with bits of greenery clinging here and there, her mind tried to piece it together.

Before it could get started, however, Jessica chirped up, "Hey loves, it might not have been very long for you, but we've been going through hell here, so maybe we could do hugs first, then figure out how the cosmos works later, eh?"

Cat smiled and held Jessica tight. "Of course, I'm so sorry for…whatever we put you through."

After hugs were sufficiently exchanged, Michael asked Cat if she'd mind drying him off.

"I'd ask Jessica, but I'm afraid she might set me on fire…again."

"Hey!" she protested, with a mixture of embarrassment and indignation. "I've apologised for that. Profusely. I just don't understand why my magic's so out of control. It worked fine on Lavos."

"Come here." Cat held out a hand, which Jessica took. "Now, you *are* going to evaporate the water from Michael's clothes and body."

Michael frowned. "Are you sure about this?"

The flash in Catriona's eyes told him it was time to shut up.

"Yes, I am," she insisted, firmly. "I am perfectly confident that Jessica can do whatever she sets her mind to."

"I wish I were," her Chetsuan friend remarked sullenly.

"OK, Jessica, let's lose that attitude," she admonished her.

"Sorry, but I even went to Calin's Tower to check out your book on druid magic – the books you borrowed are overdue, by the way—"

"So they are," Cat realised. She'd borrowed them on her way to fight Kullos. If they weren't overdue before they got lost in Time, they certainly were by now. "Oops. Anyway, let me guess, my book didn't help you?" Her friend shook her head. "That's because it's a technical manual. Your problems aren't technical, they're emotional."

"Emotional?"

"Look, you've done this before, yes? On Lavos?"

Jessica nodded.

"This is no different, technically. You can do this. Nature will listen to you, but you have to be clear. Now, take a few deep breaths. Close your eyes if it helps."

She did so. Then, with a look of intense concentration, she tried to evaporate the water, but even without opening her eyes, she could tell nothing was happening.

Out of the blue, Cat asked, "Jess, you're happy to see us again, aren't you?"

Jessica opened her eyes and frowned. "Of course I am."

"Then what's with this?" Cat gently poked and prodded Jessica's frown lines with a finger. "What's Miss Frowny Face all about?"

She smiled, and the tension left her face and body.

"Sorry, love. Still having a bit of a hard time believing it, I guess."

"Well, believe it," Cat encouraged her. She held up the hand that was holding Jessica's. "This is real. You feel it, don't you? I mean, we're friends, right? You'd tell me if I were a ghost, wouldn't you?"

Jessica laughed and nodded. "Yeah, but we'd still be mates even if you were."

"Good," Cat acknowledged with a smile. She called over to her sister. "Hey, Sara, what do you think? Can she do this?"

"Of course she can!" she affirmed.

"Well, don't tell me, tell your sister!"

"You can do this, Jess!" Sara insisted. "You've got this!"

Turning back to Jessica, Cat continued, “There, your sister believes in you. We all believe in you. Channel those feelings. Channel what you were feeling when your magic was working for you and what you’re feeling here and now, but at the same time, don’t let those feelings sweep you away. You’re the boss. You’re in control. You’re confident. Your magic will work. Expect it to work. Know that it will work. Now, in your mind and in your heart, tell nature what you want to happen.”

Jessica poured all of her positive feelings into her magic and she could feel nature respond to her call. She was clear in what she wanted to accomplish, and nature was happy to do it. It was a simple thing: the evaporation of water. Happened all the time. Jessica wanted it to happen a bit quicker, that’s all.

In less than a minute, Michael found himself completely dry.

“You did it,” he remarked in surprise.

“I did it!” Jessica echoed, hugging Cat in delight.

Sara came over and took her sister from Catriona’s arms to sweep her up in an embrace of her own, smiling and laughing. “I’m so proud of you, Jess! I knew you’d get your magic back.” Stepping back, she cast a regretful eye over the broken device on the table. “Just a shame about my tech skills.”

“Well, there I can’t help you, I’m afraid,” Cat told her. “But the two things are linked.”

It had only taken her a moment to understand the problem. Druid magic was tied to a balance of emotion and control. Where Mandalee was all fiery passion, and Dreya was all cool control, Cat walked the tightrope in between. For Jessica, of course, her emotions were linked to Sara’s. Between her tech problems and potentially dead friends, Sara had lost faith in herself and her purpose in this world. Jessica was inevitably swept up in that and she, too, lost confidence. She either didn’t believe her magic would work, so it wouldn’t, or she would try to force it, so it would flare up out of control with unpredictable results.

“You always seem so confident and in control when you do it,” Jessica marvelled. “How do you maintain that? Don’t you ever have doubts?”

It was Mandalee who answered, “Of course she does. She just sees doubts as a challenge to do it anyway.”

Dreya spoke up to say, “I always say Cat has a flair for the dramatic, but that’s how her magic works.”

Cat nodded. “I may *seem* confident and in control on the surface, but I’m not always, deep down. No-one is. But if I *act* confident and in control, then maybe I’ll trick myself into *being* confident and in control. Doubts are challenges, and flair is my style. That’s how it works for me. You need to find what works for you, and by the looks of things, you’re doing that just fine. Clearly, what you need is for your sister to be happy, and I don’t think that’s a surprise to anyone here.”

While they’d been talking, Dreya had wandered over the table upon which, amid the broken components of Sara’s device, lay the control device fragment. “What were you doing with this, Sara?” she asked, holding it up.

“Oh, it was just an idea,” she replied, blushing. She explained how on Lavos, she had successfully built a tracker to find the fragment. She’d had no such joy on Tempestria even though the device was the same. “This morning, I had a flash of inspiration…or possibly desperation,” she admitted.

She explained that Michael had long since stabilised the fragment, so it wouldn’t blow up in her face, as long as she didn’t try to pull power from it. Her device merely scanned that power, analysed it. “I thought maybe like might attract like,” she concluded.

“From what I know of shadow warrior technology,” Michael put in, “I thought it sounded like a reasonable hypothesis.”

“I think it was more than reasonable,” the sorceress attested. “Sara, I think it worked. Just not as you intended.”

“What do you mean?”

Dreya explained that travelling from Catriona’s Meadow with spatial co-ordinates alone should always naturally default to their present, but that the ‘present’ would have moved on a bit in the time they’d been away.

“The present, whenever that might be, is a very specific concept, which generates Temporal co-ordinates that serve as an anchor in Time.”

“Simply put,” Cat chimed in, “one hour in the past should bring us back an hour after we left.”

Of course, they could return the exact moment they left, she went on to say, but then that would technically be their past. Therefore, if they wanted to interact with the world, they would have to drop their Timeless state and age like everyone else. Thereby losing one of the key benefits of the Guardianship.

It was impossible to travel independently into their own future because it would necessarily involve imaginary co-ordinates. That was just asking to get lost in Time forever.

"However," Dreya said, moving on with their explanation, "it is theoretically possible to pick up a future transmission, which in the absence of specific Temporal co-ordinates could act as a beacon in Time, pulling us towards it."

While they were Timeless, such a beacon could only be from a *possible* future, but as soon as they stepped through their portal, that became their definitive Timeline.

"Cat's right," she admitted. "I should have used specific Temporal co-ordinates, just to be safe, but since I didn't, I'm grateful you acted on your inspiration today, Sara. Otherwise, I could just as easily have picked up a beacon from two centuries in the future as two years."

"So, it *is* your fault!" Mandalee growled. It had taken her a while to process the idea that two years had passed, but now that she had and she knew it was the result of a mistake, she was boiling with anger, building to fury and rage. "We missed two years, and you expect me to be grateful that it wasn't two hundred?"

"Look, Mandalee, I am sorry, but think about it: we're Timeless. Does a couple of years really matter that much?"

"Dreya!" Cat gasped. She knew why her best friend was so upset, and she couldn't believe her fiancée didn't see it, too.

"Does it really matter?" Mandalee exploded. She was a hairsbreadth from going for weapons. "Does it matter that I abandoned Shyleen for two years? Does it matter that I've been cut off from my oldest friend in the world who shares half my soul? Does it matter that she's had no-one to talk to for two years? Does it matter that without Cat or me here, there isn't a single person in the world that could understand her? Does it matter that anything could have happened to her in that time when I wasn't here? Does it matter that she's probably spent the last two years thinking I'm dead?"

Her voice cracked on that last word as her rage began to fight a war with her tears, while Dreya acted like her every line was a physical blow.

At the same time, the sorceress could sense Catriona's disappointment coming at her in waves, which was even worse.

What had she been thinking, saying something so stupid? She could feel that presence in her mind again. The sliver that had escaped her control as she fought Ulvarius. She could feel the entity gloating, smugly, as it sat in a dark corner of her mind, just out of reach. But she couldn't use that as an excuse, so she kept quiet.

Tentatively, Michael ventured, "If it helps, she's with your friend, Windell. I can ask around. Someone's bound to know where he is, and then you'll find her. I'm sure she's fine."

"I know she's fine, I can sense her, and I can find her myself!" she screamed. "That's not the point! It's—" she broke off, "—oh, why am I even wasting my time?" she spat.

Reaching out to the animals all around, she considered calling her giant albatross for a lift, but she was too far away, and Mandalee wasn't willing to wait. She needed to be out of there before she said – or did – something she'd regret later. From the chatter of the animals, she knew where there were a couple of wild horses who could carry her where she needed to go, so without another word – even to Catriona – she sped off in that direction.

There was little point in anyone going after her. They could never be fast enough to catch her.

"I'm sorry," Dreya offered, quietly, into the space her friend had vacated.

A million things flashed through Catriona's mind to say in response, but she knew none of them would help, so she didn't say any of them. Instead, she decided forgiveness, while not strictly hers to give, would be more beneficial than any harsh words. Dreya still wasn't used to emotional considerations. She'd come a long way, but there was more to be done, and her fiancée knew that as well as she did. It wasn't that Cat was trying to change Dreya – she'd never do that. She just wanted to bring out the person she knew was inside. The Dreya only she knew. She wanted to share that Dreya with the world…

…Well, she reconsidered, maybe there were a few parts she wanted to keep for herself, but everything else, she wanted to share.

Cat reached out to caress her arm. “I know you are, and I’m sure she’ll come back when she’s ready. Until then, I have an idea that might help all of us fit back into our lives here, together.”

“What’s that?” Dreya asked.

“Well, it seems to me that we’ve been engaged for over two years, now, in a way.”

“In a way, yes, I suppose we have,” Dreya agreed.

“In that case,” Cat continued, “I think it’s high time we started planning our wedding, don’t you?”

“What about the Council?” Dreya asked. “Shouldn’t we contact them?”

Cat made a dismissive noise. “They think we’ve been dead for over two years. I think they can wait a bit longer. Besides, they wouldn’t exist if not for us.”

Dreya smiled and conceded the point.

“Alright then, loves,” Jessica said, “let’s start planning!”

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They spent the next few days together, making plans, swapping stories, eating, drinking and simply enjoying each other’s company.

A week later, Mandalee still hadn’t returned, and Cat was torn. She wanted to give her friend time but didn’t want it to be another two years. Personally, she didn’t think what Dreya had done was as bad as her own actions, or inactions, a few years ago, and from what Mandalee had said, Shyleen wasn’t actually hurt this time. On the other hand, though, Mandalee didn’t have the same bond of friendship with Dreya as with her.

She wondered if this was how it would always be. Would one of them always do something to drive Mandalee away? If so, would she always find her way back, or would she quit as White Guardian? One of the main reasons she’d agreed in the first place was the prospect of more time with Shyleen. Yet, as a result of their very first mission, she had actually *lost* time.

She supposed this was one of those occasions when she needed to come up with one of her ridiculous radical plans. They had seen the effects of bringing non-Guardians to her Timeless Meadow, but Shyleen was a god and technically part Guardian.

Maybe she'd be OK, but Cat would never risk Shyleen's life on a maybe, any more than Mandalee would. She needed to be sure.

In the end, Catriona decided to give her friend a little more time while she pursued another idea. Jessica had given her the spark of inspiration for this one. Dreya had identified a problem with their Time Interventions: how could they tell if history was off track and furthermore, how could they be sure if their Intervention was getting things back on track or further 'off the rails' as Jessica would say?

In the case of Ulvarius, the change had been unmistakable, and they'd done their best to fix it, but she knew for a fact things weren't back exactly as they had been. Cat still hadn't told Dreya about her mistake that led to Dagamir's survival. She stood by that decision now more than ever. Her fiancée had enough to deal with, with one mistake. There was no need to make her deal with two. Not unless there were some dire repercussions, which, from what their friends had told them, there didn't appear to be.

Still, it did highlight the problem, and while she didn't have the details of the solution worked out yet, it seemed obvious that it must involve creating a Timeless repository of information. It made sense, then, to begin with the foremost store of free information in the world: Calin's Tower. That library was already protected by universal agreement, and many important works were protected by preservation magic. Why not go a stage further and protect its entire contents from Time shifts? But there would have to be some means of incorporating *positive* Time shifts. After all, if they hadn't used Temporal magic in the battle against Kullos, the world would not exist.

Those were the kind of rules and regulations that would have to be ratified by the Council. The Guardians couldn't be allowed to simply do as they pleased with Time, but by the same token, the Council couldn't be allowed to dictate rules over magic that was outside their experience. As ever, there would have to be a balance.

Returning her thoughts to the present, Catriona didn't want to approach the Council of Mages until the Three Guardians could present a united front, and that brought her back to Mandalee.

"So, Dreya," Cat concluded, "I suggest that I go and return my library books. While I'm there, it would be rude not to stop and discuss things with Calin when my plans obviously involve her.

After that, I'll go and find Mandalee. While I'm doing that," she continued, "perhaps you should make yourself scarce for a while."

Dreya pulled a face, not keen on the idea. She wanted to re-establish her foothold with the Council. Who knew what Laethyn might have got up to while the puppet master was away? After two years, she felt it was time to pull on those strings, remind him who was really in charge.

"Plus, I really want to check on my Tower, make sure everything's in order." Specifically, she wanted to verify that her control over her elite guards hadn't wavered in her absence. From what the Chetsuans had shared, it didn't seem so, but she liked to form her own judgements about these things.

"OK, compromise," Cat proposed. "You can stop off at home on your way."

"On my way where?"

In response, Cat took her notebook out of her pocket dimension and flicked through the pages to Dreya's notes on Kullos' portals. Her best attempt at determining where and when the fragments had gone. She pointed out one set of co-ordinates.

"Of course," Dreya nodded, understanding. It was off-world, so didn't involve Temporal magic, but unlike Lavos, they could hardly send their Chetsuan friends. "Phitonia."

Cat nodded. "You talk about wanting to re-establish your control with the Council after two years and four months, but—"

"—But it's been almost a decade on Phitonia," Dreya finished.

"Ten years with a fragment knocking around somewhere," Cat pointed out. "What if a dragon got hold of it? You could have the dragon equivalent of Ulvarius out there."

"Or a Chetsuan out for vengeance," Dreya suggested.

"Not that I'd blame them, but we have to get that fragment back, nonetheless."

"Sounds like they might need someone to save the world," Dreya considered.

"Or conquer it," Cat suggested.

Dreya smiled. "You know me too well."

Cat kissed her full on the lips, then stepped back and repeated what she'd said the last time.

"Good hunting!"

Chapter 23

Phitonia. Where the grass was always bluer.

Dreya decided that rather than simply appear amid the ruins of the Citadel of Doom, she would retrace her steps from the first time she came to this world. Daelen's former base was devastated, following his violent extraction of power to defeat Kullos and futile attempt to keep the Guardians out of it. Something that turned out to be a contradiction as he could only defeat Kullos with the Guardians' help. Still, the fact that it was undisturbed suggested the perception filter that hid the place from this world was still active.

Perhaps she should check on Daelen's base on StormClaw on Tempestria, she considered. Make sure the secret island was still hidden.

All Daelen's portals were now gone, of course, but she didn't need them. She could make her own off-world portals, at least to Lavos, Phitonia and Earth.

Part of Catriona's wedding plans had included a honeymoon somewhere on Earth. There were undoubtedly many intriguing possibilities on that world. Despite there being no wizardry or other such powers there, Dreya was sure there would be no lack of magic when the time came.

She was in no particular hurry as she began walking. The fragment had been here for ten years, Phitonian time. It was unlikely that another few hours would make much difference. She could ask the dragons for a report of the current state of play, but just as with her elite guards, she preferred to make her own observations. Besides, she was curious about how the Chetsuan people were doing.

Dreya encountered a village where there had been none before. She found that encouraging, so she stopped for a moment in the shadow of a cluster of trees to observe.

The village lay by a stream on which industrious Chetsuans had built a mill that they were using to process the wheat that they were harvesting from the land. In some ways, it reminded her a little of Compton in the time of Ulvarius, three hundred Tempestrian years ago. It was a simple way of life, but they were thriving in a way that had not been possible when they were hiding

from dragons in holes in the ground. The sorceress felt a certain glow of pride that she'd had a hand in this. Whatever her motives – public and private – this was the result: a civilisation finding its feet after decades of oppression and slaughter.

She considered shrouding herself or perhaps disguising herself as a Chetsuan, but rejected both ideas. She didn't like lies. In her mind, that immediately placed herself in debt. Back in Time, it had been necessary to conceal her true identity and in a crowded city here – if there was such a thing – it might be wise if she was going to go about her business quietly. Here there was no such need. She wanted to find out what life was like here, now. That required her to ask questions, to which she expected honest answers. Therefore, she owed them the truth in return.

Stepping out of the shadows, she approached the village, following the road. The blue grass and plants had long since overgrown the streets but hadn't erased them completely. Chetsuans of past times had built to last.

Shielding her eyes from the sun, Dreya read the simple wooden painted sign: *Whealhaven*. She called out a greeting, wondering what their reaction might be. The workers in the fields looked up and called out for someone named Scarlett. A Chetsuan woman stepped out of the mill doorway. When she saw their visitor, her eyes widened. A male Chetsuan stood by her side, drawing a sword, obviously intending to protect her. Dreya guessed he was her husband.

With one simple gesture from Scarlett, the villagers brandished their tools or whatever they had to hand and took up threatening poses. Scarlett herself carried a bow, with arrows in a quiver, but rather than use that weapon to threaten Dreya, she simply waved her hand in the air, and as Dreya looked around, the azure plants grew up and snared her, paying particular care to bind her hands. It was clearly druid magic and a sensible move against a wizard…any wizard except her.

Dreya was in no danger from these people. She was more disturbed by their actions than anything else. These were the actions of people whose land and livelihood had been threatened before and were prepared to fight to defend what they had. Dreya hadn't stopped to make laws when she was last here, but if she had,

then her law would fully support these people's right to do this. She was just concerned as to why they should feel it was necessary.

"Please, I mean you no harm," Dreya reassured them. "My name is Dreya the Dark. Ten years ago, I conquered your world, taking it out of the control of dragons and tried to give it back to you."

"And why would you do that?" Scarlett asked.

"Because I needed dragons to help fight a powerful enemy on my world. That meant I needed to make the dragons scared enough to obey me. The best way to do that was to conquer your world. When I killed Mallax, I made the dragons understand the consequences of harming Chetsuans. I told them to allow you to come out of hiding and rebuild. It seemed like the best thing I could offer in return for the intelligence that made my conquest possible. I don't like being indebted to people. It's a personal thing. Unfortunately, events on my own world have kept me away for longer than I would have wished, but I'm back now, and I intend to see to it that my law is still in force. So, if dragons have threatened you in any way…"

"Dragons don't scare us," Scarlett replied, dismissively. "Not anymore. As far as we can tell, they have kept your law. In fact, it was a dragon who helped when we were attacked."

"Attacked?" Dreya wondered, greatly disturbed. "Attacked by whom?"

"A wizard from your world," Scarlett answered.

"He would have burned down our entire crop if my Scarlett hadn't found a way to put out the flames with her magic," her husband spoke up.

The attack had shown them the continuing need to defend themselves against threats other than dragons, Dreya realised. Hence their actions against her.

"Do you know who this wizard was?" Dreya asked.

She couldn't understand how any other wizard could have made the trip. Sure, she'd missed two years of magical progress, but even she had needed a little help to figure out the wizard version of the Prismatic Sphere portals. Cat had learned her version directly from Daelen, and she had helped Mandalee with hers. Who could possibly have the ability to learn them independently?

Moreover, the location of this village, so close to Daelen's former base struck her as a highly suspicious coincidence. Almost as if this wizard had portalled in at similar co-ordinates. But that was impossible. Wasn't it?

"He didn't give a name, but he wore Black robes – simple ones, not like yours – and kept his face concealed in his hood the whole time. He claimed to be an emissary of Dreya the Dark. We didn't believe him. He told us he was on an important mission on your behalf and demanded every last scrap of food and supplies we had. He maintained it was your price for saving the world."

Dreya shook her head, deeply troubled by what she was hearing. "I would never exact such a price," she swore. That was slavery and slavery was a form of tyranny. She detested tyrants.

"And we refused to pay it," Scarlett's husband insisted. "So, he set our fields on fire as punishment."

"Fortunately, a bronze dragon called Pavay was flying overhead," Scarlett explained. "He saw the flames and took the wizard away."

"Scarlett," Dreya spoke up, wincing slightly, "I am truly sorry for what happened. I will do everything in my power to find out who did it and make whatever reparations I can, but I assure you, I sent no emissary, and he most certainly did not act in my name."

"As my wife says, we never believed him."

"But we do believe you," Scarlett added. With another gesture, the villagers put away their weapons and returned to their work.

"Excellent," Dreya approved, wincing again. "In that case, would you mind asking the plants to loosen their grip, please? Any tighter and I'm going to lose a hand."

"Oh dear, I'm so sorry!" Scarlett gasped, suddenly flustered, bringing her hand to her face. "I didn't mean for them to keep tightening! Erm..." Scarlett waved her hand in the air, uncertainly, but nothing happened. She tried again. Same result. Turning to her husband, she suggested, "Oswald, maybe you should cut her free."

He moved to do so, but Dreya, seeing an opportunity, stopped him. "No, wait. Scarlett, you can do this with your magic," she insisted.

Dreya could free herself with a simple power word at any time, but that wasn't the point. Scarlett's magic was a valuable weapon in defence of this village, but only if she could control it. It was time for Dreya to see how much she'd learned from Catriona.

"Oswald, do you believe she can do it?" she prompted.

"Of course I do," he affirmed.

"Well, don't tell me, tell your wife!"

Nodding, he turned to Scarlett. "Scarlett, honey," he encouraged her. "You can do this. I believe in you."

"Excellent," Dreya approved. "Now, Scarlett, how were you feeling when you asked the plants to restrain me?"

"Honestly, I was scared. I feared for our village, for our community, for what we'd built here."

"It wasn't just fear, though, was it?" Dreya prompted.

She shook her head. "I was angry, too. Angry that you people thought you had the right to come here and attack us, take or destroy our hard work. I was angry, and I wasn't going to let you do it! I'm sorry, Mistress Dreya."

"Don't be sorry, and you can drop the 'Mistress'. That's for the dragons, so they don't forget their place. You had every right to be angry. Every right to defend your home. More than that, though, that anger was focussed. That's good. Druid magic – that's what we call what you can do – channels emotion, but it has to be controlled, directed, focussed. Now that you realise who you've captured, you're worried. Worried how I'll react. That worry leads to doubt, indecision, hesitation. That affects your magic. Stop worrying about me. I'm not going to harm you. I've told you that you were right to do this. Suppose it wasn't the plants holding me. Suppose it was two of your muscular workers over there. If you told them to release me in the timid way you just tried with the plants, do you think they would have obeyed?"

Scarlett smiled. "No. They'd pick up on my hesitation, my uncertainty, so *they* would be hesitant and uncertain."

"Precisely. I've seen how you lead the people here. They clearly believe in you, and your husband, Oswald, he believes in you, too."

"I do, Scarlett," he agreed. "You know I do."

"So, channel that. Use that emotion, that control. Tell the plants to release me. You don't need your husband or anyone else to do it for you. You can do it yourself."

Determined, Scarlett glared at the restraining plants and with the same gesture she used to command the people around her, she told them to release Dreya. They immediately complied.

Oswald swept his wife up in an embrace. "I knew you could do it!"

Approaching Dreya, Scarlett thanked her, vigorously shaking her hand which actually helped the blood to start flowing again.

"I've never felt such control over my magic before. How did you know all the right things to say?" she asked.

Dreya smiled. "My fiancée is the most skilled druid I have ever seen, and I recently saw her give a similar lesson to a friend."

"Please, let us invite you into our home," Oswald offered. "We live over the bakery. It's not much, and our food is simple fare, but we'd be honoured to share what we have."

She had eaten quite well over the last few days at Michael's new home, but she knew that these people would be offended if she refused. She also wanted more information, so going on a diet for a few days after this would be a small price to pay.

"Very well, I will have a little, but I don't want to take too much from you after what that wizard did to you."

Scarlett waved a hand, dismissively. "Oh, that was a good seven, eight years ago now?" She looked up at her husband whose expression seemed to confirm it was about right. "Besides," she added with a wink, "can you imagine the reaction when I tell people our bread was approved by Dreya the Dark herself? The publicity will be great for business. That should more than make up for that setback."

So, the offer of a meal was as much business as it was an act of kindness.

Dreya approved.

This was precisely the sort of intelligent, hardworking enterprise that would get this world back on its feet. She hoped this village would be a taste of things to come, in more ways than one.

"I'm curious," Dreya began as they walked together. "Why did you believe I was who I said I was when you didn't believe that wizard?"

"You were honest about your motivations," Scarlett answered. "He lied. If you were an imposter, you would have claimed your actions were entirely altruistic as he did."

"My ulterior motives don't bother you, then?"

Oswald shook his head. "Why should they? Whatever your motives, the result was a chance for Chetsuans everywhere. For that, we can only be grateful and the way we choose to show that gratitude is by striving to make something of our small corner of the world. Now, if there's anything our humble village can do to help the mighty Faery sorceress who made all this possible, then we'll do it gladly."

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During the meal, Dreya asked if they could remember anything more about the wizard who attacked them, but it was a long time ago, so the details were hazy.

Dreya asked Scarlett and Oswald if they would object to her using her magic to see into their minds, to see what they saw when the wizard attacked. They agreed.

The sorceress had never had reason to use much in the way of mental magic, but she tried to be as gentle as possible. It was a mostly fruitless endeavour, however. Perhaps anticipating something like this, he had taken great pains to hide his identity. The only clues were a dagger with a distinctive jagged blade and some kind of technological device in his hand that emitted a flashing light.

"It can't be!" Dreya gasped.

"What is it?" Scarlett asked.

She recognised the device. It was like the one Sara was working on. The technology that had helped her and Jessica to find the fragment on Lavos.

"I think this wizard came here for the same reason I did."

When she briefly explained, Scarlett wondered, "Do you think he found it?"

"I'll have to find out for sure, but with that tracker and an eight-year head start, he'd have to be pretty incompetent to have failed, and if he's smart enough to build a tracker and come here, he's not incompetent."

Scarlett was none the worse for wear after Dreya's magic, but it did give Oswald a mild headache, for which she apologised. Scarlett promised to soothe it away, although whether she meant by magical or other means, Dreya didn't pry.

They suggested that if Dreya wanted to see more of their land, she might try a large market town called Axford about ten miles away. It was the closest thing they had to a capital city these days, at least that these people knew about. They would travel there two or three days a week to sell their bread and buy or barter for vital supplies.

"The road isn't up to much, but just follow the river Axa, and you can't go wrong."

Dreya thanked Scarlett and considered her options. She needed to talk to the dragons, especially this bronze one, Pavay, to find out what he did with the wizard who had dared to attack people here in her name. Still, she was keen to see more of this world, so she decided on a compromise. Rather than teleport or portal directly to her usual rendezvous with the dragons, she would head for this market town, Axford, for a short while. Then, when she was ready to leave, she would call down a dragon – of which there were no shortage in the sky – and fly to the ruined citadel, instead.

"As for the roads hereabouts, Scarlett, you could do something about that with your magic," Dreya suggested. "It wouldn't take much time once you got the hang of it, and it would make your journeys to market easier."

"Good idea, I'll have to take some time to practice," she replied.

"You should do that," Dreya agreed, "but as I'm here, I might as well do part of the job my way."

She was no druid, so her way would be a little crude, but it would get the job done. She invoked her magic to bring fire to bear on the grass and vegetation, exercising perfect control to confine the effect to what was growing on or over the path. She let the flames continue along the road as far as she could see, and then

shut them off. She didn't want to accidentally burn someone over the next hill.

"There," she declared, satisfied, "and if anyone asks, this is *not* an act of kindness from a Black robe. I'm doing this to make my own journey easier. The fact that it might help others is entirely incidental."

Scarlett and Oswald both hid a smile.

"Of course," Oswald agreed.

With that, Dreya set off walking. As she did so, she caught Scarlett's voice on the breeze. "We just spent an afternoon entertaining Dreya the Dark! No-one is ever going to believe it!"

Chapter 24

Along the way, gentle reader, Aunt Dreya spotted a few more small settlements in the distance that had sprung up since her first visit. Despite this, there were still some wild horses around, one of which she appropriated for her journey. As she travelled, my aunt periodically cleared the road with her magic, but as she approached within about five miles of the market town, she saw the job had already been done. The road was wider and, while not exactly paved, there was a flat bed of stone to make the way easier under foot or hoof.

In a border, between the road and the blue fields, there was a distinctive blanket of green and red flowers growing beneath the violet sky. Aunt Dreya was no expert on flowers, and in any case, she could have no idea what those species were called in this world. However, there was one particular variety that caught her eye. They looked something like the dahlias that grew abundantly in her own grounds, except, remarkably, all the petals were composed of three colours: black, white and red.

'*They would make a wonderful gift for Catriona,*' she thought.

Taking a wider view, there seemed to be a definite pattern to the arrangement of flowers. She didn't know what the pattern might represent, if anything, but one thing she was sure about, was that it was the work of Chetsuan hands. A promising sign of civilisation.

As Dreya began to share that road with others. She kept herself to herself, keeping her hood pulled over her head and her hands in the pockets of her robes. She steered the horse with a gentle prod of magic until finally she reached Axford.

Crossing over a stone bridge across the river, she passed beneath a stone archway and a sign that read, 'AXFORD MARKET TOWN: ALL WELCOME', and welcome was exactly how Aunt Dreya felt.

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Dismounting and giving her horse a smack on the rump to send it back into the wilds, she was impressed by what she saw as she began her exploration. Streets were clearly marked out with market stalls arranged neatly in between. The air was filled with the sounds of merchants touting their wares and the ring of steel on steel. There would always be a need for security in a place like this, and if Sara and Jessica were true representatives of their people, they had learned to take care of themselves. Among the many smells were those of the blacksmiths' forging fires, mingled with freshly cooked food. Passing a bakery, Dreya wondered whether some of their wares might have come from Whealhaven.

The Chetsuan people had come a long way in ten years. They had been given a chance for freedom and they'd grabbed it with both hands.

The dragons, for their part, seemed to be obeying her one rule, to leave them be. There were a few flying overhead, and a gathering place like this would be easy pickings for them, but there was no indication of any such trouble.

In some ways, it wasn't such a surprise that the Chetsuans were achieving so much. According to what Dreya knew from Sara and Jessica, despite their conditions, they had tried to maintain some form of education, to preserve knowledge as best they could. Obviously, in the past decade, they had been able to put that knowledge to good use. They seemed to have specialised quickly, doing what they could and trading for what they lacked. In many ways, this was an intriguing opportunity for study. Given the time difference with Tempestria, coming back at regular intervals to see their progress would be simple. Especially now that, as a Guardian, she had perhaps all the time in the world – any world.

Maybe she and Cat should have their honeymoon here, instead, she pondered. She had enjoyed showing Cat the sights of Gaggleswick in the early days of their relationship – she still had the photos. She could imagine the delight in Catriona's eyes as they explored the lands of this world together, seeing it for the first time as a married couple. Yes, Dreya liked that idea very much and resolved to discuss it with Cat when she next saw her. She was sure Mandalee would enjoy visiting this world, too, with Shyleen. Perhaps introducing the Cleric of Nature to the nature of a whole

new world would make up for her thoughtless remark, earlier. A pity Sara and Jessica could never see it.

A male Chetsuan snapped her out of her thoughts, waving a plate under her nose. Arranged on that plate were several varieties of cheese.

"Greetings, stranger. Would you care to try?"

"Thank you," she replied, "but I'm not from around here. I'm…a traveller." That was true enough. "I'm afraid I don't have whatever you use for currency around here."

"A traveller!" he declared, his face a picture of delight. "We get many of those around here these days, friend. Some like to explore this land, now that we are free of the dragons' wrath. Others, like those you see here, prefer to stay in one place and build a life." He shrugged. "The world needs both kinds. Tell you what, take one of these as a free sample. All I ask in return is that if you enjoy it, then tell others of the delicious cheeses available at Lex's in Axford Market."

"Sounds like a fair exchange to me," Dreya agreed.

She picked a slice at random and popped it into her mouth. It really was quite delicious. Similar to something she often bought in Gaggleswick, but slightly different at the same time. If she were in any sense local, she could very well see herself adding this to her larder in the Black Tower. Unfortunately, after two years, she'd been forced to tell her guards to throw everything out, since it had surely spoiled by now. She would have some serious shopping to do when she settled back into a routine.

"Strange how taste and smell can take you back home no matter how far you travel," Dreya remarked absently.

"'Lex's Cheeses: a taste of home no matter where you're from'," the man paraphrased. "With advertising like that, you can have another slice if you like."

Dreya shook her head. "No. Our agreement was one slice in exchange for me telling others. So far, the only person I have told is you. It wouldn't be fair to take more when I haven't yet fulfilled my end, but perhaps I could buy a portion to take with me on my…travels. Is there somewhere hereabouts that I could exchange something of value for currency?"

"Certainly. You should go to Kindred Currency in the Northwest quarter. They'll give you a fair deal. Stay away from

anyone promoting TrustCorp," he warned with a frown. "Despite the name, they're swindlers."

Dreya thanked him and walked away.

She was a little sorry to hear about this TrustCorp place, but she supposed it was inevitable. The Chetsuans here were evidently building their civilisation on the ideal of freedom. Within such a system, there would always be those who wanted to create something honestly like Lex or those in Scarlett's village, and those who would seek to take advantage. Dreya couldn't regulate every little aspect of their lives here and wouldn't want to. She had conquered this world for her own ends, but she had no interest in ruling it. As long as dragons didn't harm Chetsuans, both species were free to make of their world what they would. Paradise or hell was their choice.

She'd enjoyed her visit so far, but once she had some local currency and bought some of that delicious cheese to tempt Cat into coming here, she needed to get down to business. Find the fragment, if it was still here, or identify the wizard who had taken it. No more getting sidetracked.

As she headed for Kindred Currency, Dreya glanced around at the various types of goods on offer. Linen and cloth were available as well as heavier wool fleeces for the winter and a tannery selling cured leather for protection. There were ready-made garments, too, as well as foodstuffs, plus herbs and spices, giving off a heady aroma. Less pleasant odours drifted on the wind from the livestock area. There were blacksmiths and candlemakers, artisans and at least one lady who seemed to be trying to make a living as a writer of stories.

When Dreya found the place she was looking for, there seemed to be some kind of disturbance going on with a group in white robes, remonstrating with the two male Chetsuans behind the counter. Dreya hung back, not wanting to get involved, and considered what she might trade when things quietened down. She didn't have much. In the end, she decided there was only one choice: her ring. It was a family heirloom of sorts, the price she had demanded of Prince Travarin of Ainderbury, after he had sent clerics to kill her. Clerics who were now her ghoulish elite guards.

The truth was, she didn't care about her ring. It was a symbol of Sylfranian Faery nobility, which meant nothing to her. She'd

really only demanded it to annoy Prince Travarin because she knew the ring, or rather what it represented, meant everything to him. Considering he had tried to take her life, she judged that a bargain price.

Still, the ring was made of solid silver, so it would have material value here and, in a way, she felt treating it in this way was one final rejection of her parents' chosen destiny for her – becoming a Faery Princess. She had chosen magic, instead, and look what it had given her: a magnificent home, the power to travel to other times and other worlds, and best of all, it had given her the love of the amazing Catriona Redfletching.

Her family had rejected her, disowned her, in turn. Dreya deemed that a fair exchange, too.

The Sylfranian Faery had erected powerful wards that they believed protected them from 'evil sorcery'. As if they could ever stop her. She simply had no intention of ever setting foot in Sylfranian lands, wards or not – going there in the past didn't count. Those lands, the wards, her ring, they were all irrelevant.

She had briefly considered giving her ring to Catriona when she decided to propose, but it would have been entirely the wrong message. Instead, she had bought something new from another world, Earth. It was a symbol of the future adventures they would have together, not a past that was best left buried.

After a few moments, security guards showed up and took the white-robed troublemakers away. One of the two proprietors went with them. Once they were well out of sight, Dreya stepped forward.

The man called out a greeting and she returned the pleasantries before asking him what the disturbance had been about.

"Cultists," he replied. "It was the usual routine: we're all evil here."

"How scandalous!" the sorceress remarked, humour creeping into her voice. "Might I ask, in what way are you evil, specifically?"

The man raised a questioning eyebrow. "You don't know about the Cultists?"

Dreya explained she was a traveller and hadn't encountered them before, "but I do feel I have a right to know before I do business with such an evil establishment."

He chuckled. "Ah, but if you want to do business of any kind, that makes you evil, too."

"So, these Cultists are against business? Commerce?"

"And industry and making things and just about anything other than simply worshipping the Creator."

Dreya frowned, not that he could see her face beneath her hood.

"Surely, since the Creator, if we are to believe in such a thing, by definition created everything, it could be argued that by creating things yourself, you are in fact worshipping the Creator."

"You and I might think so," he allowed, "but not everyone agrees. You see, the Cultists say Creation was made perfect in the Beginning, therefore anything we create can only detract from that," he explained. "Honestly, most of them are just harmless fanatics."

The man who ran the adjacent shoe shop, having overheard their conversation, spoke up. "Maybe those 'fanatics' have a point, Kian!"

"You think so?" Dreya wondered. When she turned to look, she saw that he was packing everything up, apparently closing down.

He shrugged. "All I know is the world has changed so much in the last ten years, and I worry we're doing it all wrong."

"You'd rather you were still under threat from dragons?" Dreya asked, unable to comprehend.

"Well, no, not that, but maybe the way we were living then was a better, purer way of life." With that, he seemed to give up on what he was doing and simply walked away, abandoning everything.

"Does that happen a lot around here?" Dreya asked Kian.

"Well, his reaction is a bit extreme, but plenty of others are questioning whether what we're doing is right."

"And you?" Dreya prompted.

Kian shook his head, emphatically. "I set up Kindred Currency with my partner, Reed, to help create standards of fair trade. Barter will only take us so far. If these Cultists want to spend

their lives sitting around doing nothing all day, that's their choice. Unfortunately, some feel the need to preach and harass honest, hardworking folk. Some have even turned to violence to 'Cleanse' the world of our evil, so please be careful out there."

"I will," Dreya agreed, "but I'm quite confident of my ability to take care of any threat, as necessary."

Kian nodded. "Best way. The security guards do their best, but they can't be everywhere."

"Of course," she replied. "Anyway, since I believe we're both about as evil as each other, I don't see that conducting business will do either of us any harm."

"In that case," he grinned, "how can my evil establishment be of service?"

Placing her ring on the counter, she told him she was looking to exchange it for local currency.

Kian examined the ring with a critical eye and weighed it on his scales. "It's a fine ring. Pure silver. Highly valuable. Are you sure you want to sell? I'll have to melt it down, so you won't be able to change your mind later."

"I'm sure," she replied. "It's been in the family for generations, but this is a whole new world, isn't it?"

He nodded. "It certainly is, and sentiment is all very well, but it doesn't put a roof overhead or food on the table, does it?"

"No, it doesn't."

"Many of us are having to make such sacrifices to build for the future. It can be difficult, but I think these are exciting times."

"I couldn't agree more," Dreya concurred, watching as he scribbled some numbers on a small slate with chalk, doing some calculations. When he was finished, he gestured for the sorceress to lean closer as he discreetly showed her his valuation. Without any frame of reference, however, it meant nothing to her. She would just have to trust the recommendation that Kindred Currency was a fair and honest business.

"For such a large sum, might I suggest that you open an account with us and simply withdraw money as you need it? There are probably half a dozen thieves watching you from the shadows that you don't even know are there."

In fact, through her magic, Dreya knew precisely where they were, but she appreciated the warning, nonetheless, so she agreed to take only a portion for now and leave the rest in her account.

He excused himself while he sorted everything out, and while he was away, she noticed the pile of marketplace maps to one side. When he returned, she asked how much they were.

"They're free," he assured her, handing her one along with her money and account details. "If I want regular customers, it helps if they know where I am," he explained with a twinkle in his eye.

Dreya smiled conspiratorially. "All part of your evil master plan, no doubt."

He laughed. "That's it exactly!"

Glancing quickly at the map, she noticed a shaded area in the middle and asked what it meant.

"We call that The Pit. It's a combination of disused units from early businesses that failed, and dark alleyways where some of the more...exotic transactions are done. I don't know half of what goes on there, and I don't want to know." He shrugged. "To each their own, I suppose, but you wouldn't catch me going anywhere near it. Now, is there anything else I can help you with?"

Dreya replied, "Thank you, no. It's been a pleasure doing such evil business with you, sir."

"And you, miss. Farewell for now."

With a final nod, Dreya stepped aside to allow him to deal with his next customer.

The sorceress pondered her next move. She knew she really ought to get down to her true business here, but in the interests of seeing all aspects of this new Chetsuan culture, she was intrigued by The Pit. She had no interest in 'exotic transactions' but she was interested in building a complete picture of this place. So, after orientating herself with the map, she headed for The Pit.

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As Dreya meandered through the streets towards the centre of Axford, people called out to her from their various market stalls, inviting her to look at their wares, but she just kept walking. Eventually, it was like she had crossed some invisible line and the

active businesses thinned, markedly, being replaced by empty shells. She wasn't sure precisely when it happened, but she knew she had definitely arrived in The Pit when she began to encounter people selling items of an adult nature. A little further in and the surrounding buildings began to cut off more and more light. In these shady parts, she saw people doing probably less than legitimate deals in abandoned doorways. She found herself being propositioned by Chetsuans: males, females and individuals at whose gender she would not like to guess. She had no interest in availing herself of any of it, but neither was she shocked. Such practices were almost certain to be present in any world where there were people. Looking around, it was apparent from the general state of disrepair that this was the oldest section of the marketplace. Probably dating back to mere days after she conquered Phitonia. Allowing for the time differential, it was likely that Chetsuans were gathering here while she was fighting Kullos.

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A scream broke her introspection.

A teenage girl flashed past, down a dark alleyway a little way ahead, followed seconds later by three older Chetsuans in white robes, each wielding a wicked curved blade. More Cultists, Dreya realised.

"Come here, kid!" she heard one shout. "You can't hide from the Light of Purity!"

Dreya's chosen path naturally led her past that intersection, and as she approached the junction, she could see the three of them closing in on the girl, who seemed to have got herself trapped down a dead-end – a phrase that was likely to have a double meaning for her.

"Please let me go!" she begged, sobbing.

"We can't do that," insisted another of her attackers. "You are carrying the tools of evil."

"Hand over everything you have," ordered the third one. "Give it all up to the Creator, or you will have to be Cleansed."

The girl shook her head. "I can't! It's my Mama's! It's all we have! Please, please just let me go!"

It looked like the girl was going to come to a nasty end, which was a shame, Dreya thought, but things like this must happen all the time. It didn't concern her.

She was Dreya the Dark: a cold-hearted sorceress, a wielder of Dark magic who was only interested in power. Sure, she didn't do random violence, she accepted as she walked on by, but that was just because she detested chaos, not for any moralistic reason. She didn't do random acts of kindness, either. She was on Phitonia pursuing her own interests. The only reason she had conquered the world was that she needed dragons. She had not set out to save the Chetsuan people. Dreya the Dark was not a saviour or a hero. Absolutely not. So what if some Chetsuan girl died? What was that to her?

Why was she now thinking about her time in the past, about young Vashti? Yes, that young girl had made an impression, and yes, Dreya had taken her fiancée's advice and played with the kids. But it's not as if she'd enjoyed it...well, maybe she had a bit, but what did that have to do with this situation?

The fact was, Dreya the Dark did not go around saving children, and that was an end to it.

So, why had she turned around? Why was she heading back to that dark alley? Why was she running?

She knew who was to blame for this, of course.

"Oh, Cat," she muttered, "what have you done to me?"

Chapter 25

Reaching the intersection, Dreya could see the Cultists closing in on the young girl, who tripped and fell on the ground. It would all be over in moments if Dreya didn't act. She was still reluctant to reveal herself by using her magic, but she did have another option: the knife she kept up her sleeve.

All wizards on Tempestria were permitted, under Council rules, to carry one bladed weapon as a backup in case their magic failed. Dreya had never used her knife. Almost, against Kullos' hellhound guards, but at the critical moment, she'd figured out the hellhounds were magical constructs that could only harm them if they believed they were real. Dreya had to absolutely reject the threat and protecting herself with a knife would have meant she had doubts. Those doubts would have killed her and her friends, so she still had not used it.

It had been a very long time since she'd used physical weapons. Not since she was a child.

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Barely a teenager, she was running from bullies. That was hardly a rare occurrence, but these ones were bigger and stronger with almost a decade on her. And they had knives.

"Come here, freak!" one called out.

"Reject!" taunted another.

"Piskey throwback!" laughed the third.

"We're not going to hurt you!"

"No, we want to help!"

They laughed, seeing their victim fall to the ground, vulnerable. Defenceless. Screaming for help.

"Just hold still while we cut off those wings. Then you can be normal."

"Yeah, right!" one of her friends scoffed. "As if!"

"Yeah!" the ringleader sneered. "You'll always be a freak, Andreyanka."

"Freak! Freak! Freak!" the other two girls chanted as the leader continued taunting her.

“But if you let us cut your wings off, maybe it won’t be quite as obvious!”

Just then, a voice rang out, “Leave the girl alone or answer to me!”

The young Dreya had been astonished to see a human woman. A human in the lands of the Sylfranian Faery was practically unheard of, but there she was.

One of the attackers continued to advance on the prone form of Andreyanka, taunting her all the while. The other two rushed at the human with their knives.

“Another freak in our lands!” one of them spat.

“Yeah, we’ll be overrun with them if we don’t stop it!” another growled.

The human pulled a knife of her own, watching the young Faery women intently. At first, Dreya didn’t know how she did it, but the human woman suddenly had *two* knives. Then one of her attackers dropped to the ground, blood gushing from a severed artery in her wrist. The second died from a single swipe of her friend’s knife across her throat.

“Murderer!” the third screamed. Then, grabbing Dreya’s right arm, she tried to haul her to her feet as she growled, “Come on, you winged freak. We can get away together!”

But Andreyanka saw the situation for what it was: her attacker just wanted to use her as a shield. She wouldn’t hesitate to kill her when she was no longer useful.

The human woman threw her own knife. She didn’t dare risk the kill shot with the innocent girl so close to her attacker. Instead, she made sure the weapon landed by Andreyanka’s left hand. Andreyanka reached for it, but her attacker was too quick, stamping on her wrist.

“No, you don’t, you little witch!” she snarled.

Witch.

That word sparked something in the young Andreyanka’s brain. She *had* been dabbling in magic, lately. Experimenting. She didn’t really think – just acted on some instinct. Even as her hand was painfully crushed into the ground, Andreyanka flicked a finger and sent the out-of-reach dagger flying into her attacker’s heart.

Her attacker just had time for one last gasp of, “Freak!” before she died, collapsing on top of Andreyanka, making her scream.

Her human saviour rushed over and pulled the dead weight off her, saying, “Don’t be scared of a dead body, young Faery. The dead can’t harm you. It’s the living you need to worry about.”

Andreyanka nodded, accepting the lesson and forced herself to get control over herself as the woman helped her to her feet.

“You saved me!” she cried.

The woman shook her head. “You saved yourself. With magic, no less. Did you know you could do that?”

Andreyanka shook her head.

“Well, maybe you should think about getting some training. Magic saved you this time, but power like that needs to be controlled, or it could just as easily kill you next time.”

The human woman was right, she knew. Only a few days ago that strange figure with the dark aura had appeared to her and told her that one day she would have enough power to get rid of all the bullies in the world. Then no-one could ever harm her again. Maybe this was the start of that journey.

Shouts in the distance brought the young Andreyanka back to her current situation. As the voices drew closer, she realised people must have heard the disturbance and come to investigate.

“You need to go,” Andreyanka told the human woman. “If they catch you, they’ll blame you for this.”

“You’re right,” she agreed, “but remember, these women were going to kill you. You acted out of defence. You did nothing wrong, kid. Don’t let anybody tell you otherwise.”

Andreyanka nodded. “I won’t. Now go!”

“See you around, kid!” she grinned and dashed into the forest.

But Dreya hadn’t seen her around. She never even found out who she was. That had rankled her ever since. The one debt she could never repay.

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Well, Dreya considered, facing the scene before her in that dark alleyway, maybe this was her chance to pay that debt at last.

Was that a valid concept or was she just doing what Justaria always accused her of: making excuses for doing good things?

Whatever her motivations, she was committed to action. Even though it had been so long since she'd used physical weapons, through her Guardianship link with Mandalee, she knew what to do. She was ready.

Her voice rang out, "Leave the girl alone or answer to me!"

The Cultists whirled around and, taking in her Black robes, one of them gasped, "An Agent of Evil!"

"You must be Cleansed!" another cried.

"Purify her!" the third ordered them. Two rushed at Dreya, knives at the ready, while the other continued to bear down on the young girl.

The pair weren't as disciplined as the bigots who had attacked young Andreyanka all those years ago. Rather than attack together, one was faster than the other. As a result, she would be the first to die.

Dreya stepped into the attack, catching her by surprise. Flexing a muscle was all it took to bring her dagger to hand, which she used to slice cleanly across her wrist. The Cultist screamed and clutched her wrist in a futile effort to stem the blood flow, dropping her dagger, which Dreya caught, slicing it across her throat. Before the slower Cultist could get close, Dreya threw her own knife at her. It struck her in the face and buried itself in her brain. She didn't even have time to scream before she died.

"Murderer!" the remaining Cultist screamed.

*"*How predictable," Dreya remarked.

The sorceress didn't trust her ability to throw the curved blade accurately over the distance that separated her from the innocent teen before her, but she could get it close enough.

Over the last few days, her two Chetsuan friends, Sara and Jessica, had talked about how it was for them, growing up. Conditions were harsh. The threat of the dragons made food sources scarce and obtaining it a risky business. It was on one such food gathering mission that they had been taken to the dragon scientist Zacar for experimentation. Long before that, though, they had succeeded many times.

Dragons were not the only threat, however. There were wild animals, and also predators of the Chetsuan variety. As such, the

two girls had learned to protect their lives at an early age. That was pretty normal, they asserted. Most adults tried to protect their children, but they couldn't be there all the time. It was a dangerous world, and they had adapted to survive. If this Chetsuan girl was anything like those two, now that the odds were even, she should have no trouble, given a helping hand.

Dreya threw the knife so that it landed by the girl's left hand. She immediately picked it up, which Dreya conceded was better than she had done when she still used the name Andreyanka, but then the girl hesitated.

"What are you waiting for, girl?" Dreya demanded. "It's your life or hers!"

Seeing this, the remaining Cultist changed tack.

"Don't listen to her," she told the girl. "You're not really going to kill me. You're not a murderer like her. I know how to get out of here, a secret way. We can escape together. Just give me your purse. Let go of the evil that's weighing you down. Then you can be Pure, like me."

At the other end of the alleyway, Dreya was seething, frustrated at the girl's inaction.

Looking up at the Cultist with those wide, terrified eyes of hers, the girl was staring death in the face but refusing to see it.

The Cultist threw her weapon away. "See? I'm unarmed now. We were never going to hurt you. We only had our knives to try and scare you into letting go of the evil, that's all. You see that, don't you?"

The girl hesitated a moment longer, and then nodded and lowered her knife.

"What the hell are you doing?" Dreya demanded. This was not going at all the way she expected. If this girl didn't face up to reality fast, Dreya's efforts would be in vain.

"Now hand over all your evil money," the Cultist commanded. "Then I'll take you away. Do you want to be Pure like me, or evil like her?"

"Pure," the girl decided, and glanced away for a moment to retrieve her purse, full of evil money.

In that same moment, Dreya, too, decided. Focussing on the Cultist, she spoke a single word, "SNAP," and the Cultist dropped

to the ground, lifeless. Neck instantly broken. Her deadweight fell on top of the girl, and she screamed.

Dreya brushed the body aside with her magic and reached down to give the girl a hand up, but the terrified girl backed away and brandished the knife at her.

"Well, that's gratitude for you," Dreya grumbled.

"Keep away!" the girl warned Dreya.

Her eyes had opened even wider, her breath coming fast and shallow. She was frantic with shock, delirious, sweating profusely, unable to tell friend from foe.

Dreya couldn't understand it. It was as if she'd never fought a day in her life before. Then it hit her: ten years. It had been ten years, on a Phitonian timescale, since Dreya ended the threat of the dragons. This girl couldn't be more than fourteen or fifteen. The world in which Sara and Jessica grew up, she probably didn't remember that world, but this incident proved there were still threats in this one and if she was going to survive, she needed an education. Fast.

"You're evil!" the girl accused her.

"These three come at you with knives, I save your life, and *I'm* the one who's evil?"

The girl shook her head, unable to comprehend. "You're a murderer! And you want to murder me, too!"

"I'm not a murderer. I *stopped* a murder. Your murder. Would you rather I hadn't bothered?"

The girl lowered the knife a little, but she still couldn't grasp what had happened. "I— I don't think she was really going to kill me," she stammered, shakily, looking down the Cultist Dreya had slain with her magic.

"You don't *think* she was going to kill you?" Dreya echoed, incredulously. "How long were you planning to wait to be sure?" she asked. "Until her blade was at your throat? Until she sliced it open, and your lifeblood came pouring out?" Her voice was a great, controlled crescendo. "Or maybe you were going to wait until you were actually dead, just to make absolutely certain!"

The girl tried to scoot away on her backside. Giving up on that idea, she tried to stand, but her legs were too wobbly to support her weight.

"Stop it, you're scaring me!" she cried.

"You *should* be scared," Dreya agreed, sternly. Then she softened. "But not of me – of what nearly happened to you. Look, let me show you," she offered. "Please?"

Dreya drew her attention to the body and the girl crawled forward, cautiously.

"You don't believe this one was going to kill you," Dreya paraphrased. "Why? Because she threw away the knife she had in her right hand?"

The girl nodded, but still shrank back from the sight before her.

"Don't be scared of a dead body," Dreya told her. "The dead can't harm you, it's the living you need to worry about."

Thinking back to her recent experiences fighting Ulvarius' undead minions and meat puppets, she knew that wasn't always true, but this girl didn't need to know about that.

A little more boldly, now, the girl got to her feet and moved to Dreya's side, next to the body.

"See what's in her left hand," Dreya coached.

The girl looked where the sorceress was pointing and drew a sharp intake of breath, dropping her own weapon as the truth before her became crystallised. Having sufficiently confused and distracted her victim, the Cultist had pulled a second, concealed knife. If Dreya hadn't killed her instantly, the Cultist would have murdered the girl, grabbed her purse and fled through whatever mysterious way out she knew.

"What's your name?" Dreya asked gently.

"Amber," she replied.

"So, Amber, do you understand now?"

Amber looked up at Dreya and nodded.

Just then, there came the sound of heavy footsteps, and security guards thundered onto the scene, swords in their hands.

"Oh, look, Amber – the cavalry's here," Dreya mocked. "Just in the nick of time. Not."

Amber looked pale, but nodded to say she understood. They would have got there just in time to find her fresh dead body, the Cultists long since fled.

"What's happened here?" the chief guard demanded.

"Well, Amber?" Dreya prompted. "Here's your chance. Am I a murderer? Did I kill these three women for fun? For sport?

Because they didn't believe in the same things as me? Was I going to murder you next?"

Amber shook her head, emphatically.

Stepping forward to the chief, she told him, "Officer, these three Cultists were going to murder me, and they would have if my friend hadn't stopped them. She saved my life. She killed one with her own knife," she pointed. "Threw a dagger at the second," she pointed again. "And the last one – she was going to kill me for sure, but my friend killed her first. Snapped her neck with…"

Amber paused and frowned. With everything that had happened, she hadn't had time to process exactly how the third one died. Now her brain tried to make sense of it and the only conclusion she could come to was, "…with magic." Her frown of puzzlement deepened as she asked Dreya, "How did you do that? I've never heard of power like that. Who are you?"

The guard stepped forward and challenged Dreya. "Yes, I'd rather like to know that, too!"

Dreya sighed. This was precisely what she'd wanted to avoid, but there was no helping it now, so as slowly and unthreateningly as possible, she pulled back her hood.

The others all gasped. Her pale alien Faery features and spots were distinctive among the dark purple catlike Chetsuans, and it was clear the dragons had shared the description of the Chetsuans' 'saviour'.

Shutting her eyes against it and wincing, she quite unnecessarily introduced herself.

"I'm Dreya the Dark."

The guards sheathed their swords while Amber gazed up at her with adoration in her eyes.

At times like this, Dreya knew Mandalee was known to mutter, "Dear gods, I need a drink!" She was beginning to understand why.

Trying to shift the focus back to the incident, Dreya pointed out that the knife the third Cultist would have used to murder Amber was covered in dried blood.

"Since there isn't a scratch on Amber or me," Dreya reasoned, "I'd wager this group murdered someone already today. I'm afraid I wasn't around to stop that one."

The chief confirmed it. “It was a boy about young Amber’s age.”

Amber gulped. “That would have been me.”

Dreya tried to drive her point home. “You see? Security is all very well, but most of the time, they only get there after the murder has happened. No offence,” she added as an aside to the chief.

“None taken, Mistress Dreya,” he assured her.

“Just Dreya,” she insisted, before turning back to the girl. “Your world isn’t safe just because the dragons are behaving themselves, Amber. You need to learn it’s not evil to protect your life and the lives of innocents.”

“Dreya’s right, Amber,” the chief agreed. “I knew I was going to have to tell that boy’s parents that he’s been murdered. I can now tell them his killers will never hurt anyone again, but that won’t bring their son back.”

Amber nodded. “I understand that now, I promise.”

“Good,” he approved, “because I can tell you, it’s a much nicer part of the job to tell your parents that you’re safe. Speaking of which, we should get you back to them.”

“Can I come?” Dreya asked.

The chief regarded her curiously. “I think you can do whatever you want, can’t you?”

Dreya inclined her head, conceding the point. “In principle, yes. *On* principle, I am not Ulvarius.”

“Who?” Amber asked.

“He was a terrible tyrant on my world who kidnapped and tortured kids like you. Sometimes people compare me to him.”

Amber reached out and slipped her hand into Dreya’s. “You’re definitely not like him,” she insisted.

“You’re certainly very different to what I would have expected,” the chief commented; his team nodded their agreement.

“Excellent,” Dreya approved. “I like to keep people guessing. Sometimes,” she added, smiling down at Amber and squeezing her hand, “I even surprise myself.”

Chapter 26

The sorceress quickly recognised where Amber was leading them. Her parents ran a butcher's shop around the corner from Kindred Currency. Many people along the way, seeing that Dreya the Dark had come among them, hastily secured their shops and stalls and began to follow them. The guards were vigilant but didn't try to prevent the gathering. By the time they reached Amber's parents, there was a considerable crowd.

Dreya had concealed herself to try and avoid attention, but her actions had made that impossible, so she decided she might as well try and take advantage. For once, though, she wasn't thinking of her own benefit, but theirs. Dreya didn't like what she'd learned about these Cultists and while she was still determined not to act directly, perhaps she could inspire these people before things got too bad.

As soon as she saw them, Amber ran to her parents, who had obviously been frantic with worry. They swept her in a warm embrace, thanking the stars that their daughter was safe.

"The stars didn't save me," the girl admonished them, sternly. "It was Dreya the Dark!"

When Amber beckoned Dreya over, her parents did a double-take at the sight of the Faery in their midst. They must have been the only people in that part of Axford who had failed to notice her. So focussed had they been on the return of their daughter.

As Dreya stepped forward, she couldn't help contrasting the reaction of Amber's parents with that of her own, when Andreyanka had told them what had happened. They were far more concerned about the threat of evil humans invading their lands and murdering innocent Faery folk, than with the fact that their child had almost died. Much more worried about the scandal Andreyanka had apparently brought upon the family reputation, than with her safe return. Far more interested in finding ways to appease the families of the poor, innocent, angelic girls that Andreyanka had obviously led astray with her wicked ways, than in believing her account of what really happened.

Still, Dreya wasn't prepared to let Amber's parents off the hook. She was sure her misgivings about their apparent illusions of

safety applied to many others here. Unfortunately for Amber's parents, they were in her line of sight.

Amber's mother, through smiles and tears, thanked her over and over for saving her daughter. Her father, grinning broadly and vigorously shaking her hand, asked, "How can we possibly repay you?"

"You can start by explaining why you taught your daughter to be a victim," she replied.

There were gasps from the crowd. Smiles faded. Conversations ceased. Silence fell.

His face flushing a deep golden colour, Amber's father demanded, "I beg your pardon?"

Dreya put on the impassive face that she always used when emotion was going to get in the way of a dispassionate argument.

"I know something of Chetsuans," she began. "I'm starting to know two quite well. They've told me how it was, growing up here, never knowing if you were going to be snatched by a dragon. But they knew dragons weren't the only predators out there, so they learned to fight.

"They recognised the value of their lives, and they knew it was right to protect themselves and each other. Your daughter didn't understand that. I gave her the means to protect her life, and she refused. She chose to be a victim. I didn't save your daughter from the Cultists; I saved her from herself.

"Perhaps the dragons were a threat beyond your ability to fight. I accept that. Who knows? Maybe there are things out there beyond even me, but the Chetsuans I know would never have allowed themselves to be victims of fanatics like your Cultists."

"But the world is different now!" Amber's father protested. "Because of you, the dragons no longer threaten us. We don't want our daughter to grow up the way we did. We want a world where children are safe and don't have to think about protecting their lives because they're never in danger."

Dreya nodded. "That would be a beautiful world, and if you know the co-ordinates, I'll take you there myself. If not, I'm afraid you'll have to face the reality of this one."

"It's alright, Dreya," Amber spoke up. "I can learn how to fight if someone threatens me with a knife in future."

Dreya's expression never wavered as she looked down at her. There was no threat there, but all the same, Amber couldn't look her in the eye.

"This isn't about knives," the sorceress explained, "it's about ideas. Amber, why were you there in the first place? From what I've seen of your parents, I doubt they sent you anywhere near The Pit."

"Dear stars!" her mother exclaimed, bringing a hand to her face in horror. "That's where you were?" Amber nodded guiltily. "Why, Amber? Why would you go to that horrible place?"

"Yes, tell us, Amber," Dreya commanded her.

Sniffling, the girl explained that her mother had wanted to take her out to help her gather supplies from various places around the town, but Amber had wanted to go herself, insisting that since she had turned fifteen a few days ago, that meant she was now old enough. Her parents had relented. Everywhere she needed to go, the people who owned and ran those businesses knew Amber and her parents well, so they could see no harm.

Along the way, however, three figures in white robes approached her, acting friendly, gaining her trust. They told her they knew a secret place where she could get everything she needed at half the price.

"Think how proud your parents will be if their clever daughter can save them a lot of money," they said.

Amber had agreed to let them show her. They led her straight to The Pit, made sure she was thoroughly lost and then turned on her. They told her that her parents were evil for having money and material things. They insisted that the whole town was wicked, and they should devote themselves to the Creator. They promised that if she handed over everything she had, then she could be Blessed, brought closer to the Creator. By which, of course, they meant they were going to kill her.

The security chief expanded on this, explaining what he knew about how the Cult operated. The only reason they didn't kill Amber straight away was that they wanted her to admit they were right. Admit that her parents' money, and by extension, her parents themselves, were evil. By handing everything over, she would be confessing that she, too, was evil for having it and in the end, she would beg them to Cleanse her. Then the Cultists' views would be

confirmed, and they would kill her, secure in the belief that they were doing the Creator's work.

Dreya had surmised most of that already, having seen what that last Cultist was doing to Amber. Twisting her mind. Getting her to believe that the people who had chased and threatened her were good, and the one trying to save her was evil.

"But it all started with you, didn't it, Amber?" Dreya's tone was stern. A tone that demanded an honest answer.

Amber nodded. "It was stupid," she admitted.

"If there really was a place that could sell genuine goods for half price, why would they keep it secret?" her mother asked, rhetorically.

"I've only just met you," Dreya told Amber, "but I know you're smarter than that. Like I say, this isn't about knives. The best way to survive a knife fight is to never get in one in the first place. That's the first and most important lesson in survival: don't make yourself a victim. Use your head. Think."

Addressing the crowd in general, she declared, "You're letting these Cultists infect you with their ideas. That's far more dangerous than any knife. You've obviously built your new world on a foundation of freedom, which I respect, but it's an unfortunate truth that wherever there is freedom, there will be people who want to take it away because they think it's evil.

"You are not evil people. Trying to build something, make something of your lives is not evil. This place is not evil, but it is sick. In 'The Pit,' a rot has set in, and the Cultists are accelerating that infection. They call it Cleansing. They call it Purifying. But really, they are the disease."

"It's not as simple as that!" objected a voice in the crowd. "Not all the Cultists are violent or infectious as you say. Many are peaceful. They just have their beliefs."

"I never claimed it was simple," Dreya returned, "and I'm not proposing pitchforks and flaming torches." Seeing the blank looks, she realised what she'd said. It was funny how Jessica's Earth expressions seemed to take root so much that she would use one without thinking. "I mean, I'm not suggesting a witch hunt," she translated. "Some people once subjected me to a witch hunt," she added as an aside.

“I’m betting that didn’t end well for the hunters,” Amber piped up.

Dreya smiled. “Like I said, you’re smart. No, it’s not that simple. I could hunt down and kill every last Cultist in Axford, but that wouldn’t kill the idea. Even my magic can’t do that. I’m not here to offer a magic solution. This is your world, and you have to solve your own problems.”

A murmur from the crowd told her that her message was getting through.

“She’s right,” Amber’s mother asserted, stepping forward. “Somehow, we’ve allowed an idea to take root. The idea that building a life for ourselves and wanting to protect what we have is evil. We joke about it, we laugh about it, but deep down, many of us are starting to wonder.”

“Amber, I’m so sorry if we ever made you think your life isn’t worth protecting,” her father told her. “You had every right to defend yourself, please don’t ever think you don’t.”

“But don’t go putting yourself in danger, either!” her mum scolded, wagging her finger, sternly.

“I won’t, Mama,” the girl promised.

Another voice in the crowd spoke up. “We’ve been so focused on the end of the dragon threat that we’ve turned a blind eye to more insidious dangers.”

The crowd were buzzing now, and Dreya was beginning to think her work was done, but a dissenting male voice raised an objection.

“From what I hear, the Cultists are a worldwide problem. Even if we do find a way to snuff out the trouble in our local community, what difference will it make?”

The crowd quietened at that, and doubt threatened to take hold once more. Dreya would not allow it. The sun was starting to drift down, now, as afternoon gave way to evening, and the growing shadows gave Dreya an idea.

“Amber, can you help me with something really important?” she asked.

“Like what?” she wondered.

“I think I remember seeing a candlemaker opposite Kindred Currency. Do you know it?”

The girl nodded.

"Well, I don't know my way around here like you do. Do you think you could take us all there?"

Again, she nodded.

"If your parents say it's OK, of course," Dreya added, giving them a questioning look.

"Can I?" Amber asked them eagerly. "Please?"

They both agreed it was OK for her to help, so she grabbed Dreya's hand and led her to where she wanted to go.

When they reached the candlemaker's stall, Dreya took in the arrangement of twenty of various sizes and colours that were on display and lit them all with a snap of her fingers.

"The Cultists are a worldwide problem," she began, echoing the point for the benefit of the newcomers in the audience. "Their ideas threaten to burn down communities like yours everywhere. What happens if you extinguish the Cultist's fire here?" To Amber, she asked, "Can you show us what that looks like?"

The girl stepped forward and blew out one of the candles.

"What difference does it make?" Dreya continued. "Well, for a start, you save your local community, which is a victory all by itself. Then what happens when your neighbouring communities hear how you snuffed out the flame here?" She once more turned to the girl she had saved. "Can you show us, Amber?"

She carefully blew out the candles immediately adjacent to the first one.

"See?" the sorceress prompted. "Amber's smart. She gets it."

The girl beamed all over her face.

"Your neighbours can learn from your pioneering efforts and extinguish these dangerous flames in their communities, too. So, what if every community in the world snuffs out the Cultists' ideas in their own backyard? What difference does it make?" This time, Amber didn't even need to be asked. She just blew out all the remaining candles.

"All the fires go out!" Amber announced.

"You are not evil people," Dreya reiterated. "You can make this a better world for yourselves and for your children, but only if you're willing to protect it. Don't make yourselves victims."

As her lesson sunk in, a ripple of applause began, which grew in intensity. Cheers began, becoming a roar of determined people, rising to the challenge.

Amber's mother stepped close to the sorceress, trying to make herself heard. "Amber completely adores you now, Dreya. You're obviously really good with kids."

Dreya laughed. "Tell that to my fiancée!"

"But why do all this?" asked Amber's father.

The sorceress considered the question. "Do my motives matter?" she wondered, to herself as much as anyone else.

"Not really," he replied. "I'm just curious."

"The Cultists' ideas are a form of tyranny," she began, by way of answer. "I hate tyrants. It's a personal thing. Back home, some people still think I'm a tyrant-in-waiting myself. I like to prove that's wrong whenever I can."

"Even when they can't see you do it, like here and now?" Amber wondered.

Dreya smiled grimly. "You misunderstand me. I'm not trying to prove anything to them. I couldn't care less what they think of me. I have a few friends and their opinions matter, but ultimately I'm proving it to myself."

"To yourself?" Amber's mother wondered, not understanding.

Dreya nodded. "I took an impenetrable fortress, defended by terrible magic, in five minutes. I had effective control of our magical government within a week. I wrested your world from the claws of the dragons in a spare afternoon. I defeated a dark clone of Daelen StormTiger in under an hour. I can obviously travel to other worlds, and I am one of Three Guardians who can manipulate Time. With such power as I possess, there come certain...temptations.

"The truth is, I *could* be a tyrant. Very easily. I could be a tyrant that put all other tyrants to shame. So, every so often, I like to prove to myself that I can choose not to be. I can do better. I can *be* better. The dragons think I'm terrifying, and I am. But with you, today, I chose not to be."

"And what about tomorrow?" asked Amber.

Dreya ruffled the girl's hair affectionately, but her voice was deadly serious as she answered the incredibly astute question.

“I may be a Guardian of Time, but even I can’t see the future.”

The noise had died down by now, so Dreya shared one last thought with the crowd. “What you’ve built here in the last ten years is truly impressive. If, the next time I come here, I find that you’ve let anything spoil or destroy it, I will be very upset, and you don’t want to upset Dreya the Dark. Just ask the dragons.”

It briefly occurred to her that she’d just referred to herself in the third person, but on this occasion, she decided it was warranted.

With that, she excused herself, moving over to the candlemaker to pay for the candles she’d used for her impromptu demonstration. The owner protested that it wasn’t necessary, but Dreya insisted it was.

“You can no longer sell those candles as new,” she pointed out, “which means you’ve lost money. Money that keeps a roof over your head and food on your table. I will not steal from you. I always pay my debts. It’s a personal thing.”

The owner bagged up the barely used candles and told her the price. Dreya paid it, but that meant she didn’t have enough left for the cheese she’d intended to buy in the first place. Fortunately, Kindred Currency was just across the way.

Kian, who had served her before, remarked, “If I’d known I had Dreya the Dark for a customer, I could have given you extra.”

“I concealed my identity precisely because I did not want special treatment, although you can see how well that worked out. Now, I just have one question, which you have one chance to answer honestly and through my magic, I can tell if someone is lying.” She actually couldn’t, but the lie was useful motivation, and she would admit to it in a moment. “You knew I was a traveller who didn’t understand the value of your currency. That would have made me a tempting target to some. So, was your valuation fair, or did you take advantage?”

The man looked offended. “As the proprietor of Kindred Currency, I pride myself on my honest treatment of my customers, whoever they may be. The price was exactly the same as I would have offered to anyone. I do not cheat my customers.”

Dreya smiled. “Excellent,” she approved, admitting her own rare lie and apologising for any offence. “Do you think an official endorsement from Dreya the Dark would serve as compensation?”

The man grinned and admitted, “I believe it would at that.”

“Then I’ll leave you to draw up something you feel is appropriate. Just one thing: if you decide to go with some kind of Faery motif, just remember that Faery are not little creatures with wings.”

The man looked puzzled. “Why would anyone think that?” he wondered.

Dreya shrugged. “You’d be surprised.”

*****

Having withdrawn enough money, gentle reader, Aunt Dreya said a quick farewell to Amber and her family. Then she restored her Timeless connection to Catriona’s Meadow, making her invisible to the locals so she could slip away. When she was close to where she came in, she returned to the Timestream, making sure to conceal her face with her hood once more.

My aunt stepped up to Lex’s Cheeses and asked to buy the kind that she had sampled earlier.

Of course, Dreya had no more idea about the weights and measures system then she had about the currency, but he gave her an amount that looked and felt similar to what she usually bought in Gaggleswick. She was entirely satisfied with that.

“I heard there was some kind of disturbance,” Lex remarked, conversationally.

“Apparently, Dreya the Dark turned up and gave a lecture,” she replied.

“Damn,” Lex cursed, “I wish I’d been there. Meeting Dreya the Dark would have been quite something, don’t you think?”

Dreya nodded thoughtfully. “Yes,” she agreed. “I suppose it would.”

With that, she walked away, but as soon as she became Timeless once more, the blast of a desperate sympathic message nearly knocked her off her feet. It was a distress call: Mandalee was in trouble.

Chapter 27

It wasn't until the third day of Mandalee's journey into Southern Alloria that she realised she could have just portalled straight to her destination.

The connection of their shared soul meant Shyleen could sense Mandalee equally well, and as soon as Mandalee began moving towards her, she would have done the same. That had probably cut down the journey time by perhaps as much as half, but it still would have been quicker to portal. It was too late to try it now, though. Her portalling expertise wasn't up to hitting a constantly moving target. So, she contented herself with portalling to one of the major towns down there and then continued travelling by horse.

There was a perfectly good road heading South, providing ease of movement for trade, but Mandalee shunned that in favour of adjacent green areas. Anything she might gain from the road she would lose from inevitable interactions with people. It was a long-established aspect of her personality – a defence mechanism, really. The less her contact with people, the fewer incidents she would suffer due to their reactions to her gender identity.

Thanks to Catriona, of course, that was a thing of the past. At last, her body matched the image in her head, although she still hadn't got it working for her the way her old one had. That was simply a matter of time, patience and practice, she knew. Hopefully, with the Ulvarius Time Crisis done, once she was reunited with Shyleen, she would have the chance to do some proper training.

She also needed to work on her cleric magic.

While they were in the past, Cat had confided that one day, Mandalee would travel back in time to stop that horrible, evil man from slicing open her friend's belly and killing her unborn child. The horror of the crime filled Mandalee not only with rage but also with terror because she had no idea how to do any of the things her future-self had done.

'*First things first,*' she told herself.

*****

The Cleric of Nature did not need to stop along the way for supplies, the way most travellers did. The wildlands away from the villages and towns grew food in abundance. There was plenty of game to provide her with meat, and the rivers and streams ran with crystal clear, life-giving water and a plentiful supply of fish. Wayward pines sheltered her when it rained at night, and her magic could at least dry and set wood alight when it grew cold. What more could she possibly want?

Today, however, about a week into her journey, Mandalee had been forced to ride through a town for the first time since portalling down here. Durmchapel sat at an important crossroads in these parts. According to the signpost, it gave a choice between heading right towards the coastal town of Oarsrest, left towards Yalferndel, or to climb up into the Eastcliff region and head for Imperial Kelna, about two or three days' ride directly South. The road provided the only practical way of taking a horse up into those highlands, which was where she needed to go.

The trail spiralled upwards for several miles. The northern side was cut into the mountain itself so that travellers could make their way safely behind the gigantic raging Eastcliff Waterfall, the largest waterfall in the world, that thundered into the lake below before flowing out into the River Yalla, with whose water she had filled her flask only that morning. Having carefully guided her horse atop the cliffs, she could once again make progress towards the Southeast where she felt Shyleen growing ever closer.

There weren't much in the way of roads up here. Just a few worn trails. From what little Mandalee knew about this part of the world, there were a number of large settlements in the far South, branching out from the Kelnan Empire, but they petered out as one headed into the north of the region. Eastcliff proved enough of an obstacle to the transfer of goods that these highlands were left almost totally wild, barring the occasional cottage retreat.

Straying too close to the cliff edge could be treacherous in high winds, but today, Mandalee thought the bracing rush of air was glorious. It blew away her anger and hurt from Dreya's remarks, and her vantage point, seeing for leagues all around, gave her perspective. Her friend – and Dreya *was* her friend – hadn't meant anything by what she'd said. She just hadn't stopped to think. Sometimes, the sorceress wasn't good with people and for

Mandalee to criticise that would be, as Jessica would say, 'the pot calling the kettle black.'

She rode for a good twelve hours through that beautiful green expanse without stopping, using her magic as a Cleric of Nature to keep her mount free from fatigue. Doing that long-term wasn't good for an animal, she knew, but in a short time, now, her journey would be complete. Then her horse could rest, graze and drink as much as he wanted. He understood and was content to go along with it.

The White Guardian rode for hours without seeing another soul. Then, at last, she did, or more accurately, half of her own soul. A leopard with the finest markings ever ran into the clearing so fast, Mandalee had to work hard to reassure her horse, so he didn't bolt. Persuading him to stop and let her dismount, she then let him run where he wished.

She bounded over to Shyleen, who playfully knocked her off her feet and began licking her all over.

'*Mandalee!*' cried Shyleen's telepathic 'voice' in her head. '*I am so happy to see you! I missed you so much!*'

'*Oh, Shyleen, I'm so sorry!*' she sent in return, stroking and hugging her oldest friend. '*We got a little lost, that's all, but I'm here now.*'

Shyleen was purring as loud as Mandalee had ever heard her.

'*I won't be travelling in Time again, that's for sure,*' she vowed, but then she remembered that she couldn't promise that, for Catriona's sake.

Extracting herself from their tangle of limbs, Mandalee explained what Cat had told her.

'*Then you* must *travel in Time again,*' the leopard insisted. '*You must do all you can to protect her and her cub. Cat is our sister.*'

Mandalee smiled. '*That's what she said. Trust you to see that before I did.*'

'*This is why you need me,*' the big cat insisted. '*I often see what you do not.*'

'*I am lost without you,*' Mandalee agreed.

'*I think you proved that these past two years,*' Shyleen quipped.

Mandalee lay back in the grass and laughed, remembering times passed.

*****

Mandalee's parents had always tried to support their son, who wanted to be their daughter. They didn't really understand, but they did their best to accept it. They couldn't stop the teasing, the taunting, the name-calling. They didn't know what they could do to help, but they were always there for her when she cried. It affected them, too, but they insisted that wasn't important and told Mandalee she must be herself, no matter what. They wished they could make it all alright for her, make it go away. They couldn't, but they did everything in their power to make her feel loved, and Mandalee loved them dearly for that, in return.

She spent most of her childhood days hiding in the forest near her village. Away from people, out among nature. The animals didn't care about her gender.

It was an ordinary rainy afternoon – she was barely a teenager – when a lone leopard wandered by where Mandalee was hiding. Crying. She knew she ought to be scared – big cats were dangerous – and she should remain still and hidden, but she didn't. She crept forward instead, moving closer to the magnificent animal and she was astonished when the big cat looked at her and straight out wondered why she was upset.

The animal hadn't spoken aloud, but in her mind, in a language the girl did not know and yet somehow understood perfectly. The leopard seemed equally astonished that the human girl had heard and understood her words.

Without even thinking about it, Mandalee was soon chatting away to the leopard, stroking her, pouring out all her troubles. Happier than she had ever been. She knew right then – this was where she belonged. In the wilds with nature, not in towns with people. People were mean. Not her parents, of course, but almost everyone else. She wished she could be out there all the time, talking to the animals, sleeping under the stars on her green bed made of grass.

She and the leopard met regularly for weeks after that, becoming the closest of friends, until one day, Elric, the young

eccentric village cleric, found her and asked her who she was talking to.

"This leopard," a puzzled Mandalee answered him. "Her name is Shyleen."

The cleric told her that he couldn't see any leopard.

Mandalee couldn't understand why he would say something like that. Other than her parents, he was just about the only person in the village who she couldn't remember ever being mean to her before. Truthfully, most people thought he was a little strange, himself, but he had magic, so people didn't dare say anything in front of him.

He must have read the expression on Mandalee's face because he sat down beside her, patted her on the head and assured her that he didn't intend to be cruel.

In fact, Mandalee remembered, the exact phrase he used was, "I didn't mean to be mean," and chuckled at his play on words. He asked her to tell him everything about Shyleen. Mandalee wasn't sure she should, but Shyleen assured her it was OK. '*I like this one,*' she told her, '*and I'm an excellent judge of character. You can trust him.*'

Taking her at her word, Mandalee did as Elric asked. "But you really don't see her?" she asked when she finished.

"No," He shook his head. "I, it seems, am not so privileged."

'*Privileged?*' Shyleen remarked in Mandalee's mind, sounding inordinately pleased. '*Oh, he can definitely stay if he's going to say things like that.*'

Mandalee giggled. She had learned that Shyleen was fond of having her ego stroked from time-to-time, as well as her fur.

"She likes it when you say things like that," she told him.

Elric nodded, thoughtfully. "Yes, the gods do like to be praised."

"The gods?" Mandalee frowned. "Shyleen's not a god, silly!"

'*Actually,*' Shyleen began. For the first time since Mandalee had met her, she sounded a little embarrassed. If she were human, she was sure she'd be blushing. '*There is something I've been meaning to tell you.*'

"I take it she just confirmed it?" the cleric surmised, reading her expression.

Mandalee nodded.

Elric went on to explain that he had an interest, some would say obsession, with the Pantheon – the realm of what people termed gods. Those who existed in the plane above the mortal world. He recognised the name Shyleen immediately as the one the ancient texts described as the leopard god. He also explained that there were stories of a time, long ago, before Year Zero, when the gods might choose to visit the world of mortals, appearing only to a few extraordinary individuals, sensitive souls. No-one else could see them.

"It seemed highly unlikely that you could have made it up," he concluded.

'*You're really a god, Shyleen?*' Mandalee breathed in wonder.

'*Yes, but I don't like the term. It's pretentious. I don't want your worship, Mandalee; just your friendship.*'

Mandalee hugged her tight. '*You have it. Now and always.*'

"Just one thing I don't understand," the cleric told Mandalee. "I thought all the gods were cut off a thousand years ago when Alycia's Barrier went up."

Shyleen confirmed that he was right, but she had been in this world at the time and had been trapped here ever since, mostly unnoticed, except for rare individuals like Mandalee. '*But you are my first true friend.*'

'*And you're mine,*' Mandalee told her, '*and I don't want to lose you, but is there no way to get you home?*'

'*This is my home,*' Shyleen insisted. '*The reason I was here all those years ago was that I ran away from the Pantheon, or more accurately, the other so-called gods.*'

She had similar troubles to Mandalee. Not over gender identity, but the fact that she spoke out against their views about 'inferior mortals'. One day, the lioness god, Pryshia – something of a ringleader among Shyleen's bullies, and self-styled Queen of the gods, attacked her with terrible, painful magic. Shyleen used her own magic to sever her connection to the higher planes, sending her tumbling down to Tempestria, running away from her tormentors. She could hear Pryshia laughing, even here. Vowing never to let her return, she thought she'd condemned her to a long, lonely life, essentially as a ghost.

'*But she unwittingly did me a favour,*' she told Mandalee. '*I was already a lonely ghost in the Pantheon. At least here none of them could hurt me, especially when Blessed Alycia raised her Barrier, cutting off the mortal plane from those above. I am safe here, for not even the shadow warriors are powerful enough to break through, let alone mere gods. And now I have made a friend.*'

'*But you're still a ghost,*' Mandalee objected. '*You can't interact with the world at all, can you?*'

Shyleen admitted that was true. '*I am only partially manifest in this plane.*' Then seeing Mandalee's blank look, she rephrased it as, '*I'm only half here.*'

'*There has to be a way to help you, bring you all the way here.*'

'*It has been done before, but the price is too high, I could never ask it of anyone.*'

Mandalee turned to the cleric, who had been patient throughout their silent conversation, and summarised, "Shyleen says there's a way to help her, but she won't tell me what it is. Do you know?"

Elric nodded. "Mortals have been known to sell their souls to gods. The god becomes fully manifest and the mortal gains power in return."

He explained that his low-level cleric magic was in exchange for his worship of the gods. More devout clerics could gain more power, but that paled in comparison to what one could gain from the sacrifice of one's soul to one particular god, binding oneself to them.

"But there is a price, as Shyleen says," he went on, "and bless her for refusing to even consider it," he added. "The mortal in question loses their ability to feel, to love, to care. They are left with jealousy, envy, hatred, leading to a terrible obsession.

"I don't mean like my slight obsession with researching obscure books about the gods," he chuckled. "I mean the kind of obsession that leads to death, destruction. The kind that can start a war."

'*That is why I would never allow it,*' Shyleen vowed. '*I have you as a friend now. I am quite content with that.*'

"I take it Shyleen still refuses to allow it," the cleric surmised. Mandalee nodded, hanging her head. Of course, she

didn't want to end up like that. She didn't want to hurt innocent people, but she still wished there were something she could do for Shyleen.

"I'm happy to hear it, because there may be another way," Elric told her.

The light of hope grew in Mandalee's eyes as her head whirled around so fast, she almost gave herself whiplash.

Shyleen's ears pricked up. Even she had no idea what this 'other way' could be.

Elric recalled reading one story that spoke of something called a 'Cleric of Nature' who, rather than selling his soul, shared it with an animal god. He gained access to clerical powers – though not as much as one who sold their soul – and complete knowledge of all wild things. In return, the god was able to fully manifest in this world for as long as the mortal still lived and consented. Consent which was entirely his to revoke at any time.

"If you were such a Cleric of Nature, you would still have access to the full range of human emotions, although you would tend to shun towns and the company of people, favouring the wilds."

"But I do that already," Mandalee gasped, "because other people shunned me first! How do I do it? How do I share my soul?"

"Well, I can't be sure it will work at all. As I said, it's just an old legend."

"It's true!" Mandalee asserted. "It has to be!"

Shyleen was more cautious. '*As wonderful as this sounds, I will agree only if I am sure there is no risk to you.*'

The cleric was convinced that the only risk was that it really was just a story, in which case nothing would happen, and he would look rather foolish.

"But most people in this place think I'm crazy anyway, so what's the difference?" Mandalee was going to protest, but he waved it aside. "No need to spare my feelings. I know what people say about Elric the Cleric. But not you, Mandalee. Never you. For your kindness, I will help you if I can."

Mandalee didn't believe simply 'not being mean' to someone should be considered a particular kindness. Surely that ought to be a basic expectation. Still, she was grateful for his help.

However, Eric did insist on talking to Mandalee's parents before attempting anything.

For their part, they had never had a problem with their child preferring nature to people. They were rangers by trade, with a strong interest in the study of nature. Her father had even dabbled with a touch of druid magic. They both knew Mandalee was unhappy and were willing to try just about anything to change that, no matter how 'out there' it might seem.

They talked about it long into the night, slept on it, but by the morning they had decided. If there was a chance this could help their only child, then they had to agree.

Chapter 28

The cleric needed a few days to prepare, but as soon as he was ready, Elric met with Mandalee's family and led them away from the village to the spot where Mandalee and Shyleen had first met. Since it was a special place for them, he reasoned it might help them to forge their new bond. In truth, he didn't know if it made any difference, but he'd never done this before and was happy to grasp at any straws that might even remotely help.

Elric asked Mandalee and Shyleen to stand within a circle that would contain their essence. Mandalee's father wanted to be the one to do it, so with a great deal of effort, he persuaded the grass to grow slightly in a large ring. When Mandalee confirmed Shyleen was within the boundary, since only she could see the leopard, Elric began reading from his old, fragile books, working this forgotten magic. A silvery glowing ball of light emerged from Mandalee's body and hovered in the air for a moment, then slowly, gently, it began to pull apart into two halves, like a giant soap bubble splitting in two. Only it didn't split. Not completely. A thread remained between the two halves. A tether that Mandalee could use to reclaim her soul, any time she wished. She vowed she never would.

Golden light spread from Shyleen's partially manifest body, growing in the opposite direction.

"Do you, Mandalee, fully consent to give a half share of your soul to Shyleen," the cleric asked, ritualistically, "in full knowledge and understanding of what that means?"

"I consent gladly," she answered.

Turning to the glow of golden energy that marked Shyleen's position, he asked, "Do you, Shyleen of the Pantheon, fully accept the terms of this gift, in full knowledge and understanding that this soul still belongs to Mandalee, completely, forever?"

"She says she fully understands and vows never to try and take what is mine." Mandalee translated.

Turning to her parents, he asked, "And do you swear that your child has your full support to do this?"

"I swear," her Dad answered. "I just want my *daughter*," he stressed the word, "to be happy."

"So do I," her Mum agreed. "People have treated her horribly, where nature has never judged. If this action means her seeking a life away from our village, away from us, then so be it." Turning to Mandalee with tears in her eyes, she added, "I just pray you'll visit, sometimes."

Mandalee smiled through her own tears, mixed emotions welling up inside her and overflowing. "I will, Mum. I promise. Thank you for letting me do this. I love you both."

"Are you ready?" Elric asked.

"I am," Mandalee confirmed. "We both are."

Accepting their decision, the cleric completed the spells.

The golden light ended its journey into Mandalee's body, and one half of the silver bubble flew into Shyleen, while the other half returned to its original home inside Mandalee. The tether between them faded from view, but both could still feel it. They always would. From the perspective of the three onlookers, a great golden leopard shimmered into the circle beside Mandalee. She was now fully manifest, truly a part of this world.

For her part, Mandalee found that not only did she retain all her own feelings and emotions, but she could also feel everything Shyleen felt. Shyleen confirmed that went both ways. Their bond was unbreakable, and no matter how far apart they were, they each always knew where the other was and how they were feeling.

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That was how they found each other in Eastcliff, gentle reader, and how they always would in the future. Even in my time, a thousand years later, their bond is as strong as it ever was. Quite simply, it is a part of who they are.

Even as she reminisced with Shyleen, that day, Mandalee realised it had been quite a while since she had made good on her promise to her parents. The last time had been about a year before she met Catriona again and began her adventure with Daelen. Now that she'd skipped more than two years, she was keen to head for home again, soon.

She just hoped her parents would still recognise her after so much time and so many changes.

*****

Mandalee's reminiscence was abruptly cut short, however, when her friend suddenly got up, fur standing on end, ears and tail twitching.

The White Assassin instantly sprang to her feet, drawing her dragonclaw daggers. She didn't understand what danger Shyleen sensed, but she would never doubt it.

'*What's wrong?*' she asked. '*Did you see something?*'

'*Actually, I am more worried about what I* don't *see.*'

Shyleen explained that she had spent most of the last two years with Mandalee's friend, Windell. Though they couldn't communicate as such, they had nevertheless developed an understanding. He had journeyed North with her, the past week, realising why the leopard had taken off in such a hurry.

'*When I sensed you were close, I put on an extra burst of speed, and I knew Windell could not keep up. Still, I would have expected him to be here by now. Perhaps I should not have left him alone. I worry something has happened to him.*'

"We'll find him," Mandalee assured her, confidently. After all, when the White Assassin and Shyleen were on the hunt together, nothing could stop them.

Before they could make a move, though, Windell stumbled into the clearing, bleeding from an alarming number of lacerations that looked like knife wounds.

"Look—!" was as far as his warning got before a young woman of about eighteen, wearing brown leather, burst out of the trees behind him and swept his feet from under him, sending him tumbling to the ground. Since his hands were bound behind him, he had no way to break his fall. He cried out as he landed hard.

"That'll teach you to try and escape!" the woman growled. "Now be quiet!" She brought her bootheel down sharply and knocked him unconscious. "That's better," she sighed. Glancing over to Mandalee, she spat, "And you can wait, too. Don't worry, we'll get to the fighting all in good time, but first I want you to know exactly who it is that's going to be killing you today."

"Or I can kill *you* without ever knowing your name," Mandalee suggested with a shrug. "Yep," she decided, "I can live with that."

Invoking her super-speed, she sprinted across the clearing with deadly intent. It was only a hundred yards or so, she could do that in the blink of an eye. Far faster than this girl could do anything more to Windell, but before she could touch her, it was like she slammed into an invisible wall, bouncing off painfully, and crashing to the ground.

"Try that again, and I slit his throat!" the young woman warned her as Shyleen ran to Mandalee's side, guarding her friend while she got back to her feet. "Aww," the girl mocked, stroking her dark brown braid with one hand and threatening Windell with a sword in the other. Mandalee couldn't understand how she'd managed to draw it without her noticing. "Finally reunited with your mangy cat, only to die so soon afterwards. It'd be quite a tragic story, really...if you weren't a cold-hearted murdering bitch who was getting what she deserved!"

"What are you talking about?" Mandalee demanded. "Who have I murdered?"

"Well, yes, I guess it must be hard to keep track," the girl considered. "After all, there have been so many, haven't there? But you never forget your first, isn't that what they say? OK, I think that normally refers to your first love, not your first murder, but you obviously love murdering people, so for you, I guess it's the same thing."

Mandalee's every instinct was to strike her down. She didn't care what deluded notions she had in her head. All that mattered was that she was threatening Windell. Regardless of what crime she might imagine her guilty of, Mandalee wasn't going to let her get away with threatening an innocent life. Still, she had to keep her head. Rushing the girl once had achieved nothing, and she wasn't about to make the same mistake twice. If this girl really did want to try and kill her, she would have to move away from Windell. Then she would lose her advantage.

Mandalee sheathed her daggers and sat down. Shyleen, taking her lead, did the same, appearing to relax, while still being ready to pounce at a moment's notice.

"OK, if you want to keep talking in riddles, go right ahead," Mandalee remarked. "I've got all day. Anytime you want to come right out and say what you're obviously dying to tell me, I'll be right here."

"Ask me my name," the girl ordered her.

"I'm a cold-hearted murdering bitch, remember? Why would I care about your name?"

"Ask me!" the girl demanded.

"No," Mandalee replied, calmly.

Visibly frustrated, the girl pushed the sword closer to Windell's neck. "I'll kill him if you don't!" she screamed.

Mandalee shook her head. "No, you won't. That's the trouble with one hostage. If you kill him, there'll be nothing holding me back."

"You think I'm scared of you?" the girl scoffed.

"I think you've taken a hostage rather than fight me."

"I told you, I want you to know who I am before I kill you."

"And I told you I don't care who you are. Is it just me, or is this conversation going around in circles?"

"Fine, have it your way. The name's Nalani!" the young woman growled. "I'll carve it on your corpse!" Quick as a flash, the girl swapped her sword for a pair of knives, stepping away from where Windell lay, effectively relinquishing her hostage.

"Still don't care," Mandalee replied, standing and re-drawing her own daggers. "Finally ready to fight?"

"Oh, you have no idea how ready I am. I've been training for years, ever since you murdered my father."

"Your father?"

"I thought you said you didn't care about names!" Nalani snapped, stepping closer. She and Mandalee began circling each other, patiently, looking for an opening.

"No, I said I didn't care about *your* name," Mandalee returned. "*His* name I'm interested in."

"My father was a great wizard," Nalani said through gritted teeth, "working hard with cutting edge magic, pushing the boundaries of progress, working for the greater good to make the world a better place."

Mandalee feigned a yawn. "I said I was interested in his name, not his life story."

"His life story was a lot shorter than it should have been, thanks to you," she snarled, but the White Guardian continued to look bored until she finally spoke the name, "Irius."

That name had an impact, causing Mandalee to hesitate for a fraction of a second, giving Nalani the first strike. Mandalee dodged aside quickly, avoiding any damage, but Nalani was relentless, forcing her to remain on the defensive. The girl was good, Mandalee conceded. There weren't many fighters who could knock the White Assassin back on her heels. Still, the truth was, she was holding back.

Irius. In a way, Nalani was right: he had been her first kill, although it was far from murder.

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You might remember the incident, gentle reader. It was years ago, long before the Guardianship, before her 'mission' to stop Daelen StormTiger that morphed into helping him against Kullos. My mother had just moved in with Dreya the Dark and Aunt Mandalee was a novice demon hunter, trying to make a name for herself. Her break finally came in the form of a contract to kill a Greater Demon that was terrorising and slaughtering people in an innocent village near Compton. She had been worried about it because demons like that were almost always summoned. That was why she had asked Cat, her best friend, to help her. Except my mother had been distracted, so she never registered her plea.

Mandalee and Shyleen went to fulfil the contract, thinking they had backup when they really didn't. Slaying the Greater Demon had taken almost everything they had…and then the enraged wizard showed up.

That was the day Shyleen saved Mandalee's life, very nearly at the cost of her own. Mandalee had got lucky – the wizard got distracted at the crucial moment when Daelen whooshed overhead, rushing to fight another of his great battles. Mandalee took full advantage and slew the wizard. The first wizard, the first person, that Mandalee had ever killed.

That wizard's name was Irius.

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Mandalee regretted nothing about that day. Catriona's failure to be there when she really needed her tore apart their

friendship for a while, but she had since forgiven her, and now their bond was stronger than ever. They were sisters. Mandalee would protect Cat with her life, and she knew that Cat, in turn, was the one person who would never, ever let her down again.

Now it turned out that Irius had had a daughter, Nalani. By the looks of her, Mandalee thought, she must have been about twelve, maybe thirteen at the time. No older than Mandalee had been when she first met Shyleen. Now she was all grown up, with a toned body, sporting lean, lithe muscles that spoke of dedicated training. Dedicated, it seemed, to revenge on the one who 'murdered' her father, although it was no such thing. Mandalee became an assassin only *after* that day, and then she only killed to protect the innocent. Ironically, innocents much like Nalani had been before she got it all twisted up in her head and her heart.

As Mandalee was assessing her opponent's body, Nalani was apparently doing the same. "Look at you!" she taunted. "All suited up, looking like you're a real woman now!"

Mandalee was parrying everything Nalani threw at her. It wasn't her usual style – she didn't typically give people a second go at killing her – but she wanted to give this girl a chance. None of Nalani's physical strikes had so far landed, but that verbal blow struck home. She had thought she was done with comments like that.

"I was always a real woman!" she shot back, defensively.

Nalani's lip curled as she tried to reopen an old wound. "That's not what I heard," she jeered. "'Mandalee's the Man', that's what I heard!"

"Where did you hear that?" Mandalee demanded. She used to get that all the time when she was growing up. She had considered changing her name, but she realised that would be giving in to the bullies, and it wouldn't stop them, anyway.

"I know all about you," she replied. "Know your enemy. That's how I'm going to beat you."

"I don't want to be your enemy. Please just stop," Mandalee implored her.

"Oh, is this the part where you say how sorry you are, I forgive you, and we become best friends?"

Mandalee shook her head. "I won't apologise for killing someone in defence of myself, my friends or innocent people. Your

father's demon was going to slaughter your whole village and probably half of Compton if I hadn't stopped it."

"Lies!" Nalani screamed. "My father was a good man. He was doing great things, and you murdered him because you liked it!"

"Someone had to put a stop to what he was doing," Mandalee asserted, trying to get Nalani to accept the truth. "That someone was me. The demon was all I was after in those days. I would have just walked away, but Nalani – *he* attacked *me*. Nearly killed Shyleen."

"Yeah? Well, *someone* needs to have that fleabag put down, and that someone is me!" She threw an arc of flames at Shyleen, but Mandalee used her super-speed to throw herself in their path, relying on her magically resistant body armour to protect her.

Mandalee and Shyleen were both seeing red, now. They had given her a chance; she wouldn't get another.

"Oh, big mistake, Nalani!" she snarled. "Now it's two against one."

"Actually no," Nalani refuted. "It's two against two."

From the treeline, there came a low growl and a lioness prowled out into the open. Mandalee couldn't understand it: how could she not know it was there? The animals were always her friends. She could hear their chatter all the time. Why had they kept this from her? Before she could wonder any more about that, however, she saw and felt something from Shyleen that she never had before. She was cowering before this strange lioness. Cowering in fear.

'*What is it, Shyleen? What's wrong?*'

By way of answer, she named the lioness, '*Pryshia*'.

It took her a moment, but then Mandalee remembered. Shyleen had run away from the other gods. The ones who hurt her and cast her out, and Pryshia was their leader. Queen of the gods. Now she was here, and Shyleen was terrified.

"You see?" Nalani smirked. "I'm a Cleric of Nature, too. Just like you. Only better!"

'*Don't let her bully you, Shyleen,"* Mandalee reassured her, ignoring Nalani's taunts, '*It's different now. You have me.*'

Snapping herself out of it, the leopard agreed, '*You're right. Let's get them.*'

Chapter 29

The two big cats roared as they tore into each other with tooth and claw. Mandalee didn't need to watch – she could feel every scratch and bite, and would know if her friend's injuries required healing. If Nalani was feeling what Shyleen was doing to Pryshia, however, she was doing a remarkably good job of hiding it.

Mandalee launched herself at Nalani with equal ferocity, targeting the usual weak spots in the human body: neck, throat, wrists, belly. She even attempted a dive and roll to try and hamstring her, but Nalani dodged and danced out of the way every time. Mandalee was using her super-speed, but somehow Nalani always had plenty of time. By contrast, Nalani's knives scored hits with unerring accuracy. None of the cuts were deep so far, but the White Assassin wasn't sure how much of that was down to her own skill and how much was down to Nalani toying with her.

Shyleen was having similar problems. In the wild, a regular leopard was no match for a lioness, and while neither animal was exactly what they appeared to be, the result was proving to be the same. Sparing some healing for her friend, Mandalee tried a new tack. Her immediate problem, she decided, was the knives that were cutting her, not the hands that wielded them. Going for the wrists wasn't working, but if she couldn't disarm Nalani, then maybe she could destroy her weapons. After all, Mandalee's knives were made from dragon claws. There was nothing they couldn't cut through, so ordinary weapons would be useless against them. She just needed to get the timing right.

With a renewed, frenzied assault, Mandalee's daggers flashed with lightning speed, but then she feigned an attack. That meant she was ready when Nalani took the bait and overcommitted. The White Assassin's daggers flew up to block the strike, expecting her enemy's knives to shatter on contact. Sparks flew when the two pairs of weapons struck, ringing loudly, but Nalani's knives withstood the impact.

Mandalee couldn't believe what she was seeing. The only way Nalani's knives could still be intact was if they, too, were made from dragon claws.

Nalani confirmed it, gloating as she pressed her attack, leaving Mandalee defending desperately. “They’re great, aren’t they, these dragon claws? Cut through anything…except each other. Do you get it, yet? I’m stronger than you, I’m faster than you, I fight better than you and my knives are at least a match for yours. You can’t win this. I’m just going to wear you down until you can’t fight anymore and then I’m going to kill you while Pryshia makes mincemeat of your mangy moggy.”

Continuing to ignore her taunts, saving her energy for the furious exchange of blows with Nalani and healing Shyleen as necessary, Mandalee analysed her situation critically. She had always prided herself on maintaining a clear head in a fight. No matter how her emotions were ablaze, she never crossed the line into an unthinking battle frenzy. That was how warriors got themselves killed. Nalani was right. She and Pryshia seemed designed to be the perfect weapons to beat Shyleen and herself, but Mandalee had an advantage: she had nothing to prove. Not these days. She just wanted to survive. Mandalee wasn’t going to let pride goad her into continuing to fight a losing battle. Running away wasn’t an option – she and Shyleen weren’t fast enough – but Mandalee had friends who, thanks to the Guardianship, she could contact at any time, and there was no time like the present.

The White Guardian wasn’t as experienced at this as the other two, so as a precaution, she invoked her cleric magic to form a thick fog around them, plunging them into a deep, unnatural darkness. She suspected it would only take Nalani a second or two to counter the effect, but to the Guardians of Time and Magic, a second or two could be all the time in the world.

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Opening her Guardian senses to the Timeless zone that was Catriona’s Meadow, she called out to her two friends, crying out for help, urgently. She didn’t trust her portals enough to go there physically and she didn’t have the co-ordinates to get back if something went wrong, but she knew that communication via Catriona’s Meadow took literally no time at all.

Mandalee heard the voices of her two friends almost simultaneously asking what the emergency was. When she

explained, Catriona was astonished. She'd seen her fight many times, so she knew how swift and deadly she was. The idea that anyone could be too quick for her to fight was almost beyond imagining.

For Dreya's part, her mind was already flicking through her catalogue of powers, selecting and preparing what she thought might work. In her time, she had fought powerful enemies, hordes of enemies and enemies many times her size. Speed was a new kind of challenge altogether.

"Where are you, Mandalee?" Dreya asked.

"Somewhere on Eastcliff, Southern Alloria. South of Durmchapel, North of Kelna." Unfortunately, she couldn't be more specific, which ruled out direct portals, but after a quick discussion, they worked out a plan.

"Hold on, Mandalee, we're coming," Cat encouraged her friend. "Then this Nalani won't stand a chance."

"Until then," Dreya put in, "consider this: you've admitted yourself that Nalani is perfectly designed to fight you. She obviously knows how you fight, and she's able to counter you, so don't fight that way."

"You want me to completely change my fighting style on the spot?" she wondered, incredulously.

"Mandalee, what you're doing isn't working, so what good is it?"

With that, they cut off communications.

Dreya made a good point, Mandalee conceded, and she had a couple of ideas about that.

*****

Mandalee returned to the Timestream the instant she left it, her magical fog hiding her from Nalani's view. Usually, Mandalee would use that strategy to quickly attack from a different angle to catch her enemy off guard, but Nalani was too fast and anticipated too well for that. The solution, therefore, was to use the fog as a bluff and stay exactly where she was. The idea paid dividends. Even as she dispelled the mist, Nalani was already committed to whirling around to counter Mandalee's next strike. By staying put, Mandalee forced her to spin around full circle. It only took her a

fraction of a second, but it was all the time Mandalee needed. She had sheathed her knives in favour of a conjured flame hammer. It was something she would use on a group or a large target like Kullos or a demon that didn't necessarily have the same weak points as a human. She would never use such a crude and unwieldy weapon one-on-one. She preferred the precision cuts of a knife or a sword. Against Nalani, however, she couldn't land those precise cuts, so why not try some brute force instead?

As Nalani whirled around, her face collided with the hammer, burning her and knocking her away. She staggered backwards, slightly off-balance for the first time. Taking advantage of the opening, the White Guardian sent flames from her fingertips, but they missed Nalani and a tree burst into flames. She acted as though she were annoyed at this result, to disguise the fact that it had been deliberate intent. Her friends needed a marker to pinpoint her location on Eastcliff, and she could think of nothing better than a nice big smoke signal. Cat would be able to prevent any forest fire raging out of control when she arrived.

Pressing her advantage, Mandalee attacked wildly with her flame hammer. Nalani dodged and weaved too much for her to get in a clean strike, but even glancing blows were better than anything she'd achieved so far.

Mandalee sent some healing Shyleen's way. It was interesting that it seemed to take a growl from Pryshia for the lioness to get any healing from Nalani. She didn't know why that would be so. If Nalani was indeed a Cleric of Nature as she claimed, she should be feeling everything Pryshia did. However, she stored that query away for the moment in favour of focussing on the task at hand: staying alive.

Out of the corner of her eye, Mandalee saw Windell recover. Obviously not considering him a threat, Nalani had not disarmed him and with true warrior's spirit, he threw his spear at Nalani. The young woman almost failed to notice, but another growl from Pryshia alerted her, and he only scored a graze on her left arm.

Nalani invoked levitation magic to make the spear fly back at him, but Mandalee could counter that, easily. Still, the diversion had worked in Nalani's favour. She was back on-balance and in control.

Drawing his sword and charging at Nalani, Windell tried to enter the fight properly, but he was no match for her. With a few, deft strokes of her daggers, he was once again bleeding from multiple shallow cuts. In the battle against Kullos' forces, Windell had proven himself a fine and able warrior, one of the finest of what Michael called his 'fan club'. Nalani, however, was in a different league. In less than a minute, he once again passed out from pain and blood loss, his wounds severe, but not life-threatening. Mandalee didn't know why Nalani had chosen not to kill him but decided not to ask, lest it tempt her to change her mind.

Whatever momentum Mandalee had gained from her change of tactics had evaporated. Nalani had a glint in her eye and a smile on her lips. Mandalee couldn't understand how she was maintaining this blistering pace for so long. The White Assassin herself had never used her super-speed for such a sustained period, and she couldn't use it for much longer. Nalani's knives began to strike both more cleanly and more frequently, as did Pryshia's claws on Shyleen's increasingly torn and bloody hide. Mandalee was desperate to heal her, but she simply had nothing left. Blood was streaming out of both of their bodies, and Mandalee could no longer do anything about it. She'd kept fighting as long as she could, but it was the end. She collapsed to the ground, helpless before Nalani's hatred and vengeance.

'*I'm so sorry, Shyleen,'* she told her friend. '*I've got nothing left to give you.*'

With a supreme effort, Shyleen managed to force Pryshia back, just for a moment, using the opening to run to Mandalee's side just as her speed left her and the flame hammer extinguished.

'*You have no reason to be sorry, Mandalee,*' she insisted, placing her body between her fallen friend and their attackers. If they were to meet their end here, then they would meet it together. '*You have given me far more than I ever could have wished for. I love you, Mandalee. The finest friend anyone could have.*'

'*I love you, too, Shyleen. Better than all the gods in the Pantheon. Thank you for everything.*'

"Finished saying your goodbyes?" Nalani taunted as she stroked her braid. Pryshia just purred beside her. "That's more than I got to do when you murdered my father!"

Mandalee shook her head, weakly. “I didn’t…” but she never got to finish her sentence.

In her head, Mandalee heard a sympathic shout, ‘*STAY DOWN!*’ which in her delirium of exhaustion, she thought was vaguely funny, considering she was quite incapable of doing anything else. A figure in Black robes floated down from the sky and threw out a concussive blast in all directions, knocking Nalani and Pryshia flying.

Dreya had seen the smoke rising as soon as she materialised just North of Imperial Kelna. It was hard to judge the distance, and it had taken her three portals to get here, each a stage closer. She’d finally reached her friend and knew she had not a moment to lose. Mandalee had told her how fast Nalani was, so rather than try for a direct hit, she had lashed out in all directions.

She knew Catriona had chosen to head South from Durmchapel and was coming as fast as she could, but she was worried it might not be fast enough.

As White Guardian, Mandalee could have halted any change in her condition by portalling to Catriona’s Meadow and embracing Timelessness, but that wouldn’t help Shyleen. Dreya knew better than to even suggest it.

Dreya’s skills did not extend to healing, but maybe there was a way for her to help. During their time in the past, Dreya had learned to give power to others. Trouble was, the magics of a Black wizard and a White cleric were not very compatible. Their frequencies clashed. When Cat had first shown up outside the Black Tower and challenged Dreya, the druidess had tried to trap her using plants laced with some of Mandalee’s magic. It had hurt like hell, but it didn’t do any real harm.

It was worth a try.

Dreya focussed her magic into a low power beam and aimed it at her friend.

“Sorry, Mandalee,” she apologised, gently. “This is going to hurt.”

Mandalee screamed, but she was grateful, nonetheless. Dreya’s form of magic was alien to her system, but it was useable. It was not unlike eating food that was nutritionally good but tasted terrible. Not something she would choose to do regularly, but if it

was a choice between that and starving, she would stomach whatever was offered.

Dreya was forced to cut the beam off early to deflect a knife that she sensed hurtling towards her back. Mandalee sympathically assured her she was OK. What Dreya had given her had been just enough to keep both Shyleen and herself from death's door.

"Stay out of this, Black Witch!" Nalani snarled. "It's got nothing to do with you!"

"It's got everything to do with me," Dreya countered. "She's my friend." Then, reconsidering, she revised her statement to, "They're *both* my friends!"

"You might want to think about crossing me," Nalani warned her. "Pryshia here's no ordinary lioness – she's a god. She's *my* god!"

Mandalee shared a glance with Shyleen. There was no way she would ever refer to her friend that way. Yet more evidence that, for all Nalani claimed to be a Cleric of Nature, she seemed to have some rather odd ideas about what that meant.

For her part, Dreya just snorted. "Maybe you haven't heard, but I beat Daelen's dark clone, conquered a world full of dragons, and helped defeat the most powerful shadow warrior Champion there has ever been. You think I'm scared of a mere god? Bah!" she spat. "I'm bored already."

Dreya pricked her finger on her dagger, tapping into blood magic. She wasn't playing around here. She was taking this bitch down.

Lightning bolts flew from her hands, but Nalani and Pryshia had recovered enough by now to resume their super-speed, easily dodging the attack. Flames and fireballs, shock spheres and more lightning bolts whistled harmlessly past.

"Is speed all you've got?" Dreya taunted.

Nalani shrugged. "Seems to be enough so far."

"And yet you're nowhere near killing your target, and I can do this level of magic all day. How long can you run like that?"

"Long enough!"

"OK then," Dreya shrugged, growing an extra-large fireball, the size of a watermelon, "let's see you outrun this."

She cast it out, and her enemies tried to dodge as before, but this time the fireball was guided and kept following. She hadn't

used magic like this for years, tending to favour power words and beam cannon blasts using higher planar energy. But those powers weren't guided. It didn't matter how powerful her magic was if it missed. Perhaps that was something she ought to address, the sorceress considered. Her twin magical obsessions were power and control, but maybe she had begun to grow the former at the expense of the latter. There had to be a way to incorporate guidance magic into her higher-level powers. She'd work on that later, but for right now she had to work with what she knew. Which was a lot.

Chapter 30

Nalani and Pryshia split up, forcing Dreya to choose which one to target. She decided on Nalani and brought things to a head by throwing out a blast of air from the opposite direction. Nalani felt like she'd slammed into a wall, stunning her long enough for the fireball to catch up with her, but the fire attack fizzled harmlessly on contact.

Dreya couldn't understand it, until Mandalee croaked, "Bodysuit."

The sorceress realised she was right. Her fire spell had had some effect after all: it had burned a patch out of Nalani's brown leather, revealing another, pristine layer of fabric underneath. Fabric that looked a lot like one of Mandalee's magically resistant combat suits.

"Are those things available in shops now?" Dreya snapped, irritably.

"Why?" Nalani shot back. "Afraid that your magic's useless now and I can do anything I like to the great Dreya the Dark?" She brandished her knives as if to attack, but Dreya wasn't fooled. She was just trying to distract her while Pryshia crept up behind her and sprang.

Dreya didn't have super-speed, but she could manipulate Time, especially with a second Guardian there. She slipped quickly aside, focussed her will on the flying lioness and unfolded her power word, "FREEZE." The so-called god's muscles locked, unable to change her momentum as she flew past and collided with a tree.

The Black Guardian's eyes never left the lioness as she said, "PAIN."

Pryshia roared and whimpered in agony.

Returning her focus to Nalani, Dreya finally answered her. "No, I'm just afraid I'm going to have to hurt her to get to you, and I do hate cruelty to animals."

But on a day of surprises, there came one more. Nalani appeared wholly unaffected as she healed her 'god' and numbed her pain, unfreezing her in the process. She may call herself a

Cleric of Nature, Dreya thought, but it was quite clear that her link with Pryshia was nothing like Mandalee's bond with Shyleen.

Windell had once again regained consciousness by now but was wisely staying out of things this time.

Dreya was considering her next move when rain began to fall in their otherwise sunny surroundings, and a rainbow appeared.

"Wheee!" cried a familiar voice, sounding for all the world like she was thoroughly enjoying herself.

Nalani and Pryshia didn't know what to make of it and just stood there as the rainbow curved sharply down to the ground. They continued to stand there as the red-robed form of Catriona Redfletching hurtled down, Crystal Mage Staff in her hand, sliding on her backside and acting like she was at a funfair. The woman and lioness, sensing danger, acted on instinct and tried to run, but a mighty wind gusted up, slowing them down and accelerating Cat even further. The druidess gathered momentum, as gravity and propelling wind worked in concert to make her faster than her enemies. The rainbow road on which she slid, flew around and up and over until the pair were inside it.

Nalani didn't know how, but the walls of the rainbow appeared to be solid. She tried hacking at them with her dragonclaw daggers that could cut through anything, but they had no effect.

Catriona's slide finally took her down to the ground.

"Wow!" she cried, exhilarated. "That was awesome! I am so doing that again." With a slight stagger, however, she qualified, "But not just now. Bit dizzy.

"'Ello!" she segued, addressing Nalani, "I hear you've been giving my friends some trouble. Well, now I've got you neatly giftwrapped, so we'll have no more of that."

Nalani pounded futilely on the walls of her multicoloured prison. "What the hell is this?" she demanded.

Cat nodded. "Neat, isn't it? Pretty and functional. You're fast, I'll grant you that, but with a bit of help from the power of nature, I could be faster. OK, just briefly, I admit. As for your prison," she explained, "sunlight through moisture gives us a rainbow, but that's mostly just for show. Literally. It's so I can see the walls of air I've wrapped around you. Your suit protects you from direct magic, but not from nature, and your daggers can cut through anything solid, but guess what? Air's not solid. It just feels

that way when it's pushing against you. So, there's nothing for your daggers to cut. Now, you just wait there," she told Nalani, as if she had a choice. "I'm busy."

Seeing that Mandalee's forest fire was beginning to spread, she made it rain harder, but it wasn't enough. Turning to her fiancée, she asked her to use her magic to form a dome shield around the flames and extract all the oxygen. Dreya complied, and in a moment, the fire was extinguished.

"You might want to think about doing the same to Nalani if she gives us any more trouble," she suggested, casually. "Her suit doesn't physically protect her head," she pointed out. "It just generates an anti-magic field, and I know how you are with those."

Dreya drew her close and kissed her. "I love it when you're ruthless."

"I know," she smiled.

Mandalee called up from where she lay on the ground. "If you two lovebirds are quite finished, Shyleen and I have been *dying* for you to turn up."

In fact, Catriona knew they weren't dying at all, thanks to Dreya. As soon as her fiancée had arrived on the scene, she was able to send Cat exact co-ordinates, so she could portal straight there. Rather than do that, though, she portalled a short distance away and observed the action. She could see her friends were out of danger, because Nalani and Pryshia were never going to get past Dreya the Dark. That gave her time to come up with a way to contain them properly. A plan that, as usual, involved making a dramatic entrance. Now she could concentrate on healing her friends.

The damage to Shyleen was easy enough to fix – it was just the result of tooth and claw. As she sent out her druid senses into Mandalee's body, however, she realised that Nalani's daggers must have been laced with something that had given her an infection. That would take time.

As Cat ran through the options in her head, Dreya apologised to Mandalee for upsetting her with her ill-chosen comments, a few days ago.

Shyleen suggested to Mandalee, '*It seems to me that she came when we needed her and saved our lives. I believe those actions are more important than anything she might have said.*'

Mandalee agreed, passing on her comments and adding her own thanks. “You’re a true friend, Dreya,” she told her, smiling weakly, “and I don’t really blame you for missing two years. We’re all new at this and mistakes are bound to happen.”

“And you’ve just made another one,” came Nalani’s sneering voice. Cat, Dreya and Shyleen all whirled around to see her free of her prison and holding a knife to Windell’s throat. Pryshia was sitting beside her, looking like the proverbial cat that got the cream. “I had a hunch this one might come in handy if I kept him alive.” Her weapon was one Mandalee hadn’t seen her use during their fight. It was about six inches long with a jagged, zigzag-shaped blade, like an idealised lightning bolt, with a bejewelled hilt.

Dreya realised she’d seen it before in Scarlett’s mind. This dagger, or at least an identical one, had been hanging from the belt of the Black robe wizard that attacked Whealhaven. The sorceress filed that thought away to deal with later.

“Your rainbow showed me where the prison walls were, and therefore where they weren’t,” Nalani pointed out.

As soon as the Guardians’ backs were turned, Nalani and Pryshia had burrowed underneath the cage.

“Cat!” Dreya admonished her. “It’s not like you to make that mistake.” Catriona had once criticised even her for using a dome shield instead of a bubble, leaving an easy escape underneath.

“I was in a rush!” Cat replied, defensively. “And I couldn’t figure out how to get a rainbow to form between their feet and the ground.”

“Oh, I’ve had enough of this!” Mandalee grumbled from where she lay. “Shall we just Freeze Time and be done with it?”

“I really wouldn’t do that if I were you,” Nalani called out. “This dagger is enchanted with a Timeless spell. It protects the wielder from changes to the Timeline and anyone killed with it stays dead no matter what you do.”

“There’s no such thing!” Mandalee scoffed.

“Actually, there might be,” Cat admitted with a sick feeling in her stomach. She had started working on a kind of Timeless spell to protect Calin’s Tower. It was conceivable that it could be turned into a weapon in the future, and the Guardians knew from

experience that future events could interfere with their present, just as they could intervene in the past.

"Either way," Nalani challenged, "can you take the risk?"

They couldn't, and they all knew it. Freezing Time wasn't instant. It would take a second or two for Time to grind to a halt. For someone as fast as Nalani, that was plenty of time to kill Windell.

"I should have done what you said, Cat," Dreya grumbled. Then, with a sigh of resignation, she said, "OK, Nalani. What do you want?"

"What I want is for Mandalee the Murderer to die, but I guess that'll have to wait, so I'll settle for getting away. Let me go, don't try to follow for at least ten minutes and I'll dump this one where you can find him."

"How do we know you won't kill him anyway?" Mandalee demanded.

"Because I'm not a murderer like you!" Nalani snapped back, vehemently. "I'll only kill him if you force my hand."

The Guardians had no choice but to reluctantly agree.

Even so, Mandalee couldn't resist calling out, "Hey, Nalani! *Catch* you later!"

"No, you won't!" Nalani shot back. Keeping Windell under close guard, she commanded him to move. Pryshia followed close at her heels. As Nalani stepped into the Eastcliff woodlands, she cried, "I just beat the Guardians!" A fact she clearly found hilarious.

Her cruel, mocking laughter faded as she moved away until she was too distant to be heard.

Cat sighed, deeply. "Not exactly our finest hour, I have to admit."

That was when Mandalee's fatigue, from the battle and the infection, finally caught up with her and she passed out.

'*Don't worry, Shyleen. I'll soon fix her up,*' Cat promised telepathically, in her leopard language. '*Just like last time.*'

'*I know you will, Cat,*' Shyleen returned. '*I am not worried.*'

With that, the leopard moved away to give her space. If it was like last time, then it would involve water, and she had no desire to get her paws wet unnecessarily.

Dreya decided to give it precisely eleven minutes and then retrieve Windell.

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Catriona's ministrations purged Mandalee's infection and closed her more acute wounds, then she waited for her friend to recover naturally.

Her eyes fluttered open, taking in her situation, laying in a shallow pool of water, head cradled in Catriona's lap, bodysuit folded neatly on the bank.

"Don't tell me: I was skinny dipping again, right?" she quipped.

Cat gave her a mischievous smile. "Nope. I really am obsessed with seeing you naked every chance I get."

"I'm telling Dreya!" Mandalee threatened, acting offended.

Cat helped her up, dried her off with her magic and let her get dressed.

A short time later, Windell returned with Dreya's support. Mandalee immediately went to him, healed him and hugged him – gently for both their sakes as they were each still a little sore and tender in places.

"I'm sorry you got beaten up because of me," she told him.

"I'm sorry she got away because of me," he returned. "I felt like a damsel in distress out here."

Surprisingly, it was Dreya who offered her support. "It's not like that," she assured him. "Sometimes you come up against someone who's just too powerful, and there's nothing you can do."

"Not a concept I'd expect you to be familiar with, sorceress," he replied, a wary look of respect in his eyes.

"Not recently, no," she admitted with a crooked smile, "but who knows? There could be someone or something out there that even I can't fight."

"If that's true, I pray I never meet them," Windell declared, solemnly.

Nalani had, of course, been long gone when Dreya found Windell, but at least she had kept her word and let him live.

"That's because she honestly believes I murdered her father," Mandalee explained, shaking her head, sadly. "She just

won't accept that he was a terrible man who happily set a Greater Demon loose to maim and slaughter innocent people, and then tried to kill me when I put a stop to it."

'*I think she's being used,*' Shyleen offered. '*Pryshia tricked her into selling her soul.*'

That would explain why Nalani was more powerful than Mandalee but didn't have a bond of empathy like the one she shared with Shyleen.

'*It may have looked like Nalani was running the show, but she is effectively Pryshia's slave, albeit a willing one. I am also concerned about how Pryshia got here. She mentioned something about cracks in Alycia's Barrier.*'

'*You think other gods might find a way down here?*' Mandalee wondered.

'*There are worse things than gods,*' was Shyleen's only reply.

*****

Since the Guardians – including Shyleen – were together again, they decided it was time to pay the Council of Mages a visit. Dreya had hoped to be returning there in triumph – their first mission to save the Council's existence, ensure Ulvarius' defeat and retrieve the first fragment, a great success. Instead, they had to report that the third fragment was missing from Phitonia and they'd been beaten by a big cat with her pet human.

Catriona disagreed, however, believing instead that it was good for the Council to see some battle scars, to help them get a sense of how much they were putting on the line in their new roles.

"Although my battle scars from fighting Nalani aren't really anything to do with the Guardianship, Cat," Mandalee pointed out.

Catriona raised her eyebrows. "Aren't they?" She counted off her points on her fingers. "Dragonclaw daggers and magically resistant bodysuit, neither of which are available in this world. Possible cracks in Alycia's Barrier, and a Timeless spell that hasn't been invented yet. I'd say all those things come under the Guardians' jurisdiction."

"As if we didn't have enough to do, finding the other fragments!" Mandalee remarked.

“Oh, I’d be astonished if those things weren’t related,” Dreya replied.

Cat nodded, saying, “We can’t expect collecting the fragments to be easy. As far as we know, the only person who’s done that job before is Kullos. Who knows how long it took him?”

“Maybe we should pop back in time and ask him?” Mandalee suggested, facetiously.

They laughed at the idea in a much-needed release of tension, until the White Guardian continued, breezily, “Alright then, let’s go and see the Council!” Offering her arm to Windell, she reminded him that she’d promised him a tour of Walminster before Time went wonky. “After more than two years, I think it’s time I came good on that promise.”

Chapter 31

After a long and interminable Council meeting, the Triumvirate – Maia, Justaria and Laethyn – agreed to allow the Guardians to act with 'autonomy tempered with oversight', meaning they wouldn't interfere in the Guardians' day-to-day activities, but they might be called to account at any time. Or, to put it another way, even after more than two years, the Council still had no clue how to legislate what the Guardians did.

They proposed an alert system by which means the Council could contact the Guardians at any time. Catriona promised to put it on her list of jobs.

Dreya was initially shocked to discover she had been removed from the post of Secondmage in the order of Dark magic.

"After all I've done for the Council over the years?" she demanded.

"It is no reflection on your service, Dreya," Laethyn assured her, but you have been absent for over two years. You can't expect us to keep your seat vacant for so long."

"Besides," Justaria put in, "we were forced to question whether it is appropriate for a single mage to hold two important offices at the same time."

"Allowing a Guardian to be one step away from the Triumvirate must be seen as a conflict of interests," Maia pointed out.

Though she was still less than happy with the situation, Dreya supposed it didn't matter too much. Laethyn was still in her pocket, and as a Guardian, she could address the Council at any time, so in practical terms, what difference did it make? If anything, it would free her from some of her more tedious and mundane administrative duties. On that basis, then, she decided to accept the ruling with good grace.

The Triumvirate offered to introduce her to her successor in the post, but by that time Dreya had lost interest and declined the offer, saying she had every confidence in the Council's choices.

Upon leaving the Council building, Cat returned to Calin's Tower, and Mandalee stayed in Walminster with Shyleen and Windell.

Dreya stopped off at her Tower to put the cheese, which she was still carrying around, safely away in her larder, and the candles in a cupboard. Thus unburdened, she opened up a portal back to Phitonia. This time, going straight to the co-ordinates of the ruins of the Citadel of Doom. There, she intended to order the dragons to find the one called Pavay who had helped Scarlett and the other Chetsuans in Whealhaven, and taken the attacking wizard away. She had warned the dragons to never harm Chetsuans, but to actively help them like that had to warrant some kind of commendation.

Anything Pavay could tell her about the wizard in question would help her track him down on Tempestria. Then, one way or another, she would take the fragment from that wizard with a 'stern talking-to' about interfering in this world for which, quite to her surprise, she had come to care, deeply. She suspected that conversation would involve her using a lot of magic and that wizard being in a lot of pain.

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When she stepped through the portal, Dreya's first thought was that she must have made a mistake, but when she checked the co-ordinates, they were correct. The daytime sky was purple, which was consistent, and the grass was distinctively blue, as were all the trees and plants. The Citadel ruins looked about right. Slightly *more* ruined, perhaps, but no more than one would expect after ten years of neglect.

However, no dragons awaited her there, and none flew the skies as far as her eyes could see. There were no Chetsuan people, either, although she supposed it was possible that they might be wary of living so close to the dragons' former seat of power.

She closed her portal and opened a new one to the market town of Axford. It was gone. Buildings were left standing, and there were animals, she realised, but no people. No Chetsuans and no dragons. Anger and fury rising, she tore through the city, scaring and scattering the animals in the streets. Finding no joy there, she levitated to try and see further but she could see nothing more. She portalled to Scarlett's settlement, Whealhaven, but it, too, was abandoned. She opened portal after portal, flying rapidly, covering

half the globe. No-one. As far as Dreya could tell, there was not a single trace of sapient life anywhere in the world. Everywhere she looked, it had been extinguished by some unknown force.

Without really knowing why, Dreya returned to Axford market. She walked the streets once more, recalling the shops and businesses she had seen only a short time ago. She still had the map in her pocket. She remembered the pride she had felt, seeing that place, realising the potential of what it could become. All that potential was now gone. It would never be.

Dreya couldn't wrap her head around it. Even on a Phitonian timescale, she'd only been here a few hours ago, and the whole town had been teeming with Chetsuans. The market had been thriving.

Well, she considered, thriving apart from that Cult…

The sorceress felt chilled to the bone as a horrific idea began to develop. She'd overlooked something. Those Cultists had spoken of Cleansing rather than killing, and while that was hardly an original euphemism, she began to believe it was pointing to something quite specific. She felt the entity in her mind squirming, nervous. It knew something, and Dreya needed to know, too.

There was an obvious way to find out, of course. Whatever killed the people of this world did its work in the last few hours. She just needed to go back. She'd never attempted Temporal magic on an alien world before, but it was only a few hours. It shouldn't be difficult. She just needed to make sure she didn't see herself. The *Chronicles* warned against that, and warned further that Guardians could see themselves and each other even while Timeless. That danger was easily avoided, though. She just needed to return to Whealhaven, safely hidden from Scarlett and her people, at a time when she was sure she had been in Axford. There to watch and wait.

*****

She sat on a fallen tree trunk, watching Scarlett and her people work the land for more than an hour before a shining golden female figure appeared in the sky. Whichever direction Dreya looked, she was always there, as if she were distorting the spatial dimensions, somehow.

"People of Phitonia, Chetsuans and dragons alike," she announced in a voice dripping with honey. She spoke softly, yet the sound was crystal clear. "I am Purity. I have been among you for some time, now. In that time, I have tried to spread the word of the Creator, implored you to turn aside from your wicked, selfish ways, to cease your toil and your industry, trying to build, create and change that which was Created perfect in the Beginning. I have begged you to devote your lives solely to the worship of the Creator, but you have not listened. I can stay here no longer, but neither can I leave you to fester in evil. That would be cruel. Therefore, I leave you a gift: I shall Cleanse you of your evil, that your world may receive the Blessing of the Creator. This is a second chance for Phitonia. I pray that those who come after you will grow in the Light and reject the Darkness in a way that you could not."

As the light flared brightly, a voice in Dreya's head cried, '*Run!*'

The sorceress frantically opened a Temporal portal back to her present and dived through, closing it the instant she was on the other side.

Now that she had seen the destroyer, she was attuned to that power, and Dreya realised she was still there on Phitonia. When Dreya's magical senses detected her, it was as if the sorceress could see her head whip around, sensing her in return.

"What are you?" Purity wondered. "Why were you not Cleansed?"

Dreya had seen Mandalee in full flow, she had just witnessed Nalani run even faster, but this being made them both look like they were standing still. She was virtually on the other side of the world, but she flew so fast, she'd be with her in moments.

'*Hide!*' came that voice again.

She opened a micro-portal to Catriona's Meadow, embracing Timelessness, praying it was enough to hide from an Angel, for that was what she was. Dreya the Dark had faced down shadow warriors without flinching, but this Angel had slaughtered shadow warriors beyond counting. Fighting would be futile. She would stand no more chance than Windell against Nalani, and she doubted Purity would be as merciful. Dreya stood absolutely still,

hardly daring to breathe, as Purity arrived and began to probe the area with her power.

"Where are you?" she wondered. "I know you're here somewhere. Why can't I find you?"

'*I can help you escape,*' the voice in Dreya's mind promised, '*but I must be more.*'

Dreya knew the danger of letting more of that entity out of its box in her mind, but she feared the Angel more. She could not let Purity find her, and she absolutely could not allow her to find Catriona's Meadow or Tempestria.

'*How can you help?*' she insisted on knowing.

'*I can show you a path through the higher dimensions, help you evade her.*'

Dreya accepted its terms and opened the box in her mind just enough to allow a little more of the entity to escape. Once she was safe and free of distractions, she would put it back in its cage. For now, leaving Phitonia undetected was the priority.

Thanks to that entity, she found she could see dimensions that she couldn't before and crept along one of them in a direction for which she had no name, while Purity's back was turned. Her micro-portal was huge in this dimension, and she slipped through easily, closing it behind her. From there, she returned to her Black Tower. It was empty apart from her elite guards, whom she ordered to leave.

Closing the door to the room she shared with Catriona, she thought about the lost world of Phitonia. She recalled the meal she had shared with Scarlett and her husband. She remembered Axford, Lex's cheese, of which the portion in her larder was the last there would ever be. She remembered her demonstration about the Cultist threat – the scale of which she had completely misunderstood. She had thought the danger of Cleansing was a mere collection of candles that they could snuff out one by one. Instead, it was a rogue sun that had roasted the world in an instant. But the thing Dreya remembered most about Phitonia was Amber. The young teenage girl she had saved.

Maybe it was selfish, Dreya allowed, but she had been looking forward to telling Catriona everything she had done. Cat would have seen that Dreya the Dark would be a brilliant second Mum for her child. She would have been proud of her.

Now it seemed a hollow victory. She had saved that girl so that she might live for about one more hour.

Dreya, in her conceit, had imagined Amber growing up, having an amazing and wonderful life, telling stories about the day Dreya the Dark herself came to save her life and teach her to cherish and protect it. She would never have that life. After a mere fifteen Phitonian years – less than four in Tempestrian terms – it was over.

Part of her wished she'd been there to protect Amber again, but rationally she knew that as powerful as she was, she could have done nothing. Against Purity, even her beam cannon would be little more than a torchlight.

What was she going to tell Cat now? What about Jessica and Sara? How could she tell them that their homeworld, and the people that they thought she'd saved, were gone?

No, she resolved. They could never know.

Dreya had always valued truth and preferred to avoid lies, but where was the value in this truth? Her Chetsuan friends could never have gone home again anyway, so in practical terms, what difference did it make? No, surely in this case, there was kindness in a lie. She couldn't put her fiancée in the position of having to lie, too, however. Therefore, she would have to keep this from her, as well. She hated the idea of having this massive secret between them in their relationship, but there was no other way.

She wanted to tear that Angel apart for what she'd done – and she would – but even when she did, the Chetsuan civilisation would still be gone. Amber would still be gone.

That thought was too much for Dreya. She sat on the floor, huddled in a corner and did something she hadn't done since she was a child, using the name Andreyanka. She cried, weeping bitter tears over all that was lost, and the horror that she could never share.

How had everything gone so wrong so fast?

Dreya couldn't stop the images playing in her mind like one of those Earth movies: Scarlett, her husband, her community. Axford, the marketplace, Lex...Amber. Amber most of all. Her face smiling up at her.

Then she imagined that face melting in the Light of Purity's power. Amber's tears turning to ashes.

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Finally, Dreya dried her own tears, a rage building inside her. She *was* going to destroy that Angel.

She had been wrong, earlier, she realised. She didn't need to work on her control. What she needed was more power, the power to destroy an Angel, control be damned. There was only one place she could think of that could give her that power: the higher planes. Specifically, the realm of the shadow warriors.

According to Shyleen, Pryshia had spoken of cracks in Alycia's Barrier. Cracks surely made by Purity. Well, if Pryshia could use those cracks to Descend, then Dreya could use them to travel the other way. The means was obvious: Kullos had been trying to access the shadow realm via his control device. She needed that device to be complete and whole again, so in the short term, the mission was the same: find all the fragments.

As for what happened after that, well, Dreya had once vowed to kill Daelen StormTiger, but she had stayed her hand, although she had taken his power in the end. She saw now that she had been thinking far too small. If she wanted to stop Purity, it was no use draining one or two shadow warriors of their power. She needed to drain them all.

And if they tried to resist, if they forced her hand, then she would kill them. Every last one of them.

A sneak preview of the sequel
to *Fragmented Control*

Splintered Time

The Salvation of Tempestria
Book 5

Gary Stringer

Available Autumn 2022

Chapter 1

You are cordially invited to the Wedding of Catriona Redfletching and Dreya the Dark. The place is, of course, the Black Tower. The time is about a year since they returned from the past.

My name is Arshes Megane, and I am your humble commentator. You might consider a commentator a rather odd thing to have at a wedding, gentle reader, but in this case, trust me, it's not.

They called it a private ceremony. None of them could possibly know that was far from true. To the people of my age, thanks to recreational time travel, this wedding has become one of the most witnessed events in history, and there are commentaries galore. We even studied it at college, which as you can imagine was a strange experience for me. It was presented as 'the first official joint ceremony involving the Original Three since the formation of the Guardianship'. Can you believe that? (Apparently, a betrothal isn't 'official', so it doesn't count.)

My essay on the subject was entitled, 'A Lesson in How to Spectacularly Miss the Point, or How to Make a Lesson Truly Academic.' (And yes, gentle reader, I got marked down for that, too – you're starting to see the pattern, aren't you?)

This wedding was about two people declaring their love and commitment to each other. It was about a friendship for the ages. It was about including their alien friends and helping them feel wanted after the Guardians had inadvertently abandoned them for more than two years. Ossian Miach Kaidool was there, too, standing tall, towering above all. He had missed their betrothal as he had been wandering around Alloria, trying to come to terms with Daelen's death and his own continued existence. The Guardians had no way to find and contact him at such short notice. The wedding, by contrast, was planned, so it was about making him feel relevant. It was about this handful of people coming together not despite their differences, but because of them.

Though they didn't know it, these events were also about their uninvited guest, Princess Zarinda of Ainderbury, who looked on from her favourite spot. These days, she was putting her talents

to good use, having set up a healing centre for animals and Faery alike. Humans, too, in principle, but in practice, they were seldom allowed inside the Sylfranian border, so it almost didn't apply. At eighteen, Zarinda would be seen as a young adult by human standards but was still considered a child by the traditional Sylfranian Faery Folk. In less than three years, she would turn twenty-one, which would mark the end of her childhood. Less than three years of relative freedom and it would be her turn to marry, she knew. Only her marriage wouldn't be for love, but for closer political ties with the Quarthonian Faery. Unless her dream came true and Dreya swooped in to save her because she 'needed' her. Given today's events, that dream seemed more absurd than ever.

Watching the loving couple exchange their vows, gentle reader, the Faery princess could have no idea of the role she would play in their future...

...or mine.

Dreya could sense her, of course, but saw no point in banishing her. She had witnessed their betrothal, so in a way, it seemed only fitting that she should see this, too.

The wedding was about all these things, and probably more besides, but it had nothing, absolutely nothing to do with them as Guardians. Honestly, I sometimes think I'm the only person in the world, other than Aunt Mandalee, who can see her, Aunt Dreya and my mother, in any way other than through the lens of the Guardianship.

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The weather around the Black Tower that day was bright and sunny – Cat made sure of it. Dreya had chosen a human custom for their betrothal. For their wedding, Catriona wanted something a little more Faery.

"Is it ready?" she prompted Mandalee.

Her friend pulled something out of, of all things, a pocket dimension.

"I've been practising," she said in response to Catriona's quizzical look.

"Well, none of us ended up naked, so you're up on my early attempts," Cat admitted.

Mandalee handed her a garland of flowers – red, white, and black – their stems bound together into a two-foot-long strip. The two Chetsuans didn't know what was going on, but judging by Dreya's reaction, she clearly recognised it.

Standing beside her fiancée, Catriona took Dreya's left hand in her right.

"Dreya," she began, "you have let me get close to you in ways no-one ever has before. You've shown me the woman underneath the robes…"

Shyleen, by Mandalee's side like her feline shadow, as always, making sure only her literal soulmate could hear, quipped, '*If your pocket dimension magic had gone wrong, we might all have seen it.*'

Mandalee had to suppress a smile.

"…but I know there's so much more," Catriona continued, uninterrupted. "Every time I think I know what to expect from you, you do something unexpected. You told me I mean more to you than your magic, and I know what it cost you to say that. In return, I want to say this: I once told you that my Crystal Mage Staff was more important to me than our friendship. My obsession with my staff may have faded in recent times, but I'm sure there is more to learn about it. Still, no matter what mysteries still surround its existence and whatever functions it may yet have, its most vital role is already achieved."

She glanced over at Mandalee.

"It has gained me the best friend I could ever have," she returned her focus to Dreya, "and a love I never imagined I would find." Addressing the Champion of the Gods for a moment, she surmised, "Michael, I assume you've been around long enough to know Faery wedding customs?"

"Although I've never before had the privilege of being invited to one, I do know what they entail, yes," he confirmed.

Cat acknowledged that with a nod. "For the sake of our two Chetsuan friends, then, let me explain that in Faery tradition, when two Faery are wed, the best friend of each party binds their hands together with a garland of flowers. In this case, I believe it's safe to say we share the same best friend?" Dreya nodded in confirmation. "So it falls to Mandalee alone. The flowers symbolise the conferring of Nature's blessing, the kiss of Blessed

Alycia, on our commitment to each other. The binding, which will keep us connected for the whole day, symbolises our desire to never stray from each other. That this action is taken by a friend, symbolises that the support of those we care about reinforces our love."

To further involve the others, the garland was wrapped around a flexible metal wire mesh from Sara's Lavosian technology. A component of her higher planar energy detector that still stubbornly refused to work.

Jessica had grown the flowers with her druid magic. Like her sister, she had contributed without really understanding, until now.

Mandalee had attached her one remaining sapphire earring from her shopping trip with Daelen and Cat on Earth, so it dangled down between their wrists, further symbolising her joining them together.

Michael imbued the tiny sapphire jewel with a sliver of his own power so that it glowed.

"Dreya, is it your wish that our friend, Mandalee, should bind us in love, helping us to strengthen our bond as we prepare to take the next step in our journey through life together and marry?"

"Yes, Catriona," Dreya answered. "I wish it with all my heart."

Mandalee stepped forward, the garland strip in her hands.

"Although," the sorceress added, "for this to be completely official and legally binding, Mandalee, I suppose you ought to use my full given name."

Naturally, Catriona already knew, but everyone else shared the same puzzled look.

"Dreya isn't your real name?" Mandalee wondered.

"My chosen name is like your body, Mandalee," Dreya offered, cryptically.

"Beautiful, strong and completely awesome?" she suggested with a grin.

Everyone laughed but Dreya shook her head. "No, I mean it's real, and it's me, it's just not the one I was born with." Mandalee nodded her understanding. "And if any of you ever use it outside this ceremony, I'll turn you all into toads, or something."

Dreya accepted their word to keep it to themselves. As for Zarinda, as a Sylfranian Faery royal, Dreya would have been

astonished if she didn't know already, so she just came out and said it. "Andreyanka."

"Wow!" Sara exclaimed, pulling a face. "That so doesn't suit you at all."

"Not remotely," Mandalee agreed.

'*And I thought* '*Pryshia*' *was precious!*' Shyleen remarked.

"Yeah," Jessica put in, "I can totally see why you pared it back to Dreya. I mean, it's just so fussy and frilly around the edges. It sounds like…" she trailed off, trying to think how to finish the sentence.

Michael finished it for her. "It sounds like a Faery princess."

"Exactly!" Jessica cried, the others nodding and murmuring in agreement. "Good call, Mickey!"

"Don't call me Mickey!" he grumbled.

"Well, a Faery princess was exactly what my parents wanted me to be," Dreya explained. "If they'd had their way, I would have been married long before now to someone I barely knew. All to raise their status and supposedly protect me. Instead, I learned to provide my own protection and status. That choice led me to take this Black Tower, and then one day, this troublesome half-Faery druid girl I'd heard about came looking for a library."

Taking Catriona's hand, she gazed into her eyes and told her, "I still remember that day. The magic you used to 'challenge' me was unlike anything I'd seen before. With your strength, your confidence, your wit…" with a smile, she indicated the three colour roses framing her door, "…and your flowers, you filled my garden, my home and my life with a joy that was infectious. My library, my home, and my heart were yours from that day to this, and I vow in the future, too. A future I wish to share with you and," she added, placing her free hand on her fiancée's belly, "whoever the amazing person growing inside you might be. I give you both all that I am, all that I have, for as close to forever as our fates will allow." To her friend, she concluded, "So yes, please Mandalee, bless our marriage and bind us together."

"Catriona and Andreyanka," Mandalee began, taking care not to trip over the unfamiliar name, "when I first saw you two together, I was…" she hesitated, "…sceptical to say the least." Both Dreya and Cat flashed a smile at that. "But now, I couldn't

feel prouder or more privileged to be the one to help you symbolise the promise you are making here today."

She wrapped the garland strip around Dreya and Cat's clasped hands in an intricate pattern, and sealed it with a little magic from Shyleen, preventing them from letting go of each other until the next day.

(In practice, gentle reader, they would be unbound occasionally, so they could see to certain private bodily functions alone, but immediately afterwards, Mandalee would re-bind them.)

"With this binding, I give you both my blessing and my love, as your chosen friend, so that you may go forward in your relationship, and begin your journey into the marriage you both wish for. Congratulations to you both." She gave each a kiss on the cheek, and then the happy couple shared a deeper kiss with each other, while everyone showered them with a flurry of rose petals.

When her supply was exhausted, Jessica had to sit down and let the tears flow. She just couldn't hold back the flood any longer.

"That's it, I'm done!" she declared. "I can't handle any more emotions for at least a week!"

"Really, guys," Sara sniffled, only slightly more composed. "Thank you so much for letting us be a part of this private ceremony. I've never seen anything more amazing."

"Seconded!" Michael boomed, striding forward and shaking their free hands.

When he stepped aside, the two lovers each held their free arm wide, and Sara hauled her sister to her feet so they could both be enfolded in their embrace.

Finally, Shyleen rubbed bodily against them with a loud purr. The happy couple reached down and stroked the leopard, conveying their appreciation.

The rest of the afternoon was consumed by eating and drinking. Mandalee decided that since Catriona was, somehow, still pregnant, it was her solemn duty to drink her share as well as her own, and consequently got very drunk.

They even portalled over to Zarinda with a selection plate.

After Zarinda had gone home, the evening was filled with music and dancing. Then, when night fell, and all their guests had gone, leaving Cat and Dreya alone…

…Well, what happened after that, gentle reader, is between the two of them and protected by the highest of privacy ratings. Use your imagination.